A NOVEL

The Dry Valley

Loop Chronicles Book 5 · A novel that begins at Ezekiel 37:3

Jaehyuk Choi

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The Dry Valley, Part One

The People Who Do Not Disappear

Chapter 1. The Day, Seven Years Ago

Outside, people die.

I knew that from a very young age. In our settlement, one or two people went missing every winter. When an old person went missing, it was sad but not surprising. When a child went missing, it was surprising and sad. But both happened.

The adults never hid it. They couldn't have. The houses stood so close together that everyone heard whoever was crying at night.

I still don't think that was a bad way to raise a child. I had already learned the word "die" before I was ten. So seven years later, when I first heard the word "preservation," I understood exactly what it promised.

I was deceived precisely because I understood it exactly.

Our settlement had several words for death. Went. Left. Stopped. The adults used them differently depending on the situation. If someone was sick a long time before dying, they said "stopped." If it was sudden, they said "went."

I understood that distinction from a young age. I judged, from which word I heard, whether I should go to that house or not. For a "went," I went that day. For a "stopped," I went a few days later. "Stopped" meant everyone there had already been crying a long time.

Later, in this city, I would see that none of those words is used. Not went, not left, not stopped. With no use for them, the words disappeared too. I would spend a long time looking closely at what moved in to take the place where the words used to be.

. . .

There were four of us at home.

My father went missing when I was five. I won't write that story at length here. My mother raised us alone after that. I was the elder brother, and I had one younger brother.

My brother was eight years younger than me. A late child. He was born when I was eight, so I remember the day he was born. His face was red and wrinkled, and my mother laughed, looking at him.

My brother followed me around closely. So closely it was sometimes a nuisance. Wherever I went, he came along. When I went to draw water, when I went to gather wood, when I played with my friends.

There was a time I got angry at him.

"…Don't follow me."

My brother stopped where he was. And he didn't follow. I felt some relief that day, and some guilt by evening. But I didn't apologize. An eight-years-older brother doesn't do that.

I have replayed that scene hundreds of times over seven years. Not because I regret not apologizing. It's that I remember, too exactly, the spot where my brother stopped that day, and that exactness frightens me. The path from our house to the well, in front of the third stone wall. I still know that spot exactly.

My brother was afraid of water.

He was afraid of the sound of the well bucket going down. The rope unspooling makes a long sound, and at the end there's a splash, and the space between them was, for my brother, apparently too long.

I knew this, and I deliberately let the rope out slowly. It was a mean thing to do.

My mother saw it once and slapped my back.

"…Why make something he's afraid of even more frightening?"

"…He'll get used to it soon enough."

"…Is getting used to something the same as not being afraid of it?"

I let that question pass over me at the time. I thought of it again after coming to this city. The people of this city are afraid of nothing. But that isn't because nothing frightens them — it's because there is no longer anything to be afraid of. My mother's question, unchanged, becomes a question about this city.

. . .

Seven years ago, the year I was nine, it happened.

A sickness went around the settlement. First it was a cough. Then it was fever. And then people lay down.

The adults gathered and talked for a long time. I never heard the whole of it. They told the children to go outside.

That was when people came from the city.

I want to note first that those people were not bad people. That's the part of this record I most want to be careful with. They didn't come to deceive us. They came to truly help, and they truly did help.

They explained something called preservation. If a sick person was preserved, they said, that person would not get any worse. Not sick anymore, and not gone.

"…Does it cure them?" someone asked.

"…No," the person said. "It doesn't cure. It stops."

I thought that answer was honest. I still think so. That person did not lie.

Nobody in this city lies. I would confirm that for myself, later. And I would learn that a person can end up like this even without a single lie.

That night the adults argued for a long time.

One side said they had to send them. The other side said they must not. Someone from the side against it said this:

"…Stopping isn't the same as living."

Someone from the side for it answered.

"…And is dying living?"

I heard that from outside the door. I was nine, so I only half understood what it meant.

I have carried that half-understood exchange for seven years. And coming to this city, I learn that both sentences are true. Both are true, and they cannot stand together. This book is written in the space between those two sentences.

. . .

My mother lay down first, and then my brother lay down.

I did not lie down.

I still don't know why I was the only one who wasn't infected. I've asked. No one could answer. They just said it happens.

My mother took to her bed on the third day. My brother, on the sixth.

In between, I drew water. Four times a day. There was nothing else I could do.

My brother lay there and looked at me.

"…Brother."

"…Yes."

"…I hear the water."

I was holding the bucket rope. I had forgotten he was afraid of that sound.

"…Scared?"

My brother shook his head.

"…I like it."

I didn't understand that answer at the time. I didn't know why a sound he'd always feared had suddenly become something he liked.

Now I know. That sound meant I was there.

The day of departure was set. The people from the city would take the sick with them. Eleven left the settlement. Two left from our house.

I did not go. I wasn't sick.

The morning they left, my mother called me.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…You stay here."

"…No."

"…Anemos."

My mother said my name twice. Our mother said your name twice when she was angry. But that day, she wasn't angry.

I can still play that voice back exactly. It wasn't a voice of anger — it was a voice asking something of me. I didn't hear that then. I didn't hear it until I was sixteen.

"…That's a place for sick people," my mother said. "You're not sick."

"…Then I'll come later."

My mother laughed at that.

"…All right. Come later."

. . .

I was outside the village that day.

I went out because I didn't want to watch them leave. It was the greatest resistance a nine-year-old could make. I sat behind the hill until the sun went down.

When I came back, everyone was gone.

Inside the house, things had been put in order. My mother must have tidied up despite being sick. The blankets were folded, and a jar of water sat drawn in the kitchen.

I looked at that water jar for a long time.

My mother had drawn the water before she left. It was the water I was to drink that evening.

I didn't drink that water for three days. If I drank it, it would be gone. On the fourth day it went bad, and I threw it out. And that day, I cried for the first time.

Seven years later I would come into a city without water. I don't think that's a coincidence. It probably is a coincidence. It just never felt like one to me.

. . .

I regretted that choice for seven years. I could have looked at their faces one last time, and I didn't. I could have held their hands, and I didn't.

But writing this record now, I think differently. Sitting behind that hill that day wasn't resistance. I think I already knew, even then. That once those people left, there would be no going back to before. A nine-year-old doesn't know a thing like that in words. But he knows it in his body.

. . .

Seven years passed after that.

I stayed in the settlement. I grew up in a relative's house on my father's side, started working at twelve, and at fourteen learned to dig wells.

Outside, people kept dying. Over those seven years I saw seventeen funerals. I counted them. Counting became a habit.

I became someone who counts. That's why numbers appear so often in this record. While you're counting, you don't have to think.

Learning to dig wells at fourteen was an accident. There was an old man in the village who dug wells, and he needed a hand, so I went.

The old man hardly spoke. We dug together all day and he wouldn't say ten words. But there was exactly one thing he said, over and over.

"…You don't find water."

"…Then what do you do?"

"…You make it a way. Water is everywhere already. It just has nowhere to go."

I took that as a technical remark. I thought he meant something about the layers of the earth.

I would learn, three years later, that it wasn't a technical remark at all. In a city without water, standing beside someone digging a well that nobody had asked him to dig.

The old man stopped the winter I turned fifteen. Since he'd been sick a long time, they said he'd "stopped."

I went to that funeral too. The ninth of the seventeen.

Word came from the city a few times during those years.

The preservation had succeeded, they said. Nine of the eleven had been preserved. What became of the other two was not written down.

I would learn later where those two had gone. I'll write that in Part Two.

My mother and my brother were among the nine.

The notice read like this:

> *The subject has been stably preserved, and a visit may be applied for at any time.*

I looked at that sentence for a long time.

At any time. I thought that was a kind thing to say. It really was a kind thing to say. This city truly does let you visit at any time.

But the sentence also meant something else. It meant there was no urgency. Since the other side would not change, there was no reason to hurry.

I did not hurry for seven years. And during those seven years, I was the only one who grew older.

Once I took the notice to my uncle.

"…Can I go now, with this?"

"…You can."

"…Then why haven't you gone, all this time?"

My uncle said nothing for a long while. Then he said this.

"…If you go, you have to see it."

I didn't understand what he meant, and I asked again. My uncle didn't answer.

Seven years later I would give that same answer myself, out of my own mouth. On the day I came out from a visit, turning away from the counter after going to apply for a third visit.

If you go, you have to see it. That's all there is to it.

. . .

In the spring of the year I turned sixteen, I packed my things.

My uncle asked why now.

I hadn't prepared an answer. I just said this.

"…I think I can go now."

My uncle looked at me for a long while.

"…What are you going to do there?"

"…Bring them back."

My uncle said nothing to that. And he gave me a water flask. Something given to people from outside when they travel far.

"…I hear there's no water there," my uncle said.

I didn't know what that meant. How could a city without water exist.

I would learn what those words meant on my first day in the city. And I didn't know then, either, that this flask would become the thing I carried to the very end of this story.

. . .

On the road, I put my prepared words in order.

I had prepared a great many words over seven years. Things to say to my mother, things to say to my brother. I had even fixed the order. First, greetings. Then, everything that had happened since. Then, the main thing.

The main thing was this.

Let's go together now.

I had prepared those five words since I was nine. I prepared them while digging wells, and I prepared them while watching funerals.

The road took four days.

On the third day I passed through another settlement. I asked the people there which way the Preserve was.

An old man pointed with his hand. Then he asked,

"…Who do you have there?"

"…My mother and my brother."

The old man nodded.

"…We have one too."

I asked, glad to hear it.

"…Do you go visit?"

The old man looked at me. I would remember that look many times, later.

"…I went, at first."

"…And now?"

"…I don't go."

I started to ask why, but I couldn't. It felt like something I shouldn't ask.

The old man spoke first.

"…They're exactly the same."

I heard those words on the road and didn't understand what they meant. I would understand four days later. And I would learn that the old man wasn't a bad person. He didn't stop going because he was tired of it. He stopped because he couldn't bear that he was the only one growing old, every time he went.

In the end, I never manage to say those words myself. To be precise, I do say them, but I learn that the words are of no use at all. It takes this whole book to understand why.

I'll set down one thing here, ahead of time. I thought I was going to that city to wake my family. I was wrong. I was going back to the time when I was not alone.

That those two things are different — I understood that very late.

(Continued in Chapter 2.)

Chapter 2. Seven Years Outside

> *_Previously_ — Nine-year-old Anemos was alone outside the village the day his mother and brother left for the Preserve. Seven years later, now sixteen, he sets out with a water flask to bring them back. On the road, an old man he meets tells him, "…They're exactly the same." He does not yet know what those words mean.*

While I walked the road, I kept walking backward.

My body went forward, but my thoughts kept returning to seven years before. It was a four-day road, and through the third day there was a great deal of time to think. In that time I put those seven years in order.

I wrote "in order," but really it was a matter of counting. I was already a person who counted, even then.

. . .

Between the year I turned nine and the year I turned ten, five people went missing from our settlement. Between ten and eleven, three. The year after that, four. I remember all those numbers.

Counting became a habit around age ten. At first I just counted out of boredom. The number of times the well bucket went down, the number of axe-strokes to split wood, the number of steps left until evening. Then at some point I was counting people.

I learned later that this was a way of avoiding grief. Numbers don't cry. Names cry.

My uncle's house had three other children besides me. I was the fourth. Fourth for the rice bowl, fourth for the clothes. My cousins were never unkind to me. They simply never thought of me as a child of their own house. Neither did I.

"…Whose kid are you?" a village child once asked me.

"…I have a mother," I said. "In the Preserve."

The child didn't understand what that meant. Not many people in the village knew much about the Preserve. It hadn't been long since the city people came and took them, and no one yet knew exactly what it meant.

Only I knew. Only I was weighing the weight of that word.

My uncle's youngest was two years younger than me. His name was Gaon. Gaon didn't take to me. For the first few months he wouldn't even look at me.

"…Why won't you look at me?" I asked once.

"…You're going to leave, aren't you," Gaon said. "The kids who were at your house before did too. Whoever we got attached to always left."

I couldn't answer that. Gaon was right. I lived in that house planning to leave someday. There were times I deliberately worked at not getting attached.

I learned very late that the effort had failed. Attachment doesn't fail to form just because you try to keep it from forming. It forms with every shared meal. I ate about two thousand meals in that house. I never counted, but that's what the arithmetic gives now.

. . .

At twelve I tried to leave once.

I packed my things and told my uncle. He looked at me for a long while and said this.

"…You'll die if you go alone."

"…I won't."

"…It's four days' walk. Where will you get water?"

I had no answer. I had neither the strength to walk four days nor the sense to ration water. My uncle unpacked my bag again and said,

"…You have to be sixteen at least."

"…Why sixteen?"

"…Because by then you'll be an adult too. It's an adult going to meet adults, not a child going to fetch them."

I didn't understand that distinction then. Now I do. My uncle wasn't worried I'd fail to get there. He was worried about what I'd see once I arrived.

From that year I started counting how many years were left until sixteen. Four years. I crossed those four years off one day at a time.

. . .

A friend of mine died the winter I was thirteen.

I won't write the name here. I was told that writing it makes it cry, so I won't write it here. That child was my age, drew water with me, played with me. It started as a cough and stopped in eight days.

While that child was sick, I kept thinking one thing.

Couldn't they be sent to the Preserve?

I said that thought to my uncle. He shook his head.

"…That's not a place you go for this."

"…Why not? My mother and brother went because of sickness."

"…That was because the sickness had gone through the whole settlement, so the city sent people. The city doesn't come because one person is sick."

"…What if we brought them ourselves?"

"…Four days' road, carrying a sick child on your back?"

I had no answer. That child stopped in eight days. I went to the funeral. The third of the seventeen I counted.

That was the day I first learned the boundary of the word preservation. It didn't come to just anyone. Certain conditions had to be met. Nearly a matter of luck.

I would learn later that this boundary was the whole structure of this city. Some come in and some cannot. The standard isn't cruel. It's simply procedure. But I didn't know yet, then, that procedure can be more frightening than cruelty.

After the funeral, Gaon came and sat beside me. He hadn't even been close to that child, yet he came.

"…Brother," Gaon said. "Your mom and your brother aren't going to die, right?"

"…No."

"…Then that's a good thing."

I meant to agree, but I couldn't. Even knowing it was a good thing, the word wouldn't come out of my mouth. I didn't know why, then.

Gaon treated me a little differently after that. I think my effort not to get attached broke apart that day. In the moment Gaon sat down beside me.

. . .

At fourteen I learned the trade under the old well-digger.

The old man lived alone, a little way off from the settlement. The village people liked him but never got close. People find someone who doesn't talk hard to be around.

I didn't find it hard. Being beside someone who didn't talk was, if anything, comfortable. If he didn't talk, I didn't have to answer.

We dug all day, every day. Some days the water came quickly. Some days we dug all day and nothing came.

"…Guess there's none today," I'd say on the days nothing came, and the old man would shake his head.

"…It's not that there's none. You just haven't met it yet."

"…What's the difference?"

"…If there's none, you can dig all you want and nothing comes. If you just haven't met it, one more spadeful and it comes."

I took that as a technical remark. Now I know it was the only sermon that old man ever gave me. He hated sermons. And yet that was one.

The old man's hands were cracked. The knuckles were thick and coarse. I would look at that hand and then look at my own. Still soft.

It took three years for my hand to crack like that. I measured it in time. The old man never measured it in time. He just dug.

The old man never once asked me why I was learning to dig wells. I never asked him why he didn't go to the city either. But one day the old man brought it up first.

"…You're going to that city."

I stopped shoveling, startled.

"…How did you know?"

"…You keep looking at that flask. You tend to it even though there's no use for it yet."

That was the first time I realized I had a habit of tending my flask. It was the one my uncle had given me. I wiped it down with a cloth every night. I didn't know myself why I did it.

"…What will you do when you get there?" the old man asked.

"…Bring them out."

The old man planted his spade in the ground and looked at me. A long look. Then he went back to digging.

"…All right."

That was all. He asked nothing more. I stayed confused for a long time, unable to tell whether that short answer meant he was against it or for it.

Now I know. It was neither. The old man already knew what I was going there to do. He already knew what "bring them out" meant. He also knew that telling me anything would be useless. Some things can only be understood by going and seeing for yourself.

. . .

The year I turned fifteen, I saw a city person for the first time.

A traveling peddler. He went back and forth between the city and the settlements, selling goods. The city's emblem was stamped on his handcart.

I caught hold of him and asked.

"…Have you been to the Preserve?"

"…Been there. To deliver goods."

"…What are the people like there?"

The peddler thought for a moment, then answered.

"…Quiet."

"…They don't like noise?"

"…No. There's nothing to make noise about."

I found that answer strange. I didn't know what "nothing to make noise about" meant.

I learned the meaning later. A place with nothing to fight over, nothing urgent, nothing to cry about. That was the real meaning of "quiet."

"…Do the people there go on visits a lot?" I asked again.

The peddler looked at me for a long while.

"…Everyone goes a lot at first. Then it tapers off."

"…Why?"

The peddler answered while pulling his cart.

"…You'll know once you go."

I let those words pass too, at the time. A month later I heard something similar from an old man passing through the settlement. I let that pass too. I should have caught it the third time I heard the same words, but I let all three pass.

. . .

Four months before I turned sixteen, I received a notice at the settlement hall.

It said nine of the eleven sent to the city seven years before had been stably preserved, and a visit could be applied for at any time. There were no names for the remaining two.

I read that notice three times. The same sentence every time. I think I was hoping the sentence would change. It never did.

That night, for the first time, I did not count toward sixteen. I did not count the four months either. I just started packing.

My uncle watched me do it and said nothing. The man who had told me I was still too young to walk four days, that I had to be sixteen — that man did not stop me from leaving four months early.

I thought that was permission at the time. Now I know. It wasn't permission. It was resignation. My uncle knew I would go eventually, and he knew that pulling four years forward by four months wouldn't change much.

. . .

The old man stopped the winter I turned fifteen.

I had stayed by his side for the days before. He said almost nothing to the end. Just once, looking at my hand, he said this.

"…Cracked now."

He'd been looking at my hand. Three years of digging in the dirt had made it that way. I took it as a compliment. In the old man's way, it would have been one.

"…What happens to you now, teacher?" I asked. A foolish question. But the old man didn't call it foolish.

"…I'll stop."

"…If you're sent to the Preserve—"

The old man shook his head. He had little strength left, so it was only the smallest shake.

"…How would this body make four days' road. And I'm—"

He didn't finish. I wondered a long time about the rest of that sentence.

Later, I fill it in myself. It was going to be, I don't want to go. There's no proof. But watching the people I met in this city, that guess slowly became a certainty.

The old man's funeral was modest. A few villagers came. Gaon came too. I cried aloud at that grave for the first time. The ninth of the seventeen funerals, and the first time.

I knew exactly why I was crying that day. It was because I knew that of everything that man had said to me while he was alive, not one word had been empty. I didn't know then whether I would meet another person like that.

. . .

The night before I left, I counted those seven years again.

Seventeen funerals. Six years since I learned to count. Two years working under the old man. One meeting with a city person. One day since the notice. Seven years living with Gaon.

And seven years since I had seen my mother and my brother.

I laid those numbers side by side and looked at them. They were all correct numbers, and none of them made sense together. Only the number seven stood out, unusually large.

That night, for the first time, I grew afraid. Not because I didn't know what I would see when I arrived. I was afraid that I would see exactly what I already knew. I didn't yet know a name for that fear.

Gaon came into my room that night and sat a long while without speaking. Gaon, now fourteen, had grown as tall as me.

"…Brother," Gaon said after a long while. "You'll really bring them back, if you go?"

"…Yes."

"…So I'll really get to meet your real family?"

I laughed at that.

"…You're family too, now."

Gaon didn't answer. But I saw his eyes go red.

That night, for the first time, I understood I hadn't been the fourth child in that house. Two thousand meals had made it so. I only understood it the night before I left.

The next morning, my uncle handed me the flask. I took it and set out on the road.

And on that road, as I've already written, I met an old man. What he said still lives in me. Exactly the same. I didn't know what it meant, not until the evening of the fourth day.

The third night, I sat by a fire and thought again about what that old man had said. Our well-digging teacher had said something similar. That it wasn't that the water didn't come, but that you hadn't met it yet.

That night I laid the two sayings side by side. Not yet met, and already met so completely they are the same. I thought, then, that these two were exact opposites. Now I know. In this city, the two become the same words.

That night I opened and closed the flask's cap, again and again. It was still half full inside. I thought I could fill it once I reached the city.

On the evening of the fourth day, I was told, the city would come into view over the hill. I turned my last steps toward that hill.

(Continued in Chapter 3.)

Chapter 3. The Road Up

> *_Previously_ — Anemos walked the four-day road, retracing his seven years outside: seventeen funerals, the death of the old man who taught him to dig wells, Gaon who had taken him in as family. Leaving all of it behind him, he turned his steps toward the last hill.*

From the top of the hill, they'd told him, you could see the city.

The old man had said it. The last old man he'd met. I believed those words and walked toward that hill the whole afternoon of the fourth day.

Around sundown I reached the top.

I remember that moment exactly. I was out of breath, my legs ached, and the flask was nearly empty. And when I raised my head, the first thought that came was not about the city.

It was the thought that it was quiet.

. . .

The city sat on the flat ground above the valley.

It was less a wall than a low fence, ringing the place. The roofs stood in neat rows, all of a similar color. Not scattered in every color the way our settlement's were.

I looked at the sight for a long while. At first I thought it was beautiful.

Thinking back now, that impression wasn't wrong. It really was beautiful. The trouble was that I only learned, much later, where that beauty came from.

Before the sun went fully down, I started down the hill. About half a day's distance remained to the city.

As I went down, I listened.

Our settlement made sound even at night. Dogs barking, the well bucket, someone walking, a child crying. I had grown up inside those sounds.

This city had none of them.

I put it down to distance at the time. I thought I simply couldn't hear it yet, still being far off. That it would come once I got closer.

It didn't come, even once I got closer.

. . .

I stood a while longer on the hill, until the sun had fully gone down.

Seen from a distance, the city wasn't large. Only a little bigger than our settlement. That surprised me. For seven years I had imagined that city as far larger. I had thought of it as a place that could hold everything, and so guessed its size must be just as great.

I learned later that size didn't matter. What this city held wasn't a matter of volume.

A few streets showed between the roofs. Straight streets. Not a single one curved. I found that strange too. Every street in our settlement curved. As houses were added, the streets grew to follow them.

This city's streets had been laid out fixed from the start. There was no need for them to grow. Since no more people were being born, there was no need to build more houses either.

I found myself wondering, right then, whether there were any children in this city. I'll write the answer later.

I camped that night at the foot of the hill.

I meant to light a fire, but I gave it up. The city was too close. I had learned outside that lighting a fire when a stranger is nearby draws the eye.

I shook the flask. Little water was left. I drank it sparingly.

That night, for the first time, I wondered whether there might be a well inside the city too. I assumed there must be. A place where people lived couldn't be without a well.

I would learn the next day that this assumption was wrong.

The night sky was clear. Many stars. I counted stars until I fell asleep. That night I counted up to thirty-two. I fell asleep before I reached thirty-three.

I dreamed that night. I don't remember what the dream was. Only that when I woke, a feeling lingered as if I had heard the sound of water. I still don't know whether that was a dream or real. That night I was still outside the wall, so it could have been real.

. . .

The next morning I stepped onto the road that led into the city.

The road was strangely clean. Our settlement's roads were always cluttered with wheel ruts, footprints, animal tracks. This road had none of that. It looked like a road no one walked at all.

And yet people did walk it. I passed three groups that morning. It was a road that people walked, and yet left no trace. I found that strange too, at the time, and let it pass.

The first I passed was a man pulling a handcart. I stopped him and asked.

"…Is this the road to the Preserve?"

"…It is."

"…How much further?"

"…Half a day."

The man said nothing more and went on. I learned later that his short answer hadn't been unkindness. That was simply all he had to say.

I'll set down here that most of the people I met in this city were like that. Not unkind. Just saying only what was needed. At first it felt cold to me. Later it came to feel, instead, honest.

The cart carried cloth. All of it white or pale gray. I found that strange too. In our settlement people were proud of dyed cloth. Red cloth, blue cloth. The more it caught the eye, the better it was treated.

I would notice later that I had seen almost no eye-catching color anywhere in this city. Brightness wasn't forbidden. No one simply made it. There was no one who wanted to catch the eye.

. . .

Before noon, I passed a man walking with two children.

The children walked quietly. In our settlement, children that age would already have run around and shouted a good ten times over that distance. These children simply walked along behind their father.

"…Your children are very well-behaved," I said, striking up conversation as I passed.

The man glanced at me and said,

"…Not well-behaved. Just walking."

I thought that answer strange. I didn't know why "well-behaved" and "just walking" would be different.

I would come to understand the difference later. To be well-behaved means holding back the urge to run. This city's children weren't holding anything back. They simply had no urge to run in the first place.

I learned later that the man wasn't from this city either. He too was on his way to visit someone. That he knew the difference was because he, like me, had come from outside.

. . .

The second I passed was an older woman.

She was walking alone. Almost no luggage. I spoke to her too.

"…Visiting someone?"

The woman stopped and looked at me.

"…How did you know?"

"…There's nowhere else to go, on this road."

The woman laughed. A slightly sad laugh.

"…That's right. Going to see my son."

"…How long has it been?"

"…Three months."

I was surprised by that answer. Three months seemed short, I thought. For my family it had been seven years.

"…You go often, then."

The woman said, walking again,

"…I went every week, at first. Now it's once every three months."

"…Why did it taper off?"

The woman didn't answer that right away. Only after a few more steps did she say,

"…Go and see. You'll know once you go."

I was hearing that answer for the third time now. The peddler, the old man, and now this woman. The same words, all three times. Only then did I begin to feel a little uneasy. Why does no one tell me in advance?

Now I know. It wasn't that they couldn't. It was that it couldn't be carried in words. It was something you could only know by going through it, and everyone who had gone through it in this city already knew that.

I walked alongside that woman for a while. She asked me things first — where I was from, who I was going to see, how old I was.

"…Sixteen."

"…Did you come alone?"

"…Yes."

The woman stopped walking for a moment.

"…None of your family helped you?"

"…They did. Gave me the flask, and so on. But none of them came with me."

"…Why?"

I couldn't answer that. I had never once thought, at the time, about why my uncle hadn't come along.

I would learn later. My uncle had been to this city once. A very long time ago, to see his own parents. He never once told me that story. I set it down here for the first time in this book.

The woman spoke again, walking on.

"…I came with my husband, at first. Then he stopped coming."

"…Why?"

"…He found it hard."

I asked no further. I still didn't know what "hard" meant. It felt right, then, not to ask.

. . .

Past noon, the city's fence began to come into view.

Seen up close, the fence was low. A height you could climb over if you wanted. I found that strange. It seemed less a fence meant to keep something out than one meant simply to mark a line.

That thought wasn't wrong. This city had no need to keep people out. No one who tried to come in would bring anything from outside better than what this city already gave. The fence wasn't there to block intruders. It was only a thing that drew a line.

Inside the fence, the roofs came into closer view. I looked among them for rising smoke. The kind that comes from cooking. I saw none at all.

I blamed the distance again, then. Too far away to see, I thought. I'll write later about the fact that I still couldn't see it once I was close.

Walking along the fence, I stopped and parted ways with the woman. She went toward a different gate. I learned later that I had never even asked her name.

"…Goodbye," the woman said. "I hope you see something good."

I thought that farewell strange. Hoping I would see something good sounded like a thing you say when you're not yet certain.

I never meet that woman again in this book. But the farewell stayed with me a long time. I heard similar farewells from other people many times later. None of them wished me well with certainty. That was, in their own way, their honesty.

I watched the woman's back until it disappeared toward the other gate. Only then did I walk my road again. Walking alone had already, in that short time, come to feel strange.

A small stream ran beside the road. Glad to see it, I went over and filled my flask.

This was the last water I filled outside. I didn't know then that it was the last.

While filling it, I looked down into the streambed. The water was clear. A small fish passed between the stones. I watched that fish for a long while. It was no different from a stream outside.

I would come to find it strange, only later, that this fish lived just outside the city fence. Nothing at all lived in the water inside the fence. Though I didn't even know yet, then, whether there was a waterway inside.

. . .

Following the fence, I came to a gate.

There was no gatekeeper. Instead, letters were written on a wooden board.

> *Those entering, please register at the reception office.*
> *The Preserve welcomes all.*

The lettering was straight. Not a single crooked stroke. I thought of the wooden board at our settlement hall. The lettering there was always crooked. The size changed depending on who had written it.

I read that notice twice.

The Preserve welcomes all. I believed those words exactly as they stood. It wasn't a lie. This city truly did let anyone in. The trouble was that letting anyone in and letting anyone out were not the same statement. I would learn that much, much later.

I crossed the gate.

I have called that moment back to mind many times since. There was no special feeling as I set foot across. No threshold, even. Outside and inside simply ran together.

But the sound vanished completely. Outside the gate, the sound of the stream had been audible. The moment I stepped through the gate, that sound cut off.

I turned and looked back. The stream was flowing just the same. Only it could not be heard from inside.

That was the first time I felt real fear. What I'd felt on the hill had been vague. This was specific. From a place that made sound to a place that did not — I had just crossed a boundary.

I stood at the threshold without moving for a while. I even tried stepping back half a pace. Stepping back, the sound came again. Stepping forward, it cut off again.

I went back and forth in that spot a few times. I know it was a foolish thing to do. But I wanted to be sure, then, whether it was an illusion or not. It was not an illusion.

There was no one on the road but me. The people I had passed earlier had scattered to other gates, or had already gone in. I stood alone before that gate.

I would later come to overlay that moment with the moment I had sat behind the hill at nine years old. Both were moments of deciding whether to cross or

not. Nine-year-old me did not cross. Sixteen-year-old me did. That difference is where this book begins.

I took one deep breath and went inside.

. . .

Just inside the gate stood a small building. A wooden board read "Reception."

I stood before it. Before going in, I shook the flask once. It was half full.

I never once imagined that carrying this flask would look strange. At the time it was just a flask. Later it would become the one thing in this city that set me apart from everyone else.

Beside the building was a small flowerbed. Flowers had been planted there. White flowers, all similar in color. They hadn't wilted, and there were no insects. I touched one of the flowers. It was real. Not artificial.

I saw that flower again many times later. Always in the same spot, always in the same state. A flower that neither bloomed nor faded. It took me a long while to understand that it was a picture explaining this entire city.

I hung the flask back on my shoulder, pushed the door, and went inside.

(Continued in Chapter 4.)

Chapter 4. A City Without Water

> *_Previously_ — Anemos reached the Preserve after four days. Everyone he met on the road left him with the same words: "You'll know once you go." The moment he crossed the gate, the sound of water outside cut off completely. He pushed open the door of the reception office and went in.*

Inside the reception office it was cool.

One person sat there. Their age was hard to guess. They could have been about thirty, or about forty.

"…Is this your first time here?" that person asked.

"…Yes."

"…Your name and your purpose, please."

I gave my name. When I tried to say my purpose, I paused a moment, not knowing how to put it.

"…My mother and my brother are here. They were preserved seven years ago."

That person wrote something down on paper. Not surprised, not wearing a look of sympathy. Just wrote it down.

I felt that blank expression as coldness, at first. Now I know. It wasn't coldness. In this city, that story was nothing to be surprised at. Everyone had come here to say exactly that.

There was a nameplate on the desk. It read only "Reception Officer." No name.

"…Do you have a name?" I asked.

The person looked up. A face a little taken aback.

"…I do."

"…Then why does the plate only say—"

"…We use only titles here. It's a rule of this place."

I thought that was strange. In our settlement, people were called by name. Even the village head had a name, and everyone knew it.

I would learn later that officials in this city were generally called only by their titles. It wasn't that they had no names. Names were simply not used. I thought a long time about why, but by the end of this book I never got a certain answer.

. . .

"…How many days do you plan to stay?" the person asked.

I couldn't answer that question. I hadn't come with any notion of days. I had come only with the thought of bringing them out.

"…I don't know."

"…That's fine. We'll assign you lodging. There's no set period."

"…What about money?"

"…This city has no money."

I thought I'd misheard.

"…What?"

"…There's no currency. Whatever you need, you receive as a ration."

I felt relieved hearing that. Outside, there had been many things I couldn't do for lack of money. Here there was no such thing at all — I only took it as good news.

I would learn later that it was good news and something else at the same time. Having no money also meant there was no way to have more of what you wanted. Here everyone received the same. Because no one wanted more.

. . .

After registration, that person guided me to the ration station.

On the way, I asked.

"…Where's the well here?"

The person stopped walking and looked at me.

"…A well?"

"…Yes. To draw water."

"…This city has no well."

I stopped where I stood.

"…None at all? Then how does water—"

"…Whoever needs it receives it at the ration station."

"…Living people need water."

The person looked at me a moment, then answered.

"…Yes. That's what the ration is for. Those who have been preserved don't need it."

I turned that sentence over many times. Those who have been preserved don't need it. I didn't know exactly what it meant, then. I know now. It meant there was a kind of body that could be fine without drinking water.

. . .

On the way to the ration station, I saw, up close for the first time, a person of this city — that is, someone who had been preserved.

A woman. Her age was hard to guess. Her walk was a perfectly even pace. Neither fast nor slow. I greeted her without thinking, as I passed.

"…Hello."

The woman looked at me and smiled. An exact smile. Neither too wide nor too small.

"…Yes, hello."

That was all. The woman walked on. I watched her back. It was a fairly strong afternoon sun, but there was no sweat on her forehead. Her face wasn't flushed either.

At the time I just took it as a difference in constitution and let it go. It was only later, asking the reception officer again, that I understood. A preserved person doesn't sweat. Not because they don't feel heat, but because their body has no need to use water that way.

The ration station was a building like a small storehouse. There weren't many people.

Inside, I had the feeling that standing there holding a flask was the one strange thing about me. No one else was carrying a flask.

The station attendant saw me and asked.

"…Here for water?"

"…Yes."

"…How much do you need?"

That question flustered me too. Outside, since there was a well, there had never been a need to decide how much was needed. You simply drew what you needed.

"…A day's worth?"

"…I'll give you a day's worth."

The attendant scooped water from a jar and filled my flask. The exact amount. Neither overflowing nor short.

I admired that exactness at first, then soon found it strange. Well water isn't exact. The amount was different every time you drew it. Sometimes it overflowed, sometimes it fell short. That unevenness was the very nature of well water. This water had come out measured. Water with no room to be uneven.

"…And tomorrow?" I asked.

"…Come again tomorrow and you'll get more."

"…I have to come every day?"

"…Yes."

I thought that was a bother. If there were a well, you could draw a great deal at once and set it by.

I learned later that this way of rationing wasn't about being a bother. In this city there was almost no one, besides me, who had any reason to store water. Everyone needed only to receive what they needed for that day. Storing was something only people who worried about the future did.

. . .

Leaving the ration station, I walked the streets.

Buildings lined the roads between the roofs. People passed to and fro. Everyone walked quietly. No one ran.

I looked around for something like a well or a washing place. There was none. No stream either. Not even the sound of running water.

I walked the city for about three hours that day. In all that time I never once heard the sound of water flowing. I don't think anyone who has only ever lived in an outside settlement can fully grasp how strange that is. The sound of water had always simply been there, like air. That day was the first time I ever walked through a place where it had disappeared.

Walking on, I passed a small plaza. A stone structure stood in the middle. Round in shape, hollowed in the center. Glad to see it, I went over.

It was a fountain. A fountain with no water.

The stone floor was bone dry. Not even a trace of moss. I set my hand on the edge of the structure. Not a speck of dust — perfectly clean.

I asked a passerby.

"…Did water used to come out of this?"

The person stopped and looked at the fountain. Looked it over a moment, as if seeing it for the first time.

"…Not sure. I've never heard anything like that."

"…Then why was it built?"

"…Because the shape is pretty?"

That was all the person said before walking off. I stayed behind, looking the fountain over more.

I would learn later that this fountain had never had water in it from the start. This city had a number of things that only kept the shape of flowing water without actually letting anything flow. That day, at the fountain, was the first time I saw it. And later I would see the same shape in something much larger.

There was no one hanging washing out to dry, either. Every garment was clean. I found that strange too, but soon guessed the reason.

A preserved person's clothes don't get dirty. The living were a small minority, and their laundry, it seemed, was handled some other way. I never did see that method, to the end. It was probably a way that used no water.

There was little dust either. Outside, in the settlement, when the wind blew, dirt lifted into the air. Shoes were always grimy. Here, only my shoes were dirty. That evening I looked a long while at the soles of my own shoes.

. . .

The lodging was a short walk from the reception office. Inside that building were several rooms, and I was assigned one of them.

On the way in, the door of the next room was open, so I could see inside. A man was unpacking his things. He looked to be in his mid-twenties.

"…First time here?" he asked, looking at me first.

"…Yes."

"…I came the day before yesterday too. Who did you come to see?"

"…My mother and my brother."

The man nodded.

"…I have a brother. It's been three years."

I understood right away what that "it's been" meant. I was already, little by little, learning the way people used that word in this city.

"…Do you go back and forth often?" I asked.

The man's hands stopped their unpacking.

"…This is my third time."

"…Three times in three years?"

"…Yes."

I thought that was few. I didn't say it aloud. The man must have read my expression, because he added this.

"…At first I came every month."

He said only that and went back to unpacking. I asked nothing more and went into my own room.

That night I thought together about that man's "it's been," and about how his visits had shrunk from every month to three times in three years. I still couldn't connect the two, then. The connection wouldn't come until later, until I had stood in that place myself.

As night deepened, I looked out the window. A few lamps were lit along the street. The light was fine, even. It didn't flicker. I had watched lamp-flames flicker in the wind my whole life, but not once did a lamp in this city flicker.

I would learn the reason for that too, later. For now I only note that it was strange. That night I was counting a list of strange things in my mind. No sound, no well, no color, no flicker. Four. I didn't know, then, how much longer that list would grow.

It was a small room. One bed, one table. I sat in that room and set the flask down on the table.

I suddenly thought of the people I had passed that day. No one had carried a flask. No one had a water bottle at their hip. Only I did.

That night, turning the flask over in my hands, I thought: this object had become the thing that marked me here as someone from outside. When my uncle gave it to me, it must have meant survive. Here that meaning had turned

into a different meaning. It was like a mark that read: the only person in this city who needs water.

I drank a little water that night. About half of the day's ration.

From then on I began to conserve water. Even knowing there would be a ration every day. A habit worn into the body doesn't disappear just because it's explained.

. . .

The next morning, I went back to the reception office to find out the procedure for a visit. On the way I passed the ration station from the day before.

A line stood there. Only three people. I looked closely at those three. They all looked, like me, like people who had come from somewhere else. Their clothes were a little different from the city people's.

I tried, then, to count how many people in this whole city drank water. I couldn't count it. Instead I arrived at this: everyone who drinks water is someone who came from outside. No one was born or grew up in this city. Everyone here had come from somewhere.

Whether that was a correct conclusion, I would only confirm later. For now I set down only the guess I formed that morning.

On the way, I ran into the man from the next room again, the one from the night before. He was already coming back from finishing his visit.

"…That was fast," I said.

"…If you apply early in the morning, it happens that same morning. There aren't many people."

"…How was it?"

The man looked at me a moment. His face searching for an answer.

"…Good."

There was something strange in the way he said it. The word "good" held very little good in it. I didn't notice that at the time. I only exchanged goodbyes and we parted.

I would recall that expression again later. Once, coming back from my own first visit, when someone asked me "how was it," I found I had answered with that same tone — "good."

Reaching the reception office, the same person from yesterday recognized me.

"…Here to apply for a visit?"

"…Yes."

"…I'll walk you through the procedure. You have to see the Curator first."

That was the first time I heard that title. The Curator. I heard the word with the flask still in my hand.

"…What kind of person are they?" I asked.

"…A kind person. You don't need to worry."

That answer was reassuring. But one thing the person added afterward stayed with me.

"…Though you may have to wait a while. They've been rather busy lately."

"…Are there a lot of people applying for visits?"

"…No, it's not that, but…"

The person didn't finish the sentence. I asked nothing more. It seemed like asking wouldn't bring an answer anyway.

I turned that unfinished sentence over all that night. Busy, but not because there are many applicants. Then busy with what? I would learn the answer in Chapter 6. Here I only set down that I wondered.

Leaving the reception office, I shook the flask again. Still about half left. The ration hour hadn't come yet.

In that moment I got some sense of the shape a day would repeat in, in this city. The ration station, the reception office, the lodging. A day spent going back and forth among them. No one else's day had a flask in it. Only mine did.

(Continued in Chapter 5.)

Chapter 5. Perpetuity

> *_Previously_ — Anemos learned the city had no well. The preserved have no need of water. He became the only person receiving a ration. He was told he would first have to meet the Curator before applying for a visit. The Curator, they said, was busy these days.*

The reception officer handed me a sheet of paper.

"…Read this before your visit. Everyone reads it."

It had a title. "Concerning Perpetuity."

I stood right there and read it.

. . .

The first paragraph read like this.

> *Perpetuity is the system operated by the Preserve. It preserves the consciousness and memory of registered subjects without damage. The preserved converse, remember, and judge. They do not disappear, and they do not suffer.*

I read that sentence over several times. They do not disappear, and they do not suffer. Those two phrases sounded to me like the best words in the world.

I could find no reason to doubt that sentence then. I can find none now either. That sentence was not a lie. In this city I never once found any evidence that this sentence was false. That is the difficulty of this book.

Holding that paper, I thought of the man in the next room. The one whose brother had "become" preserved three years before. Passing him on my way out of the reception office, I brought up this paper.

"…Have you read this?" I asked.

"…When I first came. Everyone reads it."

"…Do you believe it? What's written here?"

The man thought a moment, then said,

"…There's nothing to believe or not believe. Go talk to my brother and you'll see. It's real."

"…What's real?"

"…The remembering. He remembers everything about when I was little. Even things I've forgotten."

That answer set my mind at ease. The unease that this city might be deceiving me about something eased a little.

I would confirm later that this man's words were accurate. The preserved really do remember. I never once overturn that fact in this book. There was never anything to overturn.

. . .

I moved on to the second paragraph.

> *Perpetuity does not evaluate the preserved. It does not ask their qualifications. It does not weigh what their life before preservation was like, or what weight that life carried. Every registered person is preserved in the same manner, with the same diligence.*

Reading that paragraph, I felt strangely at ease.

Until then I had unconsciously assumed this city would screen for something. In our settlement, even to receive a single thing, your qualifications were weighed. Had you been a good person, had you been of use to the village, did you owe any debt. Even of the dead, people said such things. He was a good man. She was a person too soon lost.

This city didn't do that. At first that was simply reassuring news to me. Later I would learn that this was the most frightening part of this city. I won't write that part yet, here.

I asked the reception officer,

"…So you'll preserve a bad person too?"

"…Yes. The registration standard is condition. Not the person."

"…What does that mean?"

"…Whether damage has begun in the living body — that's the standard. What kind of person they were isn't looked at."

That explanation gave me a strange sense of reassurance.

I had long been used to things I couldn't have because I lacked the qualifications for them. Outside, a great many things were a matter of

qualification. This city had no such standard at all. I liked that. I still admit that the feeling itself was good.

. . .

The third paragraph.

> *Perpetuity does not judge. It does not ask after sin. It does not weigh. It only preserves.*

I read this sentence over a second time.

I would learn later that this sentence stands in exact contrast to the systems of three earlier cities. I won't tell those cities' stories in this record. I'll only note that each of those cities had something that measured. There was a Scales. There was a Roll. Here, there was nothing.

I didn't know, then, how strange that nothingness was. I thought everyone would welcome hearing that there was no evaluation. So did I. I still think, even now, that this sentence itself is a kind one. Kinder than any system I had heard of before.

There was a fourth paragraph too.

> *The preserved have no need of new experience. This is not a defect but a stability. The purpose of this system is that the state at the moment of preservation remains exactly as it was.*

I had no particular thought on first reading this paragraph. The word "stability" sounded to me like nothing but a good word.

I would come to reread this paragraph many times later. That stability and stillness could be the same word — I couldn't think that, then. This is the sentence that hides most quietly in this entire book. I now think it is also the most frightening sentence.

Seeing my face, the reception officer asked,

"…Is something bothering you?"

"…No. It's just… good, what it says."

"…That's right. It's a good thing to say."

The way that person answered, I felt something in the tone. Not so much conviction as repetition. It sounded like an answer given many times before.

I didn't notice that repetition then. Later I would come to make the same repetition myself. It's a good thing to say. Every time someone asked me how a visit had gone. In the exact same tone the man in the next room had used when he told me it was good.

. . .

Seeing that I had finished reading the paper, the reception officer asked,

"…Anything you're curious about?"

"…What is Perpetuity made of? Is it a machine?"

"…A bit different from calling it a machine, but you can think of it that way."

"…Who made it?"

The person's face turned thoughtful for a moment.

"…I don't really know that either. I only know it was made a very long time ago."

I didn't find that answer strange. Our settlement, too, had a well that no one knew exactly when had been dug.

I didn't know then that this not-knowing had spread through this entire city. No one knew how Perpetuity had begun. Not even the Curator. Whether they knew and simply weren't telling, or truly didn't know, was never made certain by the end of this book.

. . .

I folded the paper and sat a while in the shade of a tree near the reception office. There I overheard two people talking. Both were people of this city.

"…I heard that house's daughter-in-law came by yesterday," one said.

"…Yes, I heard."

"…First time in three years, they say."

"…I see."

That was all. The conversation went no further. I found that strange. In our settlement, that conversation would have gone on much longer. What it meant to come after three years, what had happened in the meantime, why she had come only now.

I recalled that short exchange again later. Those two people weren't curious. They attached no feeling at all to the fact of three years. Neither surprise nor regret. They only exchanged the bare fact.

I know it wasn't rudeness. To those two people, three years and three days truly made no great difference. That not judging could show up this way too — I saw that for the first time in that tree's shade.

. . .

"…Can I ask one more thing?" I said.

"…Yes."

"…You said there's no judgment. Then is there no one who's refused preservation?"

"…No one. Anyone who wants it is accepted."

"…What about someone who's accepted without wanting it?"

At that question, the person hesitated a little for the first time.

"…That… it can only begin if the person themselves wants it. Registration requires consent."

"…What if they're in a state where they can't consent? Too sick to."

"…In that case a family member can apply on their behalf."

I nodded at that answer. I thought of how my mother and my brother had been preserved that way. Both had had such high fevers they were in no condition to decide anything for themselves.

I thought, then, that I had fully understood this answer. Later I would learn that this word "consent" is the heaviest word in this city. I'll write that story in Chapter 18.

I asked one more thing.

"…Can I be preserved too? Right now."

The reception officer looked at me. There was no sign of surprise. This question, too, didn't seem to be a first.

"…In principle, yes. I told you the registration standard is condition. Right now you're in good health, so you're not a candidate, but if you wish, you can apply anyway."

"…Even in good health?"

"…Even in good health, we don't block the application. We just don't encourage it, either."

"…Why don't you encourage it?"

The person looked at me a moment, then answered.

"…Because you still have something left to lose."

I didn't understand that answer right there.

I would take those words out and turn them over many times later. You still have something left to lose. I tried, then, to count what I stood to lose. I counted everything that could be counted. That something uncountable remained — I didn't know that, then.

. . .

At the very bottom of the paper was a fifth paragraph.

> *Family and acquaintances may visit at any time. Without any separate reservation or waiting, you may visit whenever you wish.*

Reading this sentence, I felt a catch in my throat right there. Any time. I had waited seven years for that word.

"…Is this real?" I asked. "Can I really go any time at all?"

"…Yes. So long as you follow the procedure."

"…Does the procedure take long?"

"…Meeting with the Curator is the first step. After that it goes quickly."

I nodded at that answer. I was glad to hear that only the first step had to be gotten past.

I didn't know then. That this word "any time" carried, along with its kindness, another face. Being able to go any time meant that if you didn't go today, you could go tomorrow; if you didn't go this month, you could go next month. It was a phrase that made all urgency disappear. I would come to see, later, just how slowly that phrase lets a person drift away.

I folded that paper and put it inside my shirt.

I still have this paper. Writing this record now, I spread it open on my desk and read it again. Not one sentence has changed. I have changed.

Walking outside, I turned those paragraphs over again. Does not judge. Does not ask qualifications. Does not ask after sin. Preserves with the same diligence.

That night, for the first time, I thought this: if a system like this had existed in our village seven years ago — no, eleven years ago — could my father have been preserved too? My father's disappearance wasn't from sickness. I said in Chapter 1 that I wouldn't write that story at length in this record. I keep that promise even now.

I'll set down only this much. I can no longer remember my father's face well. I remember my mother's face, but my father's face has gone blurred. I find that difference frightening. The blurring itself. This city was telling me it could take that very blurring away. I was drawn to that promise. I am not ashamed of that pull, even now.

Walking back to the lodging that night, I thought for the first time that this city might be a good place.

That thought wasn't wrong. This city was a good place. I don't want to paint this city as a bad place, to the end of this book. But being a good place, and giving me what I wanted, turned out to be two different questions. I wouldn't understand that difference until much, much later.

Walking to the lodging, I counted. How many sentences on that paper ended in "does not." Six. Does not evaluate. Does not weigh. Does not judge. Does not ask after sin. Does not measure. Does not need.

I walked counting those six negative sentences. I wrote in Chapter 2 that counting was a habit. This time the counting did something else. It confirmed to me that all six were good things to say. That confirmation was, that night, a comfort to me.

Now I count those six negatives again. And I think this. A system that says six times what it doesn't do is a system that has decided, six times, not to do something. That the deciding itself was a choice — it took me a very long time to notice that.

. . .

On the way back to the lodging, I passed the fountain again. The waterless fountain I had seen that afternoon.

I stopped in front of it for a moment. And I recalled the sentences I had read that afternoon. Does not judge. Does not weigh. Only preserves.

I opened the flask and drank a little of what remained. Before that fountain, only the sound of my own flask sounded. The cap opening, the water sloshing. In that narrow plaza, that sound rang unusually loud.

I should have noticed something in that moment. That not weighing and having no flow at all might be the same thing. I didn't notice, then. I only walked on thinking those sentences were kind.

I still think those sentences are kind. Even now, having finished writing this whole book. Only now I know that being kind and keeping someone alive are not the same thing.

I closed the cap and hung the flask back on my shoulder. Walking the rest of the way to the lodging, I thought that tomorrow I would meet the Curator. I said that name to myself a few times in my mouth. The Curator.

I said that name then with no feeling at all attached to it. It wasn't until the next day, seeing that face, that feeling began to attach to it.

(Continued in Chapter 6.)

Chapter 6. The Curator

> *_Previously_ — Anemos read the notice titled "Concerning Perpetuity." It does not judge, it does not ask qualifications, a visit may be made at any time. He felt this system was kinder than anything he had heard of before. The next day he was to meet the Curator.*

The Curator's office was a building at the very center of the city.

The building itself was a little larger than the others. But it wasn't ornate. There was almost nothing you could call decoration. I found that, if anything, dignified.

There were six steps. I counted them as I climbed. One, two, three. My hand trembled and I lost count a few times. I counted twice more to be sure it really was six.

I noticed later that this was the only building in this city that looked old. The stone was darker than the other buildings'. No one ever told me why.

. . .

The reception officer walked me there and said they would wait outside.

There were a few long benches in front of the building. People sat waiting their turn. I looked over their faces one by one.

One person looked anxious. Their leg was shaking. Another had no expression at all. Their eyes simply faced forward. I wondered why those two faces were

so different.

I would learn the answer later. The anxious one was a first-timer. The blank one had come many times before. I didn't even know, that day, which I was closer to. I know now. That day, I was the anxious one.

When my turn came, the reception officer called my name. I adjusted the flask on my shoulder and went into the building.

I stood a moment before the door. There was no marking on the door at all. No name, no title. I thought that strange. Every other place had had a marking.

I would learn later that this door hadn't originally been unmarked. I won't tell that story here.

I knocked.

"…Come in."

The voice was gentle. Age was hard to guess. I pushed the door and went in.

. . .

The room wasn't large. One desk, two chairs. Nothing hung on the walls.

One person sat behind the desk. They looked to be around forty. Their clothing was tidy. There was no particular expression on their face. Only their eyes looked a little heavy.

A stack of papers sat piled on one side of the desk. Fairly tall. I wondered what it was but didn't ask.

I would learn later that it was the day's paperwork to be processed. I wanted to count that height, but it wasn't the place for it. Looking back now, that pile

of paper was the most honest object showing this person's day.

"…You're Anemos, I take it," the Curator said first. "I heard from reception. Sit, please."

I sat. The chair was hard.

"…You've come to see your mother and your brother, I understand."

"…Yes."

"…It's been seven years."

"…Yes."

The Curator turned over a sheet of paper. It seemed to be my file.

I didn't see, then, what was written on that paper. I never saw it, later either. The Curator never once showed me that document.

. . .

"…The road here must have been hard," the Curator said.

"…It took four days."

"…On foot?"

"…Yes."

"…Did you have enough water?"

That question surprised me a little. I hadn't expected to be asked that.

"…Yes, it was fine."

The Curator looked at my flask. I was still wearing it on my shoulder.

"…You seem to carry that around with you."

"…Yes. It's become a habit."

The Curator smiled slightly at that. A small smile.

"…A good habit. Though it's an uncommon object, here."

I still remember that smile. It was the first real smile I saw after coming to this city. The reception officer had smiled too, but that had been an exact smile. This was a little different. I couldn't explain where the difference lay, then. I can't say it exactly even now.

The Curator pressed the corner of an eye briefly with a fingertip. A very short motion. I let it pass, assuming it was fatigue.

"…Are you all right?" I asked.

"…Yes, I'm fine. Don't mind it."

The Curator straightened again. The voice remained just as calm.

I didn't recall that brief motion again until that night. And after that I found myself looking for it every time I saw this person. Sometimes it was there, sometimes it wasn't. I got in the habit of guessing, from that, what kind of day it had been.

The Curator lowered a hand and, arranging the papers again, said,

"…Sorry. Where was I."

"…The application."

"…Ah, right."

In that brief gap I sensed something strange. This person had, until a moment ago, been explaining the procedure with perfect precision, like flowing water. And yet, for just an instant, they had lost their place.

I let that gap pass that day. I thought, people can be like that. But meeting this person many more times later, I came to see that gap arise, each time, in roughly the same spot. While explaining a procedure, for just an instant, looking somewhere else.

. . .

"…Let me explain the procedure," the Curator said. "A visit takes just one application form. If you apply today, you may see them today."

"…Do you meet with everyone like this? Every applicant?"

"…Yes. I personally walk you through the procedure for the first visit. From the second on, reception handles it."

"…Why only the first, in person?"

"…Because the first is the most important."

I liked that answer. It didn't sound like a formal answer but one with a real reason behind it.

"…How many people do you see in a day?"

The Curator thought a moment.

"…It differs day to day. Some days many, some days few."

"…Today?"

"…Today's on the busier side."

Hearing that answer, I looked again at the pile of paper on the desk. And I felt a little sorry. I was one of that many.

"…I'm sorry, you must be busy."

The Curator shook their head.

"…No. This is my work. And…"

The Curator paused a moment.

"…This work — it's not the kind of work that can be let fall behind."

I felt something heavy in that tone. It didn't sound like ordinary talk about work.

I only heard it as a sense of duty at the time. Later I would learn it wasn't duty so much as something close to a vow. This person was pressing themselves not to let this work fall behind.

"…Today?"

"…If you'd like."

Something in me swelled right there. Seven years of waiting, and now it would be a matter of minutes.

"…Can I ask something, though?" I said.

"…Yes."

"…I heard at reception yesterday that you've been busy lately. They said it wasn't because there are many applicants, so why—"

The Curator looked at me a moment. Choosing an answer, it seemed.

"…There's some other matter."

"…What matter?"

"…It's a little early to say."

I asked no further. But in that brief silence, I saw something. The Curator's eyes turned, for just an instant, somewhere else. Somewhere in the corner of the desk.

I couldn't read that gaze at the time. I know now. That gaze was directed outside the city — to be exact, below the city. Toward the valley. I wouldn't confirm that until much, much later.

. . .

"…Will you write the application?" The Curator held out a sheet of paper.

I took it. There were boxes for name, relation, and the subject's name.

In the name box I wrote my own name. In the relation box I wrote "Son / Elder brother." At the box for the subject's name, my hand stopped.

I won't disclose it here either. I didn't in Chapter 1. I don't write my mother's and my brother's names anywhere in this record. I can't explain the reason exactly myself. I only want these names to be mine alone to say.

I wrote the names. My hand trembled a little.

The Curator saw this and said nothing. Only waited.

I liked that waiting. Someone who doesn't rush you. I hadn't met many people like that.

Pushing the form forward, I asked,

"…Have you been doing this work long?"

The Curator tapped the desk lightly with a fingertip.

"…A long time."

"…How long?"

"…It's been a long time since I stopped counting."

That answer surprised me. I was a person who counted. The words "stopped counting" sounded foreign to me.

"…Why did you stop?"

"…When you keep counting, eventually all that's left is the counting."

I didn't fully understand that, right there.

I would think over those words again and again, later. I have carried numbers through every part of this book. I wrote in Chapter 2 that counting is a way of avoiding grief. The Curator had used that method far longer, far more, than I had. And knew that even that method wears out, in time.

. . .

Once the application was finished, the Curator took it up.

"…Are you ready?"

"…Yes."

"…Let me say one thing beforehand."

"…Yes."

"…After you see them, it may be different from what you expected. Don't be alarmed."

I tensed at that.

"…Is she sick?"

"…No. It's not that."

"…Then what?"

The Curator paused a moment before saying,

"…It only means the feelings you've prepared may not all get used."

I didn't understand that, then.

"…I'm not sure what that means," I said.

The Curator looked at me a moment. A face weighing whether to explain further.

"…There's a lot you've wanted to say, all this time, isn't there."

"…Yes. Really a lot."

"…Have you prepared all those words?"

"…Yes. I even decided the order."

The Curator gave the smallest nod at that. A nod that seemed both regretful and resigned.

"…That order — you may not get through all of it today."

"…Why?"

"…You'll know once you go."

Hearing that, I nearly laughed to myself. I nearly counted how many times I'd now heard "you'll know once you go" since coming to this city.

In that moment, for the first time, I faintly sensed that this answer wasn't evasion. Everyone truly could not find a way to explain it. I found that more frightening. It wasn't that there was no explanation — it was that it couldn't be explained.

"…Can I still ask one thing?" I said.

"…Yes."

"…Could it be different in a good way? Not just a bad way."

At that question, the Curator looked at me a while longer for the first time.

"…That, I don't know either. It's different for everyone."

"…What do you think, yourself?"

"…This isn't a place for me to give my opinion."

That answer was firm. I couldn't tell whether it was because of a rule or this person's own choice.

I would learn later that the distinction hardly mattered. Rule or choice, the result was the same. This person never once told me their own opinion, to the end.

I have called this sentence back to mind hundreds of times since that day. The feelings you've prepared may not all get used. It was a warning. A very precise warning. I would live out that warning myself, two hours later.

. . .

Gathering the application, the Curator said,

"…It's been received. If you follow the procedure, you should be able to see them within today."

"…How long do I have to wait?"

"…Not long. It just takes some time to prepare."

"…Prepare?"

"…There's a procedure for bringing them in. An officer will guide you shortly."

I nodded at that. As I rose and turned toward the door, the Curator called me back once more.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…Are you nervous?"

"…Yes."

"…That's all right. Everyone is."

There was something laid under that tone. I couldn't find it strange, at the time.

I know now. That wasn't comfort. It was a confirmation of fact. I didn't have the nerve to guess how many times the Curator had said those same words in that room.

I looked once more around the room. A room with nothing on the walls. One window. Through that window, the roofs were visible.

I would come to that room again, later. Many times. Each time, the room hadn't changed in the least. I thought that was this person's taste. Later I learned it wasn't taste. There was simply no reason to change it.

Before leaving through the door, I bowed once more.

"…Thank you."

The Curator nodded.

"…Go well."

That farewell, too, was short. I faintly sensed, even then, that it wasn't from a lack of sincerity. This person wasn't sparing words — they were choosing only the words that were truly necessary.

Coming out of that room, I thought, for the first time, that this person was to be pitied. I couldn't explain the reason. The thought simply came. Not a grieving person, not an angry person, and yet someone who made me think, this person is to be pitied. I had never met anyone like that until then.

Coming out into the corridor, the reception officer was waiting for me.

"…All finished? The officer will guide you through preparations for the visit now."

I adjusted the flask on my shoulder and followed that person. My heart began to race again.

(Continued in Chapter 7.)

Chapter 7. Applying for a Visit

> *_Previously_ — Anemos met the Curator for the first time. A person versed in procedure, courteous, yet somehow worn. "The feelings you've prepared may not all get used" — the meaning of those parting words, Anemos does not yet know. He handed in his application. Now only the waiting was left.*

The officer was a young woman.

"…This way, please," the woman said. "I'll call you as soon as it's ready."

I followed her to a small waiting room. There were a few chairs, and no one else there but me.

"…How long will it take?" I asked.

"…About half an hour. An hour at the most."

Hearing that span of time, my heart felt strange. I had waited seven years, and now it hadn't sunk in that only half an hour remained.

I still remember exactly how I spent that half hour, sitting in that waiting room. I spent it counting. There was nothing like a clock on the wall. I gauged the time by the sound of my own heartbeat.

I would count one breath in and one breath out and call it one. Counting up to fifty that way felt like about five minutes had passed. That afternoon I counted this way six times. On the sixth, I lost the number and had to start again from the beginning. That was the first failure I experienced that day.

. . .

The moment I sat down, I took a piece of paper from my pocket.

The paper where I had written out the words I'd worked over on the road. I unfolded it and read it again.

First, the greeting.

I had meant to open with "I've missed you." Then something like "Have you been well." I had practiced this order the whole four days of walking.

I had reworked that greeting many times too. At first, worried that if I just said "Mom" I wouldn't be able to go on, I'd considered opening with something else instead of the word itself. In the end I decided to simply say it.

I stopped counting how many times, in that waiting room, I silently rehearsed that single word, "Mom." I gave up somewhere around twenty. Counting had lost its meaning. That day I learned, for the first time, that some words come out sounding like the first time no matter how many times you practice them.

I also looked at the small note I'd written in the margin. "While smiling." I had written those two words down since I was nine years old. I mustn't meet her crying, nine-year-old me had thought.

Seeing that note, I laughed a little in the waiting room that day. It felt like homework nine-year-old me had left for sixteen-year-old me. While smiling. I had no confidence, then, that I could keep that homework.

Second, everything that had happened since.

My uncle's household, Gaon, learning to dig wells. I had meant to tell it all in order, thinking my mother would want to know.

I had broken that second item down in more detail. The story of Gaon coming to think of me as family. The story of the first time I cried aloud, when the old man stopped. Whether to include the story of my friend who stopped in eight days, I had agonized over for a long time.

In the end I decided to include it. It felt like something my mother should hear. I thought that only by knowing everything I'd endured would she understand the words I meant to use to persuade her to come with me.

Looking back now, it was a strange calculation. The calculation that if I told her everything I'd endured, she would do something for me because of it. I didn't even know, then, that it was a calculation.

I had even numbered the order on the paper. One, Gaon. Two, the old man. Three, my friend. Four, how to dig for water. I had changed that order about three times over the four days on the road.

At first I had meant to tell the old man's story first. I wanted my mother, above all, to hear what he had told me — that you don't find water, you make it a way. On the second night I changed the order. It seemed wrong to start with something sad, so I decided to tell Gaon's story first.

At the time I thought reordering it that way was consideration for my mother. Looking at it now, it wasn't consideration — it was fear. I was afraid that if I brought up something sad first, she would grieve, and I'd never get to the main thing I meant to say.

On the third night I changed the order again. I meant to cut my friend's story out entirely. It felt too heavy. But on the morning of the fourth day I decided to put it back in.

Without that story, there was no explaining why I had come this far to fetch my mother. It was only after watching my friend die that I understood the weight

of the word preservation. Without that story, I thought then, the main thing I meant to say would lose its force.

Third, the main thing.

Let's go together now. Five words.

I wrote in Chapter 1 that I first settled on those five words that night when I was nine. After that, this line nearly changed several times. At twelve I considered switching it to "I've come to bring you back." At fourteen I thought of adding "I'm grown now too." In the end I returned, every time, to the original words.

I couldn't explain the reason then. I know now. All the other words were words that explained me. "Let's go together now" was the only one that didn't explain me at all. It was a phrase aimed wholly at them. That's why I never changed it, to the end.

I folded and unfolded that paper again and again. My hands grew damp.

. . .

Through the waiting room window I could see the yard. A few small trees stood there. Though the wind was blowing, the leaves barely stirred.

I found that strange too, at the time. The same kind as the unflickering lamps I noted in Chapter 4. I didn't know the reason, that day. I know now. This city simply doesn't have strong wind to begin with. Not by chance, but because of the terrain. The valley drew all the wind down into itself.

I watched that tree and counted time. How many times the leaves stirred. When I reached twenty, the officer came back.

"…A little longer, please."

"…Is something wrong?"

"…No. It just takes some time, procedurally."

I believed that. I had reason to. I had already learned that the people of this city don't lie.

I still believe those words. From that day on, I never once heard a lie in this city. Only, the truth wasn't always the shape I wanted.

. . .

The waiting room door opened once and closed again. It seemed someone had come into the wrong room and left. In that brief moment I saw a person standing in the corridor. An older man. His face was pale.

I would come to remember that face for a long time. It had no expression to speak of. Neither sad nor glad — just a face that looked entirely used up.

I didn't know, then, what had caused that face. I couldn't have guessed it was the face of someone just finishing a visit. It was only late that afternoon, looking into a mirror, that I found my own face had come to look like that man's.

I also saw what he held in his hand. A small handkerchief. The hand holding it was not the least bit wet.

I didn't find that strange, at the time. I simply couldn't imagine, then, that a handkerchief used to wipe tears could stay dry.

. . .

While waiting, I thought about other things too.

Then, for the first time, I tested myself on whether I remembered my mother's voice exactly. I closed my eyes and tried to bring her voice to mind. It came. Exactly, it came. That was a relief to me.

I tried to bring my brother's voice to mind too. He had been eight then, so I didn't know how much his voice would have changed. I tried and gave it up. Only the eight-year-old's voice came to mind. I couldn't imagine what it might sound like now.

I didn't know, then, what that small snag meant. I know now. My brother's voice really was exactly the eight-year-old's voice, still. It wasn't a failure of my imagination. My memory had been exact.

While at it, I counted other things too. The four days it had taken to get here, the three settlements I'd passed through in those four days, the four people whose names I'd heard on the road. The numbers grew the more I counted.

That was strangely reassuring. What could be counted was still something I could hold on to.

I thought about something else too. Would my mother recognize me. I had gone from nine years old to sixteen. I had shot up in height, my voice had deepened, my face had changed. My uncle, a few months before, had looked at me and said, "I wouldn't have known you."

That was the first time I took that worry seriously, in the waiting room. For seven years I had thought only of my mother staying the same, and had hardly given a thought to the fact that I had changed. That was strange. I simply hadn't felt the change, because I saw myself in a mirror every day.

That day, in the waiting room, I asked myself that question for the first time. What if I'm the only one who changed. I would learn the answer soon.

. . .

About an hour in, I heard sound from the next room.

Not voices. Sounds like a door opening and closing, footsteps. I listened closely.

I would learn later that this room was the passage leading to the visiting room. That day I counted how many times that door opened and closed. Three times. Three people, it turned out, had gone before me.

The officer came again and said,

"…Almost ready. Just a little more."

"…What preparation is being made?"

The woman looked at me a moment, then said,

"…It takes time, bringing her in."

"…Bringing her in? From far away?"

"…Not that far."

I sensed something vague in that answer. But I didn't press further, then. My mind was elsewhere.

I would only understand what that vagueness was much, much later. I'll write that story later in this book. Here I only note that I failed to notice it that day.

Once the officer left, I was alone again. The room was quiet. So quiet that my own breathing sounded loud.

In that quiet I noticed something strange. Ever since arriving in this city, I had always felt my own breathing, my own footsteps, unusually loud. With every other sound so low, only my own sound stood out. There were times it felt like proof that I was the only living person in this city. It was an illusion. Everyone was alive. Only I was noisy.

I closed my eyes and brought my mother's face to mind again. This time not the voice, but the face. The set of her eyes, her nose, the corners of her mouth. I called up that face piece by piece, as if fitting it together.

I thought I remembered that face exactly. But when I opened the door and actually saw that face, I found there was a very fine difference between the face I remembered and the real one. What that difference was, I'll write in Chapter 9.

. . .

I looked over the paper again.

The third item, the main thing. Let's go together now.

I practiced those five words aloud, for the last time, in that waiting room. Very quietly, so only my own ears could hear.

"…Let's go together now."

The words sounded strangely awkward. Words I had practiced for four days — no, for seven years — and yet, spoken aloud, they felt foreign.

I thought, at the time, that the strangeness was from nerves. Later I would learn there was another reason. Those words had been written with a nine-year-old's heart. Spoken from a sixteen-year-old's mouth, they simply didn't fit.

I meant to say it once more but gave it up. I had thought a second try would improve it, but it seemed it would only feel more foreign.

I folded that sentence up as it was and put it away inside myself.

. . .

I fidgeted with the flask. Opened and closed the cap.

I drank exactly one mouthful of water in that waiting room. I learned that day, for the first time, that your throat goes dry when you're nervous. I was probably the only person in this city who felt thirst.

Looking at that flask, I had a thought too. Should I show it to my mother. If I told her my uncle had given it to me and I'd carried it all the way here, would she be glad.

I secretly added that as a fourth item. I didn't write it on the paper. Only in my mind. I didn't know, then, that it would turn out to be the most useless item among all the words I'd prepared.

Through the window the sun had tilted a little further. I gauged the length of the shadow. A little past noon. On my second day in this city, at the end of a road I'd walked for four days, I had finally arrived at that hour.

The officer opened the door and came in again.

"…It's ready."

I sprang up at those words. I folded the paper again and put it inside my shirt. My hands trembled.

"…This way, please."

I followed her out into the corridor. My steps felt strangely heavy. Steps I had waited seven years for, and yet now that I actually walked them, my legs wouldn't quite obey.

I can still picture that corridor exactly. It wasn't a long corridor. There were three doors. I stopped before the middle one.

The other two doors were also closed. I wondered whether someone like me was behind them too. Maybe someone else stood there clutching a flask like me, folding and unfolding a paper like me.

I learned later that my guess wasn't wrong. Those three doors in that corridor always held people carrying a similarly weighted burden. I didn't know that, that day. I thought I was the only one carrying this weight.

The officer pointed at the door.

"…Here. Go in."

I took hold of the doorknob. My hand was cold.

I still remember the feel of that doorknob. Smooth. Cold. I took one deep breath before opening that door.

I touched the paper inside my shirt once more. Still there. The greeting, everything that had happened since, the main thing. Seven years' worth of words, even the order all decided.

In that moment I believed that paper would protect me. That if I only spoke in order, only did as I'd prepared, this reunion would turn out just as I had pictured it. I would learn, the moment I opened that door, that this belief was wrong.

The officer said quietly from behind me.

"…Take your time."

Those words were strangely kind. They didn't sound like something said as a matter of procedure. I nodded at them and pushed the door.

(Continued in Chapter 8.)

Chapter 8. My Mother

> *_Previously_ — In the waiting room, Anemos went back over the words he had prepared for seven years. The greeting, everything that had happened since, and the main thing — "Let's go together now." The officer pointed at the door. He took hold of the doorknob and took one deep breath.*

He opened the door.

The room was small. There was one window, and sunlight was coming in. Two chairs stood facing each other.

My mother was sitting in one of them.

I have relived that moment more times than I can count. Even now, writing this record, if I close my eyes the room is still there exactly as it was. The chairs, the sunlight, and my mother.

The room had none of the usual things. No painting on the wall, no vase on a table. Only two chairs and one window. I didn't notice that plainness at the time. My eyes saw only my mother.

· · ·

My mother was exactly the same.

The way her hair was tied, the way she sat, even the color of her clothes — all exactly as I remembered. For a moment I felt like my breath had stopped.

She saw me and stood up.

"…Anemos."

Her voice was exactly the same too. The very voice I had called to mind with my eyes closed, for seven years.

"…Mom."

I barely managed that one word. None of the greeting I had prepared came out.

. . .

She came to me and cupped my face in both hands.

"…You've grown so much."

"…Yes."

"…Have you been eating well?"

I laughed a little at that question. The first thing said after seven years apart was about food.

"…Yes, I've been eating well."

She looked me over for a long time. Up and down, from my face to my feet.

"…Your voice has deepened too."

In that moment I understood how pointless my worry had been, that she might not recognize me. She knew me at once. She saw exactly how much I had

changed. But there was no surprise in that recognition. It was as if she were seeing someone she had said goodbye to yesterday.

She noticed the flask slung over my shoulder and tapped it lightly with her fingertips.

"…What's this?"

"…A water flask. My uncle gave it to me."

"…Did you think you couldn't get here without water?"

"…Just habit, I guess."

She smiled a little at my answer. This smile had a different texture from the one before. I didn't notice the difference at the time.

"…Same as ever, you." she said. "Even as a child you always carried everything you needed."

I nodded at that. It was true.

. . .

"…Sit." she said.

I sat in the chair across from her. The distance between the two chairs was just enough for a hand to reach across. She took my hand. It was warm. Only then did I realize I had been holding my breath until that moment.

The first thing I checked was the warmth of that hand. I had been afraid it might be cold, or strange somehow. But it was just a human hand. Warm, soft, an ordinary hand.

"…Are you all right?" I asked. "Does it hurt?"

"…No, it doesn't hurt at all."

"…Is anything hard?"

"…No. Everything's fine."

I felt relieved at that answer. And at the same time, something felt empty. Like there was some other question I should be asking, and I didn't know what it was. My mother's expression didn't move at all. To the question about pain, to the question about hardship, the same-temperature answer came back each time. I didn't know then what that emptiness was.

I would only put a name to that emptiness in the next chapter. Here I'll only note that the feeling was there.

"…Weren't you scared?" I asked. "Back then, when the fever got bad and you had to lie down."

She thought for a moment, then said,

"…I think I was scared. But I don't remember it well."

"…You don't?"

"…The feeling from back then is blurry. Because now I'm not scared at all."

That answer struck me as strange. Whether a fading memory of fear was a good thing or a bad thing, I couldn't decide. I remembered exactly how many days that fever had lasted, while my mother barely remembered even the fact that it had been frightening.

I never manage to settle that judgment by the end of this book. Whether a feeling fading is a mercy or a loss — I still don't know.

"…Mom." I called.

"…Yes."

"…Did you know I was coming all the way here? That I'd come."

She looked at me and smiled.

"…No, I didn't know. But it's not a surprise."

"…Why?"

"…Because you're the kind of child who'd come."

The answer was short. But there was some certainty folded inside it. I was glad of that certainty.

"…Did you miss me?" I asked. It wasn't something I had prepared. It just came out.

She paused a moment at that question.

"…Yes. I missed you."

I felt relieved to hear it. But the speed at which the answer came was a little strange. Too exact a speed. Not sorrow, not longing — just the speed of stating the correct answer.

I didn't find that speed strange at the time. I know now. It wasn't a lie. She really must have missed me. Only, that missing probably didn't carry the same weight as the missing I had carried for seven years.

. . .

I tried to recall the order I had prepared.

First, the greeting. Already ruined. Second, everything that had happened since.

"…A lot has happened to me since then." I said.

"…Tell me."

"…Um, there's a boy named Gaon, my uncle's youngest…"

"…Oh, that child. Is he doing well?"

I was a little surprised that she remembered Gaon. He had been young even before she left.

"…Yes, he's doing well. He's grown almost as tall as me now."

"…That's fast."

The tone was strange. There was no surprise in that word "fast." It was just a tone that confirmed a fact.

I didn't find that tone strange at the time. I know now. For her, seven years wasn't a fast span of time. The very unit of seven years had no meaning for her.

. . .

I started to bring up the old man, then stopped.

I had set that story as the second item under the second heading. The story of the old man stopping. But when it actually came time to open my mouth, my throat closed up.

"…What were you about to say?" she asked.

"…Nothing. Later."

She nodded. She didn't press.

I thought back on that moment later. Why hadn't she asked further? Was it that she wasn't curious, or that she saw I was struggling? I still don't know the answer for certain.

Instead she asked me something else.

"…Where are you staying now?"

"…There's a lodging house in this city. The information office assigned it."

"…Isn't it lonely being alone?"

I laughed at the question. The question of whether it was hard being alone — the very thing I'd just asked her — she was handing right back to me.

"…I'm fine. There's someone in the next room too."

"…Are they a good person?"

"…Yes, seems like a kind person."

She nodded. There seemed to be some relief mixed into that nod. I was glad of it. It felt like proof that she was worrying about me.

I kept that moment for a long time as the best moment of that visit. That brief moment of my mother worrying about me. I thought it was only natural. I know now how uncommon that moment was.

I can still picture her face from that moment exactly. Her eyebrows lightly furrowed, her head tilted toward me. It was the face of someone worrying. Wanting to see that face a little longer, I deliberately answered a little slower.

I couldn't bring up my friend at all. The friend who had stopped after eight days. The moment I tried to say his name, my throat closed on its own.

I never managed to tell that story in this visit, in the end. A story I had been preparing since I was nine, and in front of her I couldn't say a single word of it.

"…How's my brother?" I asked instead.

Her face brightened a little.

"…He's doing well. When I told him he'd see you later, he was happy."

"…Does he recognize me?"

"…Of course."

I felt relieved at that, and uneasy at the same time. My brother was eight. That he would still be exactly that, even after seven years had passed, weighed on me for the first time in that moment.

"…Isn't he having a hard time here either?"

"…No, he's fine."

"…Does he get bored?"

She tilted her head at that question, exactly as before.

"…He doesn't really use the word 'bored,' that child."

I let that answer pass without dwelling on it at the time. Only after meeting my brother in person, later, would I understand what those words meant.

"…Is he nearby right now too?"

"…Yes, remember, today you're to see me first, and your brother a little after."

"…I want to see him soon."

"…He hasn't changed one bit. Be ready to be surprised."

She said that, laughing. A light laugh. I tried to laugh along with it, but it didn't quite work.

I took "he hasn't changed one bit" as just a joke at the time. Two hours later I would learn that it wasn't a joke at all, but an exact fact.

. . .

"…Is my uncle doing well?" she asked.

"…Yes. Same as ever."

"…I'm grateful. For taking you in."

"…Yes."

"…It must have been hard, in that house."

I started to say it hadn't been, but just nodded instead.

I don't know why I didn't deny it. I wanted to say it hadn't been hard, but the words wouldn't come. Maybe, in that moment, I was admitting for the first time that it had been a little hard after all.

"…You must have thought of your father a lot too." she said suddenly.

I was startled by that. Eleven years had passed since my father disappeared. For her to bring him up first was rare. In our family, my father was always a subject someone raised carefully — lowering their voice, watching for reactions.

"…Sometimes."

"…Do you remember his face?"

I couldn't answer right away. I hesitated to say it had gone blurry.

"…It's a little blurry."

She nodded at that. She didn't look sad.

"…That can happen."

That calm was strange to me. In our family, talk of my father was always heavy, but the three words that came out of her mouth were far too light.

I thought at the time that lightness was because she was strong. I know now. It wasn't strength. In this city, weight itself was measured differently.

She held my hand a little more tightly.

"…You've done well."

At those two words I nearly cried. I barely held it back.

I remember nine-year-old me writing "while smiling" in the margin of that paper. I kept that homework half done. I didn't cry. I couldn't smile either.

. . .

The third item, the main thing, still remained.

Let's go together now.

I kept looking for the moment to say those five words. But I kept failing to find it. My mother was talking about other things, and I couldn't find the courage to interrupt.

"…How is it, staying here?" I asked instead.

"…Good. Everything's good."

"…Isn't it boring?"

She tilted her head slightly at that question.

"…What is there to be bored of."

I felt something blocked in that answer. But I couldn't put my finger on what it was, right then. I would only come to know the name of that feeling after I met Eikon. I'll write that story in Part Two.

. . .

I didn't know how much time had passed. The officer opened the door a little and said,

"…Time's up."

My heart sank at those words. Already.

"…Already?"

"…Yes, I'm sorry."

She didn't let go of my hand, and said,

"…Come again."

"…Yes."

"…Let's talk more next time."

I nodded at that. In that moment I realized I hadn't gotten to the main thing. Let's go together now. In the end I never once spoke those five words aloud.

. . .

At the door she held me once. Her embrace was exactly as I remembered. Same warmth, same strength.

"…Bye now."

I didn't think, at the time, how strange that farewell was. Seven years since we'd seen each other, and yet the parting words were exactly what you'd say to someone you'd met yesterday.

Before leaving through the door I turned to look at her once more. I wanted to hold her face in my eyes one last time. She was still standing right there. The same posture, the same expression as a moment before.

That feeling was strange too. I would come back anyway, and yet I took in her face as though I would never see it again. I didn't know then where that urgency came from. I know now. My mother had nothing to hurry for. I did.

I stepped out through the door. Looking back, I saw her waving. Her face was smiling.

That smile was exactly the same too. I walked out watching that smile. All the way down the corridor, through the waiting room, until I stepped outside, I couldn't think of anything at all.

Outside, the officer was waiting.

"…You can see your brother in a little while. Please rest a bit, then come."

I nodded and sat back down in a waiting-room chair. I could feel the paper against my chest. I didn't take it out to look at it.

I never unfolded that paper again that day. There was no reason to. The order written on it had already come apart entirely.

(Continued in Chapter 9.)

Chapter 9. Exactly the Same

> *_Previously_ — Anemos met his mother for the first time in seven years. She wasn't sick or sad, and she welcomed him gladly. He never got out even half of what he'd prepared to say. Before meeting his brother, he had to sit in the waiting room a moment and rest.*

Sitting in the waiting-room chair, I did nothing at all.

Even when I tried to think, thoughts wouldn't quite take hold. I just sat there and breathed. I picked up the flask and set it back down, over and over.

I couldn't even count that stretch of time. It was the one moment I gave up counting. I couldn't bring myself to.

. . .

I thought of the man next door. The one who had come three times in three years. Footsteps that had shrunk from once a month down to three times in three years.

At the time I guessed that shrinking was laziness. Now I see it differently. It wasn't laziness. Going to see the same exact thing, every time, takes something out of you. What that something was, and where it went, I began to understand for the first time that day.

I thought again of what that man had said to me earlier. "It was good." I had already written down, at the time, how little goodness I could actually hear in that tone. Now I could understand the tone. It wasn't a lie. It really must have

been good. Only, that goodness had stopped in the same place, every single time.

I recalculated the man's numbers. Once a month would have made thirty-six times in three years. But it had been three.

Thirty-three had gone missing. Right there, I had no way of knowing where those thirty-three had gone.

After a while I came back to myself a little. And I went back over what my mother and I had said, one thing at a time.

The way her hair was tied. The color of her clothes. The warmth of her hand. The way she smiled.

I went through them one by one, and then I stopped. It wasn't counting. It was checking. And checking, I finally, for the first time, looked something straight on.

All of it was the same.

. . .

I called to mind even the folds of her clothes. The way she'd sat, the shape of her collar where it had been creased. Wanting to see how close that was to the last time I'd seen her, seven years ago, I closed my eyes and laid the two scenes side by side.

My mother on the morning she left, and my mother today.

I couldn't find a single difference between those two scenes. Even the color of her hair tie was the same. I knew it couldn't be chance, and yet in that moment I wished it were. If it were chance, it could someday be different.

At first I took that fact only as a good thing.

She hadn't aged. She hadn't changed. So it was a good thing. I repeated that logic to myself over and over in that waiting room. The logic was sound. But my heart wouldn't follow the logic.

I tried to understand why my heart wouldn't follow. My mother mustn't be sick. My mother mustn't be sad. My mother mustn't fail to recognize me. And she had been none of those things. She had been exactly what I'd hoped for.

So why does this feel so strange.

I thought of the people back in our settlement. When they grew old, wrinkles gathered on their faces, their steps slowed, their hair whitened. I had once found that change sad. I had once imagined how my father's face might have changed, if he were still alive.

I used to think that change was proof of sorrow. But in that waiting room I was thinking the opposite. That not changing could be proof of sorrow too. That thought was so foreign to me that I erased it several times over.

. . .

Trying to find the answer, I went back over what my mother had said.

"…You've grown so much."

"…Your voice has deepened too."

Those words. My mother had seen exactly how I had changed. And yet she hadn't been surprised by that change. It was there, right then, that I first put my finger on the difference. Seeing a change and being surprised by a change were two different things.

I thought that day I wished there had been a mirror. I wanted to see my own face. I wanted to check for myself how much I had changed in seven years.

Later I saw my own face in the mirror at the lodging house. It was unfamiliar. Someone who recognizes an unfamiliar face and shows no reaction to that unfamiliarity at all. It was only then that I fully understood — that was my mother.

I thought back over the way she had looked at me, in that waiting room. I'd already written that there had been no surprise. More precisely, there had been, inside that gaze, both the recognition that "you've changed" and the acceptance that "I suppose you have," at the same time. There had been no gap at all between the two.

Anyone from our settlement would have had something come out of that gap. A gasp, a laugh, tears. That gap of being startled, "you've grown so much." My mother had no such gap. Recognition and acceptance were one body.

I tried, at the time, to tell myself that wasn't frightening, only different. Writing this record now, I admit that it was frightening.

. . .

I opened my hand and looked at my own palm.

There was a callus. A callus from digging wells. Something that hadn't been there seven years ago. I compared that hand to my mother's hand, in memory.

My mother's hand had wrinkles. Wrinkles that had already been there seven years ago. In that brief span I never got to check whether those wrinkles were the same or had grown. Later I regretted not checking.

I know now. Even if I had checked, they would have been exactly the same.

I folded and unfolded that hand again. I could feel the callus.

That feel struck me as unusually strange that day. It seemed like I was the only person in this whole city with a callused hand.

. . .

In that waiting room, for the first time, I said the word "exactly the same" out loud.

"…Exactly the same."

It was to myself. No one heard it. But saying it out loud made something come clear.

I had heard that phrase three times on the road to this city. From the peddler, from the old man, from the woman. All of them had only said "you'll see when you get there," and kept that phrase to themselves. It was in that waiting room that I first fully understood what it meant.

I don't resent those three people. I still don't. If they had heard this phrase beforehand, the way I had, they probably wouldn't have believed it either. Some words are just letters until you go through them yourself. That day I passed through the moment when those letters stopped being letters.

I counted back over those three moments. The peddler, the old man, the woman. All three had said it with the same expression.

I couldn't read that expression at the time. Now I could. It hadn't been a warning. It had been resignation.

Being exactly the same wasn't strange in itself. That, on its own, was a good thing. The problem was that the sameness left only me out.

I thought of the trees lining this city's streets. The tree outside the waiting-room window. The one whose leaves barely stirred even in the wind. I had guessed, back then, that it was the terrain, not the wind, that caused it. But another thought crossed my mind, right then.

Maybe those trees don't grow new leaves either. I knew that thought was a groundless leap, and I couldn't shake it anyway. In this city, the boundary between what changed and what didn't was too wide. People, trees, lamps — all of it crowded onto one side.

Only I had changed. My mother had stayed the same. The distance between us was exactly the same now as it had been seven years ago. But I had lived through all seven of those years, while my mother had stood outside them.

. . .

At that moment I made a strange calculation.

What if I came back seven years from now. If I saw my mother again at twenty-three. She would be exactly the same then too. I would go through something like this again. Only more apart.

Not seven years, but ten, twenty. I started that calculation and gave it up. I didn't stop because it frightened me. I stopped because there was no need to calculate. The result was already in.

That distance would never close. While I grew old, my mother would stay exactly where she was.

I turned that calculation into numbers. Seven years, then fourteen, then twenty-one. A picture where the gap widened with every multiple.

The picture was simple. But my heart couldn't accept that simplicity.

I pushed the calculation further. When I turned thirty. When I reached my uncle's age. When I was old someday and leaning on a cane. Even then I would come to this city, to this room, and face the exact same face of my mother that I faced now.

Picturing that gave me a strange feeling. It wasn't a frightening picture. But it wasn't a comfortable one either. I tried several words to name that feeling. It wasn't sorrow. Not exactly fear either. The closest word was misalignment. The sense that time itself was misaligned between my mother and me.

I laid that misalignment over something our well-master had once said. That you don't find water, you make it a way. Remembering that, I thought — in this city there was no need to make a way. Nothing needed to flow. My mother, the trees, the lamps — all of it was already standing still. Still water needs no way.

. . .

Thinking on that, another thought crossed my mind.

Is this really preservation, or is it something else.

I erased that question on the spot, right away. I thought of the notice I'd read in Chapter 5. The preserved converse, remember, judge. They do not disappear.

That was true. I don't doubt that fact. I still don't. My mother really had recognized me as me, really had remembered Gaon, really had brought up my father. All of that had been real.

But that realness and what I had wanted were wearing different shapes. That was the first day I felt that difference. I couldn't name it yet.

I went back over that notice from the information office, one line at a time. Does not judge. Asks for no qualification. Can be visited any time. Requires nothing new.

Requires nothing new. That day, for the first time, I truly chewed over that sentence. My mother really did require nothing new. The things I had brought her — that I had grown, that I had lived through seven years, the words I had meant to say — none of it filled any lack in her. Because she had no lack left to fill.

It was then that I first thought this: if the things I had brought weren't needed by her, then what had I even come all this way for.

I erased that question right away, on the spot. It was a frightening question. It would only be much later in this book that I would face that question head-on again.

Instead I fled into a different question. What would my brother be like. Would he be exactly the same as my mother too. I already knew the answer. My mother had said, "He hasn't changed one bit." And still, I didn't want to believe that answer until I checked it for myself.

Not wanting to believe is an odd phrase. I didn't want to believe a good thing. Not aging should have been a good thing. And yet, in that moment, I was hoping it wasn't. So that this feeling I had wouldn't be a strange one after all.

Sitting in that waiting-room chair, I opened the flask and took one more mouthful of water. My throat kept going dry. It was a thirst that felt less like a dry body than a dry heart.

That was the first time I felt this thirst. Since arriving in this city there had never been a shortage of water. And yet in that waiting room my throat burned strangely. I didn't know why, that day. Now I can guess. It was the body,

telling me — in place of the mind — that something was being lost. Not the body, but the heart.

The officer came back again and said,

"…Shall we go see your brother now?"

I came sharply back to myself at those words.

"…Yes."

Rising, I set aside, for now, the unfamiliar feeling I'd just had. This was time to meet my brother. I decided to take that feeling out again later.

I was used to setting feelings aside like that. It was a method much like counting. If I set something aside, I didn't have to think of it, at least for that moment.

But this time it didn't quite work. Even walking the corridor toward my brother, I couldn't shake that unfamiliar feeling entirely.

. . .

Walking the corridor, I looked out the window.

The sky was clear. That I was the only one for whom time flowed under that sky felt strangely frightening.

I've written several times now that I hadn't yet named this feeling. I can name it now. It was loneliness. The kind of loneliness you can feel surrounded by people, loved, even after meeting your family.

That was the day I first knew that loneliness. And I would go on carrying it with me to the end of this book.

Walking, I touched the flask. I didn't open the cap. I just ran my fingertips over its surface.

This flask was, even then, the one thing in this city that belonged to me alone. That fact felt unusually large to me that day. I was the only one whose body was changing, the only one who went thirsty, the only one who had to keep filling something. Holding that flask, I felt like the only living person in this city. I knew it was an illusion. I couldn't shake that illusion that day even so.

. . .

The officer walked ahead of me. Following behind her, I took one deep breath.

I thought, at the time, that this breath was to prepare for meeting my brother. Looking back now, it wasn't preparation. I simply didn't want to feel that misalignment I'd just discovered all over again, in front of my brother.

That wish wouldn't be granted. In a little while, I would come to face that misalignment again, in a far sharper shape. In a face that was still exactly eight years old, in a single sentence spoken up at me.

(Continued in Chapter 10.)

Chapter 10. My Brother

> *_Previously_ — After meeting his mother, Anemos sat in the waiting room and felt, for the first time, a misalignment. She was exactly the same as seven years ago, and that sameness pushed him into an unfamiliar loneliness. Now he goes to meet his brother.*

The officer opened the waiting-room door and said,

"…Shall we go now?"

I stood up. The chair I'd been sitting in still seemed to hold some warmth.

I begrudged that warmth, just for a moment. As long as I sat there, I didn't have to do anything.

The officer spoke to me as we walked.

"…Your brother likes to draw."

"…Draw?"

"…Yes. He draws every day."

I laughed a little at that. Even as a small child my brother had been good at drawing. With no paper, he'd always drawn with a stick in the dirt.

Right then I wondered whether the drawings in the dirt and the drawings now would turn out to be the same drawings.

We took a different corridor from the one that had led to my mother. Shorter, with only one window.

Walking that corridor, I counted the doors. There were two. My mother's corridor had had three. I wondered about that difference for a moment, then let it go. It wasn't a thing worth wondering about.

The corridor was quiet. Only my own footsteps sounded.

I've already written several times how loud that sound seemed to me. It was the same that day too. I was starting, now, to try to get used to that sound.

Following the officer, I tried to steady myself.

I told myself, walking: don't freeze up the way I did with my mother. It's fine if I can't say what I prepared — just look well at my brother's face. I held onto that resolve all the way to the end of the corridor.

At the door the officer said,

"…Go on in. He's waiting."

I took hold of the doorknob. The same cold I'd felt at my mother's door. I found that cold a little less unfamiliar this time.

The door opened.

I remember that moment exactly, even now. Inside the room, at the window, a small child was standing.

Eight years old.

The floor was marked with several lines. They looked drawn with fingers, not sticks. Circles and triangles, and shapes I couldn't make out.

Right then I thought of what the officer had said earlier. That he drew every day. In this room with no paper, no sticks, my brother had been drawing on the

floor with his fingers. Even the method was exactly the same as it had been outside.

. . .

Seeing that face, I stopped breathing for a moment.

It was my brother. Exactly, completely, the brother I remembered. His face, his height, the way he stood.

Even up until I stepped into that room, some part of me had still been imagining otherwise. That he'd have grown a little. That his voice, at least, would have changed. I learned how wrong that imagining had been the moment I opened the door.

My brother had been small-bodied from birth. My mother had once said it was because he was born late. Whenever I'd seen that small body I used to worry. It seemed like he wasn't growing the way other children did.

In that room I thought of that worry again. And I understood, at the same time, how pointless it had been. My brother no longer needed to grow bigger. He was no longer a body that would grow.

I looked around the room once more. One window, two chairs. The same arrangement as my mother's room.

I wasn't even surprised by that sameness anymore. It seemed this city had built every visiting room the same size, the same shape. Only the people were different; the rooms were all the same.

I'd written in Chapter 1 that my brother was afraid of water. Stepping into that room, I found myself listening, out of reflex, for the sound of water. There was none. This room had no water either.

My brother saw me. His eyes went wide.

I tried to find some trace of unfamiliarity in that look. Even the briefest flicker.

There was none. My brother knew me without a moment's hesitation. It was a look like someone seeing a person he had met yesterday.

. . .

"…Brother?"

That voice was exactly the same too. An eight-year-old's voice. The very voice I had failed to call to mind, back in Chapter 7.

"…Yeah. It's me."

My brother came toward me. Small steps. I counted them. Six steps. Exactly six steps to cross the room.

I don't remember how many steps it had taken in my mother's room. I hadn't counted. I hadn't had the presence of mind to count, that day. In front of my brother, I had returned to being someone who could count again.

My brother stopped in front of me. And looked up at me.

. . .

He looked up at me for a long time.

Starting from my face, down to my shoulders, and back down again to my feet.

I felt my own body anew, following that gaze. A sixteen-year-old's body. A body two heads taller than my brother's.

My brother said,

"…Brother, you got taller."

. . .

At that one line, I couldn't say anything at all.

I've tried, more times than anything else in this record, to write this line over again. Every time, I failed. Whatever explanation I put in front of that line, it fell short. So I'll just write it plainly, like this.

Brother, you got taller.

That was true. I really had grown. Nine-year-old me had become sixteen. But the mouth that had said it was still, exactly, an eight-year-old's mouth. In that moment I understood that seven years had passed between the two of us carrying completely different weights.

I stood there holding onto that line for a long time. My brother stood quietly looking up at me while I said nothing.

I couldn't count how many seconds that silence lasted. That was the one moment that day I failed to count. I've written several times that counting was how I protected myself. That method didn't work in that moment.

. . .

My brother took my hand. A small hand.

I remember the size of that hand. Exactly the same size as seven years ago. My own hand had grown about twice as big in that time.

"…Brother, why did you come so late?"

I couldn't answer that question. I didn't know how to explain seven years to an eight-year-old.

"…Sorry."

"…It's okay. You're here now."

My brother said that and smiled. A smile with no resentment in it at all.

I was grateful for that smile. And at the same time, it broke me. If there had been resentment, it might have been easier. Resentment is proof that time has passed. This smile had no time in it.

I took my brother's hand in mine. And held that small hand still, inside my own.

I didn't want to let go of that hand. It felt like if I let go, this moment would end.

. . .

We sat for a while in two chairs. A room much like the one where I'd met my mother.

"…Brother, want to see this?" my brother said.

He showed me a small stone. I'd seen it before. The stone he'd picked up beside our well back in the settlement.

"…You still have this?"

"…Yeah. I always carry it."

I took the stone in my hand. Exactly the same weight as seven years ago.

Everything was exactly the same. The stone, the hand, the smile, the height. In that moment I confirmed again how exact the misalignment I'd felt with my mother had been. In front of my brother that feeling grew even sharper. The distance between eight and sixteen was crueler than the distance between nine and sixteen.

"…Brother, I draw every day." my brother said. "On the floor. I draw this, and that."

"…Isn't it boring?"

My brother tilted his head.

"…What's 'boring'?"

I couldn't answer that question. It wasn't a question an eight-year-old should be asking back.

Right then I remembered something my mother had said. He doesn't really use the word "bored," that child. I had just let that pass at the time. Now I understood what it meant. My brother didn't know the word "boring" itself. Not that he didn't know it, exactly — he had never experienced the feeling that word pointed to.

My brother pointed at one of the drawings on the floor.

"…Know what this is?"

I looked closely at the drawing. A circle, with two lines running down from it.

"…Is it a well?"

"…Right. I drew you making a well."

I laughed at that. My brother didn't know I had learned to dig wells. There was no way for him to know.

Right then a chill ran through me. What my brother had drawn was our old settlement's well. And yet those words sounded as though he'd drawn it knowing what I was doing right now. I still think it was coincidence. Only, that day, the coincidence didn't feel like coincidence.

"…Brother, remember the sound of the bucket?" my brother asked.

"…Yeah. I remember."

"…I'm not scared anymore."

I couldn't respond to that at all. My brother said it as though it were nothing. As though talking about something that had happened yesterday.

I understood, then. For my brother, that fear, and the moment he'd overcome it, weren't seven years past — they were simply recent. Time hadn't been compressed. It hadn't flowed at all.

. . .

"…Are you a grown-up now, Brother?" my brother asked.

"…Not yet. But I'm your big brother."

"…You're my brother, so you're my brother."

My brother said that, laughing. Strangely, that answer comforted me.

Eight-year-olds understand that well. That a relationship comes before a number. A brother is a brother because he's a brother. That simplicity held me up a little, in that moment.

"…Brother, it's the same here every day." my brother said suddenly.

"…What is?"

"…When I wake up in the morning, I'm here, and before I sleep, I'm here. It's always here."

I didn't know what to say to that.

"…You didn't ask if I was bored." I finally managed.

"…You asked that already, Brother."

"…Oh, right."

My brother laughed at that. I tried to laugh along, but it didn't quite work.

I held onto what my brother had said for a long time after. Always here. There was no resentment in those words, no weariness. Just a voice stating a fact. That voice was the most frightening thing of all.

My brother pointed at my flask.

"…What's that?"

"…A water flask. My uncle gave it to me."

"…Is it heavy?"

"…No. Not really."

My brother held out his hand, so I passed him the flask. He held it with both hands, like cradling it.

"…Brother, can I have this?"

I paused for a moment at that.

"…I need this for the road here..."

"…Oh, I see."

My brother handed the flask back without a fuss. Not the slightest trace of disappointment.

That easy acceptance stuck with me strangely. An eight-year-old who felt nothing at all when he couldn't have something he wanted. I had never seen an eight-year-old like that. The children in our settlement cried or threw fits when they couldn't have something. My brother used to be like that too. Not anymore.

I tried to recall the words I'd prepared. But none of them came to me. The words that had scattered in front of my mother felt, in front of my brother, like they had never even existed.

Let's go together now. I couldn't say those five words to my brother either. I couldn't. The child sitting in front of me wasn't a nine-year-old brother — he was an eight-year-old brother. I didn't know what I would even need to explain to him.

I felt for the paper inside my shirt again. I didn't take it out.

I didn't even think, in that room, about taking that paper out. In my mother's room I had at least considered it, briefly. In front of my brother, that consideration didn't even arise. I fully understood, in that room, that some words simply aren't the kind that can be prepared.

"…Brother, next time I'll show you another drawing." my brother said.

"…Okay. I'll look forward to it."

I think back, later, on how easily that answer came out. I'll look forward to it. I said it with no weight at all. I didn't know then how heavy a promise it would become.

. . .

I heard again that time was up.

My brother didn't want to let go of my hand.

"…You'll come again, right?"

"…Yes. I'll come again."

"…Soon?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…As soon as I can."

My brother, satisfied with that answer, let go of my hand.

I knew, right then, that "as soon as I can" was a heavy promise to me, and just a parting phrase to my brother. To him, soon or late made no real difference. Time didn't brush past that child.

My brother stood up and held me once. His arms didn't even reach my waist.

I gauged the height of that embrace. Seven years ago it had reached my legs. Now it didn't even reach my waist. I knew that calculation was strange. My

brother's height hadn't changed at all. It was the calculation that kept changing. What was changing was me.

. . .

Leaving through the door, I turned to look at my brother once more.

He stood at the window, waving. An eight-year-old's wave.

I came down the stairs watching that wave. I tried to count the steps. I couldn't. That was the first time numbers failed to help me.

Outside, I gripped the flask tightly. I didn't open the cap.

That afternoon, for the first time since arriving in this city, I felt completely lost. I had set out to find my family, and now, standing in front of that very family, I didn't know where I was supposed to go.

Only then did I open the flask's cap. I took a mouthful of water. It wasn't that I was thirsty. My hands just needed something to do.

That night, lying in the lodging house, I thought again of my brother's one line. Brother, you got taller. I repeated it to myself three more times before falling asleep. On the third time, I cried out loud for the first time.

(Continued in Chapter 11.)

Chapter 11. The Second Visit

> *_Previously_ — At his first visit with his brother, Anemos was undone by one line: "Brother, you got taller." That night, in the lodging house, he cried out loud for the first time. A few days passed. He decided to apply for another visit.*

I waited three days, then applied for a second visit.

Three days. I still remember that number exactly. The first day simply passed. On the second, I held the application in my hand but couldn't make it to the counter. It was only on the morning of the third day that I finally submitted it.

The officer was a young woman again. I couldn't be sure it was the same one. I didn't really look at her face that day.

"…How long will it take?" I asked.

I had asked that same question, word for word, back in Chapter 7. This time, I felt like I knew the answer before I even heard it.

"…About half an hour."

It was exactly the same answer.

Right then I thought of the older man from Chapter 7. That face with every expression used up. I know exactly now what had caused that face. He must have heard this same answer any number of times. The same half hour, every time.

. . .

I sat in the waiting room. I didn't take out the paper. This time, I had no prepared words.

To be precise, I did have one. Just one. Let's go together now. I still carried those words. Only, I had no wish to write them on paper again and set them in order.

Through the window I could see that tree. The one whose leaves barely stirred even in the wind.

Confirming the tree was exactly the same, I laughed a little. I felt like I could count the leaves one by one. In fact I did. Just as before, the officer came when I reached twenty.

"…Ready now."

I stood up. My hands didn't tremble this time.

I thought, at the time, it was because I'd grown used to it. I think differently now. Trembling comes from expectation. That morning I already knew what I was about to see.

. . .

The corridor was exactly the same. Three doors, the middle one.

The officer said, from behind me,

"…Take your time."

That line was exactly the same too. I wrote, in Chapter 8, how strangely kind that line had felt. Hearing it a second time, something else came before the

kindness. This line was part of the procedure. Words said at this exact spot, every time.

I pushed the door.

. . .

The room was small. There was one window, and sunlight was coming in. Two chairs stood facing each other.

My mother was sitting in one of them.

I wrote that same sentence in Chapter 8. There was no reason to write it differently. What I saw that day was exactly that.

She saw me and stood up.

"…Anemos."

"…Mom."

Right there I noticed that even the order those two words came out in was the same as last time. She said my name first, and I said Mom after.

. . .

She came to me and cupped my face in both hands.

"…You've grown so much."

I froze a little at that.

I had come back after only three days. There was no way I could have grown taller in three days. I did the math right there. There wasn't. There really wasn't.

"…Yes." I answered, exactly as before.

"…Have you been eating well?"

"…Yes, I've been eating well."

She looked me over for a long time. Up and down, from my face to my feet.

"…Your voice has deepened too."

There was no way my voice could have deepened in three days either. A chill ran down my spine the moment I heard that. My mother was looking at me. Looking at me exactly. But that looking wasn't directed at the me standing there now. Words meant for a son she'd parted with seven years ago were coming out again, unchanged.

She noticed the flask slung over my shoulder and tapped it lightly with her fingertips.

"…What's this?"

"…A water flask. My uncle gave it to me."

"…Did you think you couldn't get here without water?"

"…Just habit, I guess."

Even as I gave that answer, I silently said the next line to myself in advance. Same as ever, you. Even as a child you always carried everything you needed. I already knew it before it was even said.

She smiled a little at my answer.

"…Same as ever, you." she said. "Even as a child you always carried everything you needed."

It was exact.

. . .

"…Sit." she said.

I sat in the chair across from her. She took my hand. It was warm.

"…Are you all right?" I asked. "Does it hurt?"

"…No, it doesn't hurt at all."

"…Is anything hard?"

"…No. Everything's fine."

I wrote these four lines in Chapter 8 without changing a single word. Copying them out again now, I still can't find a place to change. That day, these four lines really did come out exactly the same.

"…Weren't you scared?" I asked. "Back then, when the fever got bad and you had to lie down."

She thought for a moment, then said,

"…I think I was scared. But I don't remember it well."

"…You don't?"

"…The feeling from back then is blurry. Because now I'm not scared at all."

Listening to that answer, I pressed my fingernails into my palm.

I wanted to confirm, right then, whether this was really the same, or whether I was forcing something similar to overlap in my mind. The pain in my palm was real. And yet my mother's words, as vivid as that pain, were words I'd heard somewhere before. From that moment on, I was certain.

. . .

"…Did you know I was coming all the way here?" I asked.

"…No, I didn't know. But it's not a surprise."

"…Why?"

"…Because you're the kind of child who'd come."

Even that answer. I hadn't expected even that answer to be the same. This was a line that came out even when the question changed. I had thought I'd asked a slightly different question from three days ago. And yet the answer wasn't different in the least.

"…Did you miss me?" I asked.

She paused a moment at that question.

"…Yes. I missed you."

I even counted the length of that pause.

One, two. In Chapter 8 too, I had felt that pause. I hadn't counted how long it was, then. This time I counted. It was two. Exactly two.

. . .

We talked a little more. About Gaon, about the lodging house, about the person next door. Talking about those things, I tried guessing her answers ahead of time, one by one.

Every time my guess was right, I felt a strange feeling. It wasn't joy. It wasn't relief either. It was closer, if anything, to fear. I knew what would come out of my mother's mouth before she said it.

Once, I deliberately asked something different.

"…Mom, I've been thinking about something lately."

That was the first time I'd said that. It was something I hadn't said last time. I was curious what kind of reaction it would draw.

"…What kind of thing?" she asked.

I couldn't answer. Since it wasn't a question I'd prepared for, the words stuck on my end.

"…Never mind."

She nodded. She didn't press.

That part was exactly like Chapter 8. That day I learned that even throwing in something new only brought us back to the same old place. The problem wasn't my mother. She was always standing in the same place. It was I who threw in something new, and yet that newness kept getting absorbed back into place.

I tried another question.

"…How is it, staying here?"

"…Good. Everything's good."

"…Isn't it boring?"

"…What is there to be bored of."

I had already known that answer too. She had said those exact words in Chapter 8. Hearing it again, I fully accepted that it made no difference how I changed the question. It wasn't the question that was fixed — it was the answer.

I wondered whether the subject of my father would come up again.

"…You must have thought of your father a lot too." she said first.

I had known that line was coming. It was the exact line she had raised first, back in Chapter 8. I deliberately said nothing and waited. I wanted to see whether she'd really bring it up first, on her own.

"…Do you remember his face?" she asked.

"…It's a little blurry."

"…That can happen."

All three lines were exactly the same. I had thought, in Chapter 8, that calm was because she was strong. I know it differently now. It wasn't strength — it was a fixed place. In front of that question, she always stood in the exact same spot.

. . .

The officer opened the door a little and said,

"…Time's up."

She didn't let go of my hand, and said,

"…Come again."

"…Yes."

"…Let's talk more next time."

Next time. I had heard that word before too. Next time was always pushed off to a further next time. I started to count how many "next times" this would end up being, and gave it up.

At the door she held me once. Her embrace was exactly as I remembered. Same warmth, same strength.

"…Bye now."

I stopped in my tracks at those two words.

In Chapter 8 I wrote that I hadn't thought, at the time, how strange that farewell was — how it was exactly what you'd say to someone you'd met yesterday, even though it had been seven years. This time, I really hadn't met her yesterday. Only three days had passed. And yet the farewell wasn't different in the least. Only then did I understand. That farewell had nothing to do with time. Whether seven years or three days, to my mother it was the same distance, no different at all.

. . .

I came back out to the waiting room and sat down.

Sitting there, I tried, for the first time, to put into words what I'd just seen. The same greeting, the same order, the same pause, the same smile. I counted through that list in my head, up to ten, and stopped. Not because there was nothing more to count, but because I felt that counting further would be frightening.

The officer came over and said,

"…Shall we go see your brother too?"

I nodded.

The officer spoke again as we walked.

"…Your brother likes to draw."

I had heard that same line before. Not a single particle different. Right then I realized this line was something like a script. Not words the officer was saying to me now, but words attached to the procedure itself.

. . .

The way to my brother's room was short. I stopped for a moment in front of the door.

By then I half-knew what would happen when I opened that door. And still, I opened it. I learned, for the first time that day, that opening a door knowing and opening it not knowing are two different things.

The door opened. My brother was standing at the window.

His eyes went wide at the sight of me. He came toward me. I didn't count his steps this time. There was no need. I already knew it would be six.

He stopped in front of me and looked up at me.

"…Brother, you got taller."

. . .

I couldn't breathe at those words.

The exact same words as three days ago. There was no way I could have grown taller in three days. My brother didn't know that. Or rather, it wasn't that he didn't know — it didn't matter to him. This line came from the same place, always, whether three days had passed or seven years.

This one line shook me more than my mother's "you've grown so much" had. Her words had sounded like inertia. My brother's were different. He was really looking up at me, really feeling that way, and really saying it because of that feeling. And yet the exact same feeling as three days ago was being manufactured, fresh, right there.

I understood, then. This wasn't repetition. It was, every time, the first time. To my brother, I really did look, every time, like I was being seen for the first time. Three days apart or seven years apart weighed exactly the same inside him — new. And that newness carried no memory.

My brother took my hand.

"…Brother, you came again."

"…Yeah."

"…That was fast."

"…Yeah." was all I answered.

I couldn't add anything after that short answer. There was nothing to add. I wanted to say that I'd come back after only three days, but I had no idea what that would even mean to him.

. . .

The visit was shorter than last time. I didn't say much. My brother didn't say much either. We just sat there holding hands.

I heard that time was up.

"…You'll come again, right?" my brother asked.

"…Yes. I'll come again."

Giving that answer, I doubted the weight of those words for the first time. I'll come again. How many times had I said that now. I started to count and gave it up.

Leaving through the door, I turned to look at my brother once more. He was waving. The same gesture as last time.

I even felt the angle of that wave was the same as last time. The slight bend of the wrist, the speed his fingers opened. I knew that was a leap, and I still couldn't stop myself from feeling it.

. . .

Outside, I walked the road back to the lodging house.

Walking that road, I kept thinking the same thought. Everything I had seen today was exactly what I had seen three days ago. The order, the words, even

the length of the pauses. I started to calculate the odds of that being coincidence, and gave it up. I already knew it wasn't coincidence.

Only when I reached the lodging house did I stop. I opened the flask and took a mouthful of water.

That night before I fell asleep, I thought this. If I go next time, it will be exactly the same again. And the time after that, exactly the same again. I couldn't tell whether that thought was sad or frightening. But one thing was clear. I was already dreading the next visit.

That night I thought again of something my uncle had said. If you go, you have to see it, don't you. I hadn't understood those words, walking the four days here. Now I thought I understood a little. My uncle had already known about this repetition. What it meant to see the same thing, every single time.

Even so, I decided not to give up on the next visit. Not yet.

I added that day's visit to the count. One, two.

I didn't know, then, when that number would stop.

(Continued in Chapter 12.)

Chapter 12. I Couldn't Apply

> *_Previously_ — The second visit hadn't differed from the first by a single word. The same greeting, the same pause, the same farewell. That night, though he was already dreading the next visit, Anemos decided not to give up. Not yet.*

I let several days after that simply slip by.

I didn't count exactly how many days. Numbers show up this often in this record, and yet those days alone I couldn't count. It felt like counting them would mean deciding something, so I deliberately didn't.

I spent more time lying in the lodging house, staring at the ceiling. I hung the flask on the wall. Those days had the longest stretch, in all this time, of it not being in my hand.

The person next door knocked a few times. I only answered, and didn't go out.

"…Are you all right?" the person next door asked.

"…Yes. Just a little tired, is all."

It wasn't a lie. But it wasn't a complete answer either. I've written several times now that no one in this city tells lies. Over those days, I learned for the first time that you could go without lying and still not be honest.

The person next door came once more after that.

"…Have you eaten?" they asked.

"…Yes."

That was a complete lie. I hadn't eaten anything that day. In that moment I realized, for the first time since coming to this city, that I had told a complete lie. Trying to imitate the people of this city, I found I wasn't, after all, a person of this city.

In those few days, I went as far as that building's entrance twice.

The first was on the second day. I made it to the door, and then, seeing someone come out from inside, turned right back around. It wasn't anyone I knew. Just a stranger. I was afraid to see that person's face.

Even now I don't know exactly what that fear was. Maybe I was afraid of seeing what expression that person had just come out wearing. Something like the face of that older man from Chapter 7.

The second was on the fourth day. This time I got as far as taking hold of the doorknob. And let go.

I remember the feel of that doorknob. Cold, much like the one I'd felt at my mother's door. I took my hand off that cold.

I told no one about those two failures. Not the person next door, not the officer.

Over those days I thought of that older man from Chapter 7 many times. Three times in three years. I recalculated that number. I'd only gone twice so far. And already I was standing here, stuck in front of a third. By that math, I was faster than he was.

That calculation frightened me. The first time I saw that man, I'd thought he was a different kind of person from me. Someone who'd become that way from being worn down, from age, from years gone by. Over those days I came to see that thought had been wrong. He, too, must have started out exactly like me.

. . .

One morning I got up and packed the flask again.

I'd like to write that decision as some great resolve. In truth it wasn't. I got up simply because I couldn't lie there any longer. It felt like if I kept lying there, I would never go again.

I decided to apply for a third visit.

Three. I said that number to myself, once, in my head. One and two I had already counted. I thought it only natural to carry that number forward. I didn't know, then, how far from natural that was.

. . .

The application counter was in a different building from the waiting room. I'd passed that counter once, back when I first arrived in this city. At the time I'd thought it was just part of the information office.

A tree stood in front of the building. Much like the one I'd seen through the waiting-room window.

That day was unusually clear. I had never once seen bad weather in this city. No rain, no overcast sky, no strong wind. Every day, a sky of about the same brightness.

I thought even the weather was true to this city's nature. A place where nothing changed suddenly. Even the weather was like that.

I stopped for a moment in front of that tree. I thought about counting the leaves and gave it up. That day, counting felt meaningless. I didn't know, then, why that feeling came over me.

I stood a little longer in front of the door. Not going in, not leaving either.

Those few minutes are the ones I've gone back over more than any other, since. Standing in front of that door for those few minutes was, I think now, the real substance of this whole chapter. Everything else was only the result of those few minutes.

Standing at that door, I thought of the old man I'd met on the road to this city. The old man I wrote about in Chapter 1. The one who'd said his own family had someone here too.

"…Do you visit?"

"…I did, at first."

"…And now?"

"…I don't go."

I've already written that I didn't understand that answer when I heard it on the four-day road here. Standing in front of that door, in that moment, I understood that answer in my body. I had thought not going and not being able to go were different things. That day I learned how close the two really are.

. . .

I pushed the door open and went in.

There was no line at the counter. A clerk was sorting paperwork.

Seeing that empty line, I finally noticed. People applying for something new in this city, at all, were rare. Everyone here already lived according to what was

fixed. Filling out an application meant you meant to change something. In this city, there wasn't much left to change.

"…Here to apply?" the clerk asked.

"…Yes. For a visit."

"…Which visit is this?"

"…The third."

The clerk nodded and took a sheet of paper from a drawer.

"…Write your name here, and the name of the person you're visiting. Simple."

Simple. I laughed a little inside at that word. I had never seen a procedure in this city that wasn't simple. Visits were simple. Rations were simple. Simple, here, wasn't praise — it was just a word describing a fact.

At the next window, someone was handing over another form. Something like a ration change request. That person handed it over and turned to leave in under thirty seconds.

I envied those thirty seconds. I think, by then, I already knew my own paper wasn't going to finish inside thirty seconds.

. . .

I took the paper and went to a small desk off to the side. There was one chair. I sat down.

A pen lay there. I picked it up.

There was nothing else on the desk. One inkwell, a few sheets of paper. I thought that plainness resembled the visiting room I'd described in Chapter 8. This city put in each room only exactly what was needed.

I had thought that restraint was consideration — meant to make deciding easier for a person. I see it differently now. It wasn't consideration. It was this city's nature. Here, there simply wasn't much that was needed to begin with.

The space for a name was at the top. I set the tip of the pen there.

Up to that moment I still thought there was no problem at all. Write my name, write the name of the person I was visiting, submit it, and that was that. I had already done that exact sequence twice. Nothing hard about it.

But the pen wouldn't move.

I tried, right there, to find the reason. My hand wasn't hurt. There was nothing wrong with the paper. I simply couldn't draw the next stroke.

I clenched and unclenched my hand a few times. My fingers moved just fine. The problem wasn't my fingers.

I've since put it this way to myself. My hand was fine. Some nameless part, one I can't even quite call the heart, wouldn't move. I still haven't found a name for that part.

. . .

Right then, a great many things passed through my head all at once. In no order.

My mother's "you've grown so much." Those words I'd heard again after only three days.

My brother's "Brother, you got taller." The line I've tried and failed, more times than any other in this record, to write again.

"…Bye now," heard at the end of the second visit. The two words that hadn't differed in the slightest from seven years before.

"…Because you're the kind of child who'd come." My mother had said those words identically, both times.

And my brother, touching the flask, asking, "…Brother, can I have this?"

"…Exactly the same." The words I'd said to myself in the waiting room came back to me too. From Chapter 9.

And the five words I had prepared for seven years. Let's go together now. I had never once managed to bring that phrase fully out into the open air.

I looked at the blank space on the paper. Anemos. I knew exactly how long it would take to write those letters. About twenty strokes, and it would be done.

I couldn't make those twenty strokes.

I took one deep breath. The same breath I'd taken before opening the door in Chapter 7.

Back then, that breath had opened the next door. This time it didn't. I didn't know the difference in that moment. The breath had the same shape, but the place it carried me to was the exact opposite.

. . .

I began the first letter.

I drew one circle.

And stopped there.

I looked at that circle for a long time. It was an unfinished letter. Not the start of my name, not the end — just one circle. Right then I thought that circle looked exactly like me. A shape that pretends to be the start of something, when really it leads nowhere at all.

I sat there for a long while, still holding the pen.

I tried to count that stretch of time. I couldn't. It was the second moment I failed to count. The first had been in front of my brother. This time I was alone.

. . .

I set the pen down.

I folded the paper again and slid it back toward the counter.

The clerk took it. Asked nothing. Just took it and put it in the drawer.

I've said, many times since, that that moment was the most frightening one of that day. If someone had asked why, I would have made up some answer or other. Because no one asked, I didn't have to give myself an answer either.

"…Come back another time." the clerk said. Not an angry voice, not a sympathetic one. Just a voice explaining procedure.

"…Yes."

I barely managed that one word.

"…Is there any way to know ahead of time, next time?" I asked, mumbling it out. It was a question with no meaning behind it. I just felt like I had to say

something.

"…It is possible at any time." the clerk said.

That line. I had already written it down at the end of Chapter 1. It is possible at any time. I had read that line in the bulletin for seven years. I wrote then that it was a kind and a frightening thing at once. Hearing it spoken directly at that counter that day, I felt both of those meanings again, all at once.

. . .

I couldn't explain, right there, why I had done that.

Even writing this record now, I still can't, completely.

Since that day I've been asked this question many times again. By myself. Each time the answer came out a little differently, and each time it ended up back at the same place in the end. I don't know. That was the most honest answer.

It wasn't that I was afraid of my mother. It wasn't that I was afraid of my brother either. I still loved those two people. I love them now. But apart from that love, my hand simply would not move on that paper.

I didn't know then that these two things might be the same. Loving someone, and confirming that love once more by repeating it in exactly, precisely the same shape. I would only come to understand the difference between the two much later in this record.

. . .

I turned around.

Leaving the counter, I didn't look back.

I still sometimes imagine what that retreating back must have looked like. A sixteen-year-old with a flask on his shoulder, walking out and leaving the form behind. I've never seen that back with my own eyes. But what I did that day was, exactly, one thing.

I did nothing.

I pushed the door open and stepped outside. The tree was still standing right there. I never did count how many leaves it had.

I stood under that tree for a moment. I had no idea where to go.

Right then, for the first time, I truly felt that I had nowhere at all to go in this city. Not the lodging house, not my mother's room, not my brother's room — none of them, right then, was where I wanted to go. I just stood there and breathed.

A few people came and went from that building. Every one of them went in faster and came out faster than I had. Some came out without any paper in hand. Probably they'd come for some other business, not to apply, the way I had.

Watching them, I tried to figure out how long I'd been inside that building. I couldn't. I had no sense of how the time had passed. That was the first day I lost track of time. In a way different from counting.

Part One of this book ends here. I know that's a strange place to end it. Nothing happened, after all. No one was hurt, nothing was broken. I simply turned away from a counter.

And yet I think that turning away was, of everything I had done in this city up to then, the most honest act. I didn't know, in that moment, what I should do.

And I didn't hide the fact that I didn't know. At least for that moment.

That night I didn't open the flask's cap. Even though my throat was dry, I didn't open it.

I decided to just let that thirst be. Not doing something was, that day, the only choice left to me.

That night, before I fell asleep, I thought of just one thing. I hadn't accomplished a single one of the reasons I'd come to this city. And yet strangely, that night, it didn't feel so heavy.

That very lack of heaviness was the strangest part of all. And I fell asleep holding onto that strangeness.

I didn't know, then, that this lack of heaviness would take on another name in the part to come. I won't say that name here first.

(Continued in Part Two.)

The Dry Valley, Part Two

Release

Chapter 13. Fifteen Years Old

> *_Previously_ — I went to apply for a third visit. I took the form from*
> *the window. And then I couldn't write on it, and I turned away. I couldn't explain to myself why.*

It wasn't that my hand shook.

To be precise, my hand was fine. I held the pen properly. I got as far as the line for my name. I started the first letter of Anemos, and stopped there.

I tried, right then, to find the reason I'd stopped. It wasn't that my mother's face had come to me. It wasn't that my brother's face had come to me. It was the opposite, actually. No face came at all. What I'd heard at the second visit and what I'd heard at the first played back, identical, only in a different order.

I didn't know this then. I know it now. What stopped me in front of that third application wasn't fear. It was that I already knew the result. My body knew, before I did, that the third time wouldn't be any different from the first, and it stood my hand still.

I set the pen down and pushed the form back toward the window. The clerk took it without asking anything. That was the most frightening moment of the whole day. No one stopped me.

After I turned away, I had nowhere to go.

I didn't want to go back to the lodging. I felt like if I went there I'd only think about the form again. Instead I walked toward the plazas. The Preserve had several, and they all looked more or less the same. There were benches, there were trees, and no one ever ran.

I tried, later, to count those plazas. I couldn't. They all looked so alike that I lost track of how far I'd gotten. It was the first time in that city that counting something had failed me.

As I walked I kept folding and unfolding the form in my hand. The clerk hadn't said a word. Even when I'd pushed the form back across the counter, no one had asked why. They'd just taken it and put it in a drawer. That was stranger, somehow. If someone had asked me something, I could have had an answer ready.

I thought a long time about that clerk's blank face. I learned later. Here, it isn't rare for someone to change their mind. No — more precisely, changing your mind isn't really a thing that happens much at all. Everyone lives by what they first decided. By this city's standard, my turning away from that window was probably the rare thing.

I passed about three plazas. People went by. Everyone's stride was about the same. Not fast, not slow. I didn't see a single person running. It seemed like there was simply nothing to run for. It was a city with no lateness, nothing to chase, nothing to flee.

Among those strides I felt how different mine was. I still walked fast. It was a habit from outside. When you went to draw water, you had to walk fast. If you were late, everyone else had already used up the well.

At the fourth plaza I found a bench. It was in the shade of a tree. I sat down there.

I still had the water flask with me. The one my uncle had packed for me. I was the only person in this city who drew water at the ration station and carried it strapped to my waist. Everyone else had no need to.

I sat on the bench. I opened and closed the flask's cap, opened and closed it. It was another habit I had instead of counting. Open, shut. Open, shut.

"…Why do you carry that around?"

I looked up.

. . .

It was a girl. She looked about my age. She was standing beside the bench, looking at my flask. There was nothing strange in the face asking the question. Not mocking, not worried either. Just a face that was curious.

"…To drink."

"…Water?"

"…Yes."

She tilted her head. It really was a face that didn't understand.

"…If you're thirsty you can just go to a ration station."

"…Sometimes I get thirsty while I'm out walking around."

"…Ah."

She didn't look satisfied with that answer. But she didn't press further either. She just sat down beside me. She hadn't asked if it was all right, she'd just sat, and strangely, it didn't feel uncomfortable.

I learned later that this was something everyone in that city had in common. They don't ask permission. Situations that call for permission almost never arise there. Taking someone's seat, taking someone's time — both are rare here.

"…I'm Eikon."

"…I'm Anemos."

"…That's an outside name."

"…Yes."

I didn't ask how she knew that. She must have known from the flask.

. . .

"…You're not from here." Eikon said.

"…No. I came for a visit."

"…Who?"

"…My mother and my brother."

Eikon nodded. There was no surprise in the nod. It meant people coming for visits was common.

"…I came for a visit too. Here." I said it again. "…originally."

"…And now you're not?"

"…I don't know."

Eikon didn't think the answer was strange. She just waited for the next thing. I couldn't say anything more. She didn't push either.

I remember that silence. Outside, if someone sat quietly next to you for that long, you'd feel awkward and say something just to fill it. Eikon didn't. She seemed like a person with no reason to feel awkward.

After a good while, I asked,

"…How long have you been here, Eikon?"

"…Seven years."

I was startled by the number. It was exactly the year my family had been preserved.

"…So how old are you?"

"…Fifteen."

"…Even seven years ago?"

"…Yes. I was fifteen then too."

. . .

It took me a moment to understand what that meant. I'd known, in principle. That being preserved means you don't age. My mother and my brother were the same. But those were family, and family was the side I'd wanted, wanted with all my longing, to stay unchanged.

This girl was a stranger. A stranger staying at exactly the same age for seven years was strange in a different way.

"…Is it strange?" Eikon asked. She seemed to have caught it from my face.

"…No. Just."

"…It's fine. Everyone finds it strange at first."

That way of talking stayed with me. It wasn't a hurt tone. It was an explaining tone. As if she'd organized a reaction she'd seen many times before and was simply informing me of it.

"…I'm sixteen now." I said. "My birthday passed not long ago."

"…So last year we would have been the same age."

I couldn't do that math in the moment. Eikon did it first.

"…When I was fifteen. I've stayed fifteen the whole time, and you must have been fifteen last year too."

"…That's right."

"…So we were the same age last year. Now I'm a year younger."

She said it laughing. It was a laugh that found the thing genuinely funny. I couldn't laugh.

I did the math again right there. It was correct. A year ago we would have been the same age. But in that year, only I had moved. She had stayed exactly where she was. I had, in effect, passed her by.

Whether passing her by was a good thing, I didn't know then. I still don't, really, now.

. . .

"…What are you thinking about?" Eikon asked.

"…Nothing."

"…Your face is complicated."

The observation was accurate, so I couldn't say anything. Eikon looked at my face for a while, then, as if she didn't much care either way, turned her eyes back to the flask.

"…What do you do here, Eikon? All day."

"…Various things. Meeting people, walking, looking around."

"…You don't work?"

"…There's not really anything to do. There's not much here that needs making."

"…So aren't you bored?"

Eikon smiled a little at the question. It wasn't a mocking smile. It was an amused one.

"…It's been a while since I've heard the word bored."

I found the answer strange. It didn't sound like she didn't know what bored meant — it sounded like she simply hadn't had occasion to hear the word.

"…Did you used to know?"

"…Yes. Before I came here."

"…And now?"

Eikon looked up at the sky for a moment. Not a face searching for something — more like a face just resting its eyes.

"…I guess now there's no reason to be bored."

I turned that answer over late into that night. No reason. As if she meant boredom, and being tired of things, were feelings that only arose when there was a reason for them. Outside, you got bored even with no reason. Here, it seemed, without a reason nothing arose at all.

"…Want to try a sip?"

I opened the cap and held it out. Eikon took it and drank. One sip.

"…How does it taste?" I asked.

Eikon made a face like she was thinking for a moment.

"…Just like water."

"…Isn't it strange, though? Isn't this the first water you've had in seven years?"

"…What would be strange about it. Water's just water."

I didn't know what to say to that. It wasn't the answer someone who hadn't drunk water in seven years should give. More precisely, it was the answer of someone who'd never needed to.

Eikon handed the flask back.

"…Why do you keep carrying that flask around anyway? There must be times the ration station's closer."

I wasn't ready with an answer to that.

"…I don't know. I just feel better holding on to it."

It wasn't a lie. But it wasn't the whole answer either. I'd never once thought of throwing the flask away. That the water jar my mother had filled the night before she left kept coming back to me — that, I didn't tell her that day.

. . .

"…What about your family?" I asked. "Are they here?"

"…Yes. Both my parents."

"…Do you see them often?"

"…Sometimes."

"…Don't you miss them?"

Eikon's face looked at the question for a moment, as if peering into it. She wasn't angry. The question itself seemed foreign to her.

"…Why would I miss them when I can just go see them?"

I was at a loss for that answer. Outside, missing someone arose whether or not you could see them. Here, the two seemed bound

together into one thing. If you could see someone, there was nothing to miss.

"…I couldn't see mine for seven years." I said. "So I kept missing them the whole time."

"…Ah, that would be different, then."

Eikon said only that much and didn't go on. I was grateful for the brief acknowledgment, and also let down by it. It was true that it was different. But exactly what that difference was, she made no attempt to find out.

I didn't feel, at the time, that she was dismissing me. It was the opposite, actually. She honestly marked what she didn't know as not known. Everyone in that city was like that. They didn't pretend to know what they didn't. I thought that was kindness. Later I would learn how far away that kindness came from.

Eikon tapped the flask lightly with her fingertip.

"…What are you going to do once you drink all this, though? Are you going to be here a while?"

"…I don't know. Not yet."

"…Did you stop partway through writing your form?"

I looked at her, startled at how she knew. Eikon shrugged.

"…You have the face for it. People here get it sometimes too. The face of someone who stopped in the middle of deciding something."

"…People here have that too, sometimes?"

"…Very rarely. There isn't much to decide in the first place, so it's not common."

I didn't let that pass unnoticed. That there isn't much to decide. There seemed to be something important folded into that sentence, but that day I couldn't catch hold of what it was.

. . .

The sun had tilted a little. In this city that, too, felt like an exact clock. The shadows always stretched at the same angle.

"…I have to go." Eikon stood.

"…Where to?"

"…Just. There's somewhere to be."

I didn't ask what that meant. I felt I didn't yet have the right to ask.

"…See you again." Eikon said. It wasn't a parting courtesy — it was said in a tone that meant it truly would happen.

"…Okay."

She walked off. I sat on the bench and watched her back. Her walk was light. There was nothing hurried in it.

Watching that back, I had this thought for the first time. Among the people I'd met in this city, she was the first who hadn't looked at me with pity. The Curator, the ration-station clerk — everyone had, in

some way, handled me carefully. Eikon didn't. She just treated me as someone she was curious about.

At the time, that ease felt good. Later I'd learn why that was so. She had no reason to be careful with me. A person who lacks nothing has no need to pity anyone else either.

. . .

On the way back to the lodging I passed the ration station. The clerk saw me and gave a nod of recognition. Everyone recognized me once they saw the flask.

"…Filling up again today?"

"…No. I've still got some left."

The clerk nodded and went back to their work. That person, too, didn't look at me strangely. Only it was a different kind from Eikon's. That person knew I was from outside and so didn't trouble themselves over it. Eikon had simply been curious, regardless of who I was.

I didn't know the difference then. I know it now. One was a kindness that acknowledged an exception. The other was the attitude of someone for whom the very concept of an exception didn't exist.

I got back to the lodging and looked out the window. The city was still quiet. A quiet with no sound of water in it. I'd started to grow a little used to that quiet. That was what frightened me. Growing used to it.

I didn't take the form back out that night. Instead I turned over the things she'd said. To drink. What would be strange about it. Water's

just water. I guess now there's no reason to be bored.

Those words stayed with me strangely long. Each one, taken alone, was true. But gathered together, something felt missing. What it was, I couldn't put into words that day.

That day I noticed, for the first time, that she always paused briefly before she began to speak. It wasn't that she wasn't in a hurry. It seemed more like there was simply no reason to hurry in the first place. I hadn't been in this city long, and already, without noticing, I'd begun to talk the same way.

(Continued in Chapter 14.)

Chapter 14. I Don't Lack Anything

> *_Previously_ — I met Eikon in the plaza. Preserved at fifteen seven years ago, she was still fifteen. When I asked if she wasn't curious about the taste of water, she said it was just the taste of water.*

Three days later I met her again.

In those three days I hadn't done much of anything. I went back and forth between the lodging, the ration station, and the plaza. I walked past the window twice, but I didn't go in. The third application, sitting in that drawer, kept pulling at me, but I couldn't work up the nerve to ask for it back.

I can count those three days. It was exactly three. But what I thought about during them, I don't remember well. I think I was probably trying not to think about anything at all. Trying doesn't make a thing so, though.

I hadn't gone looking for her. I was sitting in the same plaza, on the same bench, and Eikon came to me first. She walked up as though she'd known I'd be there.

"…Carrying the flask again."

"…Yes."

"…Where are you off to today?"

I had nowhere in particular to go. I hadn't gone back to see my mother and my brother since the second visit. The third application was still sitting in the window's drawer.

"…I was just walking."

"…Want to come with me? I've got something I'm doing today."

I went along without asking what it was.

. . .

What Eikon did wasn't much of anything. More precisely, I wasn't even sure I could call it doing something.

We passed a garden first — a place inside the city planted with flowers and trees. Eikon met two people she knew there and talked a while.

One was an older-looking woman. Looked older was the accurate way to put it. Since she was preserved she couldn't actually have aged, but her face gave that impression. The other was a boy who looked younger than me.

"…This is Anemos. He's from outside." Eikon introduced me.

The woman looked at me and bowed her head slightly.

"…Here for a visit?"

"…Yes."

"…How lovely for you."

There was no malice in it. She meant it, honestly — that it would be lovely. I didn't know what to say, so I just nodded.

I would hear that phrase a few more times after that day. How lovely for you. That there was someone to visit — that there was still, even, someone waiting — was a thing people in that city envied. I hadn't known it was something to envy.

The boy didn't say much, just waved and went on. Eikon watched his back and said,

"…He's never had much to say."

"…Are you close?"

"…Yes. I've known him a long time."

"…How long?"

"…I don't know. Five years, maybe?"

I was a little startled by how easy the answer was. It was the first time I'd heard someone start a sentence about a five-year friend with "I don't know."

After that we went somewhere like a library. There were a lot of books. Eikon pulled one out, flipped through a few pages, and put it back.

"…Going to read it?" I asked.

"…No. Just looked."

"…Not interesting?"

"…It's not that it's not interesting. I just won't read it today."

After that we just walked. It wasn't a walk with a destination. When there was a road, we walked it; when there was a bench, we sat; then we walked again.

While walking we passed a fountain. Watching the water shoot up and fall, Eikon paused a moment.

"…Do you like that?" I asked.

"…Yes. It's nice to look at."

"…So you watch it every day?"

"…Often."

"…Doesn't it get old? Watching the same thing every day."

"…It's the same water, but the shape's different every time. Look."

I looked at the fountain again after she said that. It really was. The water shot up in exactly the same direction each time, but the shape it broke into was slightly different every time. I'd never noticed that before.

I don't forget that moment. It was the first time I felt, concretely, that the way she saw the world was different from mine. I saw repetition as tedium. She found something different, every time, even inside the repetition. Which of us is right, I still don't know.

I counted how many places we'd passed that day. One garden, one library, two fountains, five benches. But not one of them had been a destination. I'd never before seen a person walk for five hours with no destination.

. . .

"…Aren't you bored?" I finally asked.

Eikon stopped walking and looked at me.

"…By what?"

"…This. Living like this every day."

"…It's fun, though."

"…What's fun about it?"

Eikon thought for a moment. It wasn't a face avoiding the answer. It was a face genuinely searching for one.

"…Walking. Meeting people. Looking at books. All of it."

The answer was so simple I found it hard to believe.

"…But it's the same every day, isn't it? Was yesterday like this too?"

"…Yes."

"…The day before too?"

"…Yes."

"…All seven years?"

This time Eikon actually laughed.

"…I don't remember every single day of the seven years, but they were probably about like this."

. . .

I turned the answer over as we walked. Outside, every day had been different. One day the well ran dry, one day it rained. One day someone died, one day someone was born. If a day wasn't different, it hardly felt like being alive.

There was none of that here. And yet Eikon wasn't bored.

"…Have you never wanted to do something new?" I asked.

"…Something new?"

"…Like, wanting to try something today you didn't do yesterday."

I could see Eikon taking the question seriously. She seemed to have caught that I wasn't asking to tease her.

"…Not really. There's plenty to do today — why look for something else?"

"…Just, out of tedium, I mean. Usually."

"…You'd need something tedious first, to be tedious."

I stopped at that. You'd need something tedious first, to be tedious. It sounded like it didn't add up, and yet it was strangely exact.

That day, for the first time, I felt in my body that time moved differently for people in this city than it did for me. My time was

headed somewhere. The next visit, the next decision, the next day. Eikon's time went nowhere. It just was.

. . .

We sat again on a garden bench. The sun had passed noon.

"…What do you lack, Eikon?" I asked.

This time I wanted to ask more directly. The earlier questions hadn't gotten me an answer.

Eikon gave the question a truly thoughtful look. She thought about it a long time. I took that silence as a silence that was searching for something.

"…I don't think there's anything."

"…Really?"

"…Yes. I thought about it, and there isn't."

"…Friends? Isn't there anyone you'd like to see more?"

"…If I want to see someone, I can just go see them."

"…What about someone you can't see?"

"…Is there such a person? Here?"

I was stopped short by the counter-question. There wasn't. Inside this city, anyone you wanted to see, you could see. Not being able to see someone was a thing that only happened to a person like me, from outside.

"…What about your parents? Don't you ever think you'd like to live longer, or stay with them longer? Nothing like that?"

"…If I want to be with them, I go see them. I'm not sure what it would even mean to want to live longer here."

"…Growing up. Becoming an adult. Aren't you curious about that at all?"

For the first time, Eikon looked a little amused.

"…What's good about becoming an adult?"

I couldn't answer. I genuinely didn't know. I'd been taught it was good, but I'd never thought about why. All that came to mind was getting taller, getting stronger, being able to decide more things on your own. But trying to explain why that was good, I found myself at a loss.

"…See?" Eikon said. "Even you don't know, Anemos. So why should I be curious about it?"

I couldn't argue with that. I still can't. Why becoming an adult is good — I didn't know then, and I don't know exactly now. I've only lived believing that it was. Eikon didn't hold that belief at all.

. . .

"…Aren't you lonely?" I asked. It seemed like it might be more precise than saying stifled.

"…Why would I be lonely?"

"…You have time alone too, don't you?"

"…Is being alone the same as being lonely?"

I was stopped short by that question for a moment. They weren't the same. I'd had a lot of time alone too, but at some point I'd started to feel lonely. I'd never separated the two, so I couldn't find an answer.

"…I don't think they're the same."

"…Then why'd you ask me?"

"…Just, I've seen people sitting alone on benches when there aren't many people around here. They looked lonely."

Eikon thought about that for a moment, then shook her head.

"…They're alone because they want to be. If they didn't want to be alone, they wouldn't be."

"…Does it always go the way you want it to?"

"…Yes. Here it does."

I felt something like a wall in that answer. It wasn't a wall meant to pick a fight. She was simply stating a fact as it was, but to me that fact felt like a wall.

That day, for the first time, I thought it might be possible for there to be no lonely people in this city at all. Loneliness is born in the gap between what you want and what you have. A person with no such gap has no room in them for loneliness to grow.

"…Doesn't it feel stifling?" I asked again. This time with a different word.

Eikon looked straight at me. There was no defensiveness in her face. It was a face that was truly curious.

"…By what?"

I couldn't answer.

If she asked me back what exactly was stifling, I didn't know what I'd say. She wasn't shut in a small room. No one had locked her away. She went wherever she wanted, as much as she wanted. She saw whoever she wanted, whenever she wanted. She wasn't enduring anything.

I realized, in that moment, that I myself didn't know what I'd been trying to ask. Stifling is a word you use when something is blocked. For her, nothing was blocked. Asking someone with nothing blocked whether they felt stifled was a question that didn't even hold together as a question.

"…Never mind." I finally said. "I was just asking."

Eikon didn't press further. She just nodded and looked back up at the sky.

After a long while I spoke again.

"…When I was outside, something was short every single day. Water was short, and even sleeping I always wanted something more. It was hard. But thinking back on it now, I think that was what kept me moving."

"…So lacking something is good?"

"…Not that it's good. Just, that it's what made me do things. Going to draw water, learning a trade. I moved because I lacked."

Eikon seemed to take that seriously. Then she said,

"…So I don't need to move, then."

There was no sarcasm at all in that. It was simply a conclusion. I couldn't find anything else to say in front of that conclusion.

I would bring that conversation back up again, even years later. I wanted to tell her she was wrong. But I couldn't find where, not then and not fully even now. I had no grounds to tell someone with no reason to move that they should move.

. . .

On the way back to the lodging I made that question over again, several times. Should I have asked what she lacked? Should I have asked what she missed? Whatever word I put in, it felt like the same answer would come back.

By what.

I would go on remembering those two words for a long time. In writing this book, it's a line I return to again and again. She wasn't asking to deceive me. She genuinely didn't know, and that's why she asked. And that was what unsettled me longest of all.

I filled my flask passing the ration station. The clerk asked,

"…Did you walk a lot today?"

"…Yes."

"…Must have been tiring."

I didn't answer that. I wasn't sure whether it had been tiring or not. My body was fine, but something kept pulling at me, and my steps felt heavy.

On the way to the lodging I passed the preservation building where my mother and brother were. I hadn't taken that road on purpose. It was just the road I always walked.

I stood in front of the building and looked up at the window for a moment. I didn't even know which window. I was always shown to the same visiting room, but I'd never thought about where in the building that room actually was.

That day, in front of that building, I asked this question for the first time. Did my mother, too, lack nothing, the way Eikon did? Was she not bored, not lonely, with nothing left to want? After I asked that question, I stood there for a long while.

Back at the lodging, I opened and closed the flask's cap. That day I did it maybe thirty times. Even counting was no use. My thoughts kept going back to that same spot.

By what.

Out the window I could see the city's lights. All the same brightness. Not a single one flickered. Outside, lanterns flickered often — from the wind, from running out of oil, from a wick burning short. The lights here were steady, as if they had no such reasons to falter.

Watching that steadiness, I thought of Eikon. She was like that light, too. Not flickering because there was no reason to flicker.

I slept badly that night. That was strange — nothing had happened that day that should have been especially hard. I understood it later. I'd been searching, inside her answers, for something missing, and no matter how I searched, I couldn't find it, and that was why I couldn't sleep. That nothing was missing — that itself was what kept me awake.

(Continued in Chapter 15.)

Chapter 15. A Sickness

> *_Previously_ — I spent a day walking with Eikon. I asked whether she*
> *didn't lack anything, whether she didn't feel stifled. She asked me back, "By what?" and I couldn't answer.*

The next time, I went to find her first.

That morning I went to look at the fountain again. Something she'd said had stayed with me. It's the same water, but the shape's different every time. I stood in front of it a long while and watched the shape the water broke into. It really was a little different each time. But that only made me feel more stifled. She had found something inside it, and to me it still looked like nothing but repetition.

Standing in front of that fountain, I thought this for the first time. Maybe it wasn't that I couldn't see it — maybe I was looking for something that never needed to be seen in the first place. That thought didn't leave me all day.

I waited in front of the garden. I didn't know whether Eikon would show up or not — we hadn't made any promise to meet. But about an hour later she came walking up. There wasn't the slightest surprise in her.

"…Here again."

"…Yes. There's something I wanted to say."

"…You look serious today."

I didn't know what my face looked like. I touched it lightly with my hand, though it wasn't as if that would fix my expression. I just did it anyway.

"…Not serious, exactly. I just had a few things I was curious about."

Eikon tilted her head and studied me. Her eyes really were curious. In front of that gaze I felt the words I'd prepared come apart. I hadn't meant to be angry, or to press her — but looking at her face, there was nothing left to do but speak plainly.

Eikon sat down beside me. She didn't press me to get on with it. I was grateful for the waiting, and also weighed down by it.

"…Last time I asked you something strange. Whether you felt stifled."

"…Yes, I remember."

"…I couldn't answer back then, but I think I understand now. What I was asking."

. . .

"…I," I began. "When I was outside, I always wanted something more. When it didn't rain, I wanted rain. When it rained, I wanted it to stop. Whenever I got something, I wanted something else after that."

Eikon listened quietly.

"…That was hard. But I can't really imagine what it would be like without it. A life with nothing to want."

"…That's me." Eikon said. Her tone was even.

"…Yes. So I wanted to ask. Do you really never want anything? Not even once?"

This time Eikon thought for longer. I felt that this silence was different from the ones before. The earlier silences had been silences trying to understand a question. This one felt like a silence choosing whether or not to bring something out.

"…Once, I saw someone like that." Eikon said.

"…Like what?"

"…Someone who'd been here as long as I had. One day, that person started wanting something."

. . .

"…What did they want?"

"…I don't know exactly. They couldn't really explain it either. They just said something was missing. That what was here wasn't enough."

I leaned forward.

"…And then?"

"…That person got stranger and stranger. Didn't seem to sleep well, wasn't the same even when they met people. Kept trying to be alone."

"…Were they sick?"

"…No. It wasn't sickness. It just seemed like they kept looking for something. Something that wasn't there."

Eikon's voice stayed even the whole time. An evenness with no grief mixed into it. I found that strange.

"…What about that person now?" I asked.

"…They applied for release."

. . .

That word reached my ears for the first time. Release.

"…What is that?"

"…Reversing preservation. Going back to how you were before."

"…Before?"

"…A living body."

It took me a moment to understand what she meant. Once I did, my heart sped up.

"…Is that possible? Reversing it?"

"…Yes. It's possible. I heard it's not even that difficult."

"…Then why doesn't anyone do it? Everyone just stays here."

"…Because no one wants to."

I didn't understand that answer right away.

"…No one wants that? To become a living body again?"

"…Think about it. Here, no one gets sick. No one goes hungry. No one dies. So why would you give that up and go back to a body that can get sick again?"

I couldn't answer that question at all. As logic, it was correct.
And yet something kept catching at me.

"…So what happened to that person, then? Where are they now?"

Eikon gave a small shrug.

"…I don't know. There's been no word since they applied."

"…No one knows? What happened to them?"

"…Right. Word doesn't really travel from the people here to begin with. Once you're released, you're off this city's roster."

There was something chilling in that answer. A whole person had vanished completely, and it was explained this calmly, as if it were nothing at all.

Outside, I'd watched people disappear many times. They disappeared by dying. That was a sad thing, and everyone treated it that way. But the disappearance I'd just heard about was different from that. This person hadn't disappeared by dying — they'd disappeared in order to live. And yet no one knew what had become of them.

In that moment I thought, for the first time, that in this city the direction of disappearing ran opposite to outside. Outside, you disappeared by dying. Here, you disappeared by living again. Whether those two disappearances could carry the same weight, I couldn't decide, then.

. . .

"…Isn't that sad?" I asked.

Eikon looked genuinely puzzled.

"…Why would it be sad?"

"…No one even knows what happened to them."

"…That person went because they wanted to. They applied themselves. It's not something to be sad about."

I wanted to argue with that, but I didn't know where to begin. Nothing in it was wrong.

"…I think that," Eikon went on, "is a sickness."

"…A sickness?"

"…Yes. Wanting something when you lack nothing. That's a sickness."

. . .

"…But why is it a sickness? It's just wanting something."

"…Wanting comes from lacking something, doesn't it? But here, there's nothing lacking. And if you still want something anyway, isn't something wrong with your body or your mind? Like someone who isn't sick feeling as if they are."

I turned that logic over. The logic itself wasn't strange. It was, if anything, clean. If you feel a lack when nothing is lacking, then

isn't the feeling itself what's wrong? Outside, I'd been taught the opposite. That it's the person who can't feel lack who's strange. A person who's full and keeps eating, a person who has plenty and wants more. Grown-ups clicked their tongues at people like that.

Here, that standard was flipped entirely on its head. Feeling a lack was the sickness.

I couldn't find an answer to that logic in that moment. I still can't, fully, now. Even now, writing this book, I don't have a sentence that truly beats Eikon's.

"…Then could I be sick too?" I asked. "The things I was just saying."

Eikon looked at me closely. There was worry mixed into her eyes. It was an expression I hadn't seen before.

"…You're a bit different, Anemos."

"…How am I different?"

"…You're not from here. You said you really did lack things outside. That's not a sickness. That was just a fact."

"…What about now, though? I'm here now."

Eikon didn't answer right away. She looked at me for a moment, as though studying me.

"…I'm not sure, right now. If you keep wanting something even here, I can't really judge that either."

I couldn't tell whether that answer was comfort or warning.

"…Did you think that person was sick too?" I asked again.

"…No. That person didn't think it was a sickness. They thought they were right."

"…What about you?"

Eikon looked at me and said, evenly,

"…I think that person was pitiable. They caught a sickness they never had."

. . .

"…Pitiable?" I repeated. "But you just said it wasn't something to be sad about."

"…Yes. Both are true. Pitiable, but not sad. They went because they wanted to."

I couldn't understand that distinction. How could something be pitiable and not sad at the same time.

I would come to understand that distinction only later. To Eikon, sadness was a feeling that came from losing something. But that person hadn't lost anything. They had only gone to get something they wanted, something they'd chosen themselves. Nothing lost, so no reason to be sad — that was her arithmetic.

Eikon studied my face and asked,

"…Why do you look so serious?"

"…No reason. It's just — that story sounded a little frightening."

"…What's frightening about it? A story about someone who got sick?"

I couldn't answer that question. I didn't even know exactly what was frightening about it. Only that evenness, that word sickness, kept pulling at me.

"…Have you never once had that happen to you?" I asked. "Wanted something more."

Eikon shook her head.

"…No."

"…Not even once? In seven years?"

"…Yes. You keep asking, but really, no. It's not a lie."

I knew it wasn't a lie. I'd already confirmed, several times over, that no one in this city lied. That was exactly what made it more frightening. Because it wasn't a lie.

"…Then maybe that person was like you, at first." I said. "Before they wanted something."

Eikon paused for a moment at that. It was the first hesitation I'd seen in her.

"…Maybe so."

"…Then someday, could it be you too?"

"…I don't know. That, I don't know either."

In that short answer I heard, for the first time, something that wasn't certainty. Until then, every answer she'd given had been certain. This one wasn't.

I remember that moment for a long time after. It felt like I'd seen a tiny crack in something that had looked whole. Hardly enough to call a crack — no bigger than a fingernail mark. And yet it was the largest thing I saw that whole day.

. . .

The sun began to set. The garden's shadows lengthened.

"…I should get going." Eikon said, standing.

"…Okay."

"…Be careful not to catch the sickness, Anemos."

She said it and laughed. It was a joke. A real joke, meant as a joke.

I couldn't laugh.

I kept turning that line over that night. Be careful not to catch the sickness. She really believed it was a sickness you could catch. And I, the moment I heard it, thought that maybe I already had.

Walking back to the lodging, I repeated that word to myself several times. Release. I'd heard it for the first time that day. I didn't know, then, that it would become the heaviest word of everything I would hear in this city from then on.

. . .

I couldn't sleep even after reaching the lodging. I thought about my mother and my brother. And I thought about that stranger. The one

who'd caught the sickness. The one who had felt a lack in a place with nothing lacking.

I didn't know, then, who that person was. Not their name, not their face, not their age. And yet that person kept overlapping with me. I hadn't been in this city long myself, and already I kept wanting something.

I lay in bed fiddling with the flask. Opening and closing the cap. I counted to about twenty-something and stopped. Counting was no use that night either.

That night I had this thought for the first time. That I wanted to give my mother a body again. But the moment I thought it, Eikon's words followed right behind it. Because no one wants that.

My mother might not want it either. That possibility entered my head for the first time that night. I tried to push it away. It wouldn't be pushed away.

It was the same with my brother. I'd never once asked an eight-year-old what he wanted and what he didn't. I'd just assumed I could take him along however I wanted. That assumption felt strange, that night, for the first time.

I hardly slept that night. The moment I opened my eyes the next morning, I'd decided one thing. To go find the Curator and ask exactly what release was. That became the next chapter of this story.

Out the window the city's lights were still lit, steady as ever. I tried to count them and gave up. They weren't countable. They all ran together, so I couldn't tell where one ended and the next began.

I paced the room a few times. It was a small room; a few steps and you hit a wall. I circled, and circled, and circled again. Walking wasn't going to produce an answer, but it was better than sitting still.

That night, for the first time, I felt this city was frightening. Up until then I'd only felt it was strange. Quiet, without water, with everyone looking so alike. But what I felt that night was a different kind. This city wasn't a bad place. That was exactly what made it frightening. No one here wanted to leave, and I felt like the strange one, for finding that strange.

I only closed my eyes around dawn. I slept briefly, then got up and filled my flask. That day I walked not toward the ration station but toward the Curator's office. That road felt shorter than any road I'd walked until then. I hadn't quickened my pace, but I arrived in what felt like no time at all.

(Continued in Chapter 16.)

Chapter 16. The Word Release

> *_Previously_ — Eikon told me about someone who had once wanted*
> *something more. That person had eventually applied, and after that there had been no word of them. She called it a **sickness**. I couldn't sleep that night.*

The morning air was cold. In this city the air was usually about the same temperature always, but that morning it felt unusually cold. Maybe it was because I hadn't slept.

I tried, as I walked, to put last night's thoughts in order. They wouldn't come into order. What Eikon had said kept surfacing out of sequence. It's a sickness. Because no one wants that. Why would it be sad.

That morning, for the first time, I thought this. Whether what I now wanted to know was really for my mother's sake, or for my own. I couldn't make that distinction then. I walked on without making it.

I thought, suddenly, of the water jar my mother had filled the night before she left. I hadn't drunk from it for three days. If I drank it, it would be gone. Even then, I'd been trying to hold on to something. It was similar now. Only this time it wasn't a water jar — it was a person.

As I walked, I heard the sound of gravel under my feet. It was one of the few sounds this city had. I counted my steps as I listened to it, and gave up somewhere past a hundred. Counting wasn't going to change anything.

On the way to the Curator's office I asked a few people about that word.

The first person I asked was the ration-station clerk. Filling my flask with water, I asked, almost in passing.

"…Do you know what release is?"

The clerk's hand stopped.

"…I've heard of it."

"…What is it?"

"…I don't know exactly either. I heard it's the procedure for reversing preservation."

"…Have you done it? Or anyone you know?"

"…No. No one."

It wasn't a lying face. They really didn't know.

. . .

The second person I asked was an old man I ran into at the plaza. He was sitting on a bench, so I sat beside him and asked.

"…Have you heard of something called release?"

The old man looked at me for a long while, then said,

"…I've heard of it."

"…Do you know what it is?"

"…I know the procedure. But I've never once actually seen anyone who's done it."

"…Why not?"

"…Because no one wants it."

I already knew that answer. It was exactly what Eikon had told me. And yet, coming from someone else's mouth, it felt different. It seemed less like one person's thought and more like a fact this whole city held in common. If one person had said it, it would have been that person's opinion. Two people saying the same thing felt less like an opinion and more like this city's rule.

"…Have you ever thought about it yourself, sir? Release."

The old man laughed at that question. It wasn't a mocking laugh. Just a puzzled one.

"…Why would I think about it."

I stopped walking when I heard that answer. Why would I think about it. That line seemed to summarize every answer in this city. No one said it was a bad thing. They just said there was no reason to think about it.

The third person I asked was a little different. A middle-aged woman I met at the garden entrance. She said she was on her way to visit her child. When I asked her the same question, her expression stiffened for a moment.

"…Why are you asking that?"

"…Just curious."

"…Is it because of family, by any chance?"

I was startled by that question. She seemed to have read something in my face.

"…Yes. My mother and my brother are here."

The woman nodded, then said in a slightly lower voice,

"…I thought about it once myself. A long time ago."

"…And?"

"…I only thought about it. I never went any further."

"…Why not?"

"…Weren't you afraid? Just thinking about it?"

The woman stopped walking for a moment at that question.

"…It wasn't so much fear. I understood quickly that thinking about it would do no good."

"…Why would it do no good?"

"…My child was three then. Still three now. What could you ask a three-year-old?"

I felt struck from behind by that, somehow. I didn't know exactly where it caught, but it felt like there was another wall inside this woman's words that I still didn't know about.

She didn't answer that question any further. She just smiled and went on her way. I didn't notice, that day, what that smile was hiding.

I would come back to that smile later. It wasn't a smile hiding something. It was simply that she had nothing more to say, and smiled because of it. People in this city didn't get angry or fumble for words when they had no answer. They just smiled.

. . .

I didn't ask a fourth person. Instead I asked myself. As I walked, I kept repeating the same question. Why was I holding on to this word so hard? No answer came. With no answer coming, my feet kept walking toward the Curator's office anyway.

I counted those four as I walked. The ration-station clerk, the old man, the woman, and myself. All four had said the same thing, each in a different way. No one wants it. There's no reason to think about it. There's no one to ask. I had heard all three of the others, and still my feet didn't stop.

The Curator's office was the building where I'd applied for my first visit. Past the window and down the inner corridor was a small room, where you could meet the Curator.

I'd already been in that room once. The first time I arrived in the city, when the visiting procedures were explained to me. The Curator I'd met then had been kind, and had looked tired. That impression still remained.

The receptionist asked,

"…What brings you in today?"

"…I have something to ask the Curator."

"…Is it visit-related?"

"…No. Something else."

The clerk wrote my name on a form, the same way as any other visitor, as if there were nothing unusual about it at all. I found that strange, somehow. Looking back later, that clerk's hand, not yet knowing how heavy the question I was about to ask was in this city, moved with the calmest touch of anyone that day.

The clerk went to check something in the back for a moment. I sat and waited in a chair in the waiting room. It looked like the same seat I'd sat in the first day. I couldn't even tell whether it had been months ago or weeks ago. In this city, time didn't count itself well.

In that waiting room, I realized for the first time that I didn't know exactly how many days I'd been here. I was the one who counted things, but since coming here, that had stopped working. The days were too alike to tell apart.

Besides me, there were two other people in the waiting room. One was an older man, sitting quietly with a folder resting on his knees. The other was a young woman, tapping her knee with her fingertips again and again.

Watching those fingertips, I wondered whether she, too, was anxious about something. But looking again, it didn't seem like anxiety — it seemed more like a habit. Her expression was calm. That in this city a body's motions and a face's words could differ from each other — I noticed that for the first time then.

Each time a name was called, one person went into the inner room. Watching their faces when they came out, they all looked about the same as when they'd gone in. No one looked greatly changed.

I thought that was strange, at the time. Outside, if you went into a government office and came back out, your expression always changed. Whether the news was good or bad. Here, people didn't change. Probably because whatever news they heard here fell within the range they'd already expected. I was the only one about to walk into that room carrying a question outside anyone's expected range.

. . .

The clerk came back and said,

"…Come in."

The Curator was seated inside the room. The same seat, the same posture as the first time I'd seen him. He smiled slightly at me.

"…It's been a while. Are the visits going well?"

"…Yes. They're going well."

The Curator studied my face for a moment. His eyes had the look of someone trying to read something. I found that gaze uncomfortable and also, somehow, reassuring. At least this person didn't look at me carelessly.

On the desk sat several stacked folders, all with covers of about the same color. My eyes went to one of them for a moment before I looked away. It felt like peeking at someone else's papers.

"…What brings you in today?"

I started to bring out the question I'd prepared, and hesitated a moment. I didn't know why putting that word into the air felt so heavy.

"…I wanted to ask what release is."

. . .

The Curator's expression shifted, very briefly. It wasn't surprise, and it wasn't discomfort. It looked like something older than either of those. I couldn't read, at the time, what it was.

The room went quiet for a moment. I couldn't even hear leaves rustling outside the window. In this city, even the wind was quiet.

"…Where did you hear that word?"

"…From someone I know. Without a real explanation of what it is."

"…From whom, if I may ask?"

"…A girl named Eikon. I met her here."

The Curator nodded slightly at that name. He seemed to know it. Whether that was because this city was small, or for some other reason, I didn't know.

"…Eikon is a good friend." The Curator said, with a small smile. "I've known her a long time."

"…How long?"

"…Seven years. You end up seeing a lot, in this seat, over that time."

Hearing that, I tried, for a moment, to imagine what this person must have seen in this room over seven years. I couldn't quite manage it. Seven years was old enough to have seen every visit, application, and refusal this city had had since it began.

"…That friend of yours didn't tell you anything bad, Anemos. If anything, she told you honestly. Everyone here talks that way."

"…I know. I know it isn't a lie. That's exactly why I was more curious."

The Curator said nothing for a moment. He bought time by pretending to straighten the papers on his desk. I felt that silence was a silence preparing an answer.

The Curator stopped straightening the papers and looked at me directly.

"…Anemos." He finally spoke. "This isn't a question to be asked lightly."

"…I know. I still want to know."

"…Why do you want to know?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. Why I wanted to know, I didn't clearly know myself. It felt premature to say it was for my mother — I hadn't confirmed anything yet. I just felt I had to know.

"…I don't want to stay not knowing."

The Curator looked at me for a while. That gaze felt long.

"…You're asking because of your mother and your brother."

"…Yes. Probably."

"…Is there a reason you said 'probably'?"

I couldn't answer that question right away either. I wasn't even sure myself whether that was really it. Whether it was for my mother's sake, or because I couldn't bear not doing something.

"…I don't know. I just felt like I had to know."

The Curator heard that answer and nodded. Something like resignation was mixed into that nod.

"…All right. I'll explain it to you. But there's something I want to say first."

"…What is it?"

"…Once you've heard this explanation, you can't go back to not having heard it."

I didn't quite understand what that meant. But my body tensed before I did.

"…That's all right. Please tell me."

The Curator still hesitated a moment longer. I saw that hesitation for the first time then. In this city, people generally didn't hesitate. If they knew the answer, they said it right away; if they didn't, they said so right away. This man knew the answer and was hesitating anyway.

"…This isn't a common thing for me to talk about." The Curator said. "I've been here for years, and this question has rarely been put to me this directly."

"…Doesn't everyone ask?"

"…Some do. But most, once they've heard it, don't come back."

"…Why not?"

"…That's something I'd rather you hear for yourself, and judge for yourself."

"…Is it that frightening a story?"

The Curator didn't answer that question right away. He tapped the edge of the desk lightly with his finger. It was the first time I'd seen someone in this city make a gesture that looked that restless.

"…I'm not sure frightening is the right word. But it isn't an easy story."

I let that warning pass lightly, at the time. Why the Curator had bothered to say it first, I would only come to understand properly chapters later. After hearing what came next, I could never go back to who I had been before.

Outside the window, the shadows shifted a little. There was no sound of the sun moving, but the light in the room changed, little by little. I watched that change and waited for his answer.

The Curator straightened in his seat. He pulled one folder toward himself but didn't open it. He just rested his hand on top of it.

"…I'll start from the beginning." The Curator said. "It's a simple procedure. Simple, and not simple."

I wanted to write that contradiction down exactly as he said it. Not understanding what it meant made me want to, more.

"…What do you mean?"

"…You'll understand once you hear it."

I set the flask on my knees and wrapped both hands around it. There was no particular reason. I just wanted something to hold on to. The flask's surface was cold. That cold was the only sensation in that room I could actually feel in my body.

I still remember that posture. Both hands wrapped around the flask. I sat in that room in that posture, waiting for what would come next. And what came was, in small ways, different from what I'd expected, and different from what I'd feared.

The Curator drew a breath. And began to speak.

(Continued in Chapter 17.)

Chapter 17. It Can Be Reversed

> *_Previously_ — I asked the Curator what release was. He warned me*
> *that once I heard the explanation, I couldn't go back to not having heard it. I said I wanted to hear it anyway, and the Curator began to speak.*

The light in the room had turned a little more yellow than before.
It was the only proof that time was passing.

The Curator took his hand off the folder. And looked at me directly.

"…Release is possible."

He said that first. I held my breath and listened.

"…The procedure isn't difficult either. You fill out the form, wait a few days, and undergo the operation. Nothing about it is blocked."

I read that sentence over to myself, several times. Possible. Not difficult. Nothing blocked.

"…Really?" I asked. My voice shook.

"…Yes."

. . .

I nearly stood up out of my seat. Something inside me came loose all at once. For seven years I hadn't known any way to "wake" my mother and my brother — and there was a way. And not one that was blocked, not one with a difficult procedure either.

In that moment I felt like I was back at nine years old. That day I'd sat behind the hill until the sun went down. Back then there had been nothing I could do. But now it was different. There was something I could do. And it wasn't even hard.

My grip tightened on the flask. My hand opened and closed without my noticing. The habit of counting something didn't come this time. There was nothing to count. There was only the feeling that everything was already settled.

I didn't know, then, exactly what to call this feeling. I know now. It was hope. The first hope I'd felt in a concrete shape in seven years. And how thin that hope was, I wouldn't know until I sat in this same room again, a few days later.

"…So I can apply right away, today?"

"…The application itself, yes, that's possible."

The Curator's tone was strangely careful. I didn't notice that carefulness at the time. I was too happy.

"…What's the procedure? Where do I get the form?"

"…Wait a moment, Anemos."

The Curator raised a hand to stop me.

"…Before I go over the procedure, there's something you need to know first."

. . .

I stopped short at that. Something that had just come loose tightened back up again.

"…What is it?"

"…You need to know exactly what release reverses, first."

"…Isn't it reversing preservation? That's what you just said."

"…That's right. But what that exactly means — everyone gets it wrong, at first."

I didn't know what that meant. Reversing something. Going back to a state without preservation. I didn't understand what was complicated about that.

"…A preserved person, in their current state, speaks, remembers, recognizes you, Anemos." The Curator said. "That's true. It isn't a lie."

"…Yes. I know."

"…Release takes that person out of that state. Back, into a living body again."

. . .

"…That's a good thing." I said. "It's living again."

The Curator looked at me for a moment. There was something complicated in his eyes. I couldn't tell whether it was sorrow or carefulness.

"…Yes. It's living again."

He said it while looking down at his hands. That gesture looked to me like someone measuring something — how much to say, how far to go.

"…If my mother lives again," I said, "she'll eat beside me, sleep beside me, grow older. That's what happens, isn't it?"

"…Yes. That's what happens."

"…That's what I wanted. That's exactly what I've wanted for seven years."

The Curator nodded at that. Even nodding, his eyes didn't look away from me. But what was in those eyes wasn't only agreement. I felt that difference in the moment, but I couldn't put a name to it.

He said that much and stopped. I waited for what came next. But the next thing didn't come right away.

"…But?" I pressed.

"…But I'll tell you that in the next chapter."

I didn't find that sentence strange at the time. I thought he was just tired and sparing with his words. Looking back now, the Curator was, in that moment, being careful with me. I think he believed that if he told me all of it at once, I wouldn't be able to bear it.

. . .

Unable to stand the silence, I asked again.

"…Where do I get the application form, anyway?"

"…You can get it here. Only —"

"…Only what?"

The Curator opened a drawer and took out a single sheet. He didn't hand it to me — he set it down in front of himself.

"…The application itself isn't difficult. Name, relationship, subject's information. That's all there is to it."

I looked at the paper. It really did look simple. It had only a few fields.

Name. Relationship to the subject. Subject's full name. Subject's preservation number. And a single signature line at the bottom. That was all.

I traced each field with my eyes, one at a time. Writing my own name in the name field wouldn't be hard. In the relationship field I could write "son." In the subject's name field I could write my mother's name. And I thought I'd need to write one more of these, with my brother's name in it.

Looking at that form, I thought this for the first time. Could a sheet of paper this short really hold the weight of seven years? Looking back now it's a laughable question. The paper was never meant to hold the weight. It was only a road it let something pass along.

"…Is that all? I just write this?"

"…Procedurally, yes."

I let that phrase, procedurally, pass by unnoticed at the time. Later I would learn it was the heaviest phrase in this whole chapter.

. . .

"…Why doesn't anyone do it?" I asked. "When it's this simple."

The Curator didn't answer that question right away. He smoothed the edge of the form with his fingertip.

"…What's simple is the procedure. The decision isn't simple."

"…What decision?"

"…I'll tell you that later."

I felt a small stifling at that answer. But hope was bigger than that stifling. The fact that there was a procedure, that it wasn't blocked, was so large that I could hardly hear anything else.

Writing this passage now, I want to grab that earlier self and shake him. Why didn't I press harder? Why did I let "the decision isn't simple" pass by like that? The answer is simple. I had just seen hope for the first time in seven years, and hope makes a person hurry. It doesn't make a person doubt. At the time, that seemed only natural.

"…If the procedure is this simple," I asked again, "why is there no one in this city who's been released? From what I've heard, anyway."

The Curator's expression showed a small surprise at that question.

"…It's not that there's no one. It's just extremely, extremely rare."

"…How rare?"

"…In all my time in this seat, you could count them on one hand."

I wanted to ask for the exact number, but I was afraid to ask. I didn't know, at the time, where that fear came from. I know now. My body already knew, before I did. That the number wasn't a good number.

"…I want to write it today, even." I said.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes?"

"…Don't be in a hurry."

. . .

That struck me as strange. I'd waited seven years already. I thought I had every right to hurry. This man didn't know my seven years. He didn't know the three days I'd gone without drinking water, the seventeen funerals, the promise I'd broken — "I'll come back later" — and never kept.

But in that moment, I didn't say any of that out loud. I had a vague sense that it wasn't because he didn't know those things that he was telling me not to hurry.

"…Why shouldn't I hurry? If it's something that can be done, isn't it better to do it quickly?"

The Curator looked at me for a moment, then said this.

"…This isn't the kind of thing that's better done quickly."

I didn't fully understand that, at the time. Not understanding it, some corner of my mind kept holding on to the good news anyway. Possible. Not difficult. Nothing blocked.

"…Have you seen a release, Curator?" I asked. "Actually seen one."

The Curator closed his eyes for a moment, then opened them.

"…I have. Several times."

"…What was it like?"

"…That's hard for me to say right now."

"…Why?"

"…Because you don't know the whole of it yet, Anemos. If I tell you only part of it, you might misunderstand."

I felt a little stifled by that answer, but I didn't press further. I knew he wasn't doing this to toy with me. No one in this city ever lied. That concealing and lying were different things — I sensed that, vaguely, in that moment.

The Curator held the form out to me. His fingertips lingered on it for a moment.

"…You can take it with you. Just don't write on it today." The Curator said.

"…Why not?"

"…Because it won't be too late to write it once you've heard the rest."

I nodded, obediently, at that. I'd been told not to hurry again, but in that moment it didn't bother me much. I took the form and tucked it into my coat. Its weight was so light I could hardly feel it was real.

I was still smiling as I walked out of that room. The Curator never once smiled with me. I didn't notice that difference at the time. I should have. I didn't.

. . .

"…Come back next time." The Curator said. "I'll tell you the rest then."

"…What's the rest?"

"…What release truly means."

I nodded at that. I was curious, but for now, what I'd heard today was already enough to make me happy. I stood and said my goodbye.

"…Thank you."

The Curator nodded. There was no smile on his face.

Walking out of the room, I looked at the copy of the application in my hand. Name, relationship, subject's information. Looking at those fields, I imagined writing my mother's name into them.

I smiled the whole afternoon that day. I smiled at the ration-station clerk, smiled greeting people I passed in the plaza. I thought I should tell Eikon this news when I saw her. Thinking that, my steps were unusually light that day.

That lightness disappears completely in the next chapter.

. . .

I went straight to the garden from there. I looked for Eikon. Luckily I found her sitting on a bench.

"…Eikon."

"…Your face is different today."

"…I have good news."

Eikon looked at me with an interested expression.

"…What is it?"

"…Release is possible. The procedure's simple too. The Curator told me himself."

I said that expecting she'd be glad the way I was. But Eikon's expression barely changed.

"…That's already known."

"…What?"

"…That it's possible. That's not new."

I felt the air go out of me all at once. To me it was news that overturned the world. To her, it was something she'd already known all along. That the same sentence could carry such different temperatures felt strange to me.

"…Then why hasn't anyone told me?"

"…Because you never asked. People here don't tend to bring up things that aren't needed."

. . .

The sun slanted in through the garden trees. In that light I looked at Eikon's face again. There was no change in her expression. Not joy, not surprise, not disappointment — just her usual face.

"…Aren't you glad about this news?" I asked.

"…Why would I be glad? It has nothing to do with me."

"…It's glad news for me."

"…I know. I can tell from your face."

She said that, looking at me closely. There was something like worry mixed into her eyes. It was a look I hadn't seen before.

"…But I'm a little worried." Eikon said.

"…About what?"

"…The Curator didn't tell you everything, did he? Just the procedure."

I was at a loss for words at that question. She was exactly right.

"…How did you know?"

"…He always does that. He never tells you everything at once."

"…Why?"

Eikon shrugged.

"…I don't know either. But he must have a reason for doing it that way."

I let that comment pass by unnoticed that day. It was only when I sat in that room again a few days later that I learned the reason. And once I knew the reason, I came to understand, too, why Eikon hadn't been as happy as I was that day.

Eikon pointed at the flask.

"…Give me a sip."

I opened the cap and held it out. She drank a sip and handed it back.

"…How does it taste?" I asked. The same question as last time.

"…Just like water."

"…Same answer as before."

"…Same water."

I laughed at that. She laughed too. That laugh was the easiest moment between us that whole day.

. . .

On the way back to the lodging I took the copy of the application out again. A fold had already formed in it, from being held too long in my hand.

I imagined writing my own name into the name field. Son, in the relationship field. My mother's name, in the subject's name field. Just imagining it made my heart race.

I slept well that night. It was the most comfortable night's sleep I'd had since I came to that city. When I opened my eyes the next morning, I felt like the world had changed. I didn't open and close the flask's cap once that day. There was nothing to count, nothing to bear. How short that feeling would turn out to be, I couldn't have imagined then.

(Continued in Chapter 18.)

Chapter 18. They Become Able to Die Again

> *_Previously_ — I heard from the Curator that release was possible. The procedure was simple too. I took the application and was happy.*
> *The Curator said he'd tell me the rest next time.*

Two days later I sat in that room again.

In those two days I took the application out and put it back about three times. It wasn't that I was wavering over whether to write on it. I just wanted the paper in my hand. I even traced the spot where my mother's name would go, with my fingertip.

I still remember those two days exactly. They were among the happiest two days of my life. And that they were also the last time I would ever be happy in so simple a way — that, too, I know now.

I didn't wait long in the waiting room this time. The receptionist saw my name and showed me in right away, as though she'd known I was coming.

The corridor leading to the room felt long that day. It wasn't more than a few steps, but each step felt like it was preparing me for something. I didn't know what.

The Curator was sitting in the same seat as last time. He nodded when he saw me. He didn't smile.

"…You're here."

"…Yes. I came to hear the rest."

The Curator pulled a folder toward himself. This time he opened it.

. . .

"…I told you last time. That release means returning that person to a living body."

"…Yes."

"…What that means, exactly — I'll tell you today."

I set the flask on my knees and wrapped both hands around it. The same posture as last time.

"…A released person becomes, again, a fully living body. They breathe, blood moves through them, an injury hurts, they age. They go hungry, they go thirsty, and when they're tired, they sleep."

"…Yes, that's a good thing, isn't it."

The Curator looked at me for a moment. In his eyes I felt something heavy approaching.

"…And from that moment," the Curator said, "they become able to die again."

. . .

At first I didn't understand what he meant, in a strange way. To die. Wasn't that obvious? If you're alive, someday you die. I'd known that

since I was very small.

"…Right. That's just natural, isn't it. Everyone who's alive is like that."

"…Anemos." The Curator said. "The people here right now don't die."

I looked back over that sentence.

"…They don't die?"

"…No. In the preserved state, they don't die. They don't get hurt, they don't fall ill, they don't age. That's what Perpetuity does."

I already knew that. I'd already seen it — that my mother and my brother hadn't changed one bit in seven years. But that this connected to the words don't die — I felt that, truly, for the first time, right then.

"…So my mother right now," I said slowly, "is in a state where she can't die?"

"…Yes."

"…But if she's released?"

"…From the moment she's released, she becomes a body that can die again."

I repeated that sentence silently to myself. Becomes a body that can die again. It was a strange sentence. Becoming able to die sounded like gaining something, and yet at the same time I already knew it was a loss.

. . .

The room went quiet. In that silence I heard that sentence again and again in my head. They become able to die again.

I've gone back to that moment countless times since. Even now, writing this book, I can still hear that sentence. They become able to die again. I couldn't admit, right away, that it was bad news. Admitting it took time.

"…So," I said. "If I get my mother back, I could lose her again?"

"…Yes. That's right."

"…How soon? Can she live a long life, at least?"

"…No one knows that. She'd become the same as everyone else. She could have an accident, she could fall ill, she could live a long, long life. She'd become just the same as what you saw outside, Anemos."

Something in me caved in at that answer. There wasn't a single certainty left. My mother, right now, was certain. Nothing had happened to her in seven years, and nothing would happen to her going forward. Release would make that certainty disappear.

I thought of the seventeen funerals I'd counted. The old man, the neighbor's child, my father's distant relative. All of them had been alive, and then they'd died. That was what being alive meant. It meant that someday you joined that list.

In that moment I asked myself this question for the first time. Whether I truly wanted to put my mother on that list. That I couldn't

immediately answer yes to that question is something I'm ashamed of, even now, thinking back. Ashamed, and yet an honest hesitation.

. . .

"…Even so," I said. My voice cracked. "Even so, she'd be alive. She'd really, truly be alive."

"…That's right."

"…Then I still want to do it."

The Curator nodded at that. There was no anger in his face, no attempt to stop me.

"…Why are you so certain, Anemos? That your mother would think the same way?"

"…That's," I started to speak, and stopped. Had I really been certain? I asked myself that question for the first time. "…I don't know. I just assumed, of course, that she would."

"…I understand. That feeling. But I still haven't told you everything."

"…There's more?"

"…Yes. The most important part is still to come."

I drew a deep breath. My body knew, before I did, that something heavier was coming.

The Curator poured a glass of water and drank it. Watching that motion, I felt that even he found this conversation hard. He must

have done this many times, and yet each time didn't seem to get any easier.

"…Anemos, everything I've told you so far has been the procedure. From here it's the real reason. Why no one ever manages to see an application through to the end."

. . .

"…Release," the Curator said, "requires the consent of the preserved person themselves."

"…Consent?"

"…Yes. You can write the application, Anemos. Because you're family. But that alone isn't enough. The subject themselves must consent before the procedure can go forward. One more signature is needed. Not your signature — the subject's signature."

That didn't surprise me much.

"…Isn't that only natural? It's their own life."

"…That's right. It's only natural."

The Curator said that and paused for a moment. He looked down quietly at his hands on the desk.

"…But here's why that becomes a problem."

. . .

"…A preserved person," the Curator went on, "lacks nothing. They aren't sick, aren't hungry, aren't lonely, aren't afraid. There's nothing they need."

"…Yes, I know. I've met someone like that too. She told me she lacked nothing."

"…Then try asking that person for their consent. Do you know what they'll say?"

I couldn't answer.

"…When you ask for their consent," the Curator said, "most of them ask you this.

Why?"

. . .

I heard that and couldn't say a word.

I truly couldn't say anything at all. I tried to open my mouth, and nothing came out.

I've tried to rewrite this scene more times than any other in this book. I wanted to write it more dramatically. I wanted to write that I argued back, that I said something. But that would be a lie. In that room, I truly said nothing at all.

I didn't know how much time had passed. There was no clock in the room. I only gauged the time by the feeling in the fingertips holding the flask. I sat there until my fingertips went numb.

The Curator waited for me. He didn't press.

"…Why, they ask?" I finally managed.

"…Yes. Why should they become a body that can get sick again? Why should they become a body that can die again? It's good now — why?"

. . .

I tried, hard, to find something to argue back with that question. The harder I tried, the less came out.

"…That's," I said. "That's not living, is it. That's not really living."

"…That's true too," the Curator said. "But it doesn't land, for the person themselves. They already feel that they're doing fine. They speak, they remember, they meet people. If they ask you what living is, then, if that isn't it — I can't answer that either."

"…And," the Curator added, "if you say that in front of them, they'll answer you like this. Then what am I now?"

I imagined that question turned on me. My mother, looking at me, asking that. Just imagining it closed up my throat.

"…I can't answer that question either." I admitted.

"…It isn't only you, Anemos. No one can."

I tightened my grip on the flask. My knuckles went white.

"…So," I said, "no one is ever able to be released? If none of them give consent?"

"…That's right. That's why there are many applications and almost no completions. Most stop right in front of the subject's consent."

. . .

"…What do you think, Curator," I asked, "the people who made this — why do you think they built it this way? Why did they make consent a requirement?"

The Curator thought about that a long while.

"…I think it was respect. At the start, at least."

"…Respect?"

"…Yes. It's their body. Family shouldn't be able to change a person's body just as they please. That's probably why consent was made mandatory."

I nodded at that. It made sense. And at the same time, it felt more frightening for making sense.

"…The people who first made this can't have meant harm." I said. It was as much a thing I was saying to myself.

"…That's right. They didn't mean harm. It was probably a very good intention, if anything. Meant to keep anyone from reversing a person carelessly, to make sure that person's own will was respected."

"…But that respect," the Curator went on, "ended up becoming a door that, in the end, no one walks through. Asking for the consent of a person who lacks nothing is the same as leaving a door open while already knowing no one will walk out of it."

. . .

I sat there a long while, unable to say anything.

I think that was the day, in that room, that I finally saw this city clearly for the first time. Up until then I had suspected the city was hiding something. That it was fake, a trick. But it wasn't. This city hid nothing at all. It had simply arranged things so that no one had any reason to leave. And that was far more complete than hiding anything ever could have been.

"…So what can I do?" I asked.

"…You can ask. Your mother. Your brother. I can't promise you an answer."

"…And if they refuse?"

"…Then the application stops there. There's no way to force it forward."

"…What if it's not a refusal, just — no answer at all? If they just keep asking back, 'why'?"

"…That's a refusal too. Not answering is the answer."

That sounded cruel to me. But I knew he wasn't saying it to be cruel. It was simply a fact.

"…I'm still going to ask." I said.

"…Of course. You should ask. I'm not stopping you. This is something you have to go through yourself, Anemos."

"…Then why are you looking at me like that?"

The Curator paused for a moment at that question.

"…Like what?"

"…Like you're worried."

The Curator heard that and smiled faintly. It was a smile I hadn't seen before. A sad smile.

"…That's right. I am worried. But that's not a reason to stop you. I don't have the right to stop you, either."

. . .

My legs wavered slightly as I stood. I didn't know if it was from sitting too long, or for some other reason. At the door, the Curator said one last thing.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…This isn't me telling you to give up. I just want you to go in with your eyes open."

I nodded at that. What exactly I should have been braced for, I didn't know at the time.

As I left the room I looked again at the application in my hand. Name. Relationship. Subject's full name. Subject's preservation number. The signature line.

That signature line looked different to me now. It wasn't a field for my signature — it was a field that needed my mother's.

That day I didn't go to the ration station, didn't go to the plaza. I went straight to the lodging. I shut the door and sat looking at that form for a long while. Why. Those two syllables kept circling in my ears.

Until then I'd thought I'd spent seven years preparing. That day I learned that all of that preparation had been for a different question entirely. I had prepared for how to find my mother. That my mother might not want me — for that, I had never once prepared at all.

. . .

Outside the window, the city's lights came on, one by one. I started counting them and gave up again. That day, counting anything was no use.

I opened the flask's cap. I drank a sip of water. The water felt unusually cold. This was what being alive was. Feeling cold as cold. And, someday, that feeling stopping too.

That night, for the first time, I became afraid of seeing my mother again. Until then there had only been longing. From that night on, fear grew alongside it. Fear that I would ask, and hear that answer: why. Fear of not knowing what would become of me, if I heard it.

I go into the next chapter without having overcome that fear. I didn't overcome it and go. I simply carried it with me. Looking back now, carrying that fear with me was, itself, the best I could do at the time.

(Continued in Chapter 19.)

Chapter 19. Why

> *_Previously_ — I heard from the Curator what release required. Once*
> *released, a person becomes a body that can die again. And it requires that person's own consent. He told me that when you ask someone who lacks nothing for their consent, most of them ask back,*
> *"Why?" I couldn't say a word.*

After I walked out of that room in Chapter 18, for days I heard only those two syllables — *why*. When I fell asleep, when I opened my eyes. They sat on top of every other thought I had.

I still don't know what to call those days. Too frightened to call them days of preparation, and yet I kept preparing something, too frightened to call them only days of fear. Probably they were both. I meet that kind of time more than once in this book.

It took me three days to file for a visit.

To be precise, I could have filed that same day. The three days were the time I spent standing at the counter with the form in my hand and turning back.

I didn't count those three days. My habit of counting didn't help me that time. I learned then, for the first time, that there is a kind of fear that can't be turned into a number.

During those three days I saw Eikon once. Not in the garden — in front of the ration station. I was filling the flask when she came

up.

"…Haven't seen you around lately," Eikon said.

"…I've had some things to think about."

"…What things?"

I didn't answer right away. I didn't want to talk about the application. But Eikon didn't press. She just looked at my flask.

"…You've been opening and closing that a lot lately," she said. "I can tell by the sound."

That surprised me a little. I hadn't even noticed I was doing it.

"…I guess so."

"…People trying to decide something do that. People here don't have much deciding to do, so most of them wouldn't know. I learned it watching you, Anemos."

I couldn't smile at that. Eikon studied my face and went on.

"…Are you going to ask her? Your mother."

I nodded at that.

"…When?"

"…Day after tomorrow, probably."

Eikon chose her words for a moment. It was a different kind of silence from her usual one. She usually put a thought straight into words. This time she was choosing something.

"…What are you going to ask her?" she finally said.

"…Whether she wants to do it."

"…That's all?"

"…There's more, after that. I've been preparing it for seven years."

Eikon heard that and said nothing back. I couldn't tell if that silence was worry or indifference.

"…Why aren't you answering?" I asked.

"…No reason," Eikon said. "I was going to say I hope it goes well. But I'm not sure anymore what that would even mean."

Something cold moved through me at that. If even this girl didn't know what "going well" meant, then what, exactly, was I walking toward?

I didn't hold on to that question properly, at the time. I should have. If I had, I might have prepared a little differently the next day. But I let that coldness pass through me and go. Going back over the words I'd prepared, in order, felt more urgent.

On the fourth day, I finally filed the form. My hands weren't shaking. That itself felt strange.

. . .

The visiting room was the same room as always. One wooden table, two chairs, one window. I had the grain of that table's wood memorized by

then.

The door opened and my mother came in.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes, Mother."

My mother smiled. The same smile as the last three visits. A smile full of gladness, without a flaw in it.

"…You're looking well."

"…So are you."

This exchange, too, was identical. I'd grown used to the sameness by then. But that day the sameness reached me differently. For the first time, some part of me tried to guess what lay behind that smile.

I unhooked the flask from my belt and set it on my knees. I touched the cap with my fingertips. I didn't open it. I just needed something to hold on to.

I've already written, more than once in this book, that moment of holding the flask like that in that room. I did the same thing in front of the Curator. Writing this account, I counted how often that habit shows up. Already several times, in this book alone. When I'm afraid, I hold something in my hand. It was the only method I knew.

My mother saw me fiddling with the flask and said nothing about it. She just waited. A waiting that didn't hurry, the way people in this city wait. That day I found the waiting both a comfort and a fear. I would have to say it eventually.

. . .

We sat down. My mother spoke first.

"…How have you been lately?"

I didn't answer the way I usually did. Usually I just said I was doing fine. That day was different.

"…Mother." I said. "There's something I need to tell you."

My mother's expression shifted, slightly. Not a worried expression. Just an attentive one.

"…What is it?"

I tried to bring out the words I'd prepared. Seven years' worth of words. But they lost their order in my mouth.

"…I — Mother, you can." I stumbled over it. "You can be turned back into a living body again."

. . .

My mother heard that and said nothing for a moment. I was afraid of that silence.

"…What do you mean?" my mother asked.

"…There's something called release. It reverses preservation. Then you'd really be alive again, Mother. With me."

Saying that, I felt my own throat close up.

My mother looked at me for a moment. There was surprise in her eyes. Not a bad surprise. Just the surprise of hearing something unexpected.

"…So there is such a thing," my mother said. "I didn't know."

That was the first moment I felt something strange. My mother hadn't known, either. Seven years in this city, and she hadn't known there was a way to turn her own body back. Was it because no one had told her, or because it made no difference to her whether she knew?

. . .

"…Would you want to do it?" I asked.

This question was the point I'd prepared for. I'd hovered outside a counter for three days for this question, waited seven years for it.

My mother heard the question and looked at me steadily. Not an angry face, not a sad one. Just a curious one.

"…Why?"

I lost my breath at that single word.

It was different from the Curator's "Why?" That one had been a businesslike question. My mother's "Why?" was gentle. A tone that was truly asking out of curiosity. That made it more frightening.

. . .

"…Why would I need to become that again?" my mother asked again. "There's nothing wrong with me right now."

"…But," I said, "this isn't really living, is it."

"…Isn't it?" my mother asked back. "I'm talking with you right now, like this. I see your face, I hear your voice. If this isn't living, then what is?"

I couldn't answer that question. Just as I hadn't been able to answer in front of the Curator, this time too I said nothing at all.

I knew, in that moment, that I'd hit the same wall a second time. The first time, in front of a stranger. This time, in front of my mother. The same wall, and the second time hurt more.

My mother watched my silence and reached out to touch the back of my hand. Her hand was warm. As warm as it had been seven years ago.

"…Anemos. I'm not in pain right now. I'm not afraid, I'm not sad. You know that too."

"…I know."

"…So why does that become a problem?"

I couldn't answer that question either. I'd felt that it was a problem, and yet I couldn't explain, right there, why it was one. The more I searched for words to explain it, the more those words sounded like they were about my own situation, and not hers.

. . .

"…Mother." I finally managed to say. "I waited seven years."

"…I know."

"…I want you to live with me again. Eat meals together, sleep under the same roof. Just an ordinary life."

My mother heard that and closed her eyes for a moment, then opened them.

"…That means a lot to me. It really does."

"…But?"

"…But I already see you like this, don't I. Not often, but I can always come."

"…That's not the same as living together."

"…What's different about it?"

I lost my words again at that question. I'd thought I knew what was different, but when it came time to actually say it, nothing came out.

. . .

"…Anemos." My mother said my name. Not with anger in it. Like that morning — a voice that was asking something of me.

"…Yes."

"…Why do you want this so much?"

I hadn't expected that question. My mother wasn't asking why for her own sake — she was asking why for mine.

"…I," I said, "want you to be alive again."

"…That's not an answer. That's what you want. It isn't a reason."

I had nothing to say to that. She was right.

. . .

"…I'll think about it," my mother finally said.

That surprised me a little. It wasn't a refusal.

"…Really?"

"…Yes. I'll think about it. But I can't promise anything."

"…Why?"

This time it was I who used those two syllables. The question I'd heard from the Curator, I threw it back at my mother this time.

My mother smiled faintly at that.

"…I don't know that yet myself. I'll have to think about it to find out."

My mother turned her eyes toward the window for a moment. Past that window there was always the same tree. I'd already seen that tree many times. Even on windless days, its leaves stirred slightly. I'd thought that strange once, but that day the thought didn't come.

"…Are you going to ask your brother too?" my mother asked, turning back to me.

I hadn't expected that question.

"…Yes. I mean to ask him."

"…He's only eight."

"…I know. But it's his own matter, so I have to ask him."

My mother looked at me for a long time at that. A look I couldn't tell apart — worry, or something like pride.

"…What did you know, when you were eight?" my mother asked.

I lost my words at that question. I thought of myself sitting behind the hill at nine. What had I known, back then? Even now I don't know exactly.

"…I don't know."

"…Neither do I," my mother said. "That's part of why I'm a little worried."

"…About what?"

"…About what you'll do, once you hear his answer."

I had no answer to that either. My mother was already worrying about a conversation I hadn't even had yet. I didn't find that frightening so much as strangely comforting. For the first time in seven years, my mother was worrying ahead of time, for my sake.

"…You don't have to worry," I said. There was no basis for it.

"…That's the kind of thing people say without any basis," my mother said, smiling.

That smile put me a little at ease. As long as there was a smile, nothing had collapsed yet — or so it seemed.

. . .

A notice came that the visit was ending. We said goodbye the way we always did.

"…I'll come again," I said.

"…Yes. Come again."

My mother smiled and waved. The same gesture as the last three visits. Watching that gesture, I felt that nothing had changed. The content of our conversation had been entirely different, but the way we parted was exactly the same.

Leaving the visiting room, I felt the strength go out of my legs. I leaned against the wall for a moment.

I stood there a long time. I didn't count how long. I didn't want to. I just wanted to feel the coldness of that wall, nothing else.

My mother hadn't refused me. That, somehow, made it heavier. If it had been a refusal, I would have grieved and it would have been over. "I'll think about it" was a sentence that let me neither grieve nor be at ease.

That night I took out the words I'd prepared, again. Seven years' worth of words, piled up. That night I finally admitted, properly,

that not one of them had been of any use.

Back at the lodging, I took out the copy of the application again. I smoothed the crease with my fingertip. In the name field there was still only my name. The signature line was empty.

I looked at that blank line for a long time. My mother's "Why?" seemed to hover over it, still. I wanted to fill it with something. But there was nothing to fill it with.

I folded the form back up. And for the first time, I decided to count the words I'd prepared over seven years, one by one. I counted them off on my fingers. Five. Five sentences.

Let's go home now. I missed you. This isn't really living, is it. I want you to be alive again. And the last one, held so long that it had stopped being a sentence and become something closer to a weight.

I counted all five of them that night, but I couldn't bring myself to take any of them out. To take one out I'd have had to hold it in my hand, and I felt certain that the moment I did, it would break. I decided to take them out one at a time, the next day. Even if I had to watch them break, I had to watch.

Outside the window, that same steady light was still burning. I didn't count it. That night, counting anything was no use. I've already written that once, earlier in this chapter. It's worth writing again here, because that night truly was like that.

I fell asleep with the five words still hooked on my fingers. The next morning those fingers were still folded the same way. It seemed that even in sleep, some part of me had gone on counting. Five fingers, five sentences. I met that morning without having properly looked at even one of them yet.

(Continued in Chapter 20.)

Chapter 20. The Things I Had Prepared

> *_Previously_ — Instead of an answer, my mother said, "I'll think about it." That night I counted the words I'd prepared over seven years. Five of them. I fell asleep without having properly looked at even one.*

The moment I opened my eyes that morning, I unfolded my fingers first.

Five. Exactly as I'd folded them the night before. I decided not to pick any of them at random. I would go in order. The oldest one first.

I still remember that morning's resolve clearly. Deciding on an order gave me, at the time, the feeling that I was in control of something. I wasn't in control of anything at all, and yet the order, at least, was mine to decide.

Counting the five of them gave me a strange feeling. Everything I'd counted up to then had been out there, outside me. Funerals, steps, the plaza, laughter. What I was counting this time was inside me. It was the first time since I'd come to this city that the things I counted had moved inward.

Looking back now, that difference is the whole point of this chapter. Counting what's outside is observation. Counting what's inside is interrogation. That morning, I began to interrogate myself.

. . .

The oldest one was these five words.

Let's go home now.

Earlier in this account I wrote that I'd been preparing this line since I was nine. That I'd prepared it while digging the well, while watching a funeral. But taking it out again that morning, I found that this line had never come with a *why* attached. To the nine-year-old I'd been, it was simply obvious. You go together because you're family. It was a sentence that needed no reason.

Now it was different. The moment I said this sentence out loud, my mother would ask. Why. I didn't already have that answer. A reason that hadn't been needed at nine had become necessary at sixteen. A strange thing. The longer time went on, the more certain my love had become, and yet the words to explain that love had only grown more scarce.

I said the five words over to myself, several times. Not out loud — only inside my mouth. Each time I said them, the words grew a little lighter. Not lighter because they'd had weight and lost it, but lighter because they'd become useless.

I recalled the place where I'd first held that line. Beside the well in the settlement, the third stone wall. The same spot where my brother had once stopped walking. I tried to imagine what expression the nine-year-old me had worn there. Probably none at all. Back then there'd been no need for an expression. It had simply been a fact. We were family, and family goes together.

Now I had to add an explanation on top of that fact. A fact that needed explaining might, perhaps, no longer be a fact at all. I stopped myself in the middle of that thought. It seemed to be going too far.

That morning I set this first line down completely, for the first time. Not thrown away. Only, I admitted that it could no longer serve as an answer. This line belonged to a time before the question. Now was a time that had the question. That the same words could carry a different weight depending on the season — that was something I learned for the first time that morning.

. . .

The second and third had already been tried. I'd used them both the day before.

"This isn't really living, is it." My mother had asked back what, then, our talking together right now was, if not living. I hadn't been able to answer.

"I want you to be alive again." This one had ended more quickly. My mother had pointed it out on the spot. That's what you want, that's not a reason.

I looked the two of them over again. Looking them over didn't change anything. What broke yesterday didn't mend itself today. I spent about an hour just confirming that fact.

I thought again of the old man I'd met on the road. The one on the way to the settlement who didn't go to visit his family. "Because it's always the same." I felt I understood that a little now. My mother had smiled the same way yesterday and today. Only I kept bringing different words each time. And the different words kept breaking on the same spot. It was in that moment I first had the premonition that I, too, might end up like that old man. That someday I might run out of words to prepare, and after that, might simply stop going at all.

I don't write that hour out in detail here. There's nothing to write. A stretch of time spent staring again at something already broken looks, from the outside, like doing something, but is really a time of doing nothing at all. I learned that fact that day. And even learning it brought little comfort.

Leaving the lodging, I opened and closed the flask's cap over and over. I did it about three times and stopped. Counting, opening and closing — both were just gestures to get me through the time. The gestures alone solved nothing.

. . .

The fourth was a line I hadn't tried yet.

I missed you.

This was the one I'd felt most sure of. It wasn't logic. It was simply a fact. I really had missed my mother for seven years. There seemed to be no place for a *why* to get a grip on this one. To have missed her was to have missed her. True no matter what anyone said.

I applied for another visit, to test the line. This time the wait wasn't long. The attendant led me to the same room I always sat in. My mother was standing at the door, waiting for me.

"…Here again," my mother said. There was no surprise in it.

"…Yes."

"…What's the matter?"

"…Nothing," I said. "I just missed you."

My mother smiled at that. A soft smile.

"…I'm right here," my mother said. "You're looking at me right now, too."

For a moment I couldn't answer that at all.

"…So I'm looking at you right now, too," my mother went on. "Isn't missing someone what you say when you can't see them?"

. . .

I heard that and froze on the spot.

She was right. Completely right. I was looking at my mother right now. My mother was looking at me. We were, right now, in the middle of looking at each other. "I missed you" was a sentence that no longer held true, in this very moment.

I watched these five words break during that short visit. The line I'd been most certain of broke the most easily. The line I'd believed was fact and not logic turned out, I learned then, to hold true only under a certain condition. When the condition was gone, the fact was gone too. I hadn't realized that in this city, that condition was always met. The sentence that a visit is possible any time — I'd read it since Part One, and only now did I truly understand what it meant.

"…So when can I see you next?" I finally managed to ask.

"…Whenever you file for it."

"…That's it? If I can see you any time, then what more is it that I'm even asking for?"

My mother didn't answer that question. Instead she looked at my face for a long time. There was something like worry in her eyes.

"…Anemos, are you all right?"

I couldn't answer that question either. Whether I was all right or not, I didn't know myself.

My mother reached out and touched the back of my hand again. The same warmth as last time.

"…Don't prepare too much," my mother said. "Words get heavier the more you prepare them. I'd rather you came to me light."

I didn't understand what that meant right away. I understood later. My mother had already guessed what I was doing.

. . .

I left the visiting room and walked toward the garden. I thought Eikon might be there. She was. Sitting on her usual bench, looking up at the sky.

"…That face again," Eikon said, looking at me.

"…What face?"

"…The face of someone with something broken in them."

I sat down beside her. And I told her what had just happened. That I'd said I missed her, and my mother had asked back whether she

wasn't right there in front of me.

Eikon listened to the whole thing and stayed quiet for a moment.

"…Your mother's right, isn't she," she said.

"…I know. That's what makes me angrier."

"…Angry?"

I was surprised by the word that came out of my own mouth. I hadn't meant to say angry.

"…No, not angry," I corrected myself. "Just — it's true, and I don't want to accept it."

Eikon looked at that distinction with something like curiosity.

"…Why don't you want to accept something true?"

"…Because if I accept it, then I'm wrong."

"…What's so bad about being wrong?"

I lost my words at that question. Outside, being wrong was something shameful. That's how the adults had taught it. But in this city, apparently even that idea sounded foreign.

"…Have you ever been wrong about something?" I asked.

Eikon thought for a moment.

"…I don't know. I don't think I've had much occasion to be."

"…Why not?"

"…If you don't want anything, there's nothing to be wrong about. You have to expect something, to be wrong."

That answer left me at another loss for words. I'd been losing my words in front of this girl's sentences a lot, lately. This time was no exception.

"…Today," I said, "I confirmed that everything I'd prepared was wrong."

"…So what do you do now?"

"…I don't know."

Eikon heard that answer and looked toward the flask. She held out her hand. I opened the cap and passed it over. She took a sip and handed it back.

"…How does it taste?" I asked. A question that came out of habit.

"…Just like water."

That answer made me smile a little. In a day that had broken entirely, that one familiar answer, at least, had stayed the same.

"…By the way," Eikon went on, "you said five."

"…Right."

"…You've talked about four. That leaves one."

My body went stiff at that. I'd never told her about a fifth one, and she'd counted exactly right.

"…That one's not yet," I said.

"…Why not?"

This time I didn't answer. Eikon didn't press either. She just looked back up at the sky. I was grateful for that silence. In this city, someone not pressing you could be kindness, and it could be indifference too. That day, whichever it was, I was grateful for it.

. . .

Walking back to the lodging, I looked at my last finger.

The fifth line still had no name. I'd never turned it into a sentence before. That day, for the first time, I tried.

I rewrote it several times. Once it came out like this: *Then I'm alone.* I revised it. *Without my mother, I become alone.* I revised it again. *Because I don't want to be alone.*

I started to read each of these sentences out loud, one by one, and stopped myself. It felt like saying them aloud would make them real.

I thought about telling Eikon first, at least. In front of her, almost anything was relatively easy to say. But it seemed this one line, even in front of her, wouldn't come out. The other four had been words aimed at my mother. This one was aimed at myself. Bringing out a line aimed at yourself, to someone else, first — that took a different kind of courage.

I wrote only the first character of that sentence in the corner of a sheet of paper. *I.* My hand stopped there. I didn't write the rest. I stared at that one character for a long while, then folded the paper and put it in the drawer.

That night I never finished the fifth line. I know now that it wasn't that I couldn't finish it — it's that I didn't want to. This one line was the one I couldn't test in front of my mother. If this one broke, I would have nothing left. The other four, I could at least pretend were for my mother's sake. This one had been, from the start, for my own.

. . .

That night I opened all five fingers again. Four were already broken. One I was still holding closed. Holding it, only — I had no courage to use it.

Writing this book now, I can finish that fifth sentence. The boy I was that night could not. This account is, among other things, the road toward that finishing. I don't want to get too far ahead of myself, so I'll leave it at this much here. A day comes, eventually, when this last finger has to open too.

I looked out the window. The light was as steady as ever. Watching it, I thought about what I should do the next day. I had no more words left to bring to my mother. Four of the five I'd prepared had broken, and one I'd hidden away myself.

That night, for the first time, I thought of my brother. I knew I would have to ask him the same question I'd asked my mother. I also remembered what my mother had said in the visiting room, with worry in her eyes. What you'll do, once you hear his answer.

I brushed that worry off lightly, at the time. My brother was eight. I thought, if anything, it would be easier with him. I thought there'd be no need for complicated logic, no words that could break. How wrong that thought was, I would learn the next day.

That night, for the first time, I decided not to prepare any words. I'd tried five, four had broken and one I'd hidden, and now there were no more words left to prepare. Strangely, that felt like a relief. Having nothing left to prepare felt, somehow, like having nothing left to fail at.

How wrong that feeling was, I didn't know then. Having no prepared words didn't mean there was no failure to have. It was closer to the opposite. Going in unprepared, I would hear, that place, an answer of a kind I had never written down before.

I folded my five fingers again. This time with no order, all at once. And I turned off the light. In the dark I laid that hand on my chest and lay down. Five fingers, still there, carrying five weights.

(Continued in Chapter 21.)

Chapter 21. My Brother's Answer

> *_Previously_ — The five words I'd prepared for my mother broke, one*
> *by one, or were hidden away by my own hand. I decided to go and see*
> *my brother next, carrying no prepared words at all.*

Before I went to my brother, I went first to see the Curator.

There was something I needed to ask. Whether an eight-year-old could give consent at all. Saying that question out loud, I felt how odd it was, even to myself. Why had I assumed that something not even an adult could do might somehow be possible for a child?

The Curator didn't answer right away. He turned over a few pages of paper.

"…It's not a procedure that stops at age," he finally said. "Consent is consent. Old or young."

"…But?"

"…There's no but. Not procedurally."

I felt I'd heard that phrase, "not procedurally," somewhere before. I'd already heard it once, in Chapter 17. Then as now, there was always something more behind those words.

"…Anemos," the Curator said. "What an eight-year-old understands isn't mine to judge. That isn't my place."

"…Then whose place is it?"

"…Yours. You're his brother."

That weighed heavily on me. It was a sentence that handed the weight over to me. I wasn't ready to take it up yet.

"…What if," I asked, "my brother says no?"

"…Then it stops there. You can ask again later, but there's no way to force it forward."

"…What if he says yes?"

The Curator thought a little longer about that question.

"…If he says yes, the procedure moves forward. Except."

"…Except what?"

"…We confirm it once more, on our end. Directly with the subject. Not through the family."

Hearing that, I felt some relief. It sounded like the judgment wouldn't rest on me alone.

"…How do you confirm it?"

"…We simply ask. Whether they truly want it. But Anemos," the Curator looked straight into my eyes, "that confirmation isn't everything. It confirms the form of it. It doesn't confirm the content."

I didn't fully understand what that meant, at the time. I would understand it a few hours later.

. . .

The corridor to my brother's room was the same one I'd walked in Chapter 10. I'd already counted its steps once before. This time I didn't count. I had no room left over for counting.

The door opened. My brother was standing by the window. He ran to me when he saw me.

"…Brother!"

"…Been doing well?"

"…Yeah. Did you get taller again?"

I smiled at that. There was no way I'd grown taller in a few weeks. But he asked every time, in complete earnest. I knew it was this child's only way of measuring time. My height was his clock.

My brother took my hand. That small hand. Still the same size.

"…Want to see this?" he said. The stone. The one he'd picked up by the well.

"…Still have it, huh."

"…I carry it all the time."

I took the stone in my hand for a moment. Then I sat down. I had something to say today.

. . .

"…Listen," I began. "There's something I want to ask you."

"…What?"

I'd thought all night about how to explain it, but I never found the right words. In the end I started with the easiest thing.

"…Would you like to be able to grow again?"

My brother's eyes went wide.

"…I can grow?"

"…Yeah. There's supposed to be a way."

"…Can I get tall like you?"

"…Yeah."

My brother's face lit up. Watching that face, I felt my heart drop. I hadn't expected he'd be glad about it so easily.

"…But," I went on, "if you do that, some other things come with it."

"…Like what?"

I stopped for a moment. I never did find, all the way through, how to say this part.

"…You could get sick. If you got hurt. And someday…" I couldn't finish the sentence.

"…Stop?" my brother asked.

I was startled by that word. It was the word I'd written back in Chapter 1. In the settlement, that's what they called it — being ill

a long while and then going. My brother still remembered the word.

"…Yeah. Someday that could happen too."

My brother heard that and got a thinking look on his face for a moment. The face of an eight-year-old working hard to weigh something.

"…Did Mom stop?" my brother asked.

"…No. Mom's still here, just as she is."

"…So if I stay the same too, I won't stop?"

I couldn't answer that question. It was exactly right. My brother was already stating, on his own, something close to the conclusion.

. . .

"…What do you think, brother?" he asked.

I hadn't prepared for that question. I'd come here resolved to carry no prepared words, so I had no answer for this one either.

"…I don't think I should say what I think," I said. "This is your own matter."

"…But do you want it?"

I went a long while without answering that one, too. I wanted it. Of course I wanted it. But it felt wrong to say so. I'd already learned this once, in front of my mother. What I want isn't a reason.

"…I," I finally managed, "want what you want."

My brother heard that and stared at me for a moment. Then he smiled.

"…Then it's simple."

"…What is?"

"…I just want what you want."

My breath caught at that, all at once.

"…What do you mean?"

My brother said it like it was obvious.

"…If you'll do it, I'll do it."

. . .

I heard that single line and, at first, I was glad.

Truly glad. My mother had said, "I'll think about it." I'd heard Eikon's "What's that got to do with it?" more times than I could count. Here, for the first time, I heard "I'll do it." I nearly rose from my seat.

I remember those few seconds even now, exactly. Something inside me cheered without a sound. There it is. My brother wants this. I repeated that sentence to myself, over and over.

In that moment I was already picturing the next scene. Myself running to the Curator's office. My hand writing my brother's name on the application. Even the scene of holding my brother's hand and leaving a mark for him on the signature line. All of it passed through my head in a few seconds. I was startled myself at the

speed. What I'd imagined in those few seconds felt more vivid than anything I'd prepared over seven years.

But that cheer didn't last.

"…Why did you answer that way?" I asked. My voice shook strangely.

"…Because it's what you want."

"…No, I asked what you want."

My brother tilted his head.

"…If you want it, I want it too."

I heard that and looked down at the stone still in my hand. I'd been gripping it this whole time without noticing. Its shape had pressed into my palm.

"…Not that," I asked again. "Without me — just thinking about it on your own — how do you feel?"

My brother put on a serious, thinking face at that question. He thought a long while.

"…I don't know. I just never thought about it, because you were here."

. . .

I had no words for a long while, in front of that answer.

I've rewritten this scene more times than any other in this account. In my first draft, I wrote that I withdrew the application

right there on the spot. That was a lie. In reality, it wasn't so. In that moment, briefly, very briefly, I thought about simply accepting that answer as it was.

I set that thought down here honestly. I thought about taking my brother's "I'll do it" straight to the Curator. Procedurally, there was nothing wrong with it. My brother had answered. If you'll do it, I'll do it. All I had to do was write that answer on the form, exactly as it was. Probably no one would have stopped me. Even if the Curator confirmed it himself, my brother would clearly give the same answer in front of him too. If you'll do it, I'll do it. That confirmation confirms the form, not the content — those words, only then, did I finally understand completely.

I'll also note that during those few seconds, my hand was already moving toward the application in my pocket. My fingertips touched the edge of the paper. I pulled my hand back right there. I didn't know exactly why, at the time. I know now. The moment I pulled that paper out, I would have become someone who kept, on the surface, what this city calls respect, while betraying it completely underneath.

I took my brother's hand again. That small hand.

"…I'll ask you again. Later," I said.

"…Can't we do it now?"

"…No, not now."

My brother's face fell. Watching that face, my chest tore. This child had been trying to give me what I wanted. And I was refusing the gift.

. . .

On the way back to the lodging I thought again of the Curator's words. What I'd heard in Chapter 18. "A preserved person lacks nothing." And why consent was a problem in the first place. I'd never once applied those words to my brother. My brother wasn't someone who had never wanted anything — he was someone still learning, from me, how to want.

That night I saw that difference clearly for the first time. Eikon's "What's that got to do with it?" came out of her having no lack. My brother's "I'll do it" came out of having no direction of his own. Neither one was consent. And yet I had to admit that my brother's answer was, by far, the more tempting of the two. Because at least it had been a yes.

That night I took out the application again. I looked a long time at the space where my brother's name would go. My hand moved over it several times. I didn't write.

That night I thought again, for the first time, about the word "respect." The Curator had said once that the consent requirement had probably come out of respect. A respect meant to keep anyone from turning a person back carelessly. That night I also saw the other side of that word. To take my brother's "I'll do it" and carry it forward would have been, at the same time, both keeping respect and completely destroying it. The procedure would have been followed. But the thing the procedure was meant to protect would not have been.

. . .

The next morning, I went to the Curator's office.

"…I asked my brother yesterday," I said.

"…What did he say?"

"…He said, 'If you'll do it, I'll do it.'"

The Curator heard that and showed no expression at all. Not a face that was judging. Just a face that was waiting.

"…Does that count as consent?" I asked.

"…Procedurally, yes."

There it was again. Procedurally.

"…But what I want to ask," I went on, "is whether that's real consent."

For the first time, the Curator smiled, faintly. A sad smile.

"…It sounds like you already know the answer to that, Anemos."

I had no answer to that. He was right. I already knew the answer.

. . .

"…I'd like to withdraw the application," I said.

"…Your brother's?"

"…Yes. It hadn't even been filed yet, but I wanted to make it certain."

The Curator took something out of a folder and set it in front of me. A form confirming the withdrawal. I wrote my name on it. My hand didn't shake. This time, I was truly glad that it didn't.

"…You did well," the Curator said.

"…At what?"

"…There have been people, sometimes. People who, when the child answers that way, go ahead and carry it through as it stands."

I looked up, startled at that.

"…There have been people like that?"

The Curator nodded. He said nothing more. I asked nothing more. It was a weight I could understand without asking.

Leaving that room that day, I felt for the first time that I had chosen something myself. Up until then, everything had been happening to me. I'd been asked, "Why?" I'd been given, "I'll think about it." This time was different. I could have taken my brother's "I'll do it," and I set it down myself instead. It was the first choice I had made in this book.

I didn't go to my brother that day. Instead I left him a letter. I asked the attendant to pass it along.

"I'll ask you again later. Next time, think it over by yourself, without me there. You can take as long as you need."

Writing that letter, I felt that this line, of all things, was more honest than any word I'd prepared over seven years. It was honest because I hadn't prepared it. I caught that irony that very day.

. . .

Passing through the garden, I ran into Eikon. Not on the bench — we met in the middle of the path.

"…Your face is different again," Eikon said. "Different from yesterday's face."

"…How's it different?"

"…Yesterday's was a broken face. Today's is…" she chose her words for a moment. "…a face that put something down."

I thought that phrase was exactly right. I'd picked something up today and set it back down. The feel of it was still in my hand.

"…What did you put down?" Eikon asked.

I told her briefly about my brother. The answer, "I'll do it," and withdrawing it.

Eikon heard the whole thing and said nothing for a long while. Then she said this.

"…I honestly don't really see why that's a problem. Your brother said he wanted to."

"…He said he wanted to because of me. Not because he wanted to, himself."

"…Is that different?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. In this city, that distinction seemed to be a foreign one. For Eikon, wanting and having a reason always came together. If you want something, there's a reason; if there's no reason, you don't really want it either. But with my brother, the two had come apart.

"…It's different," I finally said. "I only saw that difference clearly myself, for the first time, today."

Eikon heard that answer and tilted her head. Not a face that understood, but a face that simply accepted not understanding.

"…You've been picking out nothing but hard things to do lately, Anemos."

I smiled a little at that.

"…Yeah. I have."

I remember that short conversation for a long time after. Eikon didn't understand my choice. And yet she didn't argue against it. It was the first time I felt what it was like to be respected without being understood.

(Continued in Chapter 22.)

Chapter 22. Looking Down

> *_Previously_ — My brother said, "If you'll do it, I'll do it." I decided not to accept that answer as consent, and withdrew the application myself. For the first time I felt that I had chosen something.*

After I parted from Eikon, my body felt strangely light and heavy at once.

The lightness was from withdrawing the application. It felt like I'd finished something. The heaviness was from the feeling that finishing it had solved nothing. Not with my mother, not with my brother — I still had nothing, either way.

That afternoon I didn't go straight back to the lodging.

If I went back, I felt I'd end up counting something again. Five fingers, the blanks on a form, the number of my brother's steps. That day I didn't want to count anything. So I just walked. With no direction chosen.

I remember that walk strangely well, even now. It's one of the few scenes in this account where I walked with no purpose at all. Up until then I'd always been going somewhere. To the visiting room, to the Curator's office, to the garden. That day was different.

As I walked, the streets grew steadily less familiar. At some point I realized I was moving away from the city's center. Fewer buildings, fewer people. No more benches from the plaza, no more garden trees.

Even though I'd been in this city a fair while, I'd never once come this way before. The visiting room, the Curator's office, the ration station, the garden — the paths I walked always connected those four places. This road led to none of them.

Even the ground underfoot was different. The streets at the city's center were all packed hard, but here bare earth showed through in patches. I walked on that earth. The feel of it under my feet was familiar again, after a long while. It was close to the feel of the roads outside.

The people I passed grew fewer too. At first there'd been one or two, here and there, and then at some point there was no one at all. That absence felt, strangely, like a relief. It was a road where no one studied my face.

Walking that road, I learned for the first time that this city had something like an "outskirts." At the center, people gathered. Visiting, walking, crossing paths. At the outskirts, there was no one. A place with no reason to go. At the time I thought that was simply a fact of geography.

. . .

When I reached the edge of the city, at first I didn't realize that was where it ended.

The ground simply vanished there. More precisely, the ground suddenly bent downward. I stopped in front of it.

A low railing ran along that boundary. Not high. About waist height. Not so much a barrier meant to keep you from crossing, as a height

meant only to mark that this was a boundary. I set my hand on that railing. It was cold.

I stepped forward and looked down.

. . .

At first I couldn't see anything. More precisely, it took my eyes a while to adjust to that landscape. Eyes accustomed to the city's light couldn't read the colors below right away.

Slowly, shapes came together.

It was a wide valley. Wide enough that I couldn't quite see its end. The floor was a dry, pale color. I couldn't tell if it was the color of soil or of ash. Here and there were darker marks, deeper in tone, but from up here I couldn't tell what they were.

There were no trees. Or — there were, but only a few, standing far apart, and they had no leaves. Only branches remained, standing bare. I couldn't tell whether those trees were dead or only sleeping.

The cliff was steeper than I'd expected. I tried to gauge the height from the city's ground down to the valley floor. It was higher than any hill I'd seen in the settlement. Layers showed in the cliff face. Soils of slightly different colors, stacked in horizontal bands. Red near the top, growing paler going down, until near the bottom it was almost white. I could only guess that those bands were the mark of a very long stretch of time. It was a kind of layering that nothing the old man had taught me could fully explain.

The dark marks scattered across the floor kept catching my eye. They came in every size. Some were very small, some as large as a

gathering of several people. From that distance I couldn't tell whether they were only shadows, or the trace of something else. Not being able to tell, if anything, held my eyes there all the more.

I've redrawn that first sight of the landscape in my mind many times. Writing this account, I've felt the temptation to attach some grand emotion to that scene. But to be honest, in that moment I wasn't afraid. I wasn't sad, either. I was simply — strange. Down there was a color that existed nowhere else in this city.

A wind blew upward from below. A dry, lukewarm wind. A wind I could hardly feel anywhere else in this city. I stood there a long while, taking that wind on my face.

. . .

I looked at the ground beneath my feet again. Even the ground right in front of the railing had a different texture from the ground farther inside the city. Softer, and it crumbled a little underfoot. I tried to find, with my eyes, exactly where that boundary began. I couldn't find it. Between the city's hard ground and the valley's dry ground, there was a stretch that shifted gradually. Ground that belonged to neither side.

There was no sound, either.

More precisely, it was a different kind of absence than the city's. The city was quiet because there was little sound. Down there seemed quiet because there was nothing, in itself, to make a sound. I couldn't put that difference into exact words in that moment, but my body felt it.

Out of habit, I walked along the railing counting my steps. Twenty to the left, thirty to the right. I was trying to find the valley's end.
I couldn't. Both ways, it kept running on past what I could see.

I gave up trying to gauge its size. Right there, for the first time,
I admitted that some things can't be gauged.

. . .

A person was walking past nearby. An older man, carrying a small basket, on his way somewhere. I called out to stop him.

"…Excuse me."

The man stopped walking and looked at me.

"…What's down there?" I asked.

The man glanced briefly where I was pointing. Then he looked back at me. His expression didn't change much.

"…The valley."

"…What's in it?"

"…I don't know."

I was a little surprised by that short answer.

"…You don't know? Living right here?"

"…I've never been down."

"…Not even once?"

"…No."

"…Why not?"

The man smiled faintly at that question, for the first time. Not a mocking smile. Just the smile of someone finding the question unfamiliar.

"…There's no reason to go."

. . .

I turned that answer over in my mind.

"…Aren't you curious?" I asked.

"…Being curious and having a reason to go are different things."

That distinction was unfamiliar to me. Outside, if you were curious, you usually went and looked. Curiosity itself was the reason. I wanted to check that once more.

"…Have you never once wanted to go down?"

The man took the question seriously. There was no sign he was brushing it off.

"…I think maybe I thought about it once, as a child. But I don't remember well."

"…Why didn't you go?"

"…Because I didn't know what would be down there — would that do, as an answer? But that's not quite the exact reason. More precisely,

nothing changes whether I go or not."

"…Why does it matter, whether something changes?"

The man smiled a little at that question.

"…It doesn't matter. That's exactly why I don't go, either."

I couldn't find another question to ask, in front of that circular logic.

"…Has anyone ever been down there? Anyone at all?"

"…Well. I've never heard of it."

"…Not a single one?"

"…Not a single one."

That answer gave me a strange chill. Since this city was built — or at least, as far as this man knew — no one had ever set foot in that valley.

The man, having said that, walked on. He adjusted the basket in his hands, without looking at me as though I were especially strange.

Watching his back, I felt something cold pass through me. At first I thought it must be a forbidden place. I expected a wall, at least, or a sign. There was none. Only a low railing. Anyone who set their mind to it could climb over. And yet no one did. Not because it was blocked, but because there was no reason to go.

I'd already met that kind of wall in this city more than once. Release was the same. Nothing blocked it, and yet no one did it. The valley was the same. Nothing blocked it, and yet no one went down. In

that moment I sensed, only dimly, that those two walls were built from the same material.

. . .

I drew one deep breath. And I stayed exactly there, standing still, for a long while.

The wind kept blowing. I tried to count it. One gust, two. I counted a few times and gave up. Wind wasn't something you could count, the way steps or laughs were. It kept blowing and stopping, and there was no telling where one ended and the next began.

In front of that wind, I had a strange thought. I didn't yet know that my name meant wind. That meaning wouldn't come to light until Part Four. But rewriting this scene now, it's hard for me to simply pass over that coincidence. I stood there a long time, for the first time, in front of something that couldn't be counted. And later I learned that the name of that uncountable thing was also my own name. For now I'll set down only this much, and save the rest for when the time comes.

Far off, a single bird flew across above the valley. Even seeing a bird in this city was rare. I watched to see whether it would fly down into the valley. Near the edge of the cliff it turned and flew back toward the city instead. It didn't go in.

Not even that bird went in. In the moment, I let that pass as unremarkable. Later it came back to me. If even a thing that could simply fly over never crossed in, then maybe it wasn't blocked at all — maybe there truly was nothing inside it. I would soon learn how wrong that thought was.

. . .

I leaned against the railing again and looked down.

The sun was sinking little by little. The valley's colors began to shift. The dim gray-brown of daytime caught the evening light and slowly reddened. I watched that change for a long while.

There was one spot where an especially dark shadow lay long across the ground. I tried to tell whether it was the shadow of something, or just a shadow made by a fold in the land. The distance was too great.

In that moment I thought, very briefly, about going down. I didn't hold on to that thought for long. Not that day. I didn't yet know what was down there, and even if I had, that day was already full with a different weight. My brother's letter, the withdrawn application. That was as much weight as the day could hold.

Instead I reached my hand out over the railing. As far as my hand could reach, there was only empty air. I opened and closed my hand in that emptiness a moment. Nothing to grasp. Even knowing that was obvious, I wanted to confirm it.

I only understood that gesture later. I hadn't wanted to touch the valley. I'd wanted to confirm, with my own body, that I couldn't reach it yet. My heart had already crossed that edge; my body was still inside this city. I felt that gap for the first time that day.

I stood there and watched the valley turn completely red. And then watched the red turn back to gray, and then to dark. Once the dark settled in, the valley became invisible altogether. The boundary, the cliff, those dark marks — all of it. As though none of it had ever

been there. That vanishing felt, to me, larger than anything I'd seen by daylight.

. . .

Walking back, I thought again of that man. There's no reason to go. That day, for the first time, I understood fully that this sentence applied to almost everything in this city. There was no well, because there was no reason for one. There was no release, because there was no reason for it. No one went down into the valley, because there was no reason to. All of it was explained by the same sentence. It isn't needed.

I felt, for the first time that night, how frightening a sentence that was. Bad things, mostly, have a reason behind them. If there's a reason, there's something you can fight. If there's no reason, there is no target for the fight at all. That night, for the first time, I understood that this city had no target to fight.

Back at the lodging, I opened the flask. Not much water was left. I didn't drink it all. I left some. I didn't know why. I just wanted to leave some behind.

Outside the window, the city's lights came on one by one. I followed the order they lit with my eyes. Always the same order. Watching that familiar order, my mind kept drifting back to the dark gray and the red I'd seen earlier. This city's lights and that valley's sunset felt like two different languages.

Before falling asleep that night, I had this thought for the first time. I'd thought this city was simply spread out flat, not rising above anything. But in fact there was another layer, underneath. That day I saw that layer for the first time. Having seen one, it

seemed there might be others. That night, for the first time, it occurred to me that this whole city might be a far thicker place than I'd known.

Lying under the covers, I couldn't fall asleep for a long time. When I closed my eyes, I saw that reddening valley again. I'd never once seen that color, anywhere in this city. The city allowed only an exact brightness, an exact shadow. Down there, there was no such exactness. I set it down here honestly — that irregularity frightened me, and yet I found, strangely, that I couldn't look away.

(Continued in Chapter 23.)

Chapter 23. The Ones It Failed

> *_Previously_ — For the first time I stood at the city's edge and looked down into the Dry Valley. No one ever went down there. Not because it was blocked, but because there was no reason to go. I couldn't fall asleep with that landscape still in my eyes.*

The next day I went back to that edge.

I hadn't decided to go. I'd set out to fill the flask at the ration station, and my feet turned that way on their own. I decided not to fight the direction my body wanted.

When I reached the railing, someone was already there.

It was Eikon.

. . .

I was a little surprised.

"…Do you come here often?" I asked.

"…Sometimes."

"…Why?"

Eikon shrugged at the question.

"…No particular reason. I just end up here if I walk long enough."

I didn't quite believe that at face value. There weren't many places in this city people went to without a reason. But I didn't press further.

We leaned against the railing side by side. The valley was the same as yesterday. The dry color, the sparse trees, the dark, stained marks.

"…I saw you standing here yesterday," Eikon said. "From a distance."

"…Why didn't you come over?"

"…You looked like you wanted to be alone."

"…But you came today."

"…Today you didn't look like that."

That distinction made me smile. This girl always read people that way. Accurate, in a way that was a little frightening for being so accurate.

"…Who did you meet here yesterday?" Eikon asked.

"…A man. Carrying a basket."

"…Ah, him." Eikon seemed to know who I meant. "He comes here often too. Like me."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. I never asked. People don't ask that much, in this city."

Hearing that, I realized for the first time that I wasn't the only one who stood at this low railing. It seemed the people of this city, too, sometimes walked out here, for no reason at all.

. . .

"…What's that?" I asked. The same question I'd asked the man yesterday.

Eikon didn't hesitate at all with that question.

"…The valley."

"…I know that. I mean what's down there. Those dark marks."

Eikon looked down for a moment. Then she spoke, in a tone as unaffected as ever.

"…Traces."

"…Traces of who?"

"…Of the people whose preservation failed."

I heard that and my body went stiff. Eikon's tone hadn't changed in the slightest. The exact same tone she'd use to talk about the weather.

. . .

"…Failed?" I asked back. "It can fail?"

"…Very rarely. It isn't something that happens often, to begin with."

"…How does it fail?"

Eikon thought for a moment before answering. A face choosing her explanation, not a face of discomfort.

"…Preservation starts with registering the person who's brought in. Their name, their record, who they are. If that registration doesn't finish properly, the preservation doesn't finish properly either."

"…What happens if it doesn't finish?"

"…It simply doesn't happen. That person doesn't remain in the preserved state."

"…Then what? What happens to them?"

"…Just — as they were before. A body that gets sick, grows old, stops."

Hearing that answer, I felt the strength go out of my knees.

"…How often does that happen?" I asked. "That kind of failure."

"…I don't know exactly. But it's supposed to be very rare. Rare enough that most people here go their whole lives without hearing of it even once."

"…But you know about it."

"…I heard it as a child. From my parents. Just that such a thing exists."

"…Weren't you scared? Back then?"

Eikon looked into that question for a moment.

"…I was a child too, back then. Not so much scared — I just thought, so there's such a thing in the world too. Most people here take it that way. Like bad weather. Not common, but not something that never happens either."

That comparison sent a chill through me. Bad weather. This city called a person's complete disappearance something on the order of weather.

. . .

"…Sometimes records get damaged, too," Eikon went on. "Among people registered a very long time ago, sometimes the record ages until it can't be read anymore. If that happens, the preservation tied to that record ends along with it."

"…When does that happen? At registration, or later?"

"…Mostly at registration, they say. Damage happening later is supposed to be almost unheard of."

That answer gave me a very small measure of relief. It didn't apply to my mother and brother. Their records had been intact for seven years.

"…So," I asked again, "do all those failed people end up down there?"

"…Yes. More precisely, their traces do. Whether it's the body, or whatever's left."

"…Why there, of all places?"

Eikon couldn't answer that question.

"…I don't know. It's just always been that way. I only know what I've been taught."

. . .

"…Doesn't it make you sad?" I asked. A different version of the question I'd already thrown at her once, in Chapter 14.

Eikon looked genuinely puzzled at that.

"…Why would it be sad?"

"…A person died. That's what failing means, in the end, isn't it."

"…It failed. No one did anything wrong. The registration didn't go through, and that's just what happened."

That distinction felt foreign to me. Outside, failure and fault often sat in the same place. When something failed, people went looking for someone to blame. In this city, that link itself seemed not to exist.

"…Have you ever been down there?"

"…No. There's no reason to go."

Hearing that answer, I heard the man's words from yesterday layered over it. There's no reason to go. It felt like this whole city had memorized the same sentence.

. . .

In that moment a number came to me.

Eleven.

Seven years ago, eleven people came from our settlement to this city. They were the sick. I'd received word that nine of them had been preserved. What had happened to the remaining two was written nowhere in that bulletin.

I stood there and counted that number again. Eleven minus nine. Two.

"…Eikon." I asked. My voice shook. "If — say a person came to this city, and no word ever came about whether they were preserved or not. What would that mean?"

Eikon looked at my face for a long time at that question. A face that had noticed something.

"…That usually means they failed."

. . .

I heard that answer and had nothing to say.

I unhooked the flask and opened and closed the cap. My hands were shaking. I gripped the flask harder to try to stop the shaking.

"…It's not certain, though," I finally said. "That no word means failure. It could be some other reason."

"…What other reason could there be?"

I couldn't answer that question. No other reason truly came to mind. I'd simply hoped there was one.

"…What did the bulletin say, exactly?" Eikon asked.

I still had that sentence memorized. A sentence I'd read over and over.

"…'The subject has been stably preserved, and a visit may be requested at any time.' That's what was written for the nine. For the other two, nothing at all was written."

Eikon heard that and nodded. There was no hesitation in that nod.

"…Then they failed. There was nothing to write, so nothing was written. If it's good news, this place writes all of it down."

I wanted to argue with that certainty, but I had no words to argue with. I think I'd already known it myself. I'd only not wanted to admit it.

I set this down beforehand, in Chapter 1. That of the eleven, nine were preserved, and what became of the remaining two was never written. And I wrote that I would learn later where those two had gone. This is that place.

I don't know those two people's names. I don't know their faces. I know nothing about them, beyond that they were carried away from our settlement together. But in that moment I knew that somewhere down there, there might be traces of those two people whose faces I'd never known.

"…Is there any way to confirm it?" I asked. "Whether those two are really down there."

Eikon shook her head.

"…Without a name, there's no way to confirm it. They were never registered here to begin with."

I felt that answer as cruel. Eikon's tone was still not cruel at all. Only the fact was.

. . .

We stood there in silence for a moment. The wind blew up from below again. I couldn't tell whether it was the same wind as yesterday, or a different one.

"…Are you all right?" Eikon asked. For the first time, something like worry showed on her face as she looked at me.

"…I don't know."

"…Did I say something wrong?"

"…No. You just told me the truth."

Eikon looked a little relieved at that. Watching her face, I confirmed again that she hadn't meant to hurt me. She'd only said what she knew.

That day, for the first time, I saw Eikon's composure differently. Up until then, I'd only thought that composure came from having no lack. That day it was different. That composure existed, too, because death itself had already become a very distant thing in this city. The preserved don't die. The failed aren't even registered. This city had never had a place set aside for grief, from the start.

"…Are you going to go down?" Eikon asked.

I couldn't answer that question right away.

"…I don't know."

"…What would change, if you went down? You don't even know their names."

I couldn't answer that question either. She was right. Going to look for two people whose names I didn't even know made no sense. And yet in that moment I felt some corner of my heart already leaning that way.

Eikon stood quietly beside me. She didn't hurry me. She just looked down with me.

. . .

That afternoon I went to find the Curator. There was something I wanted to confirm.

"…You said nine of the eleven sent word back," I said. "Why did the other two never send any?"

The Curator took out a folder and leafed through it. It took a while, as though the record were an old one.

"…This is a record from seven years ago. Here it is." He set his finger on a page. "Nine people, registration completed. The remaining two…" He paused a moment. "…it says here, registration incomplete."

"…What does that mean?"

"…Exactly what Eikon told you. It means the preservation procedure never finished going through."

"…What were those two people's names?"

The Curator looked over the page again. He shook his head.

"…Without registration, there's no name either. I'm sorry."

That "I'm sorry" put me at ease, oddly enough. It was the first time anyone in this city had apologized to me. Everyone else had only stated facts. This man stated the fact and was sorry about it too.

"…Are they down in that valley too?" I asked.

"…Probably. I can't promise you that. But it's by far the most likely thing."

I heard that answer and rose from my seat. There was nothing more to ask. There had been — but it felt like nothing more would change the answer.

At the door, the Curator called me back once more.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…Not many people come to ask about this kind of thing."

"…Why not?"

"…Most people just remember the number nine. It's easier to forget the two."

I had no answer to that. I too had nearly forgotten those two, for seven years. I'd lived content with the number nine.

. . .

I went back to that edge again. Eikon was already gone.

I looked down alone again. The dark marks were still there. I couldn't tell which of them, if any, were the traces of the two people who'd come from my settlement. It seemed I would never be able to tell.

I didn't go down into the valley that day. It wasn't yet the time. But from that moment on, what lay down there was no longer, for me, a strange landscape. Down there might be the trace of someone I knew. No face, no name, but someone I knew all the same.

Walking back to the lodging, I counted those eleven people again. I didn't remember their faces exactly. I'd been nine. But a few pieces

remained. Someone's cough, a child carried on someone's back, an old woman waving from a doorway.

I couldn't tell which of those fragments belonged to those two people. I probably never will. I found it strangely troubling that I couldn't write their names in this account. I had never learned how to mourn someone with no name.

That night, for the first time, I felt relief that my mother and brother had been among the nine. And I was ashamed of that relief. The boundary between nine and two had been pure chance. I couldn't tell whether I should be grateful for that chance, or sorry for it.

That day, for the first time, I saw a small gap in this city's perfection. Perpetuity has never once broken its promise. The preserved truly do not disappear. But that promise applied only to those whose registration was finished. For those never registered, there had never been a promise to begin with, to keep or to break. I would only understand later that this gap wasn't a flaw in this city, but proof that this city was honest. This city never made a promise it couldn't keep.

(Continued in Chapter 24.)

Chapter 24. The Sound of Water

> *_Previously_ — I learned what had become of two of the eleven who'd*
> *come with us from the settlement. The traces of those whose registration was never finished go down into the Dry Valley. I didn't go down that day. But the landscape was no longer strange to*
> *me.*

The days after that passed without much happening.

More precisely, nothing much seemed to happen, from the outside. I didn't go to see my mother, or my brother. I ran into Eikon twice or so, but we didn't talk long. I counted those days. Four of them.

I felt the temptation to skip these four days in this account. Nothing had happened, after all. But the fact that nothing happened was itself a rare thing in this book. Up until then I'd run into something new every day. Why, I'll do it, the ones it failed. For four days I ran into nothing at all. I only walked, went to the ration station, and slept.

During those four days I went to the valley's edge twice more. No one was there. I stood alone, looked down, and came back. I wasn't trying to find anything. It only seemed that the landscape had found its place inside my days by then.

I didn't take out the application again during those days, either. Four of my five fingers had broken, and one I'd hidden away myself. My brother's application I'd withdrawn with my own hand. I wanted to

set it all down for a while. Setting it down didn't mean giving up. I just wanted to breathe a little.

Looking back on those four days, I think they were the quietest stretch in this whole book. Quiet didn't mean peaceful. I spent those days still waiting for something. I didn't know exactly what.

On the third day the attendant at the ration station greeted me a little differently.

"…You've been quiet lately," he said.

"…Yeah. I guess so."

"…Are you all right?"

I couldn't answer that question right away. It wasn't common for someone in this city to ask after me first.

"…I don't know. I think I'm waiting for something."

"…For what?"

"…I don't know either."

The attendant didn't add anything more to that answer. He just filled the flask and handed it back. Taking the water, I felt again how strange the word "waiting" sounded in this city. People here rarely had anything to wait for. They could get what they wanted when they wanted it.

On the fourth day I ran into Eikon in the garden. She spoke first.

"…You haven't been asking lately," Eikon said.

"…Asking what?"

"…You used to ask all the time. Doesn't it frustrate you, isn't it sad, that kind of thing."

I smiled a little at that. She was right.

"…I think I understand now. Even without asking."

"…Understand what?"

"…That you really are all right."

Eikon heard that and stared at me for a moment. Not a surprised face. Just a face confirming something.

"…Finally figured it out."

I laughed again at that answer. This time she laughed too. A short laugh. And yet it was the lightest moment of those few days. I wanted to hold on to that lightness for a long while, but it wasn't the kind of thing that stretched the longer you held it.

. . .

On the evening of the fifth day, I was sitting by the window in my room.

It was not long past sunset. The city's lights were coming on one by one. I followed the order with my eyes for a while, then stopped. It was an order I'd already counted more than once.

The flask sat beside me. Nearly empty. I fiddled with its cap, thinking I'd have to fill it the next morning.

I still remember that evening clearly. I thought it would be an evening with nothing to it. It had been that way four days running, so I assumed the fifth would be the same.

A little wind came in through the gap in the window. Not a common wind, in this city. I leaned into it slightly.

. . .

That was when I heard the sound.

At first I didn't know what it was. Very faint. Mixed in with the city's other sounds, I couldn't be sure whether it was really a sound at all, or just my own imagining.

I held my breath and listened.

It came again. A little clearer this time. Something being dragged. Then something unspooling. Long, at a steady pace.

In that moment I felt my body react before my mind did. Before I could think, my hand had already gone to the windowsill. I knew this sound before I'd even realized I knew it.

. . .

It was the sound of a well rope unspooling.

I'd heard that sound since I was born. At our settlement's well, several times a day. The particular friction of the rope paying out, and the creak of the wooden pulley taking it up. Then a short

stillness. And at the end, far off and small, a splash — water touched.

I knew the order of that sound exactly. The drag, the unspooling, the stillness, the splash. I'd grown up counting those four beats. The same beats my brother had once been afraid of.

I already wrote down this sound in Chapter 1. The sound my brother had been afraid of, until one day, out of nowhere, he said he liked it. Because it meant his brother was there, and that was good. I had never once forgotten that sound, in seven years.

I closed my eyes and gave myself over entirely to the sound. The drag — I knew that was the rope going over the pulley. The unspool — the bucket falling, the rope paying out behind it. The stillness in between was the time the bucket spent crossing empty air. Its length told you the depth of the well. I counted that stillness. One, two, three, four. Only after four did the splash come.

Four beats. I remembered that number as though it had been carved into my fingers. Our settlement's well had been three. This one was deeper than that. I don't know why that difference stayed with me so strongly. Probably because that single number told me this wasn't the well I knew — it was an entirely new well.

I thought, too, of the water jar my mother had filled the night before she left. The water we'd left three days undrunk, gone bad on the fourth day and thrown out. I still remembered the weight of that jar exactly, its smell, the moment I'd cried for the first time, pouring that water away. I couldn't say why that memory rose up now, of all times. But the sound kept calling it back.

And that sound, I was hearing again, in this city without water.

. . .

I sprang up from my seat.

I looked out the window. The sound seemed to be coming from the east side of the city. I couldn't judge the exact direction. But from the nature of the sound, it wasn't close by. And yet, in this city's stillness, it carried through with perfect clarity.

I opened the window a little wider. The sound grew louder. The drag, the unspooling, the stillness, and this time, a little louder — the splash.

In that moment I realized how long I'd been waiting for this sound. Realizing it startled me. It was strange, to have been waiting for something without even knowing I was waiting for it.

I looked around the room. I wondered whether anyone else had heard this sound. I looked out over the city through the window. Everyone was moving about as usual. No one stopped walking. No one turned toward the sound.

That day I confirmed, with my own eyes, that this city truly did not hear sound. It wasn't that they couldn't hear it. That sound was clearly loud enough to hear. It was only that no one had any reason to respond to it. However loud a sound might be, if it was a sound no one needed, it wasn't a sound at all, in this city.

Footsteps sounded on the floor below. Another lodger. I threw the window open wide and called down.

"…Do you hear that?" I called down.

The person stopped walking and looked up at me.

"…Hear what?"

"…That sound, over there. Sounds like something dragging."

The person made a show of listening for a moment. Then shook their head.

"…Hm. Can't say I do."

For a moment that answer made me doubt whether I'd misheard. But the sound was still there, clear as ever. The drag, the unspooling, the stillness, the splash. I couldn't tell whether that person truly couldn't hear it, or heard it and simply let it pass.

"…Right. Sorry to bother you," I said.

The person nodded once and walked on. I watched their back and left the window open instead of closing it.

. . .

I stood there and listened to nothing but that sound for a long while.

The drag. The unspooling. The stillness. The splash.

I counted the beats with my fingers, pressing down on each one. Once, twice, three times. Someone was drawing water again and again. It wasn't a sound that ended after one round.

I think now that the repetition was, more than anything else, the proof. If it had happened only once, it could have been chance. Could have been the sound of something dropped by accident. But the sound

kept going. It was the rhythm of someone at work. I know that rhythm. Different from the rhythm I learned at the old man's side, and yet the same kind of rhythm. Not hurried, and yet never stopping.

This city has no well. I'd known that fact from my very first day in the city. The ration station handed out water. The preserved needed none, and the living received only their allotted share and drank it. I'd been the only person in this city who carried a flask around with him.

And yet right now, somewhere out there, someone was drawing water from a well.

. . .

I stepped back from the window and stood in the middle of the room.

I ran through a few possibilities. Had the ration station brought in some new equipment? No — that sound wasn't coming from the ration station's direction. The direction was wrong. Was someone digging something, on their own? But no one in this city dug into the ground. There was no reason to.

Crossing out those possibilities one by one, I found only one left standing. Someone was digging a well. Something no one had done since this city was built, someone was doing right now.

I tried to imagine who that person might be. It didn't seem like anyone from this city. People here always said there was no reason to dig a well. That meant it would have to be someone from outside, like me — and yet I'd never once seen another outsider in this city besides myself.

In that moment, for the first time, I found myself curious. That there might be another person from outside, here in this city besides me. I felt that curiosity outweigh any fear. A strange thing. A stranger was doing a strange thing, and I wasn't afraid. If anything, I was glad.

I tried to count how much time had passed since the sound began. I couldn't count it exactly. While I was listening to the sound, I couldn't count anything else.

. . .

I picked up the flask. Nearly empty. I stood there a moment, feeling that lightness in my fingertips.

In that moment I ran back, one by one, through everything that had happened to me in this city. My mother's "Why?" My brother's "I'll do it." The withdrawn application. The trace of two people whose names I didn't know. For the first time I strung all of it together into a single line. This city was a place without thirst. Without thirst, there was no wanting; without wanting, there was no consent. I couldn't lay out that connection in exact words, in that moment. But I felt it in my body.

I would unpack that evening's thought in much greater detail, much later. Here I set down only the thread of it. That the sound of water had returned to a city without water. I believed then, and I believe now, that it wasn't a coincidence.

Writing this chapter, I've thought many times about why I didn't run straight out that night. It wouldn't have been strange if I had bolted the moment I heard the sound. But I didn't. I stood there and

wanted to listen a little longer. Before confirming anything, I just wanted to listen.

The drag. The unspooling. The stillness. The splash.

I heard those beats again and again. Outside, the city's lights began going out, one by one. This city's night slept on a fixed schedule. But that sound alone never went out. It continued late into the night.

I lay down without closing the window. I wanted to fall asleep to that sound.

Closing my eyes, I saw the well at the settlement again. The path my brother used to walk behind me on. My mother's words, patting his back. Why make something scarier when he's already scared. I hadn't thought of those words in a long while. This city was a place afraid of nothing. Because there was nothing here to be afraid of — I'd already written that, back in Chapter 1. But the sound I was hearing now seemed to be waking something this city had forgotten long ago.

That night I didn't yet know what this sound was waking. If I had known, I wouldn't have fallen asleep so easily. Looking back now, I think that ignorance was, if anything, the last peace I was allowed that night.

The sound of water went on past midnight. The drag, the unspooling, the stillness, the splash. Instead of counting those four beats, I simply let my body go. It had been a long time since I'd heard a sound without counting it — only listening.

I slept deeply that night, for the first time in a long while. It was the most restful sleep I'd had since coming to this city. The

next morning, I decided to follow that sound. That is what happens in the next part of this account.

Ever since I came into this city, I'd felt as though I were standing in front of a door. In front of the people who do not disappear, in front of the words it can be reversed*, in front of the question *why*. This time was different. This time, for the first time, someone on the other side of the door was already making a sound of their own. All I had to do was follow it.*

(Continued in Part Three.)

The Dry Valley, Part Three

The Valley

Chapter 25. The Well-Keeper

> *_Previously_ — an unfamiliar sound came from outside the city. I knew it*
> *at once, because I'd grown up outside. The sound of a bucket going down,*
> *a rope paying out, and at the end, a splash. Someone was drawing water.*
> *This city had no well.*

I followed the sound.

I left the dormitory and walked east. In this city, you almost never have to follow a sound while you walk. There's so little sound to begin with. Footsteps, sometimes a door opening and closing — that's all. So an unfamiliar sound was easy to track, even from far away.

On the way I passed three people. All walking the same direction. No one hurried, and no one looked at me. I noticed that none of the three so much as turned toward the sound. They must have heard it. In a city this quiet, there was no way they hadn't.

I thought it was strange, at the time. I understood later. It wasn't strange. People in this city simply don't listen to sounds they don't need. Not that they can't hear them — they choose not to. It took me a while to see the difference.

It was at the eastern edge of the city, well past even the distribution station. There had originally been nothing there. I'd passed that stretch of ground on my first day here. Dry soil, a few weeds — that was all.

Now there was a pit.

About waist-deep on me. Wide enough that two people standing across from each other would touch shoulders. Beside it, the dug-out earth was piled like a small mountain, and a bucket and rope hung over the mound.

The water flask at my waist swung against my hip. My uncle had given it to me before he left. "No water there, they say." I hadn't known what that meant, then. I only understood once I reached the city. There really was no well. Only the distribution station.

I had never once emptied that flask all the way. I'd drink half, then refill it at the station. But in that moment, for the first time, the flask felt heavy. I didn't know why.

There was a man in the pit.

Tall, broad-shouldered. Old sun on his forearms. Even from a distance I could see the thick calluses on the hand gripping the shovel. His clothes weren't the clothes of this city. The color had faded, and the knees had been patched twice over.

I stood there a long while, watching.

He gave no sign of having seen me and kept digging. Drive the shovel in, step on it, lift the earth, throw it up. There was a rhythm to it. Unhurried, but never stopping.

I know that rhythm. I learned it at fourteen. There are two kinds of digging. Digging in a hurry, and digging built to last. The hurried kind wears out in an hour. The lasting kind goes all day. This man was the lasting kind.

"…If you're just going to stand there watching, pour some water."

The voice came up out of the pit. It took me a beat to realize he was talking to me.

"…What?"

"You've got a flask. That one."

He meant the flask at my waist. I was the only person in this city who carried one around. The preserved didn't need water, and the living took what they needed from the station, as they needed it. I was the only one who kept a flask on me all the time.

"…I'm going to drink this."

"…I know. Just give me a little. The dirt's too dry to dig."

I unhooked the flask and went to the edge of the pit. The man set his shovel down for a moment and held out his hand. I passed it over. He poured half of it onto the dirt floor and struck the spot with the shovel a few times. I watched the earth go soft.

"…Thanks." He handed the flask back. "Speon."

"…Anemos."

"…Anemos." He repeated the name once. Then he picked the shovel back up. "Wind."

I didn't answer that. It was the first time I'd met someone who knew what my name meant. No one in this city had ever asked. They had no reason to.

I let that one line pass by, at the time. I understood later. Speon wasn't a man who said what a name meant carelessly. When he said it, there was always a reason. It was only much later that he told me what the reason was.

. . .

I kept standing there.

I looked down into the pit. The soil was red on top and gray farther down. I knew what that meant — the old man had taught me. Red earth is the dry layer, gray earth is the trace of where moisture once passed through. Gray means water crossed this ground at some point.

"…Has water gone through here before?" I asked.

Speon looked up at me, still holding the shovel. For the first time his face showed a little surprise.

"…How'd you know that."

"…The color of the dirt."

"…Someone taught you."

"…Yes. An old man." I paused, then added. "He's gone now."

Speon nodded. He didn't say anything comforting. He just nodded. I found that easier, somehow. In this city, people didn't know how to say comforting things anymore. There was nothing left to be sad about. Speon's nod was better than any comforting word.

I wrote earlier that I counted that old man's funeral as the ninth of seventeen. I'll set it down again here. He died in winter. On the last day he called me over and had me hold his hand. A man who rarely spoke said a little more that day. "…One of the wells you dig is sure to come up dry." "…Why?" "…So you'll have a reason to dig the next one." I didn't understand it then. I thought success every time would only be better. I

know now. A person who only succeeds stops. You need one failure mixed in to keep digging.

"…There was a water channel down here." Speon started digging again as he said it. "It got blocked, a long time ago. Earth built up."

"…Why did it get blocked?"

"…Because no one used it. Unused things get blocked. People and water channels are the same that way."

"…There's no well here," I said.

"…I know. That's why I'm digging."

"…Did someone ask you to?"

Speon stopped digging and looked up at me. His eyes were a light brown. His face showed no irritation at all.

"…No."

"…Then why dig?"

He drove the shovel into the earth pile. Then he straightened his back. It made a sound. It meant he'd been bent over a long time.

"…Water that just sits rots." He said it. "It has to flow to stay alive."

I didn't understand what he meant. This city didn't even have anywhere for water to sit still in the first place. There was no well. And yet Speon spoke as if he were talking about water that was already sitting somewhere, stagnant.

"…This city doesn't have water," I said. "There's nothing to sit still."

"…There is." Speon said. "It's not only water that's missing."

Then he picked the shovel back up. He didn't explain any further. I didn't fully understand what he meant, not that day.

I know now. The water he meant wasn't well water. This whole city was standing water. People sitting exactly as they were seven years ago. Things that never changed. That was what Speon was talking about, and I was still listening as if it were only about a real well.

. . .

I started counting the mounds of dirt.

Each swing of the shovel brought up one heap. I have a habit of counting things. Somewhere around the hundredth swing, I asked.

"…Have you dug a lot of these?"

"…A lot."

"…How many?"

Speon's face went thoughtful for a moment. He didn't look like a man who kept count. And yet his answer was exact.

"…Thirty-seven."

"…Did they all work?"

"…No. Thirty-one came up with water. Six didn't."

"…What about the ones that didn't?"

"…Left them as they were. Thought about filling them back in, but I didn't."

"…Why not?"

"…Someone might come dig further, someday. Water I couldn't find, someone else might."

I liked that answer. A man who admitted failure without sealing it back up afterward. I'd seen very few people like that. In this city, failed things went down into the valley. They weren't left standing so someone could try again.

"…Where are you from?" I asked.

"…Here and there." Speon gave a short laugh. "Once, in some city, I saw a bridge that only had half of itself built. I had three friends then, and one of them helped finish that bridge."

"…And now?"

"…Scattered. Everyone went their own way. I'm a well-digger, so I keep moving."

I didn't ask who those three friends were, that day. I had no reason to. It sounded to me like an ordinary old story of Speon's, and I still didn't know then what he'd done before he came to this city. Later I would hear that bridge story again. That belongs to the last pages of this record.

. . .

Still, I couldn't make myself leave. I wasn't sure why, even to myself. I just liked the sound of the digging. Earth being lifted, the occasional knock against a stone, the low sound of Speon's breath going out. It wasn't the sound of water, but it was a sound for water's sake.

"…How many people have come?" I asked. "To watch you dig here."

"…You're the first."

"…No one's come at all?"

"…A few passing by. They looked, then moved on."

"…Didn't they say anything?"

Speon lifted a shovelful of earth as he answered.

"…Nothing to say, I guess. No need for it."

I heard that and looked back toward the city. Far off I could see the Curator's building. People walked by, quietly. That was how everyone in this city moved, always — quiet, unhurried, only as much as was needed.

Every time I look back on this moment, I feel a strange unease. I expected the city to get angry. A well was, after all, a thing this city had declared it didn't need. But no one got angry. That was somehow heavier. If they'd been angry, there would have been something to fight. With no anger, there was nothing to fight at all.

. . .

The sun began to set. Speon kept digging.

"…What about food?" I asked.

"…I've got some." He tipped his chin toward a small sack beside the earth pile. "Dried stuff."

"…Water?"

"…I'll have to take a bit more off your flask."

I laughed. It was the first time I'd laughed since coming to this city. It lasted a few seconds. But it was a real laugh.

I counted those few seconds afterward. In seven years I never counted the days I laughed. There was nothing much to count. Coming to this city gave me a reason to count — laughter had grown rare. I wrote earlier that counting had become a habit of mine; from that day on, laughter became one more thing I counted.

I unhooked the flask again and handed it over. Speon drank a little and gave it back.

"…Will you be back tomorrow too?" I asked.

"…I'm going to be here the whole time."

"…How long is that?"

"…Until the water comes."

"…When's that?"

Speon pressed his palm flat against the dirt floor. Then he closed his eyes for a moment. He looked like someone listening for something. I didn't know, at the time, what that gesture was.

"…Don't know." He opened his eyes. "Water comes out when it comes out."

"…You can't rush it?"

"…Rush it and all you get is a collapse."

I heard that and looked at the walls of the pit. They really were packed firm and solid. The mark of digging that hadn't been rushed.

I found myself wondering again about the gesture I'd seen earlier.

"…You put your hand down and closed your eyes before. What was that?"

"…Listening."

"…To what?"

"…Where the water wants to go."

I didn't know what that meant, so I stayed quiet. Speon motioned for me to put my own hand down and try. I crouched and did it. The dirt was just dirt. Cold and hard.

"…I don't hear anything."

"…No one does, at first." Speon said. "It's not listening, really. It's waiting. If you keep your hand there long enough, the earth forgets what it's been hiding. Then you hear a little."

I couldn't say I understood that. But strangely, the words frightened me. Waiting until the earth forgot what it was hiding — somehow, that sounded like this city's story.

I didn't see the connection then. This city, too, had been hiding something for a long time. It wasn't that the people wanted nothing — they had forgotten how to want. What Speon said to the earth, I would later hear him say to the whole city.

. . .

That day I didn't go back to the city. I stayed sitting beside him a while longer.

Speon didn't say anything more to me. He just kept digging. I watched. It had been a long time since I'd had anything to watch. There wasn't much worth watching in this city. Everyone moved exactly the same way.

Walking back to my assigned room that night, I remembered something my mother once said to me. When my brother was afraid of the sound of water, she told me, "Getting used to something and not being afraid of it aren't the same thing." I wanted to hand that line back to Speon that day. This city had gotten too used to living without a well. But that didn't mean it didn't need water.

I didn't say it that day. I couldn't say it the next day either. It would be a long time before I could say it at all.

On my way back to the dormitory I looked back three times. The sound of digging still came from the pit. It was growing dark, and still Speon didn't stop.

Listening to that sound, I had a thought for the first time.

There's someone in this city who keeps going, even when he's told he isn't needed.

That thought stayed in my head all that night. I still didn't know what it meant. I only held onto it, for a long time.

This was around my twenty-third morning in the city. Every day since I'd arrived, I'd counted something — the number of visits, the time I'd spent standing at the window, the count of sentences my mother had said

identically. But that night, for the first time, I counted something else. I couldn't count how many times Speon swung the shovel, but I counted exactly how many times I laughed. Once.

One. But that one was a different kind of number from the ones I'd counted before. Not a number that only went down. A number that could go up.

Just before the sun finished setting, one person passed by.

A girl. A year younger than me, walking slowly — the same unhurried walk everyone in this city had. I knew her face.

It was Eikon.

She stopped for a moment in front of the pit. She looked at Speon, then at me, then back at the pit. She said nothing. Her face showed almost nothing. Not surprised, not curious — just a face that was looking.

I thought she'd say something. But she said nothing at all and started walking again. A few steps on, she turned back exactly once.

I remember that retreating figure for a long time afterward. Not surprised, not dismissive. Just the back of someone who had looked at something that had nothing to do with her. I didn't know it that day, but that would become how this whole city treated Speon. Not angry, not stopping him — just regarding him as something that had nothing to do with them.

"…Someone you know?" Speon asked.

"…Yes. Fifteen years old. Preserved seven years ago."

Speon drove the shovel in once more.

"…This city must have a lot of people like that."

"…Yes."

"…Does everyone look at it like that?"

I couldn't answer right away. Thinking about it, it really was true. No one got angry, no one was curious. Everyone gave it exactly that much attention — the attention you'd give something that had nothing to do with you.

"…Yes. Everyone's like that."

Speon heard that and paused his hand for a moment. Then, as if it were nothing much, he went back to lifting earth.

"…Guess I'd better keep digging, then." He said it. He didn't explain why. I didn't know the weight of that line yet, either.

Once the sun had fully set, stars came out. Almost no one in this city looks at the stars. The preserved don't go out at night without reason, and the living go to sleep at their set hour. But that night I sat by the pit and looked at the stars for a long time.

Outside, I'd looked at stars every night. The old man taught me directions by the constellations. In the settlement, that had been useful knowledge. In this city, it was useless. No one here ever needed to find their direction at night. Wherever you went, the path was already set.

That night I found myself thinking, after a long while, about useless knowledge. The names of constellations, the knots the old man taught me, how to read the color of soil. Since coming to this city I'd thought all of it had become useless. Sitting beside Speon that night, I felt for the

first time that it wasn't that. It hadn't become useless — it had simply had nowhere to be used. Speon was making a place for it to be used again.

. . .

The next morning I went back to that spot. On the way, I didn't prepare any words to explain why I was going. I couldn't remember the last time I'd gone somewhere that didn't require me to have words ready.

The pit was a little deeper than the day before. Speon was already down inside it. He saw me and, without any greeting, said this.

"…Flask."

I laughed and unhooked it.

That day I went by way of the distribution station. In front of it, as always, a short line stood waiting. Only the living stand in that line. Standing in it, I had a strange thought for the first time. The station hands out water. Exactly as much as is needed. A well doesn't hand anything out. It just comes up. Whoever needs it draws it themselves.

I thought about that difference for the first time that day. Rationing is handing out something fixed. A well is simply something that's there. One is given by whoever manages it; the other is given by the ground itself, for nothing. This city only had the first kind. Speon had brought the second.

The station attendant looked at my flask and asked.

"…Refilling again?"

"…Yes."

"…You filled it yesterday too."

"…I shared it."

The attendant tilted his head. His face said he didn't understand what sharing a portion meant. Here, no one ever had reason to give their share to someone else. Everyone needed only exactly their own.

I took the water and walked back toward the pit. On the way I passed the spot where Eikon had turned back the day before. No one was there. Only a couple of footprints left in the dirt.

I looked at those footprints a moment. Then I kept walking.

When I reached the pit, Speon was already down halfway again. The depth had grown by a hand's width since the day before. I sat down beside it and checked the color of the soil. Still red. Gray was still a long way off.

"…How much more do you have to dig?" I asked.

"…Don't know." Speon said. "Until the red earth ends."

"…How much is that?"

"…You find out by digging."

I liked that answer better than any answer I'd heard in this city. This city knew everything in advance. Visiting hours, ration amounts, procedures. There wasn't a single thing done without already knowing how it would turn out. Speon was doing this without knowing. And even so, he never wavered.

I couldn't put that difference into words then. I can now. This city moves knowing the outcome already. Since the outcome is fixed, there's nothing new to learn. Speon moves without knowing the outcome. So every day is a day of learning something new. I wanted to stay beside that kind of day.

(Continued in Chapter 26.)

Chapter 26. We Don't Need One

> *_Previously_ — Speon began digging a well at the eastern edge of the*
> *city. No one had asked him to. "Water that just sits rots. It has to flow to stay alive." That was all he said. Every day I went and watched,*
> *sharing my water with him. Eikon passed by once and looked without a*
> *word.*

From the second night on, word began to spread.

The way rumor traveled in this city was different from outside. Outside, a rumor grows as it spreads. A story about one person dying can go around a village once and come back as three people dying. Nothing like that happened here. However many people passed a sentence along, it never lost a single syllable from the original. Someone's digging a well at the eastern edge. That sentence went all the way around the city and came back unchanged.

I found that remarkable. A city that doesn't lie has rumors that travel honestly too. They don't swell and they don't shrink. So in this city there was never any reason to be frightened by a rumor. You were only ever as frightened as the fact itself. And in this case, the fact wasn't a frightening one. Someone's digging. That was all it was.

On the third morning, someone came.

Not the station attendant. His clothes were different — gray, with a small emblem on the collar. I'd seen that emblem before, on the

Curator's building.

The man stopped in front of the pit and looked down at Speon.

"…What are you doing here?"

"…Digging a well." Speon answered without pausing his shovel.

"…Do you have a permit for this?"

"…No."

The man nodded. His face wasn't angry. Just a face confirming a fact.

"…This city doesn't need a well," he said. "The preserved have no need of water, and the living are supplied their fixed ration at the distribution station."

"…I know that."

"…Then why are you digging?"

Speon paused his shovel for a moment. He brushed off dirt and looked at the man.

"…Not needing it isn't the same as not digging."

The man nodded again at that. He didn't argue. He just wrote something in what looked like a notebook.

"…Understood. This isn't dangerous work, so I won't stop it. I'm simply informing you. It isn't needed."

Then he turned and left.

Watching him walk away, I felt a little foolish for having expected something momentous. Only then did I notice my palms had gone sweaty. I'd seen this kind of situation many times outside. Someone does something without permission, people come to stop them, an argument breaks out, sometimes it even comes to blows. I must have been waiting for a scene like that. But nothing happened here. A man came, stated one fact, and left.

I've gone back over that exchange in my head more times than I can count. I'd been expecting a fight. I'd expected him to say get a permit, or stop this. He demanded nothing at all. He simply stated a fact and left. It isn't needed. That single line sounded more absolute than any order could have.

. . .

That afternoon, someone else came.

An older woman. She was passing by, then stopped and peered into the pit. There was a little curiosity in her face — a rare expression in this city.

"…What's this?" she asked.

"…A well," Speon answered.

"…What's a well?"

I was startled by the question. It was the first time I'd met someone who didn't know what a well was. Speon wasn't startled at all.

"…A way of getting water from the ground."

"…Ah." The woman nodded. "I thought water came from the distribution station."

"…Station water comes from somewhere too. It's stored there. This is water that just comes straight up from the ground."

The woman thought for a moment.

"…So you don't need to store it?"

"…No. Because it keeps coming."

The woman turned that over in her expression. Then she said,

"…But I've never once been short of water. I always get exactly what I need, when I need it."

"…I'm sure you have," Speon said.

"…Then why is this needed?"

Speon picked his shovel back up.

"…Maybe you'll never need it."

The woman turned away, looking satisfied with that answer. It hadn't been an argument. It was a conversation in which both of them had agreed the other was right. I found that stranger still.

People in this city don't lie. So the woman's "I don't need it" had been true too. She really had never once gone without. And Speon hadn't lied either. "Maybe you'll never need it" was something he really thought, when he said it. Both of them were honest. And yet the two of them were looking at entirely different things.

. . .

That evening, Eikon came again.

This time she wasn't passing through. She walked straight up to the pit. She saw me and, instead of a greeting, asked this.

"…Why are you helping?"

"…It's fun."

"…What's fun about it? Why make something no one needs?"

I didn't know what to say to that, so I looked at Speon. Speon kept digging and just listened to the two of us talk.

"…It might turn out to be needed," I said.

"…I don't lack anything," Eikon said. Her voice wasn't angry. It was the voice of someone genuinely curious. "It's not just me. Everyone here is the same way. So why is this needed?"

I hadn't prepared an answer to that question. I couldn't say she was wrong. It was true — no one in this city was going without water, no one was struggling for it.

"…I don't know," I said honestly.

Eikon nodded at that, as if satisfied. It wasn't that she was mocking me. It was more like a confirmation that her own thinking had been right.

"…Then why dig, if you don't know?"

"…Because Speon is digging."

"…Is that a reason?"

I couldn't answer that one either. Eikon looked down into the pit for a moment. Then she turned and walked away. She hadn't been angry, and she hadn't been mocking. It was simply the walk of someone who hadn't gotten an answer to her question and was going back.

I turned that question over all that night. Is that a reason. Truly, I had no reason beyond the fact that Speon was digging. And yet it hadn't felt like an insufficient one. That was strange. It couldn't be explained by logic, but my mind was already made up.

. . .

On the fourth day, the station attendant himself came.

When I went to refill my flask, he spoke first, before I could.

"…That man digging the well — do you know him?"

"…Yes."

"…We've had a few inquiries. Whether the ration needs adjusting."

"…What did you tell them?"

"…That it doesn't. The current ration is sufficient."

I wanted to say something to that, but nothing came out. It was true that the ration was sufficient. No one died of thirst. No one got angry because the line came up short. The system was running perfectly.

Why does a perfectly running system need new water? I ran into that question every time, and every time I stalled. This city had no words to

answer it with. The ration wasn't lacking. Whatever the well was needed for, it wasn't a shortage. I still hadn't managed to put that into words.

As he filled my flask, the attendant added,

"…But he keeps digging, I hear."

"…Yes."

"…No reason to stop him. It's not dangerous."

"…No."

"…It's just a little remarkable, that's all. Doing it while knowing it isn't needed."

Hearing that, I realized this was the first time someone in this city had felt Speon to be 'remarkable.' Not anger, not interest — some feeling somewhere in between.

. . .

Late that afternoon, three children came running up.

There were children in this city too. Living children, not yet preserved. They were a little different from the adults. They crouched in front of the pit, eyes bright, and asked.

"…Is real water actually going to come out of this?"

"…It will," Speon said.

"…When?"

"…Don't know."

"…If you don't know, why dig?"

I nearly laughed at that. The children were asking the same question the adults asked, only in a different tone. The adults asked it and turned away. The children asked it and didn't turn away.

"…Because it's fun." Speon said. "Want to try?"

One child reached for the shovel, but another grabbed his arm.

"…No. We have to be back at our set time."

"…There's still time left."

"…Still no."

Listening to that exchange, something in me turned strange. These children were growing older. Not yet preserved, and maybe someday to be. By the time this well was finished, some of them might already be doing something else entirely. Or they might already have gone toward the Preserve.

I remembered those children's faces for a long time afterward. Curious faces, and yet faces that turned back exactly on schedule. This city was precise even with its children. It didn't stop their curiosity. It only allowed exactly as much as was set.

The children waved and ran off — right on time, exactly. Watching them go, I thought about how, at that age, I'd played in the water without a thought for the time.

. . .

On the fifth day, I asked Speon.

"…People keep saying it isn't needed. Are you all right with that?"

"…I'm fine."

"…Doesn't it make you angry?"

Speon drove the shovel into the dirt pile and rested a moment.

"…No reason to be angry. They're right."

"…Right? But it's needed. Water is."

"…Not right now. Really. The ration is enough, and the preserved don't drink. What they're saying isn't a lie."

That answer frustrated me.

"…Then why do you keep digging?"

Speon looked at me. There wasn't a trace of irritation or impatience in his eyes.

"…Not needing it now and never needing it aren't the same thing."

I turned that over for a long time. That it wasn't needed now was a fact everyone in this city agreed on. That it would never be needed — no one had ever confirmed that. This city believed it would go on forever exactly as it was now. And that was the city's pride, and its premise. That nothing changes.

"…This city doesn't look like it's going to change," I said.

"…It looks that way," Speon said. "But looking like it doesn't change isn't the same as not changing. It just means the reason to change hasn't come yet."

I turned that over for a long time too.

I heard it, at first, as an argument meant to persuade. I know better now. It wasn't persuasion. Speon wasn't trying to convince anyone. He was simply doing what he believed was right, whether people said it was needed or not. Persuasion demands a response. Speon demanded no response at all.

. . .

Through those six days, I measured the pit's depth every day. There was no proper ruler, so I used my own forearm. The first day, waist-high; the second, chest-high; the third, half my own height; the fourth, a little past half. By the fifth day, Speon had to stand fully inside the pit before even his head was visible.

I wrote down every one of those numbers. I didn't know why, at the time. Thinking of it now, it's because this city had exactly one thing that was changing. The people didn't change. The ration didn't change. The visit procedures didn't change. Only the pit grew a little deeper every day. I was watching something change, for the first time in a long while. That's why I wanted to count it.

That evening, I walked along turning over what the station attendant had said. Remarkable. Doing it while knowing it isn't needed. The words kept circling in my head. Only then did I realize how rare a feeling remarkable was in this city. Surprise was rare, fear was rare, joy was rare. The people of this city lived among things they already fully

knew. Being remarkable is a feeling that needs something unknown to exist at all.

I pictured the attendant's face again. He'd said the ration was sufficient, and in the same breath called it remarkable that Speon kept digging. Both feelings lived inside one person at once. I think that was the most honest reaction this city had. Not needed, and still remarkable. Neither one was a lie.

When I reached the pit, Speon was still digging, late into the evening. I stood beside him that night, for the first time, and told him everything I'd seen so far.

That evening, for the first time, I got angry at Speon. Or not exactly angry — my words just came out sounding angry.

"…It's strange," I said. "No one gets angry, no one stops him, they just say it isn't needed. I find that more frightening than anything."

"…Why is that frightening?"

"…If people got angry, you could fight them. There's nothing to fight here. Because everything they're saying is true."

Speon set down his shovel and looked at me for a long while.

"…Are you talking about this city right now, or about the well?"

I couldn't answer that right away. It was both. Or maybe it had never been two separate things to begin with.

"…I don't know," I said.

"…Neither do I," Speon said. "But once you do know, that's when the reason to dig becomes real. Right now it's just your body doing the

digging."

I fell asleep without understanding what he meant.

. . .

On the sixth morning, a piece of paper was stuck into the ground in front of the pit.

It was an official document from the Preserve. I read it first — I read faster than Speon did.

> *Notice regarding excavation work at this location. The current water*
> *supply system is operating normally across all sectors, and no assessment has found that additional water sources are needed. However, as the work itself has been confirmed to pose no hazard, no*
> *separate action will be taken to stop it. — Office of the Curator*

I read the document aloud to Speon. He listened without stopping his digging.

"…What do you think?"

"…About what?"

"…Doesn't it make you angry?"

"…Why would this make me angry. It's all true."

"…It says they're not even going to stop you."

"…Right. They won't. In this city, people stop something when they have a reason, and don't when they don't. Right now there's no reason to stop me."

I set the paper carefully on top of the dirt pile, weighing it down with a stone so it wouldn't blow away.

I still have that document. It's a document I can't resent anyone over. There's not one lie in it, and not one threat. It simply states the facts, exactly as they are. That's how this city fights. It fights by not fighting.

There was a signature at the bottom of the document. Office of the Curator. Seeing that name, I thought of the Curator himself. The man who had explained the release procedure to me. Kind, and worn thin. I found myself wondering whether he'd written this document himself, or whether someone had written it for him.

I didn't hold onto that question for long, at the time. I learned later. He was a man who wrote documents like this in his own hand. He didn't leave it to others. Whatever he decided, he put his own name to it. I would come to understand why, much later, the first time I saw his face turn sad.

I read the paper over once more. Every sentence was exact. No exaggeration, no understatement. I couldn't explain, at the time, why that exactness felt so chilling. I can now. An exact statement has no gaps in it. And with no gap, there's nowhere to dig in.

. . .

That afternoon, I sat on the edge of the pit for the first time, swinging my legs, and thought.

No one in this city hated Speon. No one tried to drive him out. Everyone, politely, precisely, only ever said it wasn't needed. And every word of that was true.

I sensed then, dimly, that this was a stronger defense than any argument. Getting angry means acknowledging your opponent — admitting they're worth fighting. This city didn't grant Speon even that much acknowledgment. It simply treated him as something that had nothing to do with it.

Speon accepted that treatment. He never felt wronged by it. I felt, for the first time, caught between those two postures. The city's quiet indifference, and Speon's quiet persistence. Neither one showed anger. And yet they were exact opposites.

As the sun began to lean toward evening, Speon climbed out of the pit and brushed off his hands.

"…Want to try digging a little yourself tomorrow?" he asked.

I couldn't answer right away. I wanted to. But it struck me as strange how quickly I'd come to want it. I'd come here to bring my family back. I hadn't come here to dig a well.

"…I'm not here to work," I said.

"…I know," Speon said. "What does that have to do with trying a shovel once?"

I couldn't answer that either. I'd thought there was some connection. When I tried to put it into words, there wasn't one.

"…I'll think about it."

Speon smiled. It was the first time I'd seen him do that. Deep lines gathered at the corners of his eyes — the lines of a man who had laughed a great deal, over a long life.

"…No need to think. Your body will decide on its own."

I heard that and refilled the flask and handed it to him. He drank and gave it back. We sat a while without speaking.

On the way back to the dormitory, I went back over everything that had happened in those six days, one by one. The official who'd asked for a permit, the old woman who hadn't known what a well was, the station attendant, Eikon, the children, and one sheet of paper. No one had gotten angry. No one had stopped Speon. And yet, over those six days, the whole city had been saying the same thing to him, over and over. That it wasn't needed.

That night I thought I finally understood why those words frightened me. It isn't needed wasn't a wrong thing to say. That's why it couldn't be argued with. Watching a man keep digging, surrounded on every side by words that couldn't be argued with — that was the first time I wanted to go on watching someone for a long, long while. And I still didn't know where that feeling had come from.

Lying in my room, I looked at my palms. Clean hands, without a single blister. Looking at them, I counted, for the first time, how long these hands had gone doing nothing at all. From the day I arrived in the city to today — twenty-nine days. In all that time I had walked, stood, stood in lines, filled out forms. The only things these hands had ever gripped were paperwork and a flask.

I fell asleep looking at that hand. The next morning, the moment I opened my eyes, the first thing that came to mind wasn't my mother, and it wasn't my brother. It was the pit. I didn't think that was strange, at the time. Looking back on it now, I should have.

(Continued in Chapter 27.)

Chapter 27. Digging Together

> *_Previously_ — for six days the city never got angry at Speon. It only*
> *told him, precisely and politely, that it wasn't needed. Speon never argued and kept digging. I carried water to him every day. Lying in my*
> *room, I looked at my clean palms for a long time.*

The night before, I couldn't fall asleep for a long time.

I kept going back over what Speon had said. No need to think. Your body will decide on its own. I hadn't believed it. I'd always been a person who thought first. Sitting behind that hill at nine years old, and later setting the order of every word I meant to say on the way — both had been the result of thinking. I had never once let my body decide on its own.

But that night, strangely, my body won. The moment I opened my eyes in the morning, my feet turned toward the pit first. Thought followed after.

Leaving the dormitory, I thought about my mother and my brother. I could apply for a visit any time. Any time at all. Since they never changed, if I didn't go today I could go tomorrow, and if not tomorrow, the day after. Whether that thought made things easier or harder for me, I couldn't tell at the time.

The next morning, I picked up a shovel.

I woke the moment the sky lightened. It had been a long time since that happened. Until then I'd always woken at a fixed hour, around when the distribution station's bell rang. That day I was already awake before the bell even sounded.

No one had told me to. There was a spare shovel Speon had left beside the pit. I'd only looked at it for days. That day my hand simply reached for it first.

"…Want to try?" Speon asked.

"…Yes."

I gripped the handle. It was a familiar weight in my hand. The wooden handle had worn smooth. I knew right away that the smoothness wasn't strange to me at all. My body already knew the angle between palm and handle, even the direction the weight leaned.

I hadn't made anything with my hands since coming to this city. I'd signed my name on forms, opened and closed the flask's cap, knocked on doors. That was all. I'd been a person who worked with his hands since fourteen, but in this city there was nothing for those hands to do.

I gripped the handle with both hands and weighed it. A little shorter than the shovel I'd used outside. The blade was thinner. It didn't seem like something made in this city, but something Speon had brought with him. The handle was chipped in places — marks left by long use.

"…How old is this?" I asked.

"…This shovel? About twelve years."

"…That's old."

"…Good wood lasts. No reason to change it."

I heard that and set the blade against the dirt. Before the first stroke, I paused a moment to steady my breath. It was such a small motion, and yet strangely, I felt tense.

. . .

I drove the shovel into the earth.

I stepped on the upper edge of the blade and put my weight into it. The feel of the soil splitting traveled up through the sole of my foot. I pulled the shovel back. A clump of earth broke free.

It was a simple motion. And yet my body remembered it exactly — the angle, the timing of the force, how to use my back. I felt my body move before my mind had even finished thinking.

"…You're good at this," Speon said.

"…Did some of this before."

"…The old man taught you?"

"…Yes."

I took a second stroke. A third, a fourth. I was counting in my head. By the tenth my breath had grown a little short. By the twentieth my shoulders had started to ache. By around the thirtieth, my breathing eased again instead. A rhythm was building. Unhurried, but never stopping — the same rhythm Speon had shown me that first day.

Sinking into that rhythm, I felt something shift. Since coming to this city I had been a person who did nothing but wait. Waiting for a visit, waiting for an answer, waiting for a procedure to end. There was no

waiting in digging. Dig, and earth came up. The result came right away. I only realized, in that moment, how much I had missed that.

. . .

I took a small knife out of my pack and hung it at my waist. It had been the old man's. He'd given it to me before he died. The handle was wood, worn glassy smooth from long use. I hadn't taken it out once, in all my time in this city. There had been no need to. In this city, there was almost nothing to cut or shape. Everything came already made.

That day I used the knife to smooth a rough patch of wood grain on the shovel handle. Speon saw and asked.

"…That's a good knife."

"…It was his. The one who died."

"…Take care of it."

"…I will."

About half an hour later, Eikon passed by.

She stopped again this time too. But this time she was watching me, not Speon. Watching my hands, to be exact — watching me hold the shovel.

"…Why are you doing that?" she asked.

"…Helping."

"…You didn't come here to live, Anemos."

"…No."

"…So why are you doing this city's work? It isn't even needed."

I answered without pausing my digging.

"…It's fun."

Eikon's face went a little strange at that answer. Not angry, not mocking. A face that truly didn't understand.

"…Are fun and needed different things?"

I stopped digging at that question. It was a good one.

"…I think they're different," I said. "Something needed is something you'd be in trouble without. Something fun is... something you don't need, but want to do anyway."

"…Why do something you don't need?"

I couldn't answer that. Eikon didn't wait for an answer and started walking again. I watched her go and drove my shovel back into the earth.

I held onto that question for a long time. Why do something you don't need. It really wasn't a strange question in this city. Here, every action had to have need attached to it as its reason. Fun wasn't a reason. That day, for the first time, I felt strange to myself, doing something for no reason but fun.

. . .

Around that time I began to feel that time moved differently inside the rhythm of digging. Over the past month in this city, I had mostly experienced time as waiting. I'd submit a visit request and wait days.

Hear the answer and wait more days. Inside that waiting, time crawled. A day would pass with nothing happening, and vanish without my even knowing whether it had been there at all.

Something like a bell sounded once from the direction of the Preserve's building. The sound announcing visiting hours. I heard it, and I didn't stop digging. It was the first time that had happened. Since coming to this city, every time that sound rang, my body had turned toward it on reflex. Not that day.

I only realized it afterward. That morning, for the first time, I let that bell pass right through me. I felt like I should have felt guilty. I strangely didn't. That was the stranger part.

While I was digging, time went differently. Every time I set the shovel, I could see with my own eyes how much earth had come up. Dig ten times, and there was ten strokes' worth of pit. A hundred times, a hundred strokes' worth. It was time that accumulated into a result. I was feeling that accumulation for the first time in a long while.

I couldn't put that difference into exact words that day. I can now. Waiting time is time that passes over me. Digging time is time I make myself. Since arriving in this city I had lived entirely inside the first kind of time. That day, for the first time, I touched the second.

About an hour in, my palms began to burn.

I had no gloves. Speon took off his own and gave them to me.

"…I'm fine," I said.

"…Blister now, you'll be useless for days. Put them on."

I took the gloves and put them on. They were a little large. Still, the fit felt familiar. It felt like returning to my fourteen-year-old self, my fifteen-year-old self.

I want to describe that feeling exactly. It wasn't that I hadn't used my body in seven years. I'd kept working the whole time — drawing water, gathering wood, digging wells. But every bit of that work had been for survival. Work someone told me to do, work I had to do. This digging was different. No one had told me to. Nothing would happen if I didn't. I was simply doing it because I wanted to.

Nothing like that had happened once in seven years. So I give this chapter its title on that account. For the first time in seven years, I used my body.

. . .

At noon, Speon said we should rest.

We leaned against the dirt pile. He shared out some dried food. Hard, strongly salty. Outside food. Nothing like the taste of this city's rations.

"…This city's food has no taste," I said.

"…It's not tasteless, it's just always the same," Speon said. "Same ration every time, same ingredients every time. No reason for it to be good or bad."

"…And this?"

"…This came out salty by accident. Nobody measured the salt going in."

I laughed at that.

"…A mistake?"

"…Something like that. But it's not bad, is it."

I chewed the salty food and turned that thought over. A mistake, and not bad. This city had no mistakes. Everything was exact. There was nowhere for a mistake to happen.

That was the first time I missed the thing called a mistake. A mistake was proof that something was alive and moving. After seven years spent among things that were only ever exact, one salty bite of food felt strangely welcome.

Outside had been full of mistakes. The day my mother put salt in the soup twice and it turned too salty. The time, after my father was gone, when my mother tried fixing the roof for the first time and made the rain leak in some new, wrong place. The time I tied the bucket rope wrong and dropped the bucket to the bottom of the well. Things like that happened all the time. And every time, someone laughed, or got angry, or fixed it. That commotion was ordinary life.

This city had none of that commotion. No leaking roof, no dropped bucket, no oversalted soup. Everything went exactly according to plan. I only learned, coming to this city, how quiet that kind of perfection was. A perfect place had nothing to talk about. The words people shared shrank right along with it.

That afternoon, looking at the half-eaten salty food, I felt, for the first time since coming to this city, like telling someone what had happened that day. I told Speon the story — the time I tied the bucket rope wrong. He laughed out loud. I remember that laugh being louder than any sound I'd heard in this city.

. . .

That afternoon, I got a blister. The gloves hadn't helped. A small, clear blister rose on the inside of my palm, just below the thumb.

Speon took my hand and looked it over.

"…That's a lot of work for a first day."

"…It hurts."

"…It's supposed to. That's how a hand gets made new."

"…What do you mean?"

"…Once the blister breaks and a callus grows in, that's a well-digger's hand. Until it does, it isn't."

I heard that and looked at my hand. It was still a hand that was nothing much. But that one blister felt like the start of something.

I thought of my brother. He used to sit beside me every time I drew water and watch my hands. When a blister came up he wanted to touch it, but I wouldn't let him, because it hurt. He still kept watching from beside me, all the same.

"…What's wrong with your hand?" he asked me once.

"…It's from working."

"…Will I be like that someday too?"

"…You don't have to be."

"…Why?"

I hadn't answered him then. My brother had been preserved at eight, so that hand was still, even now, the same smooth hand of an eight-year-old. Without blisters, without calluses — a hand that had never made a single thing.

Thinking that, I stopped my hand. A strange guilt rose in me. While blisters rose on my hand, my brother's hand stayed exactly as it was. I was growing, and he wasn't. That fact suddenly weighed on me, all over again.

I had dug a well with this hand at fourteen. But that hand had been gone a long time already. Over seven years, through other kinds of work, calluses had risen and worn away, risen and worn away again. Coming to this city, they'd disappeared altogether. That day, I had started making that hand again.

Speon wrapped my hand with a scrap of cloth instead of a proper bandage. His fingers were clumsy at it. He was a well-digger's hand, not a bandaging hand, it seemed. The knot came loose twice before it finally held on the third try.

"…You're no doctor," I said, laughing.

"…Never had much use for doctors. Get hurt, wrap it up, keep working."

"…Doesn't it hurt?"

"…It hurts. But it's better than stopping work. Stop, and you start thinking too much."

I said nothing to that. Stop, and you start thinking too much. I heard that as being about me. Since coming to this city, I'd spent most of my time stopped. And in all that time, I'd thought far too much. Words I'd prepared, words I hadn't managed to say, words prepared all over again.

Speon said it as if it were nothing. But it stayed with me from that day on. Stop, and you start thinking too much. Every time I turned that sentence over, I realized all over again how long I'd been stopped in this city.

. . .

As the sun leaned toward evening, the station attendant passed by and saw us. He stopped and watched for a moment.

"…Digging together?" he asked me.

"…Yes."

"…You don't even need it."

I answered without preparing anything, just what came out of my mouth.

"…I'm not doing it because I need it."

The attendant paused a moment at that. His face looked like he'd never heard those words before.

"…Then why?"

"…I just want to."

He seemed to turn that over for a while, then nodded without saying anything more and walked on.

I remember that moment for a long time. It was the first time I'd confirmed for myself, out loud, that I wasn't doing this because I needed to. In this city, every action had to have a reason — need,

procedure, regulation. That day, for the first time, I did something with no reason at all. And I learned how freeing that could be.

Even after the attendant walked off, I stood there a while longer, looking at the dirt on my hands. Earth was packed deep under my fingernails. It didn't look like it would come off easily even washed. I didn't mind that. If anything, that dirt felt like proof I'd done something that day.

Speon kept digging the whole time. I glanced at the side of his face for a moment. Sweat had mixed with dust and left streaks across it. He showed no sign of tiring. He really did seem like someone who could do this work all day.

"…Isn't it hard?" I asked.

"…It's hard."

"…But you don't look like it's hard."

"…Hard and unbearable are different things," Speon said, driving the shovel in. "This is a hard I can bear. There's a hard that can't be borne too. That's a different story."

I thought about that distinction for a long time. People in this city had no hard things at all. They were people who didn't even know what hard meant. Speon knew what hard was, and kept choosing it anyway. I didn't know, at the time, exactly what that difference meant.

Writing this record now, I take that thing Speon said out again. A hard that can be borne, and a hard that can't. I went on, after that, telling these two apart for the rest of my life. Which kind was the hard of walking back from visiting my mother? I didn't know then. I would only learn it much later in this book.

The pit grew noticeably deeper over that one day. Twice as fast as Speon working alone. I felt proud of that. It was the first time I'd felt proud of anything since coming to this city.

. . .

By evening, when I set down the shovel, my hands were shaking. My arms ached. My back hurt. I welcomed all of it.

"…Coming back tomorrow?" Speon asked.

"…Yes."

"…What about your family?"

I couldn't answer that right away. It was true, I'd come here to bring my family back. And yet all that day, I'd barely thought of them at all.

"…I can visit any time," I said. "Since they never change."

Speon heard that and looked at me for a long while. His face looked like he wanted to say something, but in the end he said nothing.

"…But," he said, starting again. "That they never change — is that a good thing, or a bad thing?"

I couldn't answer that right away either. I'd always thought it was good. Not disappearing, not suffering, not being forgotten. But faced with Speon's question, that answer suddenly wavered.

"…I don't know," I said. It was the answer I'd been giving most, these days.

"…Not knowing is fine," Speon said, standing and shouldering the shovel. "Better than pretending to know everything."

"…See you tomorrow, then."

Walking back to the dormitory, I kept looking down at my hand. Blisters, streaks of dirt, earth packed under my nails. A hand I couldn't have imagined, just days before.

On the way I passed the distribution station. The door was shut. For the first time, I walked past without filling my flask. There was still about half a day's water left in it. That half-full flask seemed to show how much I'd moved that day. I'd drunk far more than usual, and there was still water left. Working the body harder should mean more thirst, not less — I wondered briefly why there was any left, then let the question go. It wasn't one that needed an answer.

I slept deeply that night, for the first time in a long while. No dreams. The next morning when I opened my eyes, the first thing I felt was my hands aching. Strangely, I liked that ache. It was proof the body was alive.

I started to count that ache and stopped myself. That day I learned, for the first time, that some things are better left uncounted.

From that day I went to the pit every morning. The first few days my body was so worn out I collapsed into sleep each evening. Then my body began to adjust to the work again. Blisters broke, and thin calluses settled where they'd been. Every time I touched those calluses, I felt like I was meeting my fourteen-year-old self again.

In those twelve days, I never once applied for a visit. I knew it was strange and didn't stop anyway. I sensed, dimly, that I was avoiding

something. I wouldn't learn what it was until I went down into the valley.

On the twelfth day, the pit had grown well past my own height. Speon built a ladder and set it in place. Climbing up and down it, I found myself feeling, all at once, that this was no longer just a pit. It was turning into something else.

(Continued in Chapter 28.)

Chapter 28. Going Down

> *_Previously_ — I went to Speon's pit every morning. Blisters rose on my*
> *hands, and calluses settled in. For twelve days I didn't apply for a visit. I sensed, dimly, that I was avoiding something. The pit had passed my own height, and a ladder had gone in.*

On the morning of the thirteenth day, I didn't go to the pit.

My body was turned in a different direction from the moment I opened my eyes. I decided not to fight that feeling. Speon had been right. There were times the body knew something before thought did.

Instead I walked to the edge of the city. I hadn't been that way in a while — to the spot where I'd first looked down into the Dry Valley, and where Eikon had told me what that valley was. I met no one on the whole walk there. The city was unusually quiet, that early in the morning.

I stood at the edge and looked down.

The valley was the same as ever, that day too. Dry ground, faded soil, a landscape without a trace of moisture, however far you looked. I'd looked down into it several times before. But that day it looked different.

I thought for a long time about where that difference came from. I know now. Before, I had only ever looked down the way you look at something. That day, for the first time, I was imagining myself going down into it.

For twelve days, digging that pit, I had gone down and down every day. The moment it passed my own height, I'd started climbing up and down a ladder. The digging itself had already been a movement downward. That morning, for the first time, I felt that fact clearly. I had already been practicing how to go down. It just so happened the thing I'd been going down into was a hole in the ground.

Writing this sentence now, I think that coincidence might not have been a coincidence at all. I'm not certain. But this much is true: a body that had spent twelve days repeating the same downward motion, every day, walked one morning toward a far larger downward, on its own.

Writing this record, I often go back and count coincidences like that one. Meeting a well-digger. My hands remembering their work again beside him. And then, twelve days later, heading toward the valley. Take away any single one of them, and I wouldn't have been standing at that edge that day.

Standing at the edge, I said nothing for a long time. Wind blew. That was rare in this city. It came up from the direction of the valley — dry, lukewarm wind. I let it hit my face and closed my eyes.

. . .

I went back to the pit and told Speon.

"…I'm going to go down into that valley."

Speon stopped digging. He looked at me for a long while. Not a surprised face. If anything, the face of someone who'd been waiting.

"…Why?" he asked.

"…I don't know. I just feel like I have to go."

"…Looking for something?"

I couldn't answer that right away. I didn't know myself what I was going to look for. Eikon had said there were traces there of people whose preservation had failed. I couldn't tell whether I wanted to see those traces, or whether I was looking for something else entirely.

"…I don't know," I said again.

Speon nodded.

"…Will you come with me?" I asked.

He drove the shovel into the earth pile. Then, for the first time, he went quiet for a long while. That silence was unfamiliar to me. Speon was usually quick to answer. A question would come and an answer would follow, almost right away. This time was different. He touched the pit's wall once, as if stroking it, looked up at the sky once, and only then opened his mouth.

I was counting the length of that silence. By the time I reached ten, he finally spoke.

. . .

"…No." He said it, at last.

"…Why not?"

"…That's a place you have to go."

I didn't understand that at once. I couldn't help asking again.

"…What does that mean?"

"…I'm a man who digs wells. I can decide where the water goes. But why you have to go down into that valley isn't something I can decide for you. Only you know that."

"…I don't know it either."

"…Then you go not knowing. That's how it should be."

I wanted to argue with that, but I had nothing to argue with. Speon kept smoothing his shovel and neither pushed me nor tried to stop me.

I didn't understand it then. I understood later. Speon was a man who drew water toward a place. He wasn't a man who led people toward one. If I had to go down into that valley, it had to be on my own feet. Not led there by anyone's hand.

I stood there a while longer. From inside the pit I could hear Speon digging again — earth being lifted, feet pressing down. That familiar rhythm only made me more restless. As long as that sound went on, I kept feeling like I was putting something off.

"…Scared?" Speon asked, without stopping his digging.

"…Yes."

"…Scared of what?"

I couldn't answer right away. I couldn't tell whether it was the valley itself that frightened me, or what I'd see there, or the fear of coming back up somehow changed.

"…I don't know."

"…So you're afraid of not knowing." Speon said. "That's a fine kind of fear to have. The bad kind of fear is being afraid of what you know."

"…What's the difference?"

"…Fear of what you know keeps you from going at all. Fear of what you don't know just means you're afraid while you go."

I couldn't say I understood that distinction. But hearing it, my feet felt a little lighter.

I asked Speon one last thing.

"…What if I don't come back up?"

Speon's hand stopped. For the first time, his face turned serious.

"…Then I'll come down."

"…You just said I had to go alone."

"…You not coming back up alive, and you not being able to come back up, are different things," Speon said. "If you see something down there and decide not to come back up, that's your own to decide. But if you're hurt and can't come back up, that's mine to go for."

I liked that distinction. It wasn't a promise never to come for me. It was a promise to respect me.

"…So you're worried?" I asked.

"…I am. But being worried doesn't mean I can go in your place."

I heard that and looked at Speon's face again. It was a worried face. And yet that worry didn't hold me back. That was the first day I learned

that both things could live inside one person at once.

. . .

"…Do I need to prepare anything?" I asked.

"…Water." Speon said it shortly. "Not much else."

"…Is it dangerous?"

"…Don't know. No one's ever gone down."

That answer surprised me a little. He'd always seemed, until then, like a man who moved only once he knew something.

"…You haven't gone either?"

"…No. Thirty-seven wells, and I've never once come across a valley like this one."

"…Then why tell me to go, without telling me anything?"

"…Because there's nothing I can tell you. If it were something I knew, I'd teach it to you gladly enough. This is something I don't know."

I turned that over. Since coming to this city, I'd always been the one learning something someone else knew. Procedure, from the Curator. This city's logic, from Eikon. Digging, from Speon. The valley was a place no one knew anything about. I found, strangely, that I liked that. Somewhere I didn't have to follow in anyone's footsteps. Somewhere my own first footprint would become the only record of that ground.

I can only say it now — that it actually put me at ease. If it was a place no one knew, there was nothing shameful in not knowing it myself.

. . .

I filled my flask and shouldered the small sack Speon had packed for me. A little dried food, a coil of rope.

"…Why the rope?"

"…Don't know. There are times it's good to have."

I laughed at that. It was such a Speon answer. A man who prepared without certainty. And yet his preparations always fit exactly what was needed.

Before heading back to the dormitory, I ran into Eikon. By chance. She was standing where she always walked.

"…Where are you going?" she asked, looking at the sack on my shoulder.

"…The valley."

Eikon's expression stiffened for a moment.

"…Why?"

"…I don't know. I'm curious."

"…There's nothing to see there," she said. "They're just failures."

"…I'm curious what failure looks like."

Eikon looked at me for a long while. Then she said this.

"…Don't come back a different person."

I didn't understand what that meant and tried to ask her again. But she turned and walked off before I could.

I turned that line over for a long time afterward. Don't come back a different person. In this city, changing at all was itself something to be feared. Eikon had shared that fear with me. I couldn't tell, at the time, whether it was worry or warning. Thinking of it now, I think it was both. And either way, it meant she was thinking of me.

I opened the sack once more and checked what was inside. Rope, dried food, a small knife — the old man's knife. Packing it, I felt somehow steadier. I thought for a moment about how the old man might have walked a road like this one. He probably would have just walked, without a word.

On the way I passed the distribution station. The attendant saw me and asked.

"…Where are you off to? You filled your flask twice."

"…I'm going down into the valley."

The attendant's face moved, for the first time, in a big way. A face of surprise.

"…There? Why?"

"…I don't know. I just feel like I have to go."

"…No one goes there."

"…I know."

He looked at me a moment, then, without a word, filled my flask to the very top. More than the regulation amount. I noticed and said nothing. He said nothing either.

I remember that moment clearly. In a city that ran on exactness, that day he stepped just slightly outside the regulation, for the first time. No one made anything of it. It felt to me like proof that something was still left in the people of this city. Some small wish to slip, just a little, unnoticed, past what was set.

I thanked the attendant and started walking again. I half-waited for a moment to hear him call after me. No sound came. I decided that wasn't a bad thing either.

"…When are you coming back up?" he asked.

"…I don't know."

"…All right. Go, not knowing."

I heard that and started walking. A few steps on, I looked back. Speon was already digging again. He hadn't seen me off. He simply went on with his own work.

That retreating figure didn't hurt me. It was easier, if anything. Being seen off gives you one more reason you have to come back. Speon hadn't loaded me with that reason. My coming back had to be something for which the reason had to already be mine.

. . .

The path down into the valley began at the city's edge.

At first it was a gentle slope. I walked carefully over loose gravel. The sound of earth crumbling underfoot rose up. It was a sound I'd never once heard inside the city — every path there was packed hard and firm.

Scattered dry brush lined both sides of the path. Branches without a single leaf on them. I touched one. It rustled as if it would snap, but it didn't. It just held on, dried out. That stayed with me, strangely — things standing there a long time, neither dead nor alive.

After a while the slope steepened. I used the rope several times, hooking it into cracks in the rock and lowering myself down. It was a method the old man had taught me. My hands remembered it exactly.

That was when I understood why Speon had packed the rope. He'd said he didn't know, but he'd sensed, dimly, that a path like this might exist. Saying you don't know and preparing nothing at all are different things. I turned that difference over, going down and down.

I began counting my steps. Counting was an old habit of mine. Every hundred steps I stopped for a sip of water. Two hundred, three hundred. The path kept leading down, and down. At first I kept looking back toward where the city had been; at some point I stopped looking back at all.

I came to a stretch thick with rock. I climbed down bracing myself against them with my hands. Every time the healed-over blister marks on my palms touched stone, they stung. I bore the pain and kept going down. The pain almost seemed to show me the way — the farther down I went, the worse it hurt. Hurting meant I was doing something.

I remembered something the old man used to say. On rough ground, read it with your hands first. Hands are more honest than eyes. Following that, I checked the rock face with my fingertips before setting my feet down. A few times my foot slipped, but I never fell hard.

Around the six-hundredth step, I realized for the first time that I'd been walking without looking back at all. My eyes had been forward the whole time.

. . .

As I went down, the air changed.

The city's air was always cool and dry. The valley's air was drier still. My throat felt scratchy with every breath. I took a sip from the flask. The water seemed to be going down far faster than it had in the city.

The sound was different too. The city had at least a little sound — footsteps, a door. The valley had none at all. My own breath and my own footsteps were the only sound there was.

I thought I'd heard that silence somewhere before. It took me a long time to place it. The night before my mother fell ill, just before sickness swept the settlement — the whole village holding its breath. That silence. The silence right before something happens.

The light was different too. The city's sunlight was always the same — falling in exact, predictable brightness, morning like morning and evening like evening. The valley's light changed color with every angle it struck. Rock-shadows stretched long, then shortened; dust caught the sun and drifted in a pale haze. Watching that shifting light, I found myself thinking this valley felt, strangely, more alive than the city did. It was a strange thought. I'd been told this was a land of dry, dead things.

A few times something crumbled underfoot. I stepped on it without thinking, believing it was stone, and only realized afterward that it wasn't. Each time, I stopped and looked down. I didn't yet have the nerve to find out what it was. I just kept walking.

Once I nearly took a bad fall. A rock that looked solid crumbled soft and dry beneath me. I threw out my arm and caught the rock beside it. My heart pounded for a long while after. I sat down there a moment to catch my breath.

That was the first time I truly felt this path held real danger. Until then I'd said I was afraid, but it hadn't been a danger my body had lived through. In that brief moment when the rock crumbled, I felt that I was truly alone here. No one to help. That fact frightened me, and yet, strangely, it also felt clear.

That was the first time I understood, in my body, the difference between this city and this valley. The city had no danger. In exchange, nothing ever happened. The valley had danger. And inside that danger, I felt, more clearly than ever, that I was alive.

Sitting there catching my breath, I opened the flask and took a sip. More than half the water was already gone. I gauged what was left and started walking again.

Standing back up, I looked at my palms. Bracing myself against the rock had torn the healed blister-marks open again. No blood. Just thin, peeled skin left behind. I opened and closed my hand a moment, checking the feeling in it, and walked on.

The slope went on. I used the rope a few more times. Each time, my hands grew a little surer at the knots. What had taken two tries to tie correctly at first came together in one, later on. My body seemed to have fully remembered the work all over again.

. . .

Before reaching the bottom, I looked back up one last time.

The city was up there. Small and quiet. That was the moment I first felt, truly, how far I had come — from where my mother and brother were, from where Speon was, from the distribution station and the Curator's building.

For a moment I thought about turning back. That it wasn't too late yet. But my feet kept going down. Speon had been right. My body moved before thought did.

Dust rose low underfoot and settled again. I stood there and thought of my mother and my brother. At this very hour, they would be there, with the same faces, in the same room, waiting for me to come. Whether it could even be called waiting, I wasn't sure. They didn't wait. They simply were there. I turned that difference over once more and kept walking.

The slope beneath my feet began, little by little, to level out. I could feel I was nearly there. My last few steps came strangely slow. There was no reason to hurry. If anything, it felt like I shouldn't.

My foot finally touched the valley floor.

The soil was different from the city's. Lighter. It broke apart under my foot and scattered like powder. I stood there and caught my breath for a moment.

I looked all around.

It was different from what I'd imagined. I'd expected something frightening, something terrible. But what first came into view was simply dry ground stretching wide open — dry ground that seemed to run all the way to the horizon.

And scattered across it, there were things.

I hadn't gone close enough yet to know what they were. But I could tell, even from a distance. Those things had once been something.

I turned back and looked up at the path I'd come down. The city was no longer visible. The slope blocked the view. Strangely, that put me at ease. Not being able to see the way back didn't mean I couldn't go back. It only seemed to mean that, for now, I should look only forward.

I closed the flask's cap and fastened it firmly at my waist. Then I took a step. Dust rose quietly underfoot and settled again.

I stood there for a long while. I was afraid to take the next step. It would be a long time — not until I had properly walked the valley — that I understood exactly what that fear had been for.

I took my first step toward the scattered things.

(Continued in Chapter 29.)

Chapter 29. Bones

> *_Previously_ — I finally reached the floor of the Dry Valley. Speon hadn't come with me. "That's a place you have to go." I took my first*
> *step toward the scattered things. I hadn't yet gone close enough to know what they were.*

The floor of the valley was lower than the city, wider, and quiet.

Even the angle the light came in was different from the city's. The sky showed as a thin strip between the cliffs, and the light falling through that gap colored the whole valley a pale, milky white. The shadows were thick and long. I stood there a moment and let my eyes adjust to that light.

The cliffs rose high on both sides. They blocked off the upward direction where the city was, so that now only a narrow band of sky was visible. I followed the grain of the cliff with my eyes. Layers of differently colored soil were stacked one on another. A red layer, a brown layer, a gray layer. A cross-section with a long span of time engraved into it exactly as it had happened.

Near the base of the cliff, things that looked like roots showed through the soil. Traces of something that had tried to grow and hadn't finished. I followed those roots with my gaze. I couldn't see where the ends led.

There was a smell in the air. The city had almost no smell at all. In a place where everything was managed to an exact, regulated quantity, it seemed smell didn't survive either. The valley had a smell. The smell of

dry earth, of old wood, and another smell besides that I couldn't quite explain. Not sweet, not rank — just very, very old.

The first thing I saw was a shoe.

Only one. Half buried in the soil, its shape still intact. The leather was dry enough to crumble at a touch. The laces had rotted through and snapped. I crouched down in front of it. Inside, the shape of a foot still faintly remained. No one was wearing it. Only the trace of someone who had.

I reached out to touch it, then stopped myself.

A few steps further on there was another shoe. This time a pair. Set side by side. As if someone had taken them off, set them neatly, and walked away somewhere. That neatness stayed with me a long time. It was that day I learned, for the first time, that what is arranged carefully outlasts what is left in disorder.

There was a small shoe too. A child's. I stood longest in front of that one. The toe was especially worn through. It must have belonged to a child who ran a great deal.

. . .

Walking a little further, I came to scraps of cloth.

Things that had once been clothing. All the color had faded until it was hard to tell the cloth from the soil. In one spot several pieces lay overlapping. I guessed they must once have been a single garment. The place where a sleeve had been, the place where a collar had been. It had settled into the ground in the same shape a person once wore it.

Every time the wind blew, those scraps of cloth stirred lightly. As if something in them were still alive. And yet they looked as if they would crumble the instant a hand touched them.

Further on the scraps grew more numerous. In some places several layers of clothing lay folded over one another. I thought that must not be one person's trace but several people's, overlapping in a single spot. As time had piled up in layers, so had the traces.

Some cloth still kept a trace of color. A scrap with a reddish tint, a thread that still held a bit of blue. I couldn't gauge how long that color had managed to hold out. Everything else had already returned to the color of the earth, and only that small bit of color was still holding on.

. . .

Walking further, small objects began to appear.

A button. A comb. A broken piece of wood. Some I could tell the original use of; some I couldn't. I walked among them and counted. Ten, twenty, thirty. I didn't stop counting. If I didn't count, I couldn't bear it.

In one spot there was a small bundle of paper. It looked as if it would crumble if I unfolded it, so I didn't. A faint trace of what had been writing showed through. I couldn't tell whether it had been a letter or a list.

Around the spot where the paper bundle lay, small shards of glass were scattered as well. They looked like they had once been a bottle, though only a few fragments still kept a recognizable shape. I picked one up, then set it back down. It felt as though the things here ought to stay exactly here.

On the ground lay a single thin cord. Rotted down almost to a thread. One end was driven into the earth; the other lay on the soil, connected to nothing. It looked like a cord that had once been tied to something.

Beside it, small stones were set out in a row. Not arranged by chance. Someone had deliberately stood them up like that. I followed the row. Twelve of them. I couldn't tell what they had been counting, or marking. Only the number twelve was left behind.

Further along there was something that looked like a small toy. It seemed to have been carved from wood, though almost none of its shape remained. An animal? A person? I crouched in front of it a moment, then stood back up.

. . .

The ground grew darker in color the further I walked.

From red soil to gray-brown soil, and further still, soil that was nearly white. I remembered what Speon had said about soil colors. Gray, he'd said, was where water had passed through. But this white was different even from that. It didn't look like a trace water had passed through — it looked like a trace of where water had drained out completely.

Every time I set my foot down, that white soil rose like powder and settled again. Every breath brought a little of that powder against the back of my throat. It tasted dry.

Here and there along the valley wall there were things like shallow hollows. I couldn't tell whether they'd been made by people or had formed naturally. I looked briefly into one of them. Something was

stacked deep inside, but it was too dark to make out what. I didn't go in.

There were more traces of small pools scattered across the ground. Some large, some very small. Regardless of size, the inside of each held the same cracked pattern. A place where water had been and then vanished leaves the same trace no matter its size — I learned that that day.

I looked back at my own footprints left in that white soil. A long trail stretching behind me. It was the only new footprint pressed into this valley. Every other trace here was old; only mine had just been made.

Every time the wind blew, the edges of that footprint crumbled a little more. I walked a few more steps and turned to check. The print behind me was already going soft at the edges. It was then I learned that this valley didn't hold onto even a new trace for very long.

. . .

There were a few things whose shape had survived whole.

Something that had been a tree. A tree that must once have been large stood now hardened gray. Down to the tips of its branches, it was still exactly there. Only the leaves were gone. I laid a hand against the base of it. I could feel the grain of the bark just as it was. It was no different from touching a living tree. Only there was no warmth in it.

That tree wasn't alone. A little further off, several more like it were standing. It might once have been a forest. I walked among them, stepping through the lattice pattern their branches' shadows made. Through the leafless branches, the sky showed in small broken pieces.

One tree's base had split open. Something was inside the crack. I bent down and looked. A small bone. It looked like a bird's. Where a nest should have been, there was no nest — only its trace remained.

Beside it was the mark of a small pool. I could tell at once it was a place water had been. The cracked pattern on its floor spread out like a spider's web. The trace left by soil shrinking as water dried away. White powder had gathered in the gaps between the cracks.

I ran my fingertips along that cracked pattern. The depth varied from place to place. The deepest crack went in about the width of a finger joint. I tried to gauge how large that pool must once have been. Walking its edge, it came to about thirty of my steps. Not a small pool.

At the very center of the pool's floor, in the spot where water must have lingered longest at the very end, a small mark remained. A round, shallow depression. I recognized it as a footprint and stopped walking. It was the trace of someone who had stood beside the last of the water, until the very last moment.

. . .

Walking further, the valley widened.

The cliffs on either side drew back, and my view opened up. I tried to take in, all at once, everything scattered across that wide space, but I couldn't take it all in. I couldn't see an end to it. I had no way to gauge how long, or how widely, these traces had been accumulating.

The oldest things had already decayed to where they were barely distinguishable from the soil. Traces holding only the barest hint of shape, that would collapse at a touch. The most recent things still kept a form you could recognize as having once belonged to a person.

Watching that difference, I felt that this valley moved by the way time accumulates. The city was a place where time had stopped. The valley was a place where time flowed, very slowly, but unmistakably.

Inside the widened valley, spots crowded with traces and spots utterly empty of any trace alternated one after another. Every time I passed one of the empty spots, I felt, strangely, a heavier weight settle on me. A spot with traces told you, at least, that something had been there. An empty spot told you nothing at all.

At the center of one empty spot, one very small thing lay by itself. A ring. The metal hadn't decayed; it remained intact. I looked down at that ring for a long time. Something was engraved on the inside, but soil had gotten into it and I couldn't make it out. I left that unwiped too, and moved on.

. . .

It was around then that things that looked like bones began to appear on the ground.

At first I wasn't sure they were really bones. The color was close to the soil's, and their shape looked on the verge of crumbling. But looking closer, they were unmistakably bones. Some long and slender, some short and round. In some places they still held a complete shape; in others they were scattered.

I walked carefully among them. I tried not to step on any. In some spots they were gathered together in a single place, as if someone had once lain down right there. I stopped in front of one such spot.

That kind of spot wasn't only one. As I walked I started counting them. Five, ten, seventeen. Some spots lay close together. I thought they might

have been a family. Some lay far off, alone.

Some were divided up. Places where no complete shape remained — only a few fragments scattered here and there. I noticed the degree of scattering was different from place to place. In some spots the fragments were still gathered close, as if scattered only recently; in others they'd been scattered so long ago that the fragments had spread far apart from each other.

In one spot, unusually small ones were gathered together. I knelt down in front of it. Judging by the size, they belonged to a child. I couldn't move from in front of that spot for a long time.

Writing this chapter, I think this is as far as the most accurate description I'm capable of can go. I don't intend to carry it further into words. Some scenes become a lie the moment you add explanation to them.

I passed that spot and kept walking. At some point, without my noticing, even the habit of counting my steps had stopped. There is a point counting cannot carry you past — I learned that for the first time, that day.

Along one wall of the valley there was a row of shallow hollows worn into the rock. They looked like places where people had once sat, backs leaned against the stone. I started to count those worn hollows one by one, then gave it up. I didn't want to count again.

Below the wall, beside those hollows, a thin groove ran a long way. It looked like a mark scraped long and slow by a fingernail. I didn't follow that groove. I only swept it with my eyes and passed on.

. . .

Every time the wind blew, dry earth spun low across the ground.

Inside that spinning, small things rose and settled again together. Threads, thin fragments of bone, unnameable bits of debris. I watched them catch a brief glint in the air and then sink back down to the earth.

As the sun lowered, long shadows fell across that white soil. The shadow of a tree, my own shadow, and the shadows of the scattered things. Looking only at the shadows, it seemed as if something were still standing there.

The lower the light dropped, the deeper the colors grew. Things that had been plain white, plain gray by day caught the sunset and turned orange, turned red. Watching that change, I understood that this valley wore two entirely different faces, by day and by evening. The valley by day looked like a land of dead things. The valley by evening looked like something was burning.

In that light, I felt, for the first time, that this valley was beautiful. The moment that thought came to me, I was startled at myself. I couldn't tell whether I was allowed to find a place like this beautiful. But the sunset asked no permission of mine before it kept deepening into red.

. . .

I walked further into the valley.

The sound of things crumbling underfoot went on and on. Dry leaves, dry earth, dry bone. The sounds were all much the same. I tried to tell them apart, then gave that up too. There was no need to tell them apart. They were all the same sound.

The further I walked into the valley, the sparser the traces actually became. I thought that was strange. I'd assumed the farther from the city, the more would have accumulated — it was the opposite. The mouth of the valley held the densest crowd of traces, and going inward they thinned out more and more.

I didn't understand the reason then. Only, it occurred to me that this sparser space might actually hold the oldest things of all. Whatever had arrived here first might have gone in deepest, and been worn by wind and soil the longest, until by now it left almost no trace at all.

There was something on the ground that looked like a dry riverbed. I could tell from its winding shape that it was a place water had once run. I followed that dry course. The soil underfoot was a little firmer there than elsewhere. Earth packed down long ago by a current.

Far off, deeper in the valley, I saw something moving.

It was too far to make out what it was. I stood in place and looked that way for a long time. The movement was slow and steady. Different from something merely stirred by the wind.

I stood still and kept watching that direction. The sky was nearly dark by now. Stars were beginning to come out, one by one. The same stars I'd seen from the city's edge. That familiarity was, in a small way, a comfort.

The movement didn't vanish. If anything it grew clearer, little by little. I started walking that way. The sound of dry things crumbling underfoot went on. I decided not to count that sound.

The further I walked, the fewer the scattered traces became. In their place, the ground grew firmer. I didn't yet know what that change meant. Only, I could feel that I was drawing closer to something different.

Until that moment I had believed no one else was in this valley besides me. It didn't take long to learn how wrong that belief was.

(Continued in Chapter 30.)

Chapter 30. The One Already There

> *_Previously_ — Far off, deeper in the valley, I saw something moving.*
> *It was too far to make out what it was. I started walking that way.*
> *Until that moment I had believed no one else was in this valley besides*
> *me.*

The closer I got, the more that moving shape was a person.

I was sure of it by the time we were about a hundred steps apart. I recognized it not by the walk itself but by the rhythm of it. An animal doesn't walk that way. Only a person walks like that — stopping, then going again, lowering the body, then standing back up.

I started counting my steps. Ninety-nine, a hundred. Counting helped press the fear down. Eighty, seventy. The number shrank as the distance shrank.

He didn't seem to have seen me. Or — he'd seen me, but it didn't seem to concern him. He walked slowly among the scattered things. Every so often he stopped and looked down at something. Then he walked on again.

I understood then that his was not the walk of someone searching. A person searching looks around. He didn't look around. He walked the way someone walks who already knows exactly what is where.

I tried to count his steps. Fifty, sixty. But at some point I lost the count. The timing of when he stopped wasn't regular. In some spots he

stood a long time; some he simply passed by. I tried to start counting again, and gave it up.

That was the first time in my life I gave up counting something. It wasn't that I couldn't count it. I felt, in my body, that counting simply didn't fit this person. In the city, everything could be counted. The number of visits. The benches in the square. The number of times my mother said the same sentence. This man's footsteps were unlike any of those.

Looking down, I saw my own footprints falling in a row alongside his. Mine were clear and distinct. His pressed in and then blurred almost at once. I couldn't tell whether that was the wind, or simply the way he set his feet down. I'd learned the day before that this valley didn't hold even a new trace for long, but his footprints seemed to vanish faster than that, faster than mine.

. . .

About thirty steps off, I stopped walking.

I wasn't sure it was right to go any closer. The valley had none of the city's rules. No one here told you who anyone was, or what you were allowed to do.

He was the one who stopped first.

He didn't turn all the way around. Only his head tilted slightly this way. In the dimming light, I couldn't make out his face well. I couldn't guess his age. He seemed old, and at the same time not so old.

His clothes weren't the city's clothes. Nor were they like the outside clothes Speon wore. The color was almost indistinguishable from the

soil. I couldn't tell whether that was from long wear, or whether that had always been their color.

"…Hello," I said first.

He said nothing back. Only he turned his head a little further this way. I could tell he was looking at me, but there was no surprise in that look.

I would go back to this many times afterward. That he wasn't surprised, that day. A person had appeared in a valley no one ever comes to, and he showed no surprise at all. As if he'd already known, even if not today, that someone would come sometime.

. . .

I took a few more steps closer.

The sound of dry things crumbling came from underfoot. That sound rang unusually loud to me. It was probably because of the different kind of breathing I was hearing for the first time since I'd come to this valley. Not my own breath. Someone else's breath.

"…Were you already here?" I asked.

"…Yes."

His voice was low. Not angry, not glad to see me. Just a voice giving an answer.

"…I'm Anemos."

At that he nodded once. He didn't give his own name in return. I thought that was strange, but I didn't ask again. I seemed to have learned somewhere, without knowing where, that this was the courteous thing to do.

In this record I keep calling this person "he." I can't explain exactly why. Only, I felt for the first time that day that there are people it isn't right to give a name to.

. . .

He started walking again. It wasn't a walk meant to shake me off. It was simply the walk of someone continuing what he'd already been doing.

I followed a few steps behind.

Every place he stopped seemed to have a reason. In some spots he lowered himself and looked a long time at something on the ground. In others he reached out and touched a dry branch, very lightly. He didn't break it. It looked like a gesture only meant to confirm that it was still there.

"…What are you doing?" I asked.

"…Walking."

"…Just that?"

"…Yes."

That answer was so simple it made me want to ask more, rather than less.

"…Do you walk like this every day?"

"…Nearly."

"…Why?"

He stopped walking and looked at me. The first time our eyes properly met.

"…Why would I need a reason not to?"

I had no answer to that. He was right. Walking didn't need a reason. In the city it would have needed one. Here, apparently, it didn't.

. . .

I thought, at the time, that this man resembled Speon. A man who kept going without needing a reason. I learned later that this wasn't quite right. Speon was making something. A well, a channel for water. This man made nothing. He only walked. I didn't understand then how large that difference was.

I walked alongside him. He didn't stop me from coming up beside him. Nor did he welcome it. He simply let it be.

We walked a while without speaking. It struck me as strange that this silence didn't feel uncomfortable. Walking quietly like this beside someone I'd only just met wasn't a common thing, even outside.

He stopped again in one spot. In front of a small heap of bones. I couldn't remember whether I'd passed this spot before. Inside the valley, every heap looked alike, and then looked entirely different from every other.

He crouched down in front of it. He reached out and touched the soil, lightly. He didn't dig into it. It was only a gesture of stroking the surface.

"…Someone you knew?" I asked.

"…No."

"…Then why touch it?"

He drew his hand back and stood up.

"…Does touching have to be the same as knowing?"

Again I had no answer to that. This was a man who answered a question with a question. I couldn't tell whether that was evasion, or whether he was genuinely asking out of curiosity.

. . .

The sun went fully down.

Stars began coming out above the valley wall. The same stars I'd seen from the city's edge. That familiarity was, again, a small comfort.

"…How long have you been here?" I asked again.

This time I asked it a little differently. The first time it had been "were you already here." This time it was "how long." I felt that the difference mattered.

He said nothing for a moment.

It wasn't an angry expression. I studied his face closely. There really was no emotion in it at all. No irritation, no displeasure, and no trace of amusement either. Just empty — but not an emptiness that was cold. An emptiness that was quiet.

"…I don't know," he said.

"…You don't know?"

"…I stopped counting a long time ago."

I stopped short at that answer. It was something I'd heard somewhere before. The Curator had said something like it. That it had been a long time since he'd stopped counting. At the time I'd thought it was a way of avoiding grief.

This time something was different. This man didn't seem to not count because he was avoiding grief. He seemed not to count simply because there was no need to.

"…Longer than seven years?" I asked. I thought if I gave him a specific number, he might answer.

"…Maybe."

"…Ten years?"

"…I don't know."

I realized then that this conversation was strange. In the city, when you asked with a number, people answered with a number. Exactly. This man, asked with a number, didn't answer with a number. And yet he wasn't lying, either. He really seemed not to know.

. . .

"…Then what can you tell me?" I asked.

For the first time he tilted his head slightly. It wasn't a gesture of amusement. It was only the gesture of someone hearing the question again.

"…I was here first," he said. "Is that enough?"

"…First?"

"…Before you came."

I thought that wasn't really an answer. And yet, strangely, I didn't want to press further. I felt, in my body, before I thought it, that he wouldn't say anything more than that.

I return to that moment often, afterward. He wasn't angry. He turned the question aside, and there wasn't a trace of irritation in it. He didn't laugh either. I'd seen plenty of people who deflect while laughing. This man didn't run away into laughter either. He simply turned it aside, as it was. I felt that was a far more honest way to do it. It's a strange thing to say — honest, while turning something aside — but that is exactly how it felt to me.

. . .

I undid my flask.

"…Would you like some water?" I asked.

He looked at me a moment. Then he shook his head.

"…You don't need any?" I asked again.

"…I'm fine."

It was a phrase I was used to hearing in this city. I don't need it. I'm fine. But the way this man said it was somehow different from the way the city's people said it. In the city, people's "I'm fine" meant they really were filled up, and so they were fine. This man's "I'm fine" — I didn't know how to put it. It wasn't that he was full and so fine. It was more that he was a person who simply had very little need at all.

I drank a mouthful of water by myself. My throat was dry.

"…And food?" I asked. "You don't eat?"

"…Sometimes."

"…Only sometimes?"

"…Yes."

I noticed that he didn't look hungry. His body was thin, but it didn't look weak. I thought that was strange, but this whole valley was strange, so I let it pass as one more strangeness among the rest.

. . .

Night settled fully in.

I thought briefly about whether I should find the way back to the city. But my body pushed that thought aside. Climbing a dark slope was dangerous. And more than that, I still wanted to be here a while longer. I didn't know the reason for that, even then.

"…Can I stay here tonight?" I asked.

He looked at me. Neither permission nor refusal in the look.

"…That's for you to decide."

"…Isn't it dangerous?"

"…What is?"

"…Sleeping here."

"…I sleep every day."

That surprised me a little. It was the first time I learned that this man slept here.

"…Where?"

He pointed a hand toward the distance. I looked that way. It was too dark to see anything.

"…There's a hollow over there."

I thought of the shallow hollow I'd seen in Chapter 29 — the one too dark inside to make anything out, the one I hadn't gone into. Knowing now that he slept there, I was glad I hadn't looked inside it. I would have felt as if I'd peered into someone's room without asking.

"…Aren't you cold, there?" I asked.

"…I'm used to it."

"…Is being used to it the same as not being cold?"

Only after I'd said it did I realize it was something my mother had once said to me. When my brother had been afraid of the bucket's sound at the well, my mother had asked me: is being used to it the same as not being afraid?

At that question he looked at me a little longer than before, for the first time.

"…No," he said. "It isn't the same."

That answer surprised me. In the city no one would have answered that way. Everyone said that once you got used to something, it was fine. This man kept the two things apart.

I held onto that short answer for a long time afterward. This man never got angry and never laughed, and yet somewhere in him he was exact, precisely exact. I felt, dimly, even then, that this exactness was different from the city's exactness. The city's exactness came from knowing everything. This man's exactness seemed to come from having lived through something, for a long time.

. . .

I settled myself down on the bare ground. He sat a few steps off. Not side by side, but not far either.

"…Will you walk like this again tomorrow?" I asked.

"…Yes."

"…Can I come with you?"

This time he looked at me a little longer.

"…If you want to."

I liked that answer. It neither stopped me nor led me on.

More stars came out. I tried to count them, then gave it up. It wasn't a number that could be counted.

"…Won't you tell me your name?" I asked, last.

He was silent for a moment. There was no anger in that silence either.

"…Why would I need a name?"

I had no answer to that. He closed his eyes after that. I couldn't tell whether he was sleeping or simply had his eyes shut.

That night, before I fell asleep, I had a strange thought. This man was unlike anyone I'd ever met. The city's people gave short answers because they wanted nothing. This man gave short answers for some other reason. I didn't know what it was, then. The next day, he would ask me a question first. Standing in front of that question, I would come to see part of that reason.

The wind flowed low along the valley wall. Dry things rustled. I closed my eyes listening to that sound.

I woke once in the night. I didn't know how long I'd slept. Opening my eyes, I found he was still sitting in the same spot. His eyes were closed. He might have been asleep; he might only have been sitting there.

I looked at his back for a moment. The angle of his shoulders, the way he sat. There wasn't a single tremor in it. I wondered whether a living person could stay that unmoving for that long.

Every time I recall that night since, it's that stillness that comes back first. I had lived believing that every living person trembles a little. Everyone outside was like that. Breathing shakes you; cold shakes you. That night, for the first time, I fell asleep beside someone who did not tremble at all.

I closed my eyes again. When I next opened them, it was morning.

(Continued in Chapter 31.)

Chapter 31. Can These Bones Live

> *_Previously_ — I met him in the valley. When I asked how long he'd been here, all he said was, "I was here first." Not angry, not laughing either. I spent that night beside him. I fell asleep watching a back that never trembled.*

When I opened my eyes in the morning, he was already up.

He stood not far off, looking deeper into the valley. I watched his back a moment, then pulled myself up. My back was stiff from a night lying on bare ground.

"…Sleep all right?" he asked, without turning around.

"…Yes."

"…Not too cold?"

"…A little."

He nodded at that. It wasn't a worried gesture. Just a confirming one.

The morning light lit the valley differently. Not the red of the evening before, not the dark of night. A white, cold light. Under it, the scattered things showed more clearly than before.

I remember that morning light for a long time afterward. It was a light that hid nothing. Evening light made everything beautiful. Morning light simply showed things as they were.

. . .

We walked together.

Much the same walk as the day before. He went ahead, and I followed a few steps behind. He stopped now and then to look at something. I stopped with him each time.

As we walked I asked him a few more things. Mostly he answered short. To some questions he gave no answer at all, and simply kept walking. I was coming to understand, more and more, that silence too was a kind of answer.

"…How many people are in this valley?" I asked. "Traces like this one."

"…That's not a thing you can count."

"…Why not?"

"…The traces overlap. You can't tell where one ends and another begins, or whether it's the same person."

Hearing that, I thought of the spots I'd seen in Chapter 29 — where I'd counted up to five, ten, seventeen, and then stopped. I'd already learned there was a point past which counting couldn't go. This man seemed to have known that from the start.

"…Aren't you curious?" I asked. "Who all these people were, who came here."

"…I am."

"…Then why don't you look into it?"

"…Searching and walking are different things."

I kept walking without understanding that answer.

We walked a long while, and came to a wide, open space. Wider than the one I'd seen the day before. A place where bones had gathered in unusual numbers. In some spots they still held a whole shape; in others they were scattered.

He stopped walking there. He stayed stopped a long time.

I stood beside him and looked at that landscape with him. I didn't speak. It felt like a place where speaking wasn't allowed.

I still can't describe that silence exactly, even now. It wasn't a sad silence, and it wasn't a frightening one. It was just a very large silence. Standing in front of that size, I felt very small.

. . .

He lowered himself and sat on the earth. I sat down beside him.

The wind blew once. Dust rose low and settled again. Inside that dust, small things rose together and came down again. Threads. Thin fragments of bone.

He watched that scene for a long time. I watched along with him.

After a long while, he spoke.

"…Anemos."

It was the first time he'd said my name. It landed on me, strangely, with weight.

"…Yes."

He didn't go on right away. He took up a handful of soil, then let it run out through his fingers. The dry powder fell slowly.

"…Do you think," he said, "these can live again?"

. . .

I understood the question. Every single word in it was plain. And yet it took time to take in what it meant.

These. I looked at the scattered things in front of us. Bones, rotted scraps of cloth, crumbled shoes. Things that had once been a person.

Live again. That phrase rang strangely inside me. Living again, from a state opposite to being alive. I felt there was something more inside that question. A feeling that this wasn't only about this valley.

"…I don't know," I said.

It didn't take me long to say the words. But saying those three, I felt strangely ashamed. As if I should have offered something more convincing.

"…What do you mean, you don't know?" he asked. It wasn't a pressing tone.

"…I really don't know," I said. "If I say yes it feels like a lie, and if I say no it feels like a lie too."

. . .

He said nothing to that answer. Only he glanced at me for a moment. There was something in that look, and at first I took it for disappointment.

I would learn later it wasn't disappointment. I couldn't tell the difference then.

"…Why not say no?" he asked. "That's just bone. Look at it. It's dry."

At that I looked again at the scattered things. Truly dry. They looked very far from anything living.

"…Even so, I can't bring myself to say no," I said.

"…Why not?"

I tried to find an answer to that question. I looked for it and didn't find it.

"…I don't know. I just can't."

. . .

He traced something in the dirt with a fingertip. A meaningless line. Then he wiped it away.

"…Then why can't you say yes?" he asked again.

I couldn't answer that one either, right away.

"…I've never seen anything like this," I said. "Outside, when a person died, they were just dead. I've never seen anyone live again."

"…What about the city, then? There are people there who live again, aren't there. Release, I think it's called."

I was startled by that. It was strange that he even knew the word release.

"…That seems like something different from living again," I said. "It's turning a preserved person back — not bringing a dead person back."

"…Why is that different?"

I stopped a long while at that question. The preserved really do not disappear. They exist in a state that has not died. But the things in this valley had disappeared. Only traces remained. I'd thought that difference was very large, and yet when I tried to explain it, the words wouldn't come.

"…I don't know," I said again. "I thought it was different, but now I'm not sure."

. . .

Writing this passage, I meet myself again as I was that day. I kept saying, over and over, that I didn't know. I was ashamed. Since coming into the city I had always been the one learning something, never the one giving the answer. But in front of this man, even what I'd learned was no use. None of it could answer that question.

He asked again. This time the same question in slightly different words.

"…What I mean is — do you think that becomes a person again," he said, pointing his hand at the scattered things. "Breathing, walking. So that

if you called its name, it would turn to look."

I stopped again in front of that specific picture. Breathing, walking, so that calling a name makes it turn. I laid that picture over my mother and my brother. My mother didn't breathe. More precisely, she had no need to breathe. My brother was the same. And yet both of them turned to look, if you called their name.

The things in this valley didn't turn, however you called. I knew that difference. And still no answer came.

"…I don't know," I said, a third time.

. . .

For the first time he looked at me a little longer.

I didn't look away. There was no reason to. I truly didn't know, and I didn't want to hide that.

"…That's all right," he said.

That surprised me.

"…What is?"

"…Not knowing."

It took me time to understand that.

"…Shouldn't I give the right answer?" I asked.

"…What's the right answer?"

I couldn't answer that question either. Yes didn't feel like the right answer, and no didn't feel like it either. Neither one was it, but then I didn't know what was.

"…Saying I don't know," he said, "is sometimes the right answer."

. . .

"…Does that really count as an answer?" I asked.

"…It does."

"…How? You haven't said anything at all."

He picked up a small stone from the ground. Held it a moment in his hand, then set it back down.

"…Not knowing isn't the same as saying nothing," he said. "It's not lying that you know."

I turned that over for a long time.

"…I wanted to say yes," I said, honestly. "It felt like I should. I want those people to be alive again."

"…Then why didn't you say yes?"

"…Because it would have been a lie. I don't actually believe that's going to happen."

In that moment I felt I'd been honest with myself for the first time. What you wish for and what you know are different things. I wished. But I didn't know. That day was the first time I'd said those two without mixing them together.

In that moment I thought of that night seven years before. The adults arguing behind the door. One side had said, "Stopping isn't the same as living." The other had asked back, "And is dying living, then?" At nine years old I'd only half understood those two sentences.

Standing in front of this valley, I felt for the first time why both of them were right. Stopping and living are different — that's true. The city had shown me that. But dying isn't living either. These scattered things had shown me that. Both sentences were true, and neither one was the answer I wanted.

"…I've been carrying those two sentences around for seven years," I said. I told him briefly about that night.

He only listened, all the way through. Even after hearing it all, he didn't say which side was right.

"…Both are right," he said. "That's why they don't stand together."

"…They can't stand together?"

"…No. But that's not the problem. The problem is that you have to keep living between the two of them."

I turned that over for a long time.

. . .

"…You could have said no," I said. "That would've been easier. It's just bone, after all."

"…Then why didn't you?"

"…That felt like a lie too."

As I gave that answer, I tried to find the reason I felt that way. I found it.

"…I've seen water running toward this valley," I said. "It hasn't reached here yet. Speon is digging the channel. Even before the water arrives, I already felt like something here was alive. I don't know why that is. But I don't want to call that feeling a lie either."

Hearing that, his eyes widened slightly, for the first time. The closest thing to a surprised expression I'd seen on him.

"…That," he said. "That's what not knowing is."

. . .

I didn't fully understand what he meant. But I could feel it was something important.

"…Will these bones live again, or won't they?" I finally asked again. This time it was my turn to put the question to him.

He shook his head.

"…I don't know either."

That surprised me.

"…You've been here longer than I have."

"…Is being here long the same as knowing?"

I nearly laughed at that question. I didn't laugh. It wasn't a laugh that belonged in that place.

"…I just walk," he said. "Beside these. I don't pretend to know."

I felt, then, that I understood a little of why this man was here. I still can't explain it. Only, he wasn't someone who held the answer to this valley. He was someone who kept carrying the question of this valley, on and on.

. . .

We sat in that spot a long while longer.

The wind blew a few more times. Dust rose and settled. I watched that repeat. I didn't count it.

"…Are you disappointed?" I asked. "That I couldn't give an answer."

"…No."

"…Why not?"

"…Not many people have given the answer, I don't know."

That surprised me a little.

"…What did other people say?"

"…Yes, or no."

"…Which one more?"

"…No, more. Then yes."

That order struck me, strangely, as sad.

"…And I don't know?"

He looked at me a moment.

"…You're the first."

. . .

I couldn't answer at all, hearing that.

I keep this sentence among the ones I hold onto longest in this whole book. You're the first. I still don't know, even now, whether that was praise or just a fact. Only, from that day on, I came to know that saying you don't know something isn't a shameful thing. An honest not-knowing is better than a hastily built knowing.

He stood up. He started walking again.

I sat there a little longer, then stood and followed.

"…Do you ask other people this question too?" I asked.

"…Probably."

"…Why did you ask me?"

He answered without stopping his walk.

"…Because you brought water with you."

I didn't know what that meant. Whether he meant the flask, or something else. He explained no further.

I turned that over for a long time. I still haven't fully worked it out, even now. Only, later in this book, I would come to a place that brought that line back to me again.

We walked together the rest of that afternoon. We didn't return to that question again. Both of us seemed to know there was no need to.

As we walked, I asked myself that question again, silently, more than once. Do you think these can live again. The answer still didn't come. But the not-coming was less uncomfortable now than it had been at first. I couldn't explain why, that day.

I can explain a little now. Even not-knowing becomes bearable once it finds its place. That afternoon, for the first time, I was able to walk inside a state of not-knowing — without rushing to find an answer.

When the sun rose high, he stopped walking and looked at me.

"…Going back to the city?" he asked.

I couldn't answer right away. Wanting to stay here longer and knowing I had to go up were both in me at once.

"…Yes," I said finally. "I think I should go."

"…All right."

He didn't try to hold me back. He didn't try to stop me either.

"…Can I come down again?" I asked.

"…If you want to."

I nodded at that answer. Then I turned and started toward the slope I'd come down. A few steps on, I looked back. He was already walking again.

Among the bones, without a tremor.

(Continued in Chapter 32.)

Chapter 32. Back Up

> *_Previously_ — He asked me: "…Do you think these can live again?" I*
> *couldn't answer. He didn't fault me for that. "You're the first." By afternoon I decided to go back to the city.*

The road up felt longer than the road down had been.

The same slope, the same rocks. And yet my feet kept feeling heavy. I couldn't tell whether that was my body's exhaustion, or something else.

I used the rope a few times. The knots came together in one try now. My hands seemed to have fully relearned that work. I smiled a little, watching them. The twelve days of shoveling hadn't gone to waste.

Climbing that slope, I kept turning that question over the whole way. Do you think these can live again. The question was under my feet the entire climb. Every time I set a foot down, it asked itself again. I decided not to look for an answer. As he had told me to, the night before.

. . .

Around the six-hundredth step, I looked back.

The valley lay down there below. Wide, quiet, dry exactly as it had been the day before. I tried to find him in that view. I couldn't. Either he was too far off, or he'd gone behind some fold of ground.

I felt a strange disappointment then. It hadn't even been a full day, and already it felt natural to me that he would keep being there. I would go through that disappointment again many times, later. I'll write more about it in Chapter 47.

I turned and kept walking.

. . .

By the time I reached the city's edge, the sun had passed a little beyond its height.

I caught my breath. I brushed off the dust. There was white powder from the valley on my hands and my clothes. I didn't brush all of it off. For some reason, I didn't want to.

The city spread out before my eyes.

The buildings, the square, the distribution station, the Curator's building far off. All exactly as it had been. I confirmed that with my own eyes. Nothing had changed. Not the roof colors, not the width of the streets, not the way people walked.

Even the light was different. The valley's light had come filtered through white powder; whatever it fell on lost a shade of its color. The city's light was yellow and clear. I stood under that light and looked at my own hand. The white powder caught in the back of it stood out strangely. Even the air was different. The valley's air had been heavy and dry; here it was light, and smelled newly washed.

And yet it looked different.

I tried, for a long time, to rewrite this sentence. I wanted to explain exactly how it looked different. After rewriting it many times, I finally accepted that this sentence was the most accurate one there was. Nothing had changed, and yet it looked different. Beyond that, I have no explanation.

I stood there and tried to count the city. How many roofs there were, how many alleys. I'd done this several times before. The numbers had always come out the same. I counted again, that day. The roofs came out the same number as ever. So did the alleys, and the square.

Only after confirming that not one of those numbers had changed did I understand why I'd felt uneasy. I think I had secretly hoped something would have changed. Seeing that nothing had, I felt, if anything, even more like a stranger here.

. . .

At first I thought it might be the light.

I wondered whether my eyes, having grown used to the valley's white light, were simply taking in the city's familiar light differently. But as I walked I learned that wasn't it.

I passed the distribution station. The attendant recognized me and nodded. The same greeting as always. And yet, receiving it, I felt it as something strange. This man had greeted me exactly the same way yesterday, and the day before that. I noticed it, freshly, as if for the first time.

I passed the square. There were the benches. A few people sitting on them. I looked at them. They all sat quietly. No one running, no one hurrying.

I must have seen that scene dozens of times. It had been over a month since I'd come to this city. And yet that day the scene looked strange to me, as if I were seeing it for the first time. To eyes that had just come from the valley, this quiet read differently.

One person was standing in front of a flowerbed. A small flowerbed. One of the few in this city — planted not with flowers, but simply with dry grass. That person was holding a watering can. Giving it exactly the regulation amount of water. I watched that motion for a long time.

That flowerbed wasn't receiving water because it needed it. It was receiving it because that was the set procedure. I noticed that difference for the first time that day. There was no one watering anything in the valley. No one had set a schedule for it there. And yet I'd felt something alive there. This flowerbed, receiving its exact water every single day, gave off no such feeling at all.

Passing in front of the Curator's building, the clerk at the front desk recognized me and gave a light greeting. Receiving it, I thought of my mother and my brother. At this very moment, the two of them were still in that room, in the same posture as yesterday. My steps slowed a little at that thought. Then I kept walking. I didn't want to go that way, today.

. . .

I walked along the channel.

Speon's channel. It was running all the way to the city's edge now. I walked listening to it. The sound of water was exactly the same as yesterday. And yet even that sound was heard differently.

I had a thought for the first time then. It wasn't the sound that had changed. It was my ears. I had heard true silence, in the valley. A silence with no sound in it at all. Coming back to the city, even this small sound of water rang loud.

Walking, I heard, freshly, sounds I'd never before picked out one by one. The click of the distribution station's scale. The sound of someone opening and closing a door. Footsteps far off, all of them small and careful. It had been over a month since I'd come to this city, and even having lived that long among these sounds, I had never once listened to them separately, one by one.

I went to the pit. Speon was there, smoothing the soil.

"…Back," he said, setting his shovel upright. It wasn't a worried face. But there was something in the eyes that looked at me.

"…Yes."

"…All right?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know," I said. "Whether I'm all right or not."

Speon nodded at that answer. He didn't press further.

. . .

"…What was down there?" he asked.

I didn't know how to answer that question. Bones, traces, and a person. I didn't know which of those to say first.

"…I met someone," I said.

Speon stopped shoveling.

"…Someone?"

"…Yes. Inside the valley. Walking among the bones."

Speon looked at me for a long time. It was a surprised face, though not enormously surprised.

"…What kind of person?"

"…I don't know. He didn't tell me his name."

"…What did he say?"

I stopped for a moment at that question. I wasn't sure I could carry that question over to Speon — do you think these can live again.

"…He asked me one question," I said. "I still haven't answered it."

Speon didn't press further at that. He just nodded.

"…There are questions you don't answer," he said. "Not everything has to have an answer."

Strangely, that was a comfort to me.

. . .

On the way back to the dormitory, I stopped in front of the tub of water they kept for washing. A large tub. The water lay still inside it.

I looked at my own face reflected on it.

My face had tanned a little over the past few days. Dried dust still lay in a thin film on my cheeks. My eyes looked a little more sunken than before. I looked at that face for a long time.

It was then I understood, exactly, for the first time, that the city hadn't changed at all. The city hadn't changed one bit. What had changed was me. A face that had spent a day in the valley simply looked different to eyes that had come back to the city. But knowing that didn't make the strangeness go away.

I scooped water in my hand and washed my face. The dust washed down. The water clouded and then cleared again. I looked into that tub a long while before I moved on.

. . .

I walked the city the whole afternoon.

No particular purpose. I just wanted to walk. As I walked I kept comparing things. The valley's soil against the city's streets. The valley's silence against the city's small sounds. The valley's scattered things against the city's ordered people.

I knew that comparison wasn't fair. One was a land of failures, and the other was a city of successes. And yet I couldn't stop making it.

Passing in front of the Curator's building, I stopped walking a moment. I thought of my mother and my brother. I thought about going to visit. But my feet wouldn't move that way.

I didn't know the reason then. I learned it later. I didn't want to see my mother while I still hadn't found an answer to that question. The question and my mother had, somewhere along the way, become bound together as one.

I saw the Curator climbing the steps to his building. He didn't seem to notice me. He was climbing with a folder tucked under his arm. His pace was slower than usual. I watched his back for a moment.

I saw something in that back, though I couldn't put a name to it then. A weight different from mere tiredness. I would only come to know what it was in Chapter 34. Writing this passage now, I find myself wanting to count how many times a day he climbs and descends those six steps. I've never counted it.

. . .

That evening I met Eikon.

By chance. She was in the spot where she always walked. The moment she saw me, her expression changed slightly.

"…You're back," she said. "You're still you?"

I laughed a little at that question. I remembered what she'd said before I went down to the valley. Don't come back a different person.

"…I don't know," I said, honestly. "I'm not sure I know myself well either."

At that answer, Eikon's face took on a slightly strange look.

"…Isn't that the same as becoming a different person?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…What was down there?" she asked.

"…Bones. Traces. And there was a person."

"…A person? In that valley?"

"…Yes."

Eikon's face stiffened slightly.

"…There can't be a person there."

I said nothing to that. I wanted to ask why she was so certain, but I didn't.

. . .

"…What did that person say?" Eikon asked.

I hesitated a moment. I wasn't sure I could carry that question over to her either.

"…He asked me — do you think these can live again."

Eikon's face showed nothing at all, hearing that. After a long while, she said this.

"…That's a strange question."

"…Why?"

"…The answer's obvious. Bones don't live."

I wanted to say something to that, but the words wouldn't come. I couldn't call her wrong. But I didn't want to say she was right either.

"…Is that what you think?" I asked.

"…Of course. It's right that they don't live."

I envied that certainty. At the same time, it frightened me a little.

"…Why couldn't you answer, Anemos?" Eikon asked. It wasn't a mocking tone.

"…I don't know either. I didn't want to say yes, and I didn't want to say no."

"…Why not?"

I thought about that question for a long time.

"…If I say no, it feels like admitting those people are really over. I couldn't do that."

"…And if you say yes?"

"…That feels like a lie. Not something I said because I really believe it — just because I wish it were so."

Eikon looked at me steadily for a moment, hearing that.

"…That's strange," she said. "I've never once had to think about that."

"…Why not?"

"…Because for me there's only one answer. There's nothing to think about."

Listening to that, I felt that in her world there was no place at all for not knowing. I felt both envy and sadness at that. I couldn't gauge, then, which was larger.

I kept turning that conversation over on the way back. Eikon had said no without a moment's hesitation. I couldn't. I would come to understand a little more where that difference came from, in the next chapter.

. . .

That night, I lay in the dormitory looking up at the city's familiar ceiling.

The night before, there had been the valley's stars. Tonight it was just a ceiling. I turned that difference over for a long time.

That was the first night I didn't feel this city was holding me prisoner. Instead I felt this city was putting something off. I couldn't put into words, then, what it was putting off. I can now. This city was a place that deferred the question. The valley was a place that kept asking it.

I looked at my palms. I could feel the thin callus that had settled over the old blister marks. I started to count how many times that hand had touched the city's walls that day, and gave it up. The days I gave up counting were growing more frequent.

I lay down with my head on the flask. Water sat half-full inside it. I thought about where that water had come from. The distribution station. The valley's water hadn't reached that far yet.

I didn't know, then, that this water would one day run all the way to that valley. If I had known, I wouldn't have slept as easily as I did

that night.

Before falling asleep, I brought that question to mind one last time. Do you think these can live again. This time too, I made no answer to it. Instead I simply set the question down beside me and closed my eyes.

I dreamed that night. A dream in which the valley and the city ran together. My mother was walking across the white soil, and my brother was holding the water flask. I didn't remember all of the dream when I woke. Only one scene stayed with me clearly. My mother turned to look at me and said something, but no sound came.

(Continued in Chapter 33.)

Chapter 33. Eikon's Logic

> *_Previously_ — Back up from the valley, the city looked different though nothing about it had changed. I carried the question over to Eikon. "Do you think these can live again." She'd said no without a moment's hesitation.*

The next morning, I went to find Eikon again.

It wasn't that there was anything left unsaid from the day before. To be exact, I didn't know myself why I'd gone looking for her. Her certainty just kept sitting on my mind. That face saying no, without hesitation.

She was on the bench she always sat on. She saw me and nodded slightly. No surprise. In keeping with this city's people.

"…Back again," she said.

"…Yes."

"…Because of what we talked about yesterday?"

I was a little surprised she'd guessed that.

"…Yes. That's right."

. . .

On the way there I'd passed Speon's pit. The sound of running water came from it. Listening to it, I'd thought — everyone always said it was a

good thing when water appeared where there had been none. But that reasoning didn't work on Eikon. For her, everything was already there.

I sat down beside her. I set the flask on my knees. My hand fiddled with the cap.

"…There's something I wanted to ask yesterday, and didn't," I said.

"…What is it?"

"…Is there really nothing you wish for?"

Eikon's face took on a thinking look at that question. Not an angry expression. A face that was really thinking it through.

"…What do you mean, wish for?" she asked back.

"…Wanting something more, because something's lacking."

"…I don't lack anything."

I'd heard that answer from her many times before. But that day it sounded a little different. I wanted to ask her more.

"…Really?" I asked. "Not one thing?"

Eikon looked straight at me.

"…Yes. Really."

"…For example?" I asked. "Something you'd like to eat, something you'd like to wear — nothing at all?"

"…There's nothing I'd like to eat," she said. "What the distribution station gives is enough. I've never wished for anything more

delicious. It's the same with clothes."

I lost words in front of that answer. Outside, wanting something more delicious, something warmer to wear, was simply a given. Only then did it really sink in that here, that given didn't hold at all.

. . .

"…Can you explain it to me?" I asked. "Why you don't lack anything."

Eikon was quiet a moment. Not a silence for choosing her words — a silence more like rethinking the question itself.

"…I've never been hungry," she said. "Never been sick. Never been lonely. My parents are here, and I'm still me. What more would I need?"

"…But isn't there something you wish for anyway? Anything at all."

"…No," she said. It wasn't a firm tone. Just a tone stating a fact. "Wishing means wanting something you don't have right now. There's nothing I don't have right now."

I tried to find something to argue against that. I couldn't find it.

"…Is there nothing you're curious about?" I asked again. "Something new, something you've never seen."

"…There are things I'm curious about. I'm curious about that person you say you met, yesterday. But curious and lacking are different things."

"…How are they different?"

"…When you're curious, it ends once you know. When you're lacking, filling it just makes more come up. From what you've said, that's how it

sounds for you."

Something in me flinched at that. It was an exact hit. Outside, filling it had always just made more come up. In this city, there was nothing like that.

"…So you've never once gone through that? Filling something and having more come up."

"…No. Not since I came here."

"…And before?"

Eikon closed her eyes a moment, then opened them.

"…My memory's hazy. It was seven years ago. But I probably did. Everyone does."

I turned that over for a long time. It was the first time it occurred to me that she might once have been like me.

. . .

"…So why would I need more?" she asked, first this time.

I stopped at that question.

"…What do you mean?"

"…I know you keep looking at us thinking it's a pity. You try not to show it on the outside, but it shows anyway."

I felt ashamed at that. I wanted to deny it, but I couldn't.

"…But me," Eikon said. "I don't lack anything. Why would I need more?"

I read that sentence over to myself several times. I don't lack anything. Why would I need more. It had the shape of a question, but it wasn't really a question at all. It was the speech of someone who already had the answer.

. . .

I hold onto this sentence longer than any other in this record. Writing this book, I tried, over and over, to argue against it. I failed every time.

"…If you had more," I tried to go on, "you'd learn more, and grow more, and—"

"…More what?" Eikon asked. It wasn't a taunting tone.

I stopped at that question. Grow more. But why should you grow. Why is growing better than not growing. I tried to find the answer and realized it had always been so obvious to me that I'd never once had to put it into words.

"…I don't know," I said, honestly.

Eikon smiled a little at that answer. Not a mocking smile.

"…You say I don't know a lot lately too."

"…I guess I do."

. . .

"…I'm not sad," she said again. "I'm not suffering. I'm me. The same as I was seven years ago. Why is that bad?"

I had no answer to that question either.

"…I didn't say it was bad," I said.

"…But you think it. You look at me and feel sorry for me."

I started to deny it, then stopped. It was true.

"…I'm sorry," I said.

"…There's nothing to be sorry for," Eikon said. "I just think it's strange. I'm fine, so why does everyone look at me feeling sorry?"

In front of that question, for the first time, I saw this whole city differently. Maybe it wasn't this city that was to be pitied. Maybe it was me, looking at this city and finding it pitiable. I tried to push that thought away for a long time.

. . .

"…If you're really all right," I asked, carefully, "why did that person apply for release, back then? You told me about it before. The one you called sick."

Eikon's expression shifted slightly, for the first time.

"…That person was sick."

"…Sick with what?"

"…I don't know. She just turned strange. She started wanting things, over and over. She hadn't been like that before."

"…What did she want?"

"…I don't remember. Anyway, then she applied, and after that she was gone."

That word — gone — stuck with me.

"…How can you be sure it was a sickness?" I asked.

Eikon looked at me. For the first time something other than certainty flickered a little in her eyes.

"…I can't be sure," she said. "But there's no other word for it. If someone who was fine suddenly starts wanting something, what else would you call it?"

. . .

I had no answer to that either.

"…Have you ever been afraid?" I asked. A question that came to me suddenly. "Seven years ago, before you came here."

Eikon paused a moment at that question.

"…Maybe. I don't remember well."

"…Not even what you were afraid of?"

"…The dark, maybe. Doesn't everyone get afraid of that?"

"…And now?"

"…Now there's no reason to go anywhere dark. I sleep at the set time, at night."

Something bitter came over me at that answer. It wasn't that the fear had gone away — it was that there was nothing left to be afraid of at all. I remembered feeling this same distinction with my mother and my brother. This city hadn't overcome fear. It had simply removed everything there was to fear.

In that moment I understood how honest that word "sickness" really was. Eikon wasn't using it out of malice. In her world, it truly was a word with no other name to give it. When a lack appears in a world with no lack in it, there's no word for it but sickness.

"…I don't think it's a sickness," I said, carefully.

"…Then what do you think it is?"

I stopped a long time at that question.

"…I don't know," I said finally. "But I don't think 'sickness' is the right word."

Eikon showed no particular reaction to that. Not angry, not agreeing either. Just a face that seemed to set the words aside somewhere inside her.

. . .

"…You know," Eikon said, after a long while, "I don't understand why you keep trying to shake me."

I was startled by that.

"…I wasn't trying to."

"…You are. By asking so many questions."

I didn't know what to say to that.

"…I'm sorry," I said again.

"…I told you there's nothing to be sorry for," Eikon said. "But know this much — I'm not shaking. No matter how much you ask."

For the first time, I felt something else behind her certainty. It sounded almost like a defense. And yet the certainty was still perfectly clear. It was strange that the two could sit together.

I didn't know, then, how to hold those two things together. I still don't fully know now. Only, having finished this whole book, I've come to think this was one of the most honest moments in it.

"…But," Eikon said again, "why do you keep trying to shake me? I don't shake you."

I thought about that question for a long time.

"…I guess it's because I'm worried about you," I said.

"…There's nothing to worry about, I keep telling you."

"…I'm still worried."

At that, for the first time, Eikon's face softened, just a little.

"…You're a strange person. Worrying about someone with nothing to worry about."

"…I guess I am."

. . .

"…I don't lack anything. Why would I need more?"

Eikon said it once more. This time it wasn't asked of me — it sounded more like something she was confirming to herself.

I tried again to argue against that sentence. I thought about bringing up love. That love doesn't need a lack. But before I could say it, I knew it wouldn't persuade her. She was loved. Her parents were still beside her. Even love, for her, was already something fully filled.

In that moment, for the first time, I admitted I had no words that could beat this logic. She wasn't wrong. She wasn't suffering. No argument had any power in front of her satisfaction. I think this is the most frightening fact in this whole book. I still think so now.

In that moment I thought of my brother. Preserved at eight, he stood in the same place as Eikon. An eight-year-old who lacked nothing. I remembered the answer I'd gotten when I first brought up release to him. "I'll do it if you do it." I'd withdrawn my own application because I couldn't accept that as consent. Standing in front of Eikon now, I felt I understood that reason a little more clearly. My brother hadn't answered because he had no lack to answer from. It was the same with Eikon. Both of them weren't refusing to want something — for both of them, the very motion of wanting had become unnecessary.

I saw that difference clearly for the first time, in that moment. Refusal and having-no-need are different things. My brother and Eikon had never refused. They simply had no reason to want. I had confused the two for a long time.

"…What about longing?" I asked, last. "Missing someone who's gone. Isn't there any of that either?"

Eikon looked at me for a moment.

"…There's no one for me to miss," she said. "My parents are here. I'm here. There's no one who's gone, so there's no one to miss."

I was completely out of words at that. For longing to exist at all, something had to be lost first. In her world, nothing had been lost.

"…Yeah," I said finally. "I think you're right."

Eikon looked a little surprised at that. She didn't seem to have expected I would concede so easily.

"…And yet something's still left over?" she asked. For the first time she turned the question back on me.

"…Yeah," I said. "Something's left."

"…What is it?"

"…I don't know. I'd feel better if I knew what it was, too."

. . .

The sun was going down. Eikon stood up.

"…I hope you find that answer," she said. An unexpected thing to say.

"…Why?"

"…So you'll stop shaking me."

I laughed at that. She smiled, just barely, too.

"…I'll come again," I said.

"…All right. But I'm not going to change."

She walked off. I watched her back and turned that sentence over again. I'm not going to change. I understood that it wasn't a threat, and it wasn't a warning either. It was just her stating a fact.

I stayed sitting there a long while after. I could feel the bench cooling. I watched the people passing by. All of them wore the same face as Eikon. A face that lacked nothing. Those faces looked a little different to me now. Before, I'd thought of them as empty faces. That day I understood they weren't. Not empty — full. Only what filled them held none of the things I knew.

Since I'd come to this city, I'd kept looking at these people with pity. That day, for the first time, I thought that the pity might be a lack on my side. Was it not because something was missing in me that I looked at them and found them pitiable? I held onto that question a long time, and set it down again without an answer.

That night, I tried to write Eikon's logic down on paper. I lack nothing. Therefore I have no reason to want more. There was no flaw anywhere between those two sentences. I sat a long time in front of that perfection.

(Continued in Chapter 34.)

Chapter 34. The Curator's Sorrow

> *_Previously_ — Eikon stated her logic plainly. "I don't lack anything.*
> *Why would I need more?" I couldn't argue against it. She said she wasn't shaking. I felt something else behind that certainty.*

The next day I went to see the Curator.

I had no particular business. It wasn't a visit application either. I simply couldn't stop thinking about that back I'd seen climbing the steps the day before.

The clerk at the front desk looked a little puzzled to see me.

"…Not a visit today?"

"…No. I just came to see him."

The clerk went off to ask inside. I sat on the long bench and waited. I didn't count the chairs, always twelve of them. I felt no need to count.

. . .

The Curator's room was exactly as it had been.

One desk, two chairs. The walls still bare. The stack of papers looked a little taller than before.

Every time I walked into that room, I felt anew how completely unchanged it was. The first time, the second time, today. I used to think this was simply his taste. Now I know better. It wasn't that he had no reason to change it — it was that he had no time to. The stack of papers in that room had never once gotten smaller.

The varnish had worn off the corner of the desk, at the spot where he rested his hand. One armrest of his chair shone unusually smooth on one side only — the side, it seemed, he leaned on when he signed. Looking at those spots, I felt, for the first time, as though I had actually seen with my own eyes how long this man had sat at this desk.

The Curator saw me and rose slightly from his seat.

"…Anemos. It's been a while."

"…Yes."

"…I heard you went down to the valley."

I was startled at that.

"…How did you know?"

"…There's a record that you filled your flask twice at the distribution station." The Curator smiled slightly. "This city keeps a record of even that."

I felt that smile was a little different from his usual one. I didn't know then what was different about it.

. . .

"…How was it?" the Curator asked.

I couldn't answer that right away. I didn't know where to begin.

"…There were a lot of bones," I said. "And I met someone."

At that the Curator touched the desk with his fingertips. A very brief motion.

"…Someone?"

"…Yes. He was walking there."

The Curator said nothing for a moment. I felt that silence resembled that gap I'd seen in him before — that instant, while explaining a procedure, when his eyes had drifted somewhere else, very briefly.

"…Did you know?" I asked. "That there's a person down there."

The Curator nodded. Then he spoke very slowly.

"…I knew. I've known for a long time."

. . .

"…Who is he?"

"…I don't know either," the Curator said. "I've never asked him his name."

"…Why not?"

"…I thought he wouldn't answer, even if I asked."

I laughed at that. It matched exactly what I'd experienced in the valley.

"…Have you been down there?" I asked.

The Curator looked out the window a moment. Only rooftops were visible through it. Not a direction that looked toward the valley.

"…Yes," he said. "Many times."

I was startled by that. I'd heard that no one in this city went down. There was no need to.

"…Why do you go down?"

The Curator didn't answer that right away. He squared the corners of the stack of papers, though they were already square.

"…Because it's my work," he said.

. . .

"…Is that your work? Going down into the valley?"

"…No one assigned it to me," the Curator said. "I just thought someone had to know. What's down there."

I turned that over for a long time.

"…What is down there?" I asked. "As you've seen it."

This time the Curator was silent for a long while. I nearly started counting that silence. Then I stopped myself. For the first time, counting something in front of this man felt like rudeness.

"…Failure," he said finally.

Something in me went rigid at that word.

"…Are the ones who failed, down there?"

"…No," the Curator said, shaking his head. "It isn't the people who failed."

. . .

"…Then what failed?"

The Curator looked straight at me. For the first time, I saw something unhidden in those eyes.

"…I did," he said. "I'm the one who failed."

I had no answer to that.

"…What do you mean?" I managed. "What did you fail at?"

The Curator laced his fingers together. He sat like that for a moment.

"…When I first came to this post," he said, "I thought preservation was a completion. Keeping a person from pain, keeping them from disappearing. I believed that was the best thing we could do."

"…You don't now?"

"…I still think that. Preservation really is a good thing. No one is in pain, no one disappears. That's not a lie."

"…But?"

"…But I learned, later, that believing that was the whole of it — that was my failure. That not being in pain and being alive are different things — I didn't know that. Not for a very long time."

"…Perpetuity doesn't fail," the Curator went on. "That's a fact. Preservation is exact. It does exactly what it promises. No disappearing, no losing memory, no pain. It has never once broken that, not a single time."

"…But?"

"…But believing that was the whole of it — that was my failure."

I didn't fully understand that sentence at the time. I know now. This man wasn't doubting the system. The system worked perfectly. What he doubted was himself — himself, who had believed a perfect system to be only that: perfect.

. . .

"…What's down there," the Curator said, "isn't something preservation failed to produce. It's a place that shows what preservation left out."

"…Left out what?"

The Curator opened his hand, then closed it again.

"…I don't know exactly, either. That's why I go down. To find out."

I felt that answer was strangely honest. This man never seemed ashamed to say he didn't know. I'd sensed before that he didn't tell me everything he knew. But that wasn't him hiding something — it was that there really were things he didn't know.

"…The first time I asked you," I said, carefully, "when you told me release was possible. You didn't look glad."

"…No."

"…Why not?"

The Curator looked at me a long while at that question.

. . .

"…While I'm in this post," he said, "my work is to explain this procedure exactly. As it is. Without hiding anything, without exaggerating anything. That's my job."

"…Yes."

"…But every time I do that work, I know exactly what I'm saying."

I hadn't yet felt the full weight of those words.

"…What do you mean?"

For the first time I saw that his eyes were wet. He wasn't crying. Just something heavy around them.

"…Every time, I recommend preservation to people," he said. "Because it's my work. And I know what that means for that person. They will never be in pain again. They will never disappear again. And they will never, ever again, laugh or cry."

I couldn't breathe at that.

"…Knowing that," the Curator went on, "I do that work every day."

"…How many times a day?" I asked.

"…Usually three or four," he said. "Sometimes more than ten."

I was startled by that number. This man repeated words of the same weight ten times a day. I tried to count how many years that had accumulated over, and gave it up. It seemed a number too large for counting to mean anything.

. . .

"…Then why do you keep doing it?" I asked. I didn't mean it as an accusation. I was truly curious.

"…If I don't, someone else will," the Curator said. "And I — at least if I'm the one doing it, I can do it without hiding anything."

"…Does that comfort you?"

"…No," he said, right away. "It's no comfort. It's just the best I can do."

I couldn't say anything in front of that answer. This man didn't look for comfort in his own work. He didn't justify his own work either. He simply knew the work was sad, and didn't stop because of that sadness.

. . .

"…What about kids like Eikon?" I asked. "Do you know them too?"

"…Yes. I know all of them."

"…How do you feel, seeing them?"

The Curator looked out the window a moment.

"…At first I was glad," he said. "It was proof that preservation was working well. No pain, not forgotten. That was the goal of my work."

"…And now?"

"…I'm still glad," he said. "And at the same time, I'm sad."

I started to ask how those two feelings could exist together in one person, and gave it up. I already knew the answer. I'd heard something like it from Speon. Worried, but that doesn't mean I can go in your place. Hard, but that doesn't mean I can't bear it. This man was holding two things together in the same way.

. . .

"…I'm not going to quit this work," the Curator said. "That's the most honest answer I can give you."

"…Why not quit?"

"…Because if I quit, someone who doesn't grieve as much as I do will do this instead."

My throat tightened at that. This man was using his own sorrow like a resource. He seemed to believe that if someone who grieves does this work, the work becomes, if only a little, less cold.

I came to see this man differently, that day. At first I'd seen him as a kind man. Then I'd seen him as a tired man. That day, for the first

time, I saw him as a sad man. And I saw that his sadness didn't stop him. I think the last of those three is the heaviest.

Elsewhere in this record, I've heard about other officials in other cities. One believed the system so completely he never doubted it. One didn't believe it, but followed it anyway for lack of any alternative. Another didn't even know what shame was. Every time I hear those stories, I think of this man. He was unlike all three. He believed the system — because the system really was exact. And at the same time, knowing exactly what that exactness meant for a person, he kept doing the work every day. I think that is the hardest place to stand. Believing, and grieving.

From the stack of papers on his desk, he pulled out one sheet, then put it back without showing it to me. I didn't ask what it was. But watching that gesture, I remembered what Speon had said — that this man wrote every document himself instead of leaving it to anyone else. That he staked his own name on anything he decided.

"…Did you write that yourself?" I asked.

"…Yes. I write every document I sign, myself."

"…Why? You could leave it to someone else."

"…If I don't write it myself," the Curator said, "it feels like I'm not taking responsibility for it."

My throat tightened again at that.

I looked down at the floor by the window. It was worn far more than the rest of the floor. It looked like the spot he stood in every time he looked outside. I knew that kind of wear didn't come in a few days. It

takes a long time, a very long time of standing, to make a floor look like that.

. . .

"…Thank you," I said. I wasn't sure exactly what I was thanking him for.

"…For what?"

"…For being honest with me."

At that the Curator smiled, very slightly, for the first time. A sad smile.

"…Anemos, you're the first person I've said this to."

I asked, startled.

"…You never told anyone?"

"…No. No one ever asked."

That sentence rang, to me, like Eikon's had. It's been a while since I've heard the word bored. No one in this city ever asked each other things like this. They were people with no reason to ask.

. . .

"…Can I ask one more thing?" I said, standing to leave.

"…Yes."

"…You said you'd seen someone released. The first time. Can you tell me, now, what that was like?"

The Curator looked at me for a long while.

"…I trembled," he said. "Seeing someone who could die again. But that person smiled, for the first time. I still remember that face."

I couldn't ask anything to that.

"…What happened to that person afterward?" I asked.

"…They lived. A few years," the Curator said. "And then they stopped."

I recognized that word. It was a word I'd used outside. The word for someone who passes after a long illness. It was the first time I'd heard anyone in this city use it.

"…Where did you learn that word?" I asked.

"…That person taught it to me. After the release. They asked me to use it, when they died."

"…Why?"

"…They said they wanted to leave it behind as proof they had lived."

I caught my breath at that.

"…Was that smile a good thing, or a bad thing?" I managed.

"…Both," the Curator said. "I still don't know the answer."

Leaving that room, I thought again of the day I'd first felt sorry for this man. That day I couldn't explain why. I can now. I think I was

already sensing this man's sorrow, even then. It just took twenty-eight chapters to give it a name.

(Continued in Chapter 35.)

Chapter 35. The Water Reaches

> *_Previously_ — The Curator spoke his own sorrow for the first time. He*
> *said he kept doing his work knowing exactly what it was. "If I don't,*
> *someone else will. At least I can do it without hiding anything." I carried those words back to the pit with me.*

That afternoon, the sound from the pit changed.

I felt the difference from far off. It wasn't the sound of a shovel. It was some kind of splashing.

I hurried my steps. The weight that had sat on me ever since I'd left the Curator's room lifted, all at once, at that single sound. I had no time, then, to think about where that lightness had come from.

. . .

When I reached the pit, Speon was standing inside it. Water had risen to his ankles. He saw me and grinned.

"…It came."

I didn't understand that right away.

"…What did?"

"…The water."

I looked down into the pit. Water was rising from the bottom. Not clear — closer to muddy. But it was unmistakably water. It moved, it caught the light, it flowed.

I remember that moment exactly. I'd seen water many times since coming to this city. The distribution station's water, the water in my flask. All of it water that had been held somewhere. The water I saw that day was different. It was water rising up out of the ground. Not water someone had set there — water that simply came, from there.

. . .

"…How long has it been?" I asked.

"…About an hour."

"…Why didn't you call me?"

"…There wasn't time to," Speon said, laughing. "First it just got damp, and then all at once it surged up."

I crouched down there and looked at the water. I reached out to touch it and stopped.

"…Can I touch it?"

"…You should be the first."

I dipped my hand into the water. It was cold. Grains of soil slipped between my fingers. I let myself feel that touch for a long time.

Outside, I'd never once thought of this touch as anything special. Water had been everywhere. In every well, along every riverbank. It was

only here, in this city, that I felt as if I were relearning this sensation from the beginning. That it was cold. That it flowed. That it slipped between my fingers. Things that had once been simply given were, here, new and astonishing, one by one.

I felt something strange in that moment. This water came from the thirty-seventh well — thirty-second, out of the thirty-seven he'd dug. I could count that number. But the water itself couldn't be counted. It just flowed. It was the first thing to arrive in this city that couldn't be caught by a number.

. . .

Water kept rising the whole afternoon. Speon shaped the walls of the pit and steered where it would run. I scooped soil out beside him.

Toward evening, people began to gather, one by one.

The distribution station attendant came first. He looked into the pit and his eyes went wide.

"…It really came."

"…Yes," Speon said.

"…Amazing."

The attendant said only that and stood there a long while. He didn't drink it. He just watched.

Next came the older woman — the same one who'd once asked Speon what a well even was.

"…Well," she said. "It really was coming, after all."

"…Yes," Speon said. "I told you."

"…I believed it, but seeing it for myself is different."

She didn't drink either. She stood at the edge of the pit and simply looked down at the water for a long while.

. . .

The official in gray came too. The same one who had asked about the permit on the first day. He still had his collar's insignia on. He stood in front of the pit and looked at the water for a long time.

"…Congratulations," he said to Speon. It was a businesslike tone, though not as stiff as before.

"…Thank you," Speon said.

"…This will need to go into the record now. As a successful excavation case."

"…You're welcome to."

The official took out his notebook and wrote something down. Watching him, I remembered him writing "Not required" on the first day. I was curious what he was writing now, but I didn't ask.

"…Is this water fit to drink?" he asked.

"…It'll take a few days to clear," Speon said.

The official nodded and closed his notebook. Then, like everyone else, he left without drinking it.

The children came too. The same ones who'd once been caught reaching for a shovel. This time no one stopped them.

"…Can we drink this?" one child asked.

"…Still a little cloudy," Speon said. "Once it settles you can drink it."

The children looked disappointed at that, then quickly turned to watching the grains of soil swirl on the water's surface. Stirring it with a finger, watching it settle.

Watching those children, I saw for the first time, in this city, a face purely enjoying itself. Not enjoyment born of need — just enjoyment born of wonder. I was glad to see that face.

Eikon came too.

I recognized her coming from far off. Her walk was as unhurried as ever. She stood in front of the pit and looked down at the water for a long while. Her expression barely changed.

"…It really came," she said. The same words the attendant had used, but with a different temperature.

"…Yeah," I said.

"…It's interesting, I guess," she said. "But I don't understand why it's drawing this many people."

"…You don't find it interesting?"

"…I do. But interesting and liking are different things."

I laughed at that. It had the same grain as what she'd said before — that curious and lacking were different things.

"…Want to try some?" I asked.

Eikon shook her head.

"…I don't need it."

"…What about just drinking it out of curiosity?"

"…Curiosity is satisfied by looking," she said. "Drinking is a different matter."

That distinction was exactly like her. I didn't press her further. She stood a little longer, then left quietly, like the others. Once, on her way, she looked back. There was something in her eyes, but I couldn't read what it was, that day.

I would recall that look again, later. In Chapter 44, I learn its name.

. . .

By the time the sun had gone fully down, nearly ten people had gathered.

That was a large number by this city's standard. I was surprised, counting it. No one had called anyone, and yet this many had come.

I noticed the way they stood too. Not crowded close together. Spaced at a regular distance, each looking down into the pit on their own. No one pushing, no one trying to get ahead. That spacing was exactly this

city's people. Even in front of something astonishing, they didn't hurry.

They all wore a similar expression. A face that didn't need this, but had come to see it because it was interesting. I felt a strange comfort among those faces. This city's people weren't entirely numb. There had just been very little, for a very long time, to move them.

No one drank. I didn't find that strange. It was to be expected. This city's people weren't thirsty. The distribution station's water was enough. This new water wasn't need — it was something else.

It was only then I realized that none of these people knew what it felt like to be thirsty. The sensation of thirst itself had vanished from this city long ago. I thought that maybe they hadn't come here because they were thirsty, but because some faint memory in their bodies still recalled, dimly, what thirst had once been.

. . .

I thought a long time that night about what that something else was. I can say it a little now. It was proof. Proof that in a place everyone had called unnecessary, something could really come out of the ground. There was no need to drink it, but there was a reason to want to see it.

People began drifting off, one by one. At night everyone went in at their set time. That exactness felt, that day, a little regrettable to me.

The last one left was the distribution station attendant. He crouched at the pit's edge and looked at the water for a long time.

"…What happens to it now?" he asked.

"…Let it settle," Speon said, "and then we'll have to cut a channel for it."

"…To where?"

"…Haven't decided that yet."

The attendant nodded. Then he reached out his hand.

. . .

He held his hand out and paused for a moment. I didn't know what that pause meant. It looked like hesitation, or maybe just a moment spent making up his mind.

He dipped only the tips of his fingers into the water.

A very brief motion. Not meant to drink. Just a gesture to confirm, with his fingertips, that the water was really there.

A drop gathered at his fingertip and fell.

The ripple spread to the edge of the pit and faded. I followed that small ripple with my eyes for a long time. That was the only motion left on the water's surface.

He looked at his hand a moment. His wet fingers. Then, without a word, he drew his hand back.

I remember that gesture exactly, even now. He said nothing. He didn't drink. He just dipped his hand in and took it out again. I think that motion is the biggest thing that happened in this city that day. No one would call it that, but I do.

He hadn't dipped his hand in because he needed to. He was a man who received water from the distribution station. He lacked nothing. And yet he dipped his hand in. There was no reason for that gesture. Or rather — there was a reason, but it was the kind of reason "need" can't explain.

. . .

"…It's cold," he said. I couldn't tell whether he was speaking to Speon or to himself.

"…Yes," Speon said. "Water from underground is always cold."

The attendant stood up. He wiped his wet fingers on his clothes. Then he looked at me a moment.

"…Anemos, have you tried this water?"

"…Not yet. I only touched it."

"…Why not drink it? You're the one who wanted it."

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…It doesn't feel like the time to drink it, yet," I said.

The attendant tilted his head at that. His face said he didn't understand. But he didn't press further, said goodbye, and left.

. . .

After the sun had set fully, one more person came, last of all.

I recognized the silhouette from far off. The Curator. He had no folder with him. Empty-handed, unlike his usual self.

"…I heard the news," he said, standing in front of the pit.

"…Already?" I asked.

"…Word travels fast in this city. It just never swells."

He looked into the pit for a long time. The water dimly reflected light in the dark.

"…How do you feel?" I asked.

The Curator's face took on a moment of choosing his words.

"…It's strange," he said. "I've told people today, more than once, that this city has no need for water. It's the truth. But seeing this now, I feel something else."

"…What?"

"…I can't explain it," he said. "It's just — good."

That sentence felt heavier to me than anything I'd heard from anyone else all day. This was a man who knew the weight of every procedure he carried out. A man like that had just said, without explanation, that it was simply good.

He didn't dip his hand in. He just stood there a long while, looking down. Then he said goodbye and turned to walk away.

I watched his back for a long time. I thought of what he'd told me that afternoon. If I don't, someone else will. At least I can do it without hiding anything. That night I thought a long time about how those words

and this — standing here doing nothing but watching — could live inside one person. Some people were already wet, without ever dipping their hand in.

. . .

Only Speon and I remained. The water in the pit was still, little by little, rising.

"…Why didn't you drink it?" Speon asked.

"…I don't know," I said. "It just doesn't feel like it's time yet."

"…Not a bad answer."

I looked at the stars reflected in the water. Even in that still-cloudy water, a few stars shimmered on the surface.

That night, I kept coming back to the attendant's gesture. He hadn't drunk it. He'd just dipped his hand in. I think this whole book is inside that small motion. Even a person who says he needs nothing still reaches out his hand. Without explaining why. Of the nearly ten people who came to the water that day, in the end only that one had reached out. Counting that number, this time, I didn't find it lacking at all.

The sound of water ran all through the night. Small, steady. I walked back to the dormitory listening to it. For the first time in days, I walked without counting anything.

On the way I passed the Curator's building. One light was on. His room. I looked up at that light for a moment. It meant he was still working, at this hour. Even on the day the water had come, he had gone back to his own place.

Watching that light, I thought of my mother. I wanted to tell her about this. That the water had come, that people had dipped their hands in. But in that moment I knew — she would not come, hearing this news, to dip her hand in. She had no need. Something in me ached at that thought. The two people closest to me in this city were, that day, the two people with the same reason for not being there.

Back at the dormitory, I opened my flask. Half of the distribution station's water was still inside. I drank it. It tasted the same as always. And yet that day even that water's taste felt different. Water that had been held, and water that had come running up out of the ground — the same water, and yet they reached me with a different weight.

Last, that night, I had this thought. This water hadn't wet anyone's throat yet. And yet it had already done something to this city. Nearly ten people had gathered for no reason at all, and one person had dipped in a hand. These were things need couldn't explain. I liked those things that couldn't be explained.

(Continued in Chapter 36.)

Chapter 36. It Runs Down to the Valley

> *_Previously_ — Water came up in Speon's pit. People gathered. No one*
> *drank it. Only the distribution station attendant dipped in a fingertip. That night even the water in my own flask felt different.*

The water cleared in three days.

I stopped by the pit every day through those three days. The first day it was muddy. The second day it had settled a little. By the third day it was clear enough to see the bottom. That day, for the first time, Speon scooped up a mouthful and drank it.

"…How is it?" I asked.

"…Tastes like water," he said, laughing.

I tried a mouthful too. Cold, with a faint trace of earth still in it. Close to the well water I used to drink outside. That familiarity surprised me. Every drop of water I'd had since coming to this city had passed through the distribution station. Exact, regulation amounts. This water was just water. Untouched by anyone's hand.

I noticed his answer was exactly the same as Eikon's had been. Tastes like water. But this time it sounded different. Eikon had said it because there was nothing surprising in it. Speon said it though there was. The same words held something different inside.

. . .

On the fourth day, Speon set up a small stone marker at the edge of the pit.

"…What's that?" I asked.

"…I'm going to run the channel from here."

I watched him point his hand out. Not toward the city's inside. Toward the outside of the city — more exactly, downward.

"…Where's it going?" I asked.

"…The valley."

I stopped for a moment at that.

. . .

"…Shouldn't it go toward the city first?" I asked. "The people are here."

"…The city already has it," Speon said. "There's the distribution station. Regulation amounts, but it's there."

"…But the valley has none at all."

Speon planted his shovel in the soil and looked at me. Something a little mischievous showed in his eyes.

"…Well, there's your answer, then."

I liked that answer. But I still wanted to ask more.

"…Still, shouldn't the city come first, in order? It's closer."

Speon thought about that for a moment. Then he said this.

"…Up there isn't dry."

. . .

I didn't understand that right away.

"…What do you mean?"

"…No one in the city dies of thirst. There's the distribution station. It's not that the water's not enough — it's that they don't need water. That's different from being dry."

"…And the valley?"

"…The valley is really dry. Not because there's no water — because water's never once gone there."

I turned that distinction over for a long time. The city wasn't dry because it had no need. The valley was dry because water had never reached it. On the surface, both places had no water. But Speon saw the two as different.

I didn't fully understand that, that day. I know now. The city was a place that had forgotten thirst. The valley was a place that had never even had thirst to forget. Speon knew exactly which of the two was more urgent.

. . .

That afternoon, Eikon passed by and stopped walking.

"…Where's it going?" she asked, looking at the stone marker Speon had set.

"…The valley," I said.

Eikon's expression stiffened slightly.

"…Why there?"

"…Speon says up here isn't dry already."

Eikon turned that over a moment.

"…There's no one there. No one who needs water."

"…Seems that way."

"…Then why send it there?"

I looked at Speon at that question. He didn't stop shoveling, and answered in my place.

"…You don't only give water to people who need it," he said. "You can make a need, too."

Eikon's face showed she didn't understand.

"…What does that mean?"

"…I don't know either," Speon said, laughing. "It just feels that way."

Eikon didn't ask further at that answer. She looked once more at the pit and the channel, and walked off without a word. Watching her back, I

saw, for the first time, that she wasn't certain of something. Only for a moment.

I couldn't properly read that brief unsteadiness, then. I know now. In that moment, for the first time, she'd seen something her own logic couldn't explain — sending water to a place that had no need for it. In her world, there was no place for a thing like that.

. . .

I stood there and turned to look back at the city.

The distribution station, the square, the Curator's building. All quiet. That quiet looked different to me, this time. Before, that quiet had looked like peace. That day it looked like something being held back.

"…Won't the city's people feel hurt?" I asked. "That it's not coming to them, and going down instead."

"…I asked," Speon said.

I was surprised at that.

"…Asked who?"

"…The distribution station attendant, that official in gray, a few others."

"…What did they say?"

"…All of them said it didn't matter. That what they had was already enough."

That answer wasn't strange to me. This city's people always said that. That it didn't matter. That it was enough. And that wasn't a lie.

. . .

That evening, the Curator heard the news and came by as well.

"…I heard it's going to the valley," he said.

"…Yes."

He stood a long while in front of the marker. I tensed for a moment, thinking he might object. The valley wasn't a light place for him either.

"…Are you all right with this?" I asked.

"…Yes," he said. "If anything, I think this should have happened long ago."

"…Why?"

"…I've been going down there alone, all this time," he said. "Without water. Now I won't be alone anymore."

Something in me stirred at that. This man was receiving a single channel of water as company for his own sorrow.

"…You won't stop it?" I asked.

"…There's no reason to stop it," he said. "This is the first thing I've ever not wanted to stop."

He left with only those words. I looked at Speon. Speon said nothing and picked up his shovel again.

. . .

We began cutting the channel together.

Starting from the city's edge. We dug the soil shallow to make a ditch, and packed the edges with stone. The water began to flow slowly along it.

I found the work similar to, and yet different from, the digging I'd done going down into the valley. Back then it had been downward, narrow, cut deep. This time it was sideways, long, cut far. The blisters on my palms broke open again. I felt the callus already sitting there and picked up the shovel again.

"…Is it all right to dig this shallow?" I asked. I felt uneasy that we were taking the soil so thin.

"…Shallow is what keeps it from collapsing," Speon said. "Dig deep and it goes faster, but it collapses just as fast. The more you rush a channel, the less it lasts."

Hearing that, I remembered what the old well-digger had once told me. That you don't find water — you make it a way. I passed those words along to Speon.

"…That's exactly right," Speon said, laughing. "I wish I'd known that old man."

Standing there, I felt strangely steadied that two people who'd never once met were saying the same thing.

I watched the water flow. At first it was slow. The soil was drinking it in. But after a day or two, the soil grew wet and packed, and the water ran faster.

Digging that ditch, I thought of the twelve days I'd spent going down into the valley. Back then I'd dug down and down. Now the water was running along that same direction. I wanted to believe that wasn't a coincidence. I'm still not sure.

The channel reached the city's edge in three days. From there the ground grew steep. I gathered stones and built up embankments. It had become work my hands knew by now.

Over those three days I measured the channel's length in my own steps. The first day, two hundred and thirty steps; the second, four hundred more; and on the third, it reached the city's edge. Writing those numbers down again, I remembered the steps I'd counted going down into the valley. Back then I'd counted my own steps going down. This time I counted the water's steps, not my own. The direction was the same.

Digging this channel, I found myself remembering something Speon had told me once before. That in some city he'd seen a bridge only half finished, and that he'd had three friends, and one of them had helped finish that bridge. I hadn't asked, then, where that bridge led. Watching this channel now, I thought this channel and that bridge might be the same kind of thing. Not something for one city alone, but something that joins city to city. I'm not certain. I only set the thought down here.

. . .

At the city's edge, in front of the slope that led down into the valley, Speon stopped walking.

"…From here on," he said, "we have to go slow."

"…Why?"

"…The slope's steep. Rush it and the channel collapses. You have to cut it a little at a time, to make it last."

I listened to that and packed the soil down evenly. Speon set stones as supports. We worked on that the whole day.

The first tier we cut collapsed. The water surged in all at once and overran the earthen bank. Speon didn't get angry seeing that. He simply rebuilt the bank. This time he cut the tier lower and narrower. It took time for the water to fill that tier before crossing to the next. Rush it and it collapsed; wait and it crossed over. I learned that rhythm with my hands, and with my whole body.

Every time the water crossed to the next tier, a short, broken sound came. A brief trickling, then a stop, then trickling again. Every time I heard that sound, I could count one more tier finished. By evening I had heard that sound eleven times.

By evening, the water had reached the first tier of the slope. I stood there and looked down.

The valley was down there. Still wide, still dry. I thought that somewhere in that landscape, he must be there. Walking among the bones, even now.

. . .

"…How long will it take?" I asked. "To reach all the way down there."

"…Don't know," Speon said. "Won't know till we get there."

That answer was familiar to me. Speon always said that. And it was always right.

"…But it will reach, won't it?"

Speon looked at me.

"…It'll reach," he said. Not a voice full of certainty. Just a voice stating a fact.

"…How do you know?"

"…Water goes down. As long as nothing blocks it."

That sentence was simple, and yet it felt heavy to me. As long as nothing blocks it. This city hadn't been blocking the water, all this time. It had just never made a way for it to go. Speon had made that way. Now the water was only going where it had always meant to go.

. . .

Standing there, I thought of something I'd heard from Book Two. Something Speon had once said, they told me. Water rots when it sits still. It lives when it flows. I'd taken that, at the time, as only talk about a well. That day, standing in front of the slope, I understood that it had been a much larger story than that.

I listened to the water running down. Still a small sound. The sound of it crossing from the slope's first tier to the next. A trickling sound, but one that didn't stop.

"…When this water reaches down there," I asked, "what changes?"

Speon slung the shovel over his shoulder.

"…Don't know," he said again. "Won't know till it reaches."

I laughed at that answer. It was an answer no one in this city ever gave. This city knew every outcome in advance. Speon never knew, right to the end. And he was never ashamed of not knowing.

. . .

The sun went fully down. We sat side by side there and listened to the water.

"…Cutting more tomorrow?" I asked.

"…Yeah. One tier at a time."

"…I'll help."

"…I know," Speon said. "You don't have to ask."

I laughed at that. I knew things like that about him now too.

I couldn't fall asleep for a long time that night. I imagined the day the channel would reach the valley. Whether he would see that water. Whether the bones would really live again, once it reached them. I still had no answer to that question. But this time, not having one didn't weigh on me.

I went back over everything that had happened these past three days, in order. Meeting him in the valley. The question I couldn't answer. Coming back to the city and finding the view looked different. Eikon's

logic, that sentence I couldn't argue against. The Curator's sorrow, the wet eyes he'd shown me for the first time. And the water. That night no one drank it, and one person dipped in a hand.

Laying those four things side by side, I felt for the first time that everyone I'd met in this city was, in the end, standing in front of the same thing. He had said it was all right not to know the answer. Eikon had said she needed no answer because she lacked nothing. The Curator had grieved even while he knew the answer. I belonged fully to none of those three, and stood somewhere between all of them.

The sound of water came through the window all through the night. I listened to it and turned that sentence over again. Up there isn't dry already. I turned it over a long while, and fell asleep with it.

I still don't know the day this water will reach the valley. But writing this record now, I know this much: that water does, in the end, reach it. And when it reaches, I come to stand again in front of the question I put off longest in this whole book. That is not Part Three's story. It is Part Four's.

Before I closed my eyes, I looked at my hands, last of all. Blisters and calluses mixed together on them. Tomorrow I would dig soil with these hands again. And the day after that too. These hands would carry this water all the way to the valley. I decided to believe that.

(Continued in Part Four.)

The Dry Valley, Part Four

Breath

Chapter 37. Asked Again

> *_Previously_ — Speon had run the channel toward the valley. When I asked*
> *why down instead of up, he said, "Up there isn't dry." I turned that over the whole way back into the city.*

In the morning I helped Speon work on the ditch.

The channel now ran all the way to the edge of the city. From there the ground turned steep, and the water kept slipping sideways. I gathered stones and built up the banks. My hands knew the work.

"…Going again today." Speon asked it. He wasn't a man who asked me things much, so the question stood out.

"…Yes."

"…What for."

I couldn't answer him right away. Speon didn't wait for an answer. He picked the shovel back up and dug.

"…Take some water with you." he said. "Don't go empty-handed."

I didn't ask what he meant by that. I filled the flask.

. . .

Walking toward the inner part of the Preserve, I heard the sound of water.

The first time I'd come into this city, what had struck me strangest was the absence of sound. There had been no sound of water. Now there was. Along every alley, faint under everything else, ran the sound of the channel.

A few of the city people passed by, hearing it. No one stopped. They didn't need to. But I saw one of them slow down. Just for a moment. Then that person went back to their ordinary pace.

I didn't take much notice of that brief slowing, at the time. Looking back now, that was the first tremor I ever saw in this city. A very small one. One step's worth of a tremor.

. . .

I carried the visitation form with me, and at the counter I folded it back up.

I didn't know, right there, why I folded it. The form always had the same box on it. Purpose of visit. I stood there a long time holding the pen, not knowing what to write. Persuasion. I couldn't write that. It was too honest to count as a purpose.

The clerk looked at me.

"…The purpose box is empty."

"…Just a visit."

"…That's what everyone puts." The clerk smiled. "There are sub-items listed over there."

I looked at the sub-items. Well-being, counsel, notification, other. I marked other.

It took me that long to fill in one small box. Looking back now it seems absurd. But at the time I truly didn't know. What I was going there to do, that day.

. . .

There was no one else in the waiting room besides me.

I was the only one in this city who ever applied for a visit. It had been that way the first time I came, and it was that way on this, my thirty-second time. City people had no need of visits. If you wanted to see a preserved family member, you simply walked over. You didn't get startled, and you didn't miss them.

I started counting the empty chairs, then stopped. There were always twelve. No need to count them.

Instead I called up my past visits. The nineteenth, the day I'd tried to ask why and couldn't. The twentieth, the day I'd learned that I missed you wasn't an answer. The twenty-first, the day I'd cancelled the application myself, in front of my brother.

Writing those numbers down here again, I realize all over how faithfully I'd been counting those visits, all that time. Counting was how I endured things. But that day, even sitting in the waiting room, I didn't count. I just sat.

The clerk called my name. I stood up.

. . .

My mother welcomed me as she always did.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…You've come again."

You've come again. I could count that phrase by now. I didn't count which visit this made. I'd started to, and stopped. At some point I'd understood that the number told me nothing. To my mother, the first visit and the tenth were exactly the same.

I sat down across from her. I had no words prepared. For the first time. For seven years I had always come with something ready.

I counted back through what that preparation had been. At the nineteenth visit I'd come prepared to ask why. At the twentieth I'd come to confirm that I missed you wasn't an answer. I always came to confirm something. Today there was nothing to confirm.

"…I don't have anything to say today." I said.

My mother looked at me. Her expression didn't change much. This person's expression never changes much. I know that now.

"…Then why did you come."

I hadn't prepared an answer to that question.

"…No reason."

. . .

I just talked about the valley.

Not words I'd prepared. I just told her what I'd seen that day. How Speon had run the water channel downward, how when I'd asked why down and not up, he'd answered, "Up there isn't dry."

"…A water channel?" my mother asked.

"…Yes. From the well."

"…There's a well in this city?"

I caught the way she said it. Not the same polite form she used when she spoke about herself. She'd said in this city. As if this city weren't the place she lived.

That was the first time I noticed that my mother never spoke of this city as her own. In this city. Over there. My mother always spoke of this city as though standing one step outside it. I didn't know, that day, what that meant.

"…Yes. Newly dug. Someone named Speon."

"…Speon." My mother repeated the name. "That's an unfamiliar name."

"…He's an unfamiliar person. Nobody asked him to come, but he came."

My mother smiled, a little, for the first time. Very small.

"…It takes someone like that, for a well to come to be."

. . .

I told her about the valley too.

I told her about going down, about seeing traces there dry as bone, about meeting a man. I didn't say what he'd asked me. That wasn't something to tell my mother, not yet.

"…Why did you go there." my mother asked.

"…Speon told me to go see it."

That wasn't a lie. But it wasn't the whole of it either.

"…Were you afraid?"

I stopped for a moment at that question. It had been a long time since my mother had asked me what I was afraid of. No — it was the first time. In seven years of visits.

I didn't count it, right then. It didn't even occur to me to count it. I counted it later. Seven years, thirty-two visits, and this question, once. I still remember that ratio exactly.

"…No." I said. "It was strange."

"…How."

"…The water hadn't reached there. The channel hasn't gotten that far yet. But even so, something there felt alive."

My mother didn't answer that. She just looked at me for a long time.

"…What kind of person was he, the one you met there." she asked, after a while.

"…Someone whose age I couldn't guess. He was just walking among the bones."

"…What did he say."

I stopped there for a moment. The question he had asked me — whether I thought these could live again — was something I hadn't yet passed on to anyone.

"…He didn't say much." I said. "We just walked together a little."

That was a lie. A very small one. My mother didn't press.

. . .

I took out the water flask.

The one given to me when I left my father's relatives' house, the one I'd carried for seven years. It was half full inside.

"…This." I said. "It's not this city's water. It's water flowing down to the valley. I got a little from Speon."

My mother looked at it. She didn't hold out her hand.

"…May I drink it?"

That question startled me. My mother had never needed anything, all this time. Not water, not food, not sleep. And now she was looking at the flask and asking a question like that.

At the time I thought it was just a politeness. Now I know. It wasn't politeness. It was the first time she'd been curious about something.

I didn't catch the difference, that day. In the next chapter, I come back to what I did that day, not even knowing why myself.

"…No." I said. "Not yet."

My mother nodded. She didn't seem hurt. She simply accepted it, as it was.

"…I see."

. . .

I brought up my brother too, briefly.

"…My brother's doing well." I said. "He couldn't come today. He came first, earlier."

"…Does he still do that." my mother asked. "Ask if his brother's come."

"…Yes. Every time."

My mother laughed at that. Just for a moment.

"…He's been that way since he was small. He always asked, when you weren't there."

Listening to that, I remembered again the path where my brother used to follow me, the spot in front of the third stone wall where he always stopped. I didn't tell my mother that. Not yet.

. . .

Near the end of visiting hours, my mother asked,

"…Weren't you here to persuade me?"

I stopped at that.

"…No."

"…Then what did you come for."

I couldn't answer that question. To be precise, it wasn't that I had no words for an answer — I didn't know myself what the answer was. That night I would go looking for it for the first time. It's one of the most important nights in this book.

"…I don't know." I said honestly. "I just wanted to talk."

My mother looked at me. Something in her eyes was a little different from usual. I couldn't put my finger on what, at the time.

"…All right." my mother said. "I was glad you talked to me."

. . .

I gathered the flask back up.

Standing, I turned back for a moment. My mother was still sitting there. In the same posture as seven years ago.

"…I'll come again." I said.

"…All right."

It was the same farewell as always. But that day something was different. I thought about what it was, walking out the door. No answer came.

I only understood it later. That I'd written other in the purpose box on the form, that I'd gone without any words prepared, that I'd just talked about the valley — those had all been the same thing. That was the first day I hadn't gone there to persuade her. What I had gone there to do, I would only find out that night.

. . .

I ran into the Curator in the hallway.

"…You kept it short today." he said. He always recorded the length of visits.

"…Yes."

"…Are you all right?"

I raised the flask instead of answering.

"…Will there be a day I can give this to my mother?"

The Curator looked at the flask for a moment. Something crossed his eyes. I couldn't read what it was, at the time.

"…After release." he said. "Not before then. The body doesn't need it."

"…I know."

"…But you didn't bring that up today."

I stopped at that. I didn't ask how he knew. This man couldn't hear everything that happened inside the visiting room, but he always read the face of the person who came out.

"…No." I said. "I didn't, today."

The Curator nodded. He didn't ask further. He just walked past me.

A few steps on, he turned back.

"…Your mother's expression was a little different today." he said. "I've been recording this for years now, and I've never seen this before."

"…Different how?"

"…It's hard to explain." the Curator said. "Just — different."

He left it at that and walked on.

I watched his back for a moment. This man always knows something and doesn't ask. I used to think that was consideration. Now I know. It was that, and it also meant this man already knew the answer to that question himself.

. . .

I walked to the edge of the city. I could hear the channel running. Along the ditch Speon had dug, water was flowing down, toward the valley.

I sat there for a long while.

Eikon passed by, saw me, and came over.

"…Coming back from a visit?" she asked.

"…Yeah."

"…Did you try to persuade her again today?"

I couldn't answer that right away. Eikon knew exactly what I went to my mother to do. She didn't mock it. She was just curious.

"…No." I said. "Not today."

"…Why not?"

"…I don't know."

Eikon looked at me for a moment. There was no judgment in her eyes. She doesn't judge people. She lacks nothing, so she has no interest in measuring others either.

"…That's strange." she said. "After preparing so long."

"…Yeah."

She didn't ask further and went her own way. I watched her go, and ran back through everything that had happened that day, in order. The folded form, the empty preparation, my mother's then why did you come, my I don't know.

That night I realized something strange. In that whole visit, not once had I said let's go together now. Five words I'd been preparing for seven years. I hadn't forgotten them. I'd just felt, that day, that the words weren't needed.

Why I felt they weren't needed, I still didn't know. I would find out the next day.

The sound of water kept going. Listening to it, for the first time in a long while, I counted nothing at all.

That night I slept with my head on the flask. It was half full again inside. The water Speon had told me to take. I didn't know, even then, exactly why I'd brought it. It was water I couldn't even give my mother. And yet I hadn't emptied it out. I'd filled it back up.

Before I fell asleep that night I asked myself one thing, once. Had I really gone today wanting nothing at all. I wanted to answer yes to that. But the answer wouldn't come.

(Continued in Chapter 38.)

Chapter 38. Why I Came

> *_Previously_ — I went to my mother without trying to persuade her, and*
> *only talked about the valley and the water. Her expression was different from usual. That night I asked myself whether I'd really gone wanting nothing at all. The answer wouldn't come.*

I couldn't sleep that night.

I lay with my head on the flask, but my eyes kept opening. I looked at the ceiling. This room was one the Preserve set aside for people like me. No furniture in it. No one who needed any.

In that room, that one night, I thought more than I had in the sum of all my seven years' nights. I still think so now. Some nights are longer than others.

I closed my eyes and counted back from the beginning again. From the day I left the settlement, from the day I reached the city after four days' walk, up through the thirty-second visit.

Somewhere among those numbers there seemed to be one I'd missed. I didn't know which. It just felt like it was there.

I was a person who counted things. But that night, no matter how much I counted, no answer came. I learned then, for the first time, that there were things counting alone could not reach.

. . .

Toward dawn I fell asleep briefly and dreamed.

In the dream I was nine years old. Sitting behind the hill. But this time I wasn't alone. My brother was sitting beside me. Still eight years old.

"…Brother." my dream-brother said. "Why are you sitting alone."

I couldn't answer. I opened my eyes.

I still remember that dream exactly. The moment I woke from it, I knew. The nine-year-old me who had sat behind that hill hadn't been there because he wanted to be alone. He had been there because he was learning, for the first time that day, how to be alone.

. . .

In the morning I went to Speon.

He was already at the ditch. He saw me and handed me a second shovel.

"…Looks like you didn't sleep well." he said.

"…How could you tell."

"…I can tell by the face. Same when you're digging."

I took the shovel and dug at the earth. I'd thought using my body might help. It didn't.

"…Speon." I said. "That old man, before — he said water isn't something you find."

"…He said you make it a way."

"…What did that mean, exactly."

Speon stopped digging and looked at me. It was a look I hadn't seen before.

"…Why are you suddenly asking that."

"…I don't know. No reason."

. . .

He went back to digging. The answer didn't come right away.

"…Water is everywhere." he said, after a long while. "Under the ground. You think it isn't there because you can't see it, but it's all there, really. Digging a well doesn't mean finding it. It means making a place for water that's already there to come out."

I turned that over.

"…Then what about me." I said. "Did I come here to find something, or to make a place for it?"

Speon looked at me again. Longer, this time.

"…That's not a question I can answer." he said. "You have to dig it up yourself to know."

. . .

Hearing that, I set the shovel down. I stood there a long while, just like that.

For seven years I'd thought I had come to find something. My mother. My brother. To find what I'd lost.

But my mother had never been lost. She'd been in the city the whole time. I could see her whenever I wanted. I'd kept looking for someone who didn't need to be found.

So what had I been looking for?

I followed that question through to the end, for the first time.

. . .

The seventeen funerals came back to me again.

I'd written down many times that the old man's had been the ninth. He was the one who'd taught me to dig wells. A man of few words. For a while after he stopped, I kept digging that field alone.

At the other eight funerals there had been other people. Relatives, neighbors, a child I'd played with. Each time I'd watched the people crying beside me. I'd cried too. But every time, once the crying ended, I walked home alone.

I counted that fact for the first time that night. Seventeen funerals, and after them, seventeen roads walked alone. Every time I lost someone, I left that place alone, every time.

. . .

I thought back to that day when I was nine again.

The day I sat alone behind the hill. The day I stayed until the sun went down. The day I came back to find everyone already gone.

From that day on I was always alone. I grew up in my relatives' house, watched seventeen funerals, and in not one of them did anyone who cried beside me stay for long.

I'd written many times that counting was how I'd endured those seven years. That's true. But it wasn't the whole of it. Even while I counted, I was alone the whole time. Counting is something you do alone.

I remembered the years my brother used to follow me. When I went for water, when I went for firewood. The years he followed so closely it annoyed me. I hadn't known, then, that I wasn't alone in those years.

. . .

I remembered too, what my brother had said, looking up at me.

Brother, you got tall.

I had turned sixteen and my brother was still eight. I hadn't properly felt, at the time, how large that one sentence was. It meant seven years of growing up alone.

I had been alone the whole time I was growing. While I got taller, while I got stronger, while I learned how to go to a funeral. No one beside me.

I hadn't wanted to undo those seven years. To be precise, the fact that my mother and my brother were still exactly as they'd been seven years

ago was the force that had dragged me all the way here. If they hadn't changed, it seemed like I might be able to go back to before, too.

. . .

I pushed that thought all the way through. For the first time, I didn't run from it.

When I came to the city, I believed I had come to wake my family. That much wasn't wrong. But hidden inside that sentence was another sentence. I had come to go back to the time when I wasn't alone.

Waking someone and going back are different things. I saw that difference for the first time there at the edge of the field, shovel still in hand.

It was a shameful thing. That's how it felt. Inside the work I'd believed was for my family's sake, I was there too. My own share of it.

. . .

Eikon came to mind, all at once.

I don't lack anything. Why would I need more? She'd said that. I hadn't been able to answer it. I couldn't refute it.

There at the edge of the field, I admitted for the first time that there was a lack in me too. I lacked something. I lacked someone beside me. Eikon didn't have that lack. So she had nothing left to want. I did. That was why I'd come all this way.

I looked straight at that difference for the first time. Eikon's logic was hard to refute. You can't tell someone with nothing lacking to want more. But I lacked something. My lack had carried me this far. Without it, I would never have come to this city at all.

In that moment I felt, for the first time, one of this book's questions become my own. Is what is preserved different from what is alive. I didn't know the answer. I only knew, that day, that I lacked because I was alive, and that I had come because I lacked.

. . .

Speon came over again. He must have noticed I hadn't been holding the shovel long.

"…Dig anything up." he asked.

The question made me laugh. A strange laugh.

"…Yeah." I said. "I thought I came here for my mother."

"…Weren't you?"

"…I was. No — that part's true too, but it wasn't the whole of it. I came to go back to the time when I wasn't alone."

Speon wasn't surprised at that.

"…What's wrong with that." he said.

"…It's wrong. Because I said it was for my mother, when really it was for me."

. . .

"…It can be both." Speon said. "When I run a channel, I do it for whoever's thirsty. But it's also true I do it because I like the sound of water. Both are true. Does that make it a flaw?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…Your share being mixed in doesn't make the love for your mother fake." he said. "But now that you know it, now that you know, you can't go on pretending you don't."

I remember that as the most exact thing he ever said. When I didn't know my own share was mixed into my love, I was a person who persuaded. Once I knew, I couldn't be that anymore.

"…Then what am I supposed to do now." I asked.

Speon shrugged.

"…I don't know either. I'm a well-digger. Not a heart-digger."

"…You just dug one pretty well, though."

"…That was luck." he laughed. A laugh I hadn't seen before. "There's only one thing I can tell you. Once you've made the way, you have to wait and see whether the water comes. Digging doesn't make it come right away."

I held onto that for a long time.

I learned that day, for the first time, that waiting and doing nothing are different things. I'd thought of waiting as doing nothing, all this time. It wasn't.

. . .

At midday I ran into the Curator. He was carrying papers, headed somewhere.

"…Your expression is different from yesterday." he said.

"…How's it different."

"…Yesterday it was a face asking something. Today it's a face that's learned something."

I was struck by that observation. This man had truly spent a long time reading faces.

"…I learned something." I said. "Why I came here."

"…What is it."

I hesitated for a moment, then said,

"…Turns out I came for myself. I'd thought it was for my mother."

The Curator stopped walking. He looked at me for a long while.

"…It takes many people a long time to learn that." he said. "I learned it too, doing this work. Even I'm not certain whether I became a Curator purely for other people's sake."

I couldn't answer that at all. He left it there and walked on.

That was the first time I felt I understood a little of where this man's sorrow came from. Every day he read, in people's faces, the same

thing I had seen in myself that day. A love with his own share mixed into it. And even reading it, he kept doing the work.

. . .

I picked the shovel back up.

Moving my body helped a little. The earth grew familiar to my hands again. The channel stretched a little farther downward.

From that day on, I never went to my mother again as a person trying to persuade her. To be precise, I couldn't. Persuading is pretending to act for someone else's sake while really driving them toward the outcome you want. I now knew what I wanted. So I could no longer call it something done for my mother's sake.

From that day I tried to become someone who went with her, not someone who persuaded her. I would test the difference between those two, for the first time, at my next visit.

. . .

That evening I met Eikon. She was sitting by the channel.

"…What did you dig up today?" she asked. She remembered what I'd said the day before.

"…Myself." I said.

"…You dug up yourself?"

"…Yeah. Something a little shameful came out."

Eikon looked at me steadily.

"…What was shameful?"

I laughed for the first time at that.

"…I'll tell you later."

"…Is it a secret?"

"…No." I said. "I just haven't put it into words yet."

Eikon didn't find that answer strange. She didn't much understand why a person would hide something. She had nothing to hide, herself.

"…Me." she said. "There isn't much I'm curious about. But I'm a little curious what you dug up."

"…Why?"

"…I don't know." she said. "No reason."

I let that no reason pass without thinking much of it. Eikon said that often. Being curious without giving a reason. I only thought it was a turn of phrase she had.

Eikon stood up. She was about to go on her way, then turned back suddenly.

"…Anemos." she said.

"…Yeah."

"…Wanting to take your mother with you — is that a bad thing?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't really know." she went on. "I was just curious what it's like, wanting something. Looking at you, you always seem like someone who wants something."

"…It's not bad." I said. "But there's some of me mixed into it. I learned that today."

"…So will you stop?"

"…No." I said. "That's not a reason to stop."

Eikon listened to that quietly. She didn't ask further and walked away.

. . .

I was left alone by the channel.

The sun had fully set. Only the sound of water remained. Listening to it, I went back through, in order, everything I'd learned that day. Speon's words, the seventeen roads walked alone, the hill when I was nine, Eikon's logic and my own lack.

It's still strange to me that I learned all of that in a single day. Maybe I had already known it, long before. It's only that the courage to look at it came to me, that day, for the first time.

I opened the flask and drank a little water. It was still water I couldn't give my mother. But that day the fact didn't weigh on me the way it had before. For the first time, I simply let myself believe that someday I would be able to give it to her.

That night, listening to the sound of the channel, I fell asleep for the first time with my own share acknowledged. The shame was still

there. But the shame didn't stop me. The next day, I applied for another visit. And I already knew what I would write in the purpose box on the form.

(Continued in Chapter 39.)

Chapter 39. My Mother's Question

> *_Previously_ — I came to understand, myself, why I had come to this*
> *city. Not only for my family, but to go back to the time when I wasn't alone. With that share acknowledged, I applied for another visit the next day.*

In the morning my brother came looking for me.

Lately he often came and waited in front of the room where I was staying. Not a visit — just there in the yard. He never came inside the room itself. I didn't ask why.

"…Brother, are you going again today?" my brother asked.

"…Yeah."

"…Should I go too?"

"…No." I said. "I'll go alone today."

My brother nodded at that. No sign of hurt. Eight years old doesn't hold onto hurt for long.

"…Tell Mom I said hi." my brother said.

Hearing that, I smiled a little. Well-being. I heard the word I would write on the form that day from my brother, before I thought of it myself.

. . .

I wrote well-being in the purpose box on the form.

Before, it had taken me forever to fill in that box. This time I didn't hesitate. Well-being. That was the exact word. I wasn't going there today to get anything.

The clerk took the form and looked at me.

"…You filled that in quickly today."

"…Yes."

I didn't explain further. The clerk didn't ask further either.

. . .

Sitting in the waiting room, I went back over what had happened the day before.

Speon's words, the seventeen funerals, the hill when I was nine. I knew all of it now. But I had no intention of laying it all out for my mother today.

I couldn't have put that resolve into exact words, at the time. I can say it now. That day, instead of going to say something, I wanted to go to listen to something.

The clerk called my name.

. . .

My mother welcomed me as she always did.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

"…You've come again."

I knew a different answer to that greeting now. But I held that answer back too. I just sat down.

My mother studied me for a moment.

"…Your expression is different again, today."

"…Different from yesterday too?"

"…Yes. Yesterday it was a face that had learned something. Today it's just a face that's here."

Hearing that, I felt all over again how long this person had been watching me. Someone who notices that my face is different every time. I'd taken that for granted, all this time. It wasn't a thing to take for granted.

. . .

I didn't talk about the valley, or about the water.

Instead I asked,

"…What did you do today?"

My mother paused at the question. Her face looked as though she'd been asked something strange.

"…The same as always." she said. "Getting up, sitting, waiting for you."

"…Is waiting something you do?"

"…Well." My mother smiled. "I'm not sure about that."

I liked that answer. If it had come before, I would have found it sad. Today I just liked it. It had been a long time since my mother had said I'm not sure that lightly.

. . .

I passed on my brother's message.

"…My brother said to tell you hello."

"…So he knows how to use words like that." my mother smiled. "Who taught him?"

"…Me, probably."

"…That's not a phrase you used to use either."

I couldn't answer that. It was true. I had almost never used the word well-being, all this time. I'd never had anyone whose well-being I needed to ask after.

. . .

We sat for a while without saying much.

The room was always the same. The walls, the chair, the position of the window. My mother had sat in that same spot in that room for seven years now. With a face that was neither in pain nor bored. I wasn't unfamiliar with that face anymore.

The silence wasn't uncomfortable. That struck me as strange. For seven years, in this room, silence had always been a blank I had to fill. Today it wasn't.

I still remember that silence exactly. Inside it, for the first time, I was at ease with nothing prepared. That I could be here even with no words ready, I learned that day, for the first time.

Through the window came the faint sound of water. The ditch Speon had dug had reached this far by now. My mother listened to it for a moment.

"…That sound, it's often here lately." she said.

"…Yes. It keeps spreading."

"…There was a sound like that when I was young, too." my mother said. "The well-bucket sound. Do you remember?"

I stopped at that. It had been a long time since my mother had brought up her own childhood too.

"…I remember." I said. "My brother was scared of that sound."

"…That's right. And you used to let the rope down slowly on purpose."

"…That was a mean thing to do."

My mother laughed at that.

"…But he liked it later, didn't he."

"…Because when that sound came, it meant I was there."

Saying that, I surprised myself a little. I'd thought I had realized that a long time ago, alone. And now here I was, saying it to my mother.

. . .

My mother looked at me again. That look in her eyes must have been the difference the Curator had mentioned yesterday. I still couldn't have named it, at the time.

"…Anemos."

"…Yes."

My mother was quiet for a moment. Her face was one of choosing something. That was a face I'd never seen before, too. This person always answered right away. She never chose her words.

I can still count that brief silence, even now. It wasn't long. A few breaths' worth. But seven years fit inside those few breaths.

. . .

"…How have you been?"

I couldn't say anything at all, hearing that.

My mother was looking at me. Not a face asking a question back at me. A face wanting to know.

In seven years I had come to this room more than thirty-two times. In all those thirty-two visits, my mother had never once asked me that. If I asked why, she asked why back. If I said I missed you, she said me too. She always handed back whatever I'd said, unchanged. But not today. Today she asked, herself.

. . .

"…I've been fine." I managed to say.

My voice came out strangely. I didn't know why, at the time.

"…Liar." my mother said. Not an angry tone.

"…What?"

"…I can tell from your face. That's not the face of someone who's been fine."

I didn't know how to answer that. My mother didn't press for an answer. She just waited.

. . .

"…It's been hard." I finally said. "A lot."

"…How."

Faced with that question, for the first time, I wanted to say it as it was, not summarize seven years.

"…I was alone." I said. "That was the hardest part. Watching people die was hard too, but harder than that was always having to walk home alone afterward."

My mother listened to that quietly. She said nothing. But this time the silence wasn't a blank to be filled. It was just a listening silence.

"…I learned to dig wells too." I went on. "At fourteen. From a quiet old man. He stopped too. I started counting from his funeral, the ninth. It's seventeen, up to now."

"…Seventeen." My mother repeated the number. "You've been counting all of that?"

"…Yes. Counting became a habit."

"…So that's how you endured the hard parts." my mother said. "By counting."

I couldn't answer that at all. It was the first time my mother had seen my counting habit as a way of enduring. I had never called it that myself, even to myself.

. . .

"…I'm sorry." my mother said, after a long while.

That surprised me.

"…For what."

"…For leaving you alone."

"…It's not your fault. You weren't sick."

"…Even so." my mother said. "Sorry is sorry."

I held onto that sentence for a long time. I had never once seen this person apologize, all this time. The preserved don't feel regret. They have no lack to regret. But my mother apologized, that day.

I didn't know how to answer that, so I just fiddled with the flask.

"…What about your brother." my mother asked. "Was it hard for him too?"

"…He was younger than me, so he probably didn't understand much."

"…No." my mother said. "Even an eight-year-old understands. He's just pretending not to."

Hearing that, I remembered my brother waiting for me in the yard. Tell her I said hi. I felt, for the first time, that I understood a little of what had been inside those words.

. . .

Near the end of visiting hours, my mother asked again,

"…So, how are you, now?"

"…Now?"

"…Yes. Today. This moment."

I thought about that for a moment.

"…I'm all right." I said. "Because I'm here."

Saying that, I felt, this time, that it was really true. It wasn't words I'd prepared, and it wasn't said to reassure my mother. It was just exactly what I felt in that moment.

My mother smiled at that. Not a large smile. But I could tell that smile was different from before. Before, the smile had simply been there. This time it had come from something.

. . .

Standing to leave, I gathered the flask back up.

"…I'll come again."

"…All right." my mother said. Then she added, "Tell me more about yourself, next time."

I stopped at that.

Tell me more about yourself, next time. I repeated that sentence to myself again and again, walking out the door. This person had never asked anything of me in seven years. She'd had no reason to ask. But today, for the first time, she asked.

At the door I turned back to look at my mother once more. She had already turned her eyes to the window. Toward where the sound of water was coming from.

I remember that back for a long time. The face looking out the window. I had never once, all this time, seen my mother look out a window that long. She'd had no reason to look. But that day she was looking at something.

. . .

I ran into the Curator in the hallway. This time he didn't ask first. He just saw me and nodded.

"…My mother asked me something today." I said first.

The Curator stopped walking.

"…What."

"…How I'd been."

He said nothing at all for a long while, hearing that. I saw something surging, large, inside that silence.

"…I've never seen a record like that." he finally said. "I've done this work a long time. This is the first time I've ever heard of one of the preserved asking something, first."

"…What does this mean?" I asked again.

The Curator closed his eyes for a moment, then opened them. A face choosing an answer.

"…I don't know exactly, myself." he said. "But if there's one thing I've learned doing this work, it's that asking something means not knowing something, and not knowing is something that doesn't happen to the people here. That's the whole of what I know."

He left it at that and adjusted his grip on the papers. I felt that he wanted to say more. He didn't.

. . .

I walked to the edge of the city, carrying those words with me.

The sound of the channel was running. I sat there, and went back over my mother's question again. How have you been.

My brother was waiting for me. Crouched at the edge of the yard, watching the channel.

"…Did you tell her?" my brother asked.

"…Yeah."

"…What did Mom say?"

I thought for a moment about how to answer.

"…She asked." I said. "How I'd been."

My brother tilted his head at that.

"…Doesn't she usually not ask that?"

"…Right. She usually doesn't."

My brother's face didn't understand why that was special. I started to explain, then gave it up. It wasn't something I could explain to an eight-year-old.

"…Should I ask you too?" my brother said. "You."

That made me laugh.

"…Sure. Go ahead."

"…How was your day, brother?"

"…It was good." I said. Not a lie.

My brother nodded, satisfied with that answer, and went back to watching the channel. I sat beside him for a while.

. . .

That evening I told Speon about it.

He stopped mid-motion, putting the shovels away.

"…She asked, you said." he asked, as if to confirm.

"…Yes. For the first time."

Speon said nothing for a long while. Then, looking toward the ditch, he said,

"…It's like this too, when water first starts moving underground. No sound at all. Just a very small change of direction."

I started to ask exactly what he meant, then didn't. I felt I already knew, without asking.

"…So what comes next." I asked.

"…I don't know that either." Speon said. "A change of direction doesn't necessarily mean it makes it all the way here. But if the direction doesn't change, it never comes at all."

He shouldered the shovel again.

"…Let's stop here for today." he said. "You should rest too."

. . .

I write down that question the most carefully of anything in this record. I didn't fully understand, that day, what it meant. I only knew: to be curious about something means something is lacking. And my mother, for the first time in seven years, had come to know that there was something about me she didn't know.

That night I tried not to think about it any further than that. If I let it weigh too heavily, it felt like it might break. I decided just to hold the question, quietly.

(Continued in Chapter 40.)

Chapter 40. Consent

> *_Previously_ — My mother asked me, for the first time, "How have you*
> *been?" For the first time in seven years she was curious about something. I decided to hold that question, quietly.*

I only held onto that question for three days.

I didn't apply for a visit. My resolve not to persuade her held me back this time in a different direction. I didn't want to rush the question into something.

I still think, now, that those three days were the right thing. Some things disappear if you check them too quickly. I was afraid that question would disappear.

. . .

Over those three days I kept helping Speon dig the ditch.

The channel had now passed the halfway point of the city. Speon dug alongside me without saying much. He glanced sideways at me sometimes, but never asked what I was doing.

Only on the evening of the second day did he ask.

"…You still haven't gone."

"…No."

"…Why."

"…I'm not ready."

Speon set down his shovel.

"…Even after water changes direction, it takes time before it comes out. If you keep tearing at the ground in the meantime, you only block it. You have to know how to wait, too."

Hearing that, I felt a little relieved. It meant what I was putting off might not be running away, but waiting. I fell asleep that night holding onto those words.

. . .

On the fourth day, my brother pushed me himself.

"…Brother, when are you going again."

"…Why."

"…I miss Mom."

Hearing that, I knew I couldn't put it off any longer. I had been spending those three days for myself. My brother hadn't.

"…All right. Let's go today."

. . .

We went together.

It had been a long time since my brother had walked beside me. As we walked, he kept glancing sideways at the channel. I didn't ask whether the sound of the water scared him. Instead I watched. He wasn't scared.

That day, for the first time, I wondered when my brother had stopped being afraid of the sound of water. There was no way to find out. Asking him wouldn't have told me either. Seven years changes a person that way. Without the person even knowing it themselves.

Walking along, my brother suddenly asked,

"…Brother, what are you going for today?"

"…To see Mom."

"…Not that. Your face isn't the face of someone just going to see someone."

That surprised me. I hadn't expected to hear something like that from an eight-year-old.

"…I'm going to ask Mom something."

"…What?"

"…You'll find out when we get there."

My brother didn't press further. He just kept walking beside me.

. . .

At the front desk I hesitated a moment over what to write in the purpose box on the form.

I wrote counsel.

I looked at that word a long while. Counsel is words exchanged to decide something. For the first time, I had written the exact word.

My brother wrote his own name beside mine. His handwriting was crooked.

. . .

My mother was glad to see the two of us.

"…You came together."

"…Yes." My brother answered first. "Brother brought me."

"…I was the one who said let's go." my brother added. "He was about to go without me."

My mother laughed at that.

"…That sounds like you."

It had been a long time since I'd seen the two of them talk back and forth so easily. I stayed a little back from it. Today I had something else to say.

. . .

My brother talked about himself for a long while first.

"…The water's reached the big tree down there now." my brother said. "I go every day to see how far it's gotten."

"…Is it fun?" my mother asked.

"…Yeah. Yesterday there was a little bug in the water. Mr. Speon says that's a good thing. It means the water's alive."

"…Living water." my mother repeated the phrase. "That's an interesting way to put it."

My brother kept going, excited. The nameless weeds blooming by the ditch, the dry bread Speon sometimes gave him, how the sound of water was like a lullaby at night.

My mother listened to all of it. Her eyes never left my brother.

Watching that, I felt all over again that this was how she had always responded to my brother. Listening to a child's words all the way through. I knew that wasn't a response born of lack. It was just my mother.

. . .

When my brother's story wound down, I looked at my mother.

"…You asked me, last time." I said. "How I'd been."

My mother nodded.

"…I want to answer that properly, today."

My brother went quiet, reading the room. Eight years old, but he knew when to do that.

. . .

This time I didn't summarize.

The winters at the settlement, the seventeen funerals, the well where I drew water, the old man who taught me to dig. I told it in order. I left some things out, but I didn't rush.

"…My uncle raised me." I said. "He wasn't a bad person. But since I wasn't his own child, he only looked after me up to a point. I thought that was just how it was."

"…It isn't how it should be." my mother said quietly.

"…I know that, now."

I went on — learning to dig wells at fourteen, the old man who'd been a man of few words, that the ninth funeral had been his. My brother sat quietly through all of it, just listening.

My mother never once interrupted. Only after hearing it all did she ask,

"…So now."

"…Now I'm here." I said. "Because I want to see you and my brother with living bodies again."

. . .

Even saying that, I tried to keep last month's self and this month's self separate.

"…Before, I only thought it was for your sake." I said. "Now I know. My own share is mixed into it too. I came here because I wanted to not be alone again."

My mother wasn't surprised at that. Her face was one that had known for a long time.

"…Is that a bad thing?" she asked.

"…I don't know. But I didn't want to hide it."

. . .

My mother looked out the window for a moment. Toward where the sound of water was.

"…I've been thinking about it too." she said. "After you left, last time, and the time after that, and the time after that. I kept thinking."

"…About what."

"…This thing called release."

I stopped breathing at that. I had never brought that word up first. Not this time either.

I still remember that moment exactly. I heard that word from my mother's mouth for the first time. Not me — my mother said it first.

. . .

"…How did you know." I asked.

"…The Curator told me. That you'd asked, many times."

Hearing that, I thought of the Curator. He had never told me how my mother was taking the idea. But apparently he had told her side of it.

"…Are you afraid?" I asked.

My mother thought about that for a moment.

"…I'm not even sure what afraid means, anymore." she said. "That's probably the strange part."

. . .

In the meantime, my brother asked quietly,

"…What's release?"

"…It means becoming a living body again." I said. "Then you can get sick again, and get hurt again."

"…So can you die again too?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…Yeah." I managed to say. "You could."

My brother listened to that quietly. He didn't ask anything further.

. . .

My mother looked at me again.

"…You came to ask me that, knowing all that?"

"…No." I said. "I didn't come to ask, today. I just came to answer your question from last time."

My mother nodded at that.

"…But you ended up here anyway."

"…Yes."

. . .

The room was quiet for a while. Only the sound of water.

"…I don't." my mother finally spoke. "I don't really know what being able to die again means. But watching you stand here talking about it, it doesn't seem like a bad thing."

"…Is that the reason?" I asked.

"…Of course not." my mother laughed. "That's not a reason. It's just a thought that came to me."

. . .

"…Then what's the reason?" I asked.

My mother looked at me for a long time. Then at my brother. Then at me again.

"…I want to see the two of you standing here, side by side."

That was all. It wasn't a long speech. It wasn't an argument. The moment I heard that sentence, I knew there was nothing left to ask.

I've copied that sentence out many times since. I tried to change it into something better. I couldn't. That sentence was right exactly as it was.

. . .

"…Are you consenting?" I asked. My voice shook.

"…Yes." my mother said. "I'll be released."

In that moment I didn't know what to say. I must have had words prepared, but not one of them came to me.

In that silence I called up all seven years of visits at once. The faces that had answered why with why. The answers that never changed. And now, this one sentence, this moment. I understood that all of it had been pointed toward this moment. But now that I had arrived, I didn't even know whether I was supposed to feel glad.

My brother asked in my place.

"…So what happens now?"

"…There's a procedure." I managed to say. "They say it's simple."

I remembered what the Curator had told me. That one signature was enough. That simplicity felt strange, somehow. That undoing seven years could end with one signature.

"…So will Mom get sick again?" my brother asked.

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I might." my mother answered in my place. "But that's all right too."

"…Why is it all right?"

My mother stroked my brother's head.

"…Because being sick is being alive too."

My brother stayed quiet, his face unreadable — whether he'd understood or not. I carved that answer into myself too.

. . .

We left the room and walked for a while without talking.

My brother took my hand. It had been a long time. He used to do it all the time when he was little, but not these last few days.

"…Brother." my brother said. "Is Mom really going to live with us now?"

"…Yeah. That's how it'll be."

"…Then I want to do that too, later."

I stopped walking at that. My brother didn't seem to know yet what he meant by it. I decided not to explain it, today.

"…Let's talk about that later." I said.

My brother nodded obediently.

. . .

Leaving the room that day, I looked for the Curator.

He was standing at the end of the hallway. It looked like he'd been waiting.

"…My mother consented." I said.

The Curator nodded at that. Not a surprised face.

"…I knew." he said. "I've seen a few people come out with that face before."

"…How many times?"

"…Not many." he said. "Truly not many."

"…What happened to them?" I asked.

The Curator hesitated a moment.

"…Most of them were released. After that, it's not our concern anymore. Once they become living bodies again, they may leave this city, or they may stay. That belongs to them."

"…Have some left?"

"…There have." he said. "I don't know how they went on to live. I want to know, and at the same time I feel it might be better not to."

In those words I felt this man's old weariness again.

. . .

Walking back to my room with the procedure papers, I met Eikon.

"…Your face is different again today." she said.

"…Yeah. My mother consented."

Eikon stopped walking.

"…Really?"

"…Yeah."

She said nothing for a long while. I tried to read something in her face. It wasn't envy. It wasn't fear either. Just a face weighing something.

"…Wasn't she afraid?" she asked.

"…She said she wasn't sure what afraid even means."

"…Same with me." Eikon said. "Is that the same thing, that and this?"

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know." I said honestly.

Eikon nodded at that answer and went on her way.

. . .

That evening I told Speon the news too.

He was sitting by the ditch, watching the water flow.

"…She consented." I said.

Speon's face took a moment to take that in. Then he stood up and put his hand into the channel.

"…I won't say congratulations." he said.

"…Why not?"

"…Because it's just the beginning. A well isn't finished just because water comes out. That's when the upkeep starts."

I turned that over. It seemed right.

"…Still, rest a little today." he added. "Days like this don't come often."

. . .

That night I thought back on that sentence again. I want to see the two of you standing here, side by side. I know that isn't an argument. If you ask why choose to become able to die again, this sentence isn't an answer. And yet this sentence was enough.

Of everything in this book, this is the scene I rewrote the most, while writing it. I wanted to put in a more plausible reason. Every time, I deleted it again. My mother didn't argue that day. She simply wanted.

Before I fell asleep that night I thought back, too, on what my brother had said. I want to do that too, later. I hadn't made any

promise to that yet. I only knew that it was the thing I would have to face next.

(Continued in Chapter 41.)

Chapter 41. The Release

> *_Previously_ — My mother consented. "I want to see the two of you*
> *standing here, side by side." Not an argument. She simply said it. The Curator began preparing the procedure.*

The procedure was set for three days later.

The Curator said there was no need to rush, but no need to put it off too long either. Something in the way he said it let me guess how many times he'd already been through this.

I didn't count those three days. It was the first time I ever let a number go.

. . .

Through those three days I helped Speon as usual.

If I wasn't working, other thoughts kept crowding in. Digging at the earth was better than nothing.

"…Nervous." Speon asked.

"…Yeah."

"…What's the most nervous part."

I thought about that question for a long while.

"…That nothing will change." I said. "That after making a decision this big, once the procedure's over, nothing will actually be different."

Speon stopped digging at that.

"…No chance of that." he said. "Once water starts coming out, the ground changes. Even if you can't see it from outside, the inside changes. People are the same."

. . .

On the second day, my brother came and asked me,

"…Brother, is Mom going to get old now?"

"…Probably. That's just how people are."

"…So will Mom get older than me?"

"…She always was. She's the grown-up."

My brother thought about that answer for a long while.

"…I'm fine with it." my brother said. "Even if Mom gets old."

I could tell that wasn't a prepared line. It was just a mind an eight-year-old had made up on his own.

. . .

On the evening of the third day, Eikon came looking for me.

"…Tomorrow, right." she said.

"…Yeah."

"…How do you feel?"

I tried to answer that honestly.

"…I don't really know. Kind of glad, kind of scared."

"…It's strange to me, that you feel both at once." Eikon said. "I only ever feel one thing at a time. And not even that, often."

I turned that over for a long while.

. . .

The day before the procedure, I looked at the papers.

The Curator had shown them to me ahead of time. A single sheet. At the top, my mother's name and registration number. At the bottom, a line for a signature.

The content was short. The undersigned consents to the release of the preservation state, and acknowledges and accepts all resulting physical consequences thereafter — including illness, aging, and death.

I read that sentence over many times. The whole of this book was inside that short sentence.

. . .

"…This is all of it?" I asked.

The Curator nodded.

"…That's all. There's no reason for it to be complicated. Perpetuity doesn't judge a person. It asks no eligibility, no reason. If you want it, this is enough."

"…Then why doesn't anyone do it?"

"…Because no one wants to." he said. "Not because there's anything blocking them."

. . .

I brought the paper to my mother myself.

My brother came too. The air in the room felt different from usual. My mother saw us come in and straightened where she sat. I felt something even in that small motion. That this person was getting ready for something.

My mother took the paper and looked at it for a long while. She didn't rush.

"…Should I read it to you?" I asked.

"…No. I can read it myself."

My mother really did read it start to finish. I stood beside her holding my breath.

. . .

"…Including illness, aging, and death." my mother read that part aloud.

"…Yes."

"…This includes all of it."

"…Yes."

My mother set the paper down.

"…I understand."

That was all. She didn't ask anything else.

My brother couldn't bear the silence and asked,

"…Mom, are you scared?"

My mother looked at him and smiled.

"…No. But it is strange."

"…What's strange?"

"…That one sheet of paper decides something this big."

I couldn't answer that. I'd been thinking the same thing myself.

. . .

I lay awake again that night.

This time it wasn't anxiety. I just had two feelings at once — wanting tomorrow to come quickly, and wanting it to come a little later.

That night, for the first time, I understood that those two feelings weren't fighting each other. Wanting it to come quickly and wanting it to come slowly were, in fact, two faces of the same feeling. Both came from the same place: this moment mattering too much.

. . .

On the day of the procedure, the room was smaller than I'd expected.

One desk, three chairs. There was one window, facing the direction the channel ran. I didn't think that was an accident.

The Curator set the papers on the desk.

"…Are you ready." he asked.

"…Yes." my mother said.

"…I'll confirm one thing again." he said. "This procedure cannot be reversed. After release, you may apply for preservation again, but you cannot return to exactly the state you are in now. Do you understand."

"…I understand."

"…And this procedure proceeds only by your own will. Here, in this room, you are signing by your own will, not your family's. Do you confirm this."

My mother looked at my brother and me for a moment.

"…I confirm it." she said. "This is my will."

I still remember those words exactly. All this time, I'd thought I was the one leading this. But in that room, my mother said it plainly. This is my will. In that moment I understood that I was only someone standing beside her. And I liked that better.

. . .

I stood in that room with my brother.

No one came to celebrate. No one from the rest of the city, no one from our settlement. Just the three of us, the Curator, and one sheet of paper. That was all.

I didn't find that strange at the time. Thinking back on it now, it is strange. That no one was there for something this large.

But now I know. This wasn't a thing to celebrate. It wasn't a thing to grieve, either. It was just one person returning to her own body.

. . .

My mother picked up the pen.

Her hand didn't shake. That struck me as strange. That her hand wouldn't shake, in front of a decision this big.

I only understood later. For a hand to shake, there has to be fear. My mother didn't properly know that fear yet. Fear too was an emotion you learn only once you become a living body again.

My mother wrote her name in the signature line.

The sound of the pen touching the paper was the loudest sound in that room. Hearing it, I only then realized I'd been holding my breath.

Once she'd finished writing her name, my mother set the pen down.

"…It's done." she said. It sounded like something said to herself.

. . .

The Curator took the paper and checked it.

"…Confirmed." he said. "I'll begin the procedure now."

He opened a small panel on the wall. Inside was a single simple switch.

"…Is that all it is?" I asked.

"…Yes." he said. "Perpetuity isn't a complicated system. Preservation and release are both simple. What's difficult isn't the procedure. It's the decision."

. . .

He pressed the switch.

No sound came. No light. I'd expected something dramatic to happen. Nothing happened.

Strangely, in that moment, I was disappointed. And I was ashamed of that disappointment. What had I expected? Light bursting out, wind blowing, some visible proof.

I set that disappointment down honestly, here. At that moment I still wanted something dramatic. It was a feeling exactly opposite to what this book means to say. Perpetuity does not seize a person with any fanfare. Release does not let a person go with any fanfare either. Both are quiet.

My mother closed her eyes for a moment. Then opened them.

"…How do you feel?" the Curator asked.

My mother couldn't answer that right away. She looked down at her own hands.

. . .

"…Different." she finally said.

"…How?" I asked.

"…I don't know. It just feels different."

My brother took my mother's hand.

"…It's warm." my brother said. "It's different from before."

My mother looked at her own hand again, hearing that.

"…Was warmth always like this." she said, almost to herself.

Hearing that, I reached out and took my mother's hand too. It really was warm. I had touched my mother's hand at every visit, all this time. It had been warm then too. But today's warmth was different. I had no words to explain the difference. It was just different.

. . .

The Curator spoke as he put the papers in order.

"…Your registration has now changed. You are no longer a subject of preservation. You've been converted to a regular resident."

"…What does that mean?" my brother asked.

"…It means Mom's the same as us now." I said.

My brother beamed at that. My mother didn't smile. Her face wasn't ready to smile yet.

. . .

We sat in that small room for a while, just as we were.

No one said congratulations. No one cried. I didn't think that was strange. This wasn't that kind of thing.

I wanted to write this scene the most quietly of anything in this book. That day, I truly didn't feel anything large. Joy, fear — those came later. Inside that room there was just one sheet of paper, one switch, and three people.

My brother broke that silence first.

"…Are we going home now?" my brother asked.

I stopped at that question. The word home sounded unfamiliar. We hadn't had a home, all this time. The house at the settlement had passed into

other hands seven years ago, and in this city I had simply been living in a room the Preserve had given me.

"…Yeah." I managed to say. "We'll have to find somewhere to live together now."

Hearing that, my mother smiled a little, for the first time.

"…A home." she said. "That's a word I haven't heard in a while."

. . .

The Curator watched us as he gathered up the papers. His face carried the same weary look as always. But something else was mixed into it too. I couldn't read exactly what it was, at the time.

"…You're not saying congratulations." I said.

"…I don't know that I'm entitled to say something like that." he said. "I'm the one who builds this procedure. Not the one who goes through it."

"…Still, you must be glad today."

The Curator was quiet for a moment at that.

"…I am glad." he said quietly. "But it doesn't feel right to show that too openly, here. This is your day, not mine."

I held onto that for a long time. This man handled even his own gladness with care. I only understood later that it came from the same place as the way he handled his sorrow.

. . .

The Curator opened the door for us and said,

"…You may go out now."

We left that room. Standing in the hallway, I looked at my mother. She looked the same. But something was different.

I couldn't put that difference into words, at the time. I understood it later. From that moment, my mother had become someone who could die again. Nothing had changed on the outside. But that one fact changed everything.

. . .

The three of us walked down the hallway side by side.

The sound of water came from outside the window. My mother turned her head toward it.

"…I want to hear that sound up close." she said.

That surprised me. It had been a long time since my mother had said she wanted something. Or maybe — it had been seven years.

"…Let's go." I said. "Let's get close to it."

. . .

We walked to the edge of the city. Our steps were slower than usual. My mother didn't seem used to her own body yet. A walk that checked

something with every step, at every footfall.

My brother walked beside her, holding her hand. I walked on the other side. It was the first time the three of us had walked side by side in seven years.

I didn't count those steps. I didn't want to. Some things only get smaller when you turn them into numbers.

. . .

The closer we got to the ditch, the louder the sound of water grew. My mother stopped walking.

"…So this is it." she said.

Speon happened to be working on the channel there. He saw us and set down his shovel.

"…I won't say congratulations." he said to my mother. "I'll give you a mouthful of water instead."

He filled the flask with water and held it out to her.

My mother took the flask. She wrapped both hands around it.

In that moment I remembered what Speon had said to me a few days before. I won't say congratulations. Because it's just the beginning. I only understood then that those words were a principle of his. He must have said them every time water first came out.

My mother stayed still for a moment, holding that flask. She didn't drink. She just seemed to be feeling the weight of it in her hands.

I watched that from beside her. The sound of water kept flowing.

My brother said nothing, and neither did Speon. Everyone seemed to know that this was a moment that shouldn't be hurried. In that silence, I thought of the water jar from seven years ago. The jar my mother had filled and left behind before she went away. I hadn't drunk from it for three days. Because drinking it meant it would be gone.

The water in my mother's hands now was water that could disappear and it would still be all right. Because it could be drawn again. I thought that difference might be the whole of everything that had happened.

(Continued in Chapter 42.)

Chapter 42. Breathing

> *_Previously_ — My mother was released. One signature, one switch. No*
> *one celebrated and no one cried. Speon offered her a mouthful of water. My mother stood holding the flask in both hands, not drinking.*

My mother blinked.

Once. Twice. Three times.

I saw that too.

. . .

My mother moved her fingers, one by one.

Thumb, index, middle, ring, little.

They all moved.

"…They all work." she said.

. . .

The wind blew.

My mother drew her shoulders in.

"…Cold." she said.

That word startled me. I hadn't heard it once in seven years.

. . .

My brother took off his own coat and put it over my mother's shoulders.

It was too small to cover her fully. She left it on anyway.

"…Thank you." she said.

. . .

My mother raised the flask.

Brought it to her mouth.

Drank.

. . .

One mouthful.

Her throat moved. I watched that movement. A movement I hadn't seen in seven years.

My mother took the flask away.

. . .

She coughed.

Once, twice, three times. Bending forward each time.

My brother, startled, patted her back.

"…Mom, are you okay?"

. . .

My mother raised a hand to say she was fine. She couldn't speak until the coughing stopped.

Speon said quietly,

"…It's been so long, her throat's startled."

Hearing that, I looked at the flask again. It was half full.

. . .

The coughing stopped.

My mother steadied her breath. Breathed in deep, breathed out.

"…The taste of the water." she managed to say.

"…How is it?" I asked.

Instead of answering, my mother drank another mouthful.

. . .

This time she didn't cough.

Her throat moved again. A little bigger, a little easier.

My brother stared at that.

"…There's a sound in Mom's throat."

"…Her throat's remembering." Speon said.

. . .

My mother touched her throat.

"…It still feels strange." she said.

"…Does it hurt?" my brother asked.

"…No. Just unfamiliar."

. . .

One more mouthful.

This time no sound at all. Her throat just moved.

My mother felt that and opened her eyes wide.

"…There. Now it's working." she said.

. . .

My mother set the flask down.

Wiped her mouth with the back of her hand. A completely ordinary motion. I was struck, rather, by that ordinariness.

I still remember that motion exactly. Wiping her mouth with the back of her hand. A motion more ordinary than anything else, and it was the biggest event of that day.

. . .

We sat down by the ditch.

Sitting, my mother swayed slightly. I reached out and caught her.

"…Are you all right?"

"…Yeah. My legs feel a little strange."

"…Strange how?"

"…Heavy." she said. "Having a body that's all mine — was it always this heavy?"

. . .

My mother dipped her hand into the water.

"…Cold." she said.

"…Do you like the cold?" I asked.

"…I don't know. It's just cold."

. . .

My brother dipped his hand in too.

"…It's cold for me too."

"…Your hand already knew that." my mother said.

"…Didn't Mom's hand know?"

My mother paused for a moment at that. She pulled her hand out of the water, then dipped it back in. Pulled it out, then dipped it back in.

. . .

"…I don't think I knew." she said.

The sound of water kept flowing. We sat for a while with our hands in it, listening to that sound.

I didn't count how long that lasted. I didn't want to.

. . .

The sun fell across my mother's face.

She narrowed her eyes.

"…Bright." she said.

She raised a hand to shield the sun.

. . .

Under that shade of her hand, my mother closed her eyes for a moment.

Stayed still.

"…What are you doing?" my brother asked.

"…Just feeling it."

"…Feeling what?"

"…The sun."

. . .

The wind blew again.

This time my mother didn't flinch.

Her hair scattered in it. She swept it back with her hand.

. . .

Speon brought out a piece of dry bread.

"…You must be hungry." he handed it to my mother.

My mother took it and looked at it. Smelled it.

"…Was this what bread smelled like." she said.

. . .

She took a bite.

Chewed.

Chewed slowly.

My brother watched. No one rushed her.

She swallowed.

. . .

My mother stayed still there for a moment. A face checking something.

"…It's good." she said.

Her voice shook.

. . .

My brother laughed at that.

"…Mom's voice sounds weird."

"…It's not weird." Speon said. "It's shaking."

My brother's face didn't quite understand the difference.

. . .

My mother finished chewing the bread. Something glinted in her eyes. Not tears. It might just have been the light catching them that way.

I still can't be sure whether it was tears or not. My mother didn't cry that day. Her eyes were only a little wet. That's a different thing.

. . .

Finishing the bread, my mother brushed off her hands.

"…Was this what being full felt like." she said.

"…Don't you remember?" I asked.

"…I remember. But feeling it is different."

. . .

There was a small scratch on the back of my mother's hand. A mark from brushing against something on the way. She noticed it and pressed a finger to it.

"…That hurts." she said quietly. Half surprise, half wonder, in her voice.

My brother blew a breath on the scratch. A habit he'd had since he was small.

"…It'll heal." my brother said.

. . .

My brother kept laughing beside her.

A laugh with no reason. A laugh that came just because things were good.

My mother watched that laugh and laughed along with it.

. . .

A very small laugh.

Almost no sound at all. The corners of her mouth rose slightly, then came back down.

I didn't miss it.

. . .

In that moment I found myself counting a number. I hadn't meant to. My body counted before I could stop it.

Seven years.

It was the first laugh in seven years.

I couldn't say anything, right there. Not because my throat had closed up. I simply had no word to call it.

My brother, not knowing what it was, kept laughing. The sound of that laugh overlapped with the sound of the water. I heard both sounds at once.

. . .

I write down that laugh the most carefully of anything in this book. It wasn't a big laugh. There was almost no sound to it. The distance her mouth moved was probably less than a finger's width. But I knew, right there, that this one small movement was the whole of what I'd been waiting seven years for.

I didn't cry. My mother didn't cry either. We just sat by the channel, drank water, coughed, ate bread, and laughed. That was all. And because that was all it was, that's the day I still go back to, more often than any other.

. . .

My brother asked,

"…Laugh again, Mom."

My mother shook her head at that.

"…It doesn't work that way." she said. "You need something funny to laugh."

My brother looked around, trying to find something funny at that. He couldn't find anything. But the sight of him looking was funny enough that my mother laughed a little again, once more.

. . .

The second laugh.

I counted that one too.

. . .

My mother yawned.

Covered her mouth with her hand. Then looked surprised.

"…That was a yawn, wasn't it." she asked.

"…Yes."

"…So this is what being tired is."

. . .

My mother rubbed her eyes.

"…I'm sleepy." she said.

That was another word I was hearing for the first time from her.

. . .

Standing up, my mother swayed again. This time my brother caught her hand.

"…I'll help." my brother said.

It was as much help as an eight-year-old could give. Still, my mother took that hand and stood.

. . .

The sun began to set. The sound of water carried more clearly in the dark.

My mother raised the flask again and drank one more mouthful. This time she didn't cough.

"…I think I'm getting used to it now." she said.

. . .

Walking back toward the room, my mother stopped a few more times.

Once she braced a hand against the wall.

Once she just stood and looked down at her own feet.

"…What are you looking at?" I asked.

"…It feels strange, my feet touching the ground."

. . .

Crossing the Preserve's yard, her foot caught on a stone.

My mother staggered slightly.

"…Ah." she made a small sound.

"…Are you all right?"

"…That hurt." my mother said. A surprised face. "So this is what it means to hurt."

I couldn't answer that at all.

. . .

At the door of the room, my mother touched the doorframe with her hand.

Ran her fingers along the wood grain.

"…Rough." she said.

. . .

Inside the room, my mother touched the blanket.

Pressed on it.

"…Soft."

My brother pressed the blanket the same way beside her.

"…I want to touch it too." my brother said. It was a blanket he'd always touched. But today his face wanted to touch it together with his mother.

. . .

That night the three of us slept in one room for the first time.

A room the Preserve had lent us temporarily. Cramped. But no one complained about it.

My brother fell asleep first. My mother lay beside him, listening to his breathing for a long while.

. . .

"…Anemos." my mother called my name.

"…Yes."

"…I didn't know a breathing sound could be this loud."

"…It was always like that."

"…But today it sounds different."

. . .

I didn't answer for a moment. My mother's breathing and my brother's breathing sounded, in turns, through the room.

I felt I understood what she meant.

When the listener changes, the same sound is heard differently. I learned that, that day. My mother had had no need, all those seven years, to listen to my brother's breathing. A person with no need doesn't listen. That night, for the first time, my mother needed that breathing sound.

. . .

We laid out the bedding.

My mother was a little awkward about how to lie down. Not sure where to put her arms, she shifted position a few times.

"…It wasn't like this before." she said.

"…Before, you didn't need to lie down."

"…That's true."

. . .

My mother wiggled her feet under the blanket.

"…My feet are cold." she said.

My brother pressed his own feet against hers.

"…My feet are warm."

"…So they are."

. . .

My mother put a hand to her chest.

Stayed still.

"…This is it beating, isn't it." she asked.

"…Yes."

"…It's fast."

"…Maybe it's surprised."

"…No." my mother said. "I think it's because it's glad."

. . .

My brother fell asleep first. His breathing evened out.

My mother listened to that breathing for a long while.

She reached out and touched my brother's forehead.

"…Warm." she said.

. . .

I lay down beside them too.

Three breathing sounds filled the room. I didn't count them.

That night, for the first time, I set the habit of counting down completely. It was all right not to count. Not because there was no need to count, but because I simply didn't want to turn that moment into a number.

The sound of water kept running outside the window. I listened to it last, and fell asleep.

. . .

In the morning I woke to find my mother already awake.

Sitting up, looking down at her own hands.

"…Did you sleep well?" I asked.

"…I don't know. I saw something strange."

"…What was it?"

"…A dream."

. . .

I sat up at that.

"…What kind of dream was it?"

"…I don't remember." my mother said. "I just know I saw something."

Hearing that, I was quietly astonished. The preserved don't dream. They have no need to. That morning, for the first time in seven years, my mother had dreamed. And she couldn't remember the dream. I thought even that was enough.

My mother looked at her own hand again. Ran a finger along the lines of her palm.

"…It's like I'm seeing this for the first time too." she said.

"…It was always there." I said.

"…I know. But it feels like I'm seeing it for the first time, today."

. . .

My mother stretched.

Something in her body cracked.

My brother opened his eyes at the sound.

"…What was that sound?"

"…It came from Mom's body." my mother said. A wondering face.

. . .

Her stomach made a sound.

My mother pressed a hand to it.

"…Is this something new too?" I asked.

"…Yes." she said. "Was being hungry always something that made a sound too?"

. . .

We got up and opened the door to the room.

The morning sun came in.

My mother walked out into that light. One step, one step, a little lighter than yesterday.

At the edge of the yard, my mother stopped and looked toward the channel. The sound of water had kept flowing through the night without stopping.

"…I guess it ran all night." I said.

"…I suppose it did." my mother said. "Without even sleeping."

"…Water never sleeps."

My mother nodded at that. Then she took a deep breath. It looked as though I could see the morning air going into her lungs.

I watched her back.

(Continued in Chapter 43.)

Chapter 43. My Brother, Not Yet

> *_Previously_ — The morning after my mother was released, we went out*
> *to the yard and looked at the water channel. My mother took a deep*
> *breath. I watched her back.*

The three of us spent those two days in the room the Preserve had lent us.

We hadn't even started looking for a house yet. My mother's body still felt strange to her, and moving any distance was hard. I spent that time helping Speon with the ditch, and my brother played beside it.

I think those two days were the most ordinary two days in this whole book. Nothing big happened. And it was exactly that ordinariness that felt strange. I couldn't even remember the last time the three of us had spent two days like that, with nothing happening at all.

. . .

Two days later, my brother asked.

"…Can I do it now too?"

I had been waiting for that question. And now that I heard it, I didn't know how to answer.

"…Do what." I asked back. A question meant to buy time.

"…Release."

. . .

The three of us were sitting in the yard. My mother spoke first.

"…Why do you want to?"

"…I want to be like you and Mom."

"…Be like us how?"

My brother thought about that for a moment.

"…Sick." my brother said. "You said it yourself. Being sick is still being alive."

. . .

I remembered that I had said that myself, a few days ago. I hadn't expected my own words to come back to me like this.

"…Is being sick a good thing?" I asked.

"…I don't know. But when Mom was sick, I want to be sick too."

Hearing that, I felt my breath stop. My brother hadn't meant it badly. It was only a way of saying he wanted to be with us.

I remembered how my brother used to be afraid of the sound of water when he was small. The rope of the well-bucket unspooling, and the long silence in between. I remembered once deliberately unspooling it

slower, just to scare him more. My mother had seen it and hit me on the back. Why would you make something scarier when it already scares him.

I bring up that memory here for a reason. That day, I didn't want to make the same mistake in front of my brother. I didn't want to make something frightening more frightening. But at the same time, I didn't want to rush something he wasn't ready for either. I swung a long time between those two.

. . .

"…But how is that different from you saying, if you do it, then I will?" I asked.

My brother's eyes went wide at that.

"…How's it different?"

"…Before, when I asked you, you said if I do it, then you would too. Isn't this the same thing now? Don't you want it just because your brother and Mom did it?"

My brother thought about that for a long while.

. . .

"…No." my brother said. "Back then it was because I thought you'd like it. Now I want it myself."

I couldn't tell whether that distinction was real. I couldn't tell whether an eight-year-old could really make that distinction at all.

In that moment I thought back to Part Two. When my brother said if I do it, then I will too, I had judged that this was not consent but obedience, and withdrew the application myself. I still believe that judgment was right. And now, today, I had to make the same judgment again.

There was one difference from that time. Back then I had judged it alone. Now my mother was beside me. I thought that was a good thing. I didn't want to make this decision by myself.

My mother looked over at me. Her face was thinking the same thing I was. We confirmed it between us without a word.

. . .

My mother sat my brother on her knee.

My brother shifted a little in her lap.

"…So Mom says no too?" my brother asked. His voice had hurt in it.

"…It's not no." my mother said. "It's not yet."

"…What's the difference between not yet and no?"

My brother asked that with a serious face. I saw something in that face that didn't belong to an eight-year-old. And at the same time, I saw a stubbornness in it that belonged entirely to one.

My mother was quiet for a moment at the question.

"…Not yet changes, when enough time passes." she said. "No doesn't change."

. . .

"…I think I understand why you want this." she said. "But this is a different kind of thing."

"…How's it different?"

"…This can't be undone." my mother said. "You're eight years old right now. But after release, you'll grow up again. Nine, ten, and on. You don't know yet what it means to grow older."

. . .

"…Does my brother know?" he asked.

"…Your brother already grew up that way." my mother said. "You haven't, yet."

My brother turned that over.

"…So is getting older a bad thing?"

"…No." my mother said. "It's not bad. It's just something you can't know until you've lived through it."

. . .

I listened to that conversation beside them and thought of the Curator's words.

The consent requirement. Release requires the consent of the preserved person themselves. I had heard the word consent many times

by then. But it was in front of my brother that I first felt, all the way through, how heavy that word was. To consent means you have to know what it is you're consenting to.

. . .

"…It's not." I said carefully, "that I'm saying no because you're eight. It's just that I'm not sure yet whether you really understand what you want, and really want it."

"…I understood it." my brother said.

"…Understood what?"

"…That I can get sick."

"…That you can die, too?"

My brother had no answer to that at all.

. . .

I set that silence down here honestly. I took the silence as proof that my brother didn't understand it yet. And at the same time, I knew that even adults don't fully understand death either. I had watched seventeen funerals and I still don't know.

After a long while, my brother spoke again.

"…What happens when you die?"

I didn't know how to answer that question. My mother seemed the same.

"…I don't know." I said, honestly. "Nobody knows for sure. Even grown-ups don't."

"…You don't know either?"

"…No. I don't know either."

That answer seemed to put my brother a little at ease, oddly.

And still, I had to make a decision right there. Complete understanding couldn't be the standard. But some minimum was needed. My brother didn't seem to have reached even that minimum yet.

. . .

"…Brother." my brother said. "I still want to."

"…I know." I said. "But not now."

"…Why."

"…I want to wait until you can be asked again, later, and really, truly want it for yourself."

My brother's face went dark.

. . .

"…I don't like waiting."

"…I know. I didn't like it either."

"…Then why are you making me wait?"

I couldn't answer that right away. My mother answered instead.

"…Because you're precious." she said. "You don't rush what's precious."

. . .

My brother's face still wasn't fully convinced by that.

But he didn't push any further either. He just sat quietly and looked at the channel.

I don't think that silence was consent. It was just an eight-year-old's kind of acceptance. And I needed to be clear, that day, that acceptance and consent are not the same thing.

. . .

I sat down beside my brother.

"…Instead." I said. "I'll ask you again every year. Whenever you want it."

"…Every year?"

"…Yes. Every birthday."

My brother brightened a little at that.

"…So you'll ask me again on my next birthday?"

"…Yes."

"…Promise?"

"…Promise."

My brother held out his little finger. I hooked my finger through his. A promise from when we were small. I noticed, all over again, how small that finger was.

"…Mom too." my brother said.

My mother hooked her finger in as well. The three of our fingers tangled together at once.

I know that pinky promise is a completely different kind of promise from signing a document. It had no legal force at all. But I don't think it was lighter than the document. I think, if anything, it was the opposite.

. . .

I wrote this scene more carefully than any other in this book. I felt the temptation, more than once, to resolve this cleanly — to have my brother suddenly say something wise beyond his years and convince me, or to have me convince him with some great argument. I didn't write either of those scenes. They didn't happen in fact, either.

This book doesn't resolve everything. My brother has not been released. I believe that was the right decision. And at the same time, I know that belief could be wrong. I close this chapter holding both of those at once.

. . .

In the afternoon I saw Eikon. I told her about it.

"…My brother said he wanted to be released. I told him no."

Eikon tilted her head at that.

"…Why? Your brother and your mother got to."

"…He's eight. I'm not sure he really understands and really wants it."

"…I don't understand that." she said. "If you want something, don't you just want it? Why does understanding have to come into it?"

. . .

I couldn't answer that right away either.

"…Some things are dangerous to want without understanding." I managed. "Especially things you can't undo."

"…There's plenty I don't understand either." Eikon said. "But I've never really wanted much of anything. So I don't really understand that danger you're talking about."

Something went cold in me hearing that. Eikon had nothing to want, so there was no danger for her either. My brother had something to want, and that was exactly what made it dangerous. I confirmed again, right then, that this difference split their two worlds completely apart.

. . .

"…What about you, Anemos." Eikon asked. "Did you understand and want it? Coming here."

I stopped for a moment at that.

"…No." I said. "I didn't come here with full understanding either. But I'm an adult. So I carry the responsibility for my own choice, myself."

"…And your brother can't carry it?"

"…Not yet."

Eikon listened to that answer quietly and went on her way.

. . .

That evening I told the Curator about it.

"…You did well." he said. "I've seen the opposite far more often — a parent deciding for a child instead of the child."

"…I'm not his parent."

"…And yet you're standing in that place right now."

I had no answer to that.

. . .

"…Could I." I asked. "Could I be wrong about this?"

The Curator thought for a moment.

"…You could." he said. "But I also know it was the best decision you could make right now. The best isn't always right. But it's better than what isn't the best."

"…And if I regret it, years from now?"

"…Then you decide again, when that time comes." he said. "If there's one good thing about this line of work, it's that a decision you couldn't make today, you can make again tomorrow. Unlike death."

I held on to that for a long time.

. . .

I ran into Speon on the way back.

"…Your face is heavy." he said.

"…My brother said he wanted to be released. I told him no."

Speon set down his shovel and looked at me.

"…Good."

"…How can you say that so fast?"

"…I had something similar happen once, a long time ago." he said. "There was a kid who wanted to learn to dig wells way too early. I told him no. He was hurt by it."

"…What happened after that?"

"…He came back a few years later. By then he was really ready."

. . .

"…What happened to that kid?"

"…He became a well-digger." Speon said. "Like you."

I laughed a little at that.

"…So all I have to do is wait, then."

"…I told you before, waiting isn't the same as doing nothing." he said. "You're waiting right now. That's work too."

. . .

That night I lay awake and listened to my brother's breathing for a long while after he fell asleep.

His breath was even and slow. I tried not to count it. My body counted anyway. One, two, three.

My mother was listening beside him too.

"…When will the right time be?" I asked.

"…I don't know." my mother said. "But when it comes, I think we'll both know."

. . .

I decided to believe that.

. . .

The next morning, my brother drew something on the wall of the room.

One small line. About the width of a finger's joint.

"…What's that." I asked.

"…A mark." my brother said. "I'm going to count how many days until my next birthday."

I looked at that line for a long while.

I had always thought I was the only one who counted. That day, for the first time, I found out my brother had started counting too. Only what he counted wasn't something that had already passed — it was something still coming. I thought that difference mattered. I counted to hold on to what had slipped away. My brother counted to wait for what hadn't arrived yet.

"…Do you want me to help?" I asked.

"…No." my brother said. "I'm counting this one by myself."

I said nothing back to that. It felt like the right answer.

From then on, my brother drew one more line every morning. Every time I passed that wall, I counted the lines with my eyes. Once I'd counted, I never said the number out loud. That number belonged to my brother.

That year, his birthday was still many months away. I didn't know how many lines that wall would end up holding. But I knew that each one of those lines was a way for us to wait.

Writing this chapter, I thought more than once about other endings. An ending where my brother finally wins the argument and gets released. An ending where my brother changes his own mind. I wrote neither. I understood that this isn't a story that ties off every thread before it ends. Some threads carry over, unresolved, to the next page.

My brother, that night, and even now as I write this record, is still a preserved body. Not released. Still eight years old. I don't think that's a sad thing. There is simply a time that hasn't come yet.

(Continued in Chapter 44.)

Chapter 44. What the Names Mean

> *_Previously_ — My brother wanted release, but I judged that an eight-year-old couldn't truly give that consent, and put it off. We made a pinky promise that I would ask him again every year. The Curator told me it was the best decision I could make.*

Around that time, it had become a habit for us to gather by the channel each evening.

Me and my brother, sometimes my mother, and Eikon too. Speon always sat there watching the water run for a while after he finished work, before he left. That evening was no different. My brother had already gone in to the room, and my mother, still tired, had gone to rest early. Only Eikon, Speon, and I were left.

. . .

One evening, sitting by the channel, Speon said out of nowhere.

"…Do you two know what your names mean."

Eikon and I looked at him at the same time. We had been sitting there together.

"…They mean something?" Eikon asked.

"…They do."

. . .

I had wondered about that question for a long time. But I had never asked. I didn't know why myself.

Not from the settlement's paperwork, not from any of the grown-ups there — I had never once heard what my own name meant. I had just assumed my parents picked it because it sounded nice. It was the same with Eikon's name. It had never even occurred to either of us to ask the other.

I know now. I was afraid to hear the answer. If a name has a meaning, it means someone made me for that meaning. I didn't know who that someone was. Not knowing was what frightened me.

"…Tell us." I said.

. . .

Speon looked out at the channel for a moment. His face was choosing something.

"…Anemos." he said. "In an old, old language, it means wind."

"…Wind?"

"…Yes. Not just wind. The thing that cannot be kept. The thing that can't be held in a container. That meaning comes bundled in with it."

. . .

I said nothing at all for a long while after hearing that.

The thing that cannot be kept. In that moment I knew I had lived that phrase across this entire book. I was a counter. Counting is an attempt to hold on. I had spent my whole life trying to hold on to something. And my name had been telling me, from the very start, that I was a person who could not be held.

. . .

"…You don't know who gave it to me?" I asked.

"…I don't know that either." Speon said. "That's how names are. They outlast the one who gave them."

I didn't ask anything further after that answer. It felt like asking wouldn't help.

I looked down at the channel. Water and wind shared that much, at least — neither could be held in a container. In all my time beside Speon learning to dig for water, I had heard, more than once, that standing water rots. That it has to flow to stay alive. I thought my own name might have come from that same place. Something that must not be kept. Something that has to flow.

In that moment, for the first time, I stopped being ashamed of my name. I had blamed myself, more than once, for being the kind of person who couldn't stay close to his family for long. I had even wondered whether leaving the settlement and coming all this way was just some restlessness in my nature that couldn't stay in one place. Hearing the name, I found myself thinking it wasn't a flaw — I had simply been born with a name like that, and that was all.

. . .

"…What about me?" Eikon asked.

Her voice sounded exactly the same as always. I didn't even notice, then, that it sounded exactly the same as always.

Speon looked at her. He paused for a moment.

"…Eikon." he said. "It means image. Or likeness."

. . .

"…What's that mean?" Eikon asked.

"…A form made in the shape of something else." Speon said. "Something copied over exactly from a thing that already exists."

Eikon's face turned that over.

"…A copy of what?"

Speon didn't answer that question.

. . .

I felt something unfamiliar in that silence.

Eikon seemed to feel it too. She asked again.

"…I'm a likeness of something?"

"…That's just what the name says." Speon said carefully. "A name doesn't necessarily explain the whole of a person."

. . .

"…Then why would someone give a name like that?"

Eikon asked it that way. For the first time, I heard something shake a little in her voice, in that question.

I heard that shake and, even then, didn't know exactly what it was.
It was the first time I'd ever heard Eikon's voice shake.

. . .

Speon didn't answer.

Eikon started to ask something more into that silence, and stopped.

She opened her mouth, then closed it again.

. . .

I watched that beside her.

It was the first time I had ever seen Eikon fail to answer something.
She always had an answer. I don't lack anything. What do you mean. Why would I need more. Her answers had always come fast and clear.

That day was not like that.

. . .

I write this moment more carefully than any other in this book. I don't want to attach any explanation to that silence. Eikon heard the meaning of her own name, and had no reply to it. That's all there is.

The sound of water filled the silence. No one tried to break it.

. . .

After a long while, Eikon finally spoke.

"…I just." she said. "I feel kind of strange."

"…Strange how?" I asked.

"…I don't know."

That answer was unfamiliar too. Eikon was a girl who almost never said I don't know.

. . .

Speon quietly got to his feet.

"…Let's leave it here for tonight." he said. "This kind of thing doesn't get taken in all at once."

He gathered his shovel and left. Only Eikon and I remained.

. . .

We sat without speaking for a while.

The sound of water kept running. I didn't know what to say. Ordinarily Eikon would have been the one to ask something light first, but that night she was quiet too.

. . .

"…Anemos." she said, after a long while.

"…Yeah."

"…How did you feel, hearing what your name meant?"

I thought about that question for a moment.

"…Strange. But the strangeness wasn't bad."

. . .

"…For me." Eikon said. "It's strange, but I don't even know if this is a bad thing or not."

"…Is this the first time?"

"…First time for what?"

"…This feeling of not knowing."

Eikon went quiet again for a long while at that question.

. . .

"…I don't know." she said, finally. And she laughed a little at her own words. Something like a bitter laugh. "I don't even know how many times I've said I don't know, by now."

I said nothing back to that. Not because I had nothing to say, but because it felt like silence was the right thing for this moment.

. . .

Eikon leaned a little toward the channel.

She looked down at her own face reflected on the water. The current kept the reflection shaking.

"…Is this me too?" she asked.

"…What is?"

"…The one in the water."

I didn't know how to answer that.

"…Probably close." I said. "But it's water, so it keeps shaking. Your real face doesn't shake."

Eikon heard that and touched the water lightly with a fingertip. The reflected face shook harder for a moment, then settled again.

"…Is that what a likeness is?" she asked. "Something that shakes."

"…I don't know." I said. "You'd have to ask Speon."

"…Speon didn't answer either."

I had no answer to that. She was right.

. . .

"…You know." Eikon said again, after a long while. "I've never once, in my whole life, felt like I lacked something. You know that, Anemos. You've heard me say it, always."

"…Yeah. I know."

"…But right now." she said. "I don't even know if this is lacking something or not. Whether it's because the name is strange, or whether something that was already there is only showing itself now."

That distinction was foreign to me. I had always thought lack was just something you knew. When you're hungry, you know you're hungry. But Eikon, right now, wasn't even sure what it was that she felt.

In that moment, for the first time, I thought that lack might not arrive all at once. Speon had once told me it takes time even for water to change direction underground. I remembered that, right then. Maybe a person's heart worked the same way.

"…So will I change too, someday?" Eikon asked. Not looking at me — at the water.

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know." I said, honestly. "But the fact that you're asking a question like this tonight — that wasn't true even yesterday."

Eikon said nothing back to that. She just kept looking down at the water.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I felt the temptation more than once to attach some great meaning to Eikon's silence here. That this was her first lack. That this was the beginning of her changing. I decided not to write it that way.

I only set down what I saw, in that place, that day. Eikon heard the meaning of her own name. And for the first time, had no reply to it. What that meant, neither she nor I knew.

. . .

The sun went down. Eikon stood.

"…I'll go on ahead." she said.

"…Okay."

She walked a few steps, then turned back.

"…Anemos."

"…Yeah."

"…Say my name's meaning once more? Exactly what it was."

. . .

"…Image." I said. "Likeness."

Eikon mouthed the words after me. No sound, just the shape of it on her lips.

Then she walked on.

I watched her back for a long while. I knew, that day, that I had witnessed the quietest crack in this whole book. Where that crack led, I didn't know yet, then.

. . .

I went back to the room and told my mother about it.

She was sitting on the bedding, mending my brother's clothes. Her hand was still a little unpracticed at moving the needle.

"…Speon told me what my name meant today." I said.

"…What did he say?"

"…Wind. The thing that can't be kept."

My mother's hand stopped.

. . .

"…Your father gave you that name." my mother said.

I was startled by that. It had been a very long time since my mother had brought up my father.

"…My father did?"

"…Yes. I never knew the meaning myself. He just always said it was a good name."

"…Why that name of all names, do you think."

My mother thought for a moment, then smiled.

"…Your father was another one who could never stay in one place for long. That was probably why."

. . .

Hearing that, I felt, for the first time, that I knew my father a little better as a person. I knew almost nothing about him. All I had ever known was that he'd disappeared when I was five.

"…Did you ask about Eikon's name too?" my mother asked.

"…Yes. It means image. Likeness."

My mother's hand stopped again.

"…That's a different kind of meaning."

"…Yes. She had no answer at all when she heard it."

. . .

My mother stopped her sewing for a long while at that.

"…So that's the first time she's ever said she didn't know something."

I was startled by that. My mother had barely even met Eikon, and yet she'd named it exactly.

"…How did you know?"

"…Because I was the same." my mother said. "When you asked me that question, I couldn't say anything either. At first."

. . .

Hearing that, something opened up in me all at once.

In that moment I set my mother and Eikon side by side. Both of them had been women who lacked nothing. Both of them had, at some moment, met the first time they had no answer to give. My mother changed after that. Eikon does not know yet.

That day, for the first time, I saw that these two stories held the same shape. Only my mother's story had already turned the page, and Eikon's story had only just turned its first.

. . .

The next morning, I went to find the Curator and told him about it.

He stopped, mid-paperwork.

"…The meanings of your names." he said. "Who told you?"

"…Speon."

The Curator nodded. There was no surprise on his face.

"…I already knew the meanings of both your names." he said. "They're written in the registry from the start. I simply didn't think it was my place to be the one to tell you first."

"…Why not?"

"…The meaning of a name belongs to the one who gave it, not to the one who keeps the record." he said. "I'm only the one who preserves it."

. . .

Something in that answer caught at me.

"…Eikon had nothing to say, when she heard hers." I said.

The Curator set down his pen at that.

"…I thought that might happen." he said quietly.

"…You knew?"

"…I guessed." he said. "I've been reading her file for seven years. In that whole record, there was never once a moment when she had no answer to something. Today will be the first."

"…What does that mean?"

The Curator looked out the window, toward the channel.

"…I don't know exactly, myself." he said. "But I've learned one thing, doing this work. Sometimes, not being able to answer isn't because there's no answer. It's because the answers have started becoming too many."

I held on to that for a long time.

. . .

That evening I saw Eikon again by the channel.

She looked much like her usual self. She smiled, said hello, asked me what I'd done that day. I was a little reassured by that ordinariness.

But before she left, she asked.

"…Anemos."

"…Yeah."

"…I said my name over a few more times, when I was alone. Image. Likeness."

"…And?"

"…It's still strange." she said. "But less strange than yesterday."

I couldn't tell whether that was a good sign or a bad one.

"…Is that it getting better?" I asked.

"…I don't know." Eikon said. "But I was glad you asked me about it. Better than holding it by myself."

She left those words and walked on. I watched her back. The same walk as yesterday. But I knew now that something was following behind that walk.

That night, I thought again, side by side, about my name and hers. Wind is wind because it cannot be held. Image is image because it carries over something that already exists. I was born a person who cannot be held, and she was born a person carrying something within her. Why those two names came, of all names, to the two of us — that night, I still didn't know.

(Continued in Chapter 45.)

Chapter 45. Eikon's Postponement

> *_Previously_ — Speon told us what our two names meant. Anemos: wind,*
> *the thing that cannot be kept. Eikon: image, likeness. Hearing the meaning of her own name, Eikon had no answer for the first time. That*
> *night I thought about our two names, side by side.*

For several days after that, Eikon went on exactly as she always had.

She came to the channel at the same time, sat in the same spot. Her laugh was the same. I found that, oddly, stranger than if something had changed. I had expected something big to shift. Nothing shifted much at all.

I understood something for the first time, then. A person doesn't change all at once. I had been thinking of this story as one racing toward a turning point. It wasn't. Some changes arrive at a speed too slow to see.

. . .

The channel kept growing, those same days.

It had crossed half the city and was nearing the edge now. I helped Speon dig, and came back each evening to the place where the water sounded. Day to day it all looked the same. But I knew the color of the soil changed a little each day. To the eye it was still the same brown, but under the hand there was more moisture in it, little by

little. Speon had taught me how to measure that moisture — by fingertip, by smell, by weight.

I think Eikon was measuring something the same way. A moisture invisible to the eye, by fingertip. I didn't understand that clearly at the time. I only had the sense that something was changing.

My brother went on drawing one line on the wall each of those days too. I counted the lines every time I passed. Twelve, thirteen, fourteen. I set that number beside the length of the channel and looked at the two together. Both were growing a little every day, too slowly to see.

. . .

Still, there were small things.

One day Eikon asked me.

"…What did you do yesterday, Anemos?"

I stopped short at that question. Eikon rarely asked things like that. She'd always said there was little she was curious about.

"…Dug the ditch. Why?"

"…No reason." she said. "I just wanted to ask."

This time I couldn't let that no reason go by unremarked, the way I once would have.

. . .

Another day she asked this.

"…If I don't lack anything, how can something start making me curious?"

I didn't know the answer to that.

"…I think you'd know that better than me."

"…I don't know either." Eikon said. "That's why I'm asking."

I turned that answer over for a long time. I had failed to answer Eikon's questions plenty of times before. But that day was different. That day, she was asking a question knowing that even she didn't know its answer.

. . .

There was another moment, too.

Eikon didn't come one evening. I worked on the channel longer than usual, waiting for her. She didn't appear until nearly an hour had passed.

"…You're late." I said.

"…Yeah." she said. "I was just sitting in my room."

"…Doing what?"

"…Nothing." she said. "I just sat there. I wanted to."

That answer was unfamiliar to me. Eikon had never spent time that way before. If there was something to do, she did it; if not, she simply

moved on to the next thing without a second thought. Wanting to do nothing, and doing nothing because of it — I had always thought that wasn't a thing that happened to someone who lacked nothing.

That day, for the first time, I noticed she had begun spending more time alone. A person seeks solitude when there's something to sort through. I'd learned that outside. Someone with nothing to sort through has no reason to be alone either.

. . .

The Curator called me aside around that time.

"…It's about Eikon." he said.

"…What is it?"

"…Nothing's wrong." he said. "But I've been watching her file, and in the last few days her rate of questions has gone up. We keep records of that sort of thing."

"…What does that mean?"

The Curator thought for a moment.

"…I've done this work a long time." he said. "Lack usually arrives this way. Not as one big event, but as questions accumulating one by one. I call it the way water seeps in. Not pooling all at once, but drop by drop."

I thought of Speon, hearing that phrase. Two people I'd met in this city, saying the same thing in different places.

. . .

"…So what do we do now?" I asked.

"…Nothing." the Curator said. "We never ask first. Not until the person wants it themselves. That's the one principle of this whole procedure. Never rush."

"…Why be so careful about it?"

"…Because once you ask, it can't be undone." he said. "Being asked, in itself, becomes pressure on a person. I don't want to put that pressure on her. Waiting is our work too."

"…Then why are you telling me this?"

"…Because you're family, Anemos." he said. "I thought family should know first. What comes after that is hers alone."

I thought, hearing that, about whether Eikon was someone I could really be called family to. No answer came. But I didn't dislike the word.

. . .

That evening I passed the news on to my mother.

She had been moving her body a little more easily these days. She could walk out to the yard on her own now.

"…Eikon's been asking a lot more questions lately." I said. "The Curator says that's how lack arrives."

My mother's hand stopped at that. She was still mending my brother's clothes these days.

"…Do you want to help her?" she asked.

"…I don't know. I don't even really know what helping would mean."

"…For me." my mother said. "When you came to me, the hardest thing was doing nothing at all. You wanted to do something, anything. But I wasn't ready, then."

Something clicked in me at that.

"…So should I do nothing with Eikon?"

"…Being there beside someone and doing nothing aren't the same thing." my mother said. "That's something I learned."

. . .

A few evenings later, Eikon spoke first.

"…Anemos." she said. "Can I be released too?"

I stopped digging.

"…You can. You're fifteen. It's not like my brother."

"…Then all I need is to consent?"

"…Yes."

Eikon didn't say anything right away, hearing that. She looked down at the channel for a long while.

. . .

"…Are you scared?" I asked.

"…I don't really know what scared is, yet." she said. "But it's different from before. Before, that word had nothing to do with me at all. Now it's doing something to me."

I started to ask exactly what that difference was, and stopped myself. She didn't seem able to explain it yet either.

. . .

"…Why did Anemos's mother do it?" Eikon asked.

"…She said, she wanted to see the two of us standing side by side."

"…That's all?"

"…Yes. That was all."

Eikon turned that answer over.

"…I don't have a reason like that." she said. "I have people who want to see me. My parents. But I can see them even now, without release. They're here too."

I couldn't argue with that. It was true. My mother's reason was my mother's own. Eikon needed a different one. I felt the temptation to make one up for her, in her place. I held back.

. . .

"…Then why are you telling me all this now?" I asked.

Eikon was quiet for a long while at that question.

"…I don't know." she finally said. "But lately this thought keeps coming back to me. A thought I never used to have. I don't even know why it started. Whether it's because of the name, or whether it was always there and I'm only seeing it now."

"…Is that why you started wanting to be alone too?"

Eikon looked at me at that. Her face was a little surprised.

"…How did you know?"

"…You came late, a few days ago. You said you just sat there."

"…I guess that's what it was." she said. "I can't explain what it is, either."

. . .

The sound of water filled the space between us.

I put nothing on top of that silence. I didn't want to be the one persuading her, this time. I already knew that would be the moment my own wanting got mixed into hers.

That night I thought of something Speon had said a few days before. Water changing direction doesn't guarantee it will reach here. But if the direction never changes, it will never come at all. I was confirming that, again, in front of Eikon.

. . .

"…Do you want to be released?" I finally asked. Very carefully.

Eikon looked at me. For a long time.

"…I don't know." she said. "I can't even tell whether I want it, or whether I'm just curious."

"…Are those different?"

"…Do you know, Anemos?"

I had no answer to that question. I didn't know either.

. . .

"…For me." Eikon said. "This is fine, just as it is. Really. You think I'm pitiable, don't you, Anemos."

"…No." I said. Honestly. "Maybe I did once. Not anymore."

"…Then why?"

"…Because you saying you're satisfied doesn't sound like a lie to me anymore."

Eikon laughed a little at that. Her usual laugh, the kind I hadn't seen in a while.

. . .

"…But." she said. "Being satisfied and this being everything — I guess those turned out to be different things. I thought they were the same."

I stopped breathing at that sentence.

I set this sentence down more quietly than anything else in this book. I don't want to attach any explanation to it. Eikon had begun to tell satisfied and everything apart. What that meant, I didn't know that day. I still don't fully know now.

. . .

"…So are you deciding today?" I asked.

Eikon shook her head.

"…No."

"…Why not?"

"…Not yet." she said. "I want to hold on to this question a little longer. If I answer too fast, I don't think I'll know if it was really my own answer."

Hearing that, my brother's voice overlapped in my mind. What's the difference between not yet and no? My mother had answered him. Not yet changes, when enough time passes.

. . .

"…So is this the end of this conversation?" I asked.

Eikon looked straight at me.

"…No." she said.

She paused a moment.

"…Ask me again later."

. . .

I heard that sentence several times over, right there, though it had only been spoken once. It rang again and again inside me.

I know that sentence isn't an answer. It isn't a conclusion either. Of everything in this book, I rewrote this moment the most. At first I wanted to make her say something more definite. But that was my own greed. Eikon, that day, did not close the door. She didn't open it either. She simply left it standing ajar.

. . .

"…I'll ask." I said. "Whenever."

"…Promise?"

I thought of the finger my brother had hooked with mine. I didn't hold out a finger this time. I said it in words instead.

"…Promise."

Eikon nodded at that. Not so much a relieved face as a face that had set something down.

. . .

"…One thing." she added. "Don't ask too often."

"…Why?"

"…If you keep asking, I'm afraid it'll stop being my answer and start being the answer Anemos wants."

I had no reply to that. She understood that boundary more precisely than I did.

"…Then how often should I ask?" I asked.

"…I don't know." she said. "Don't decide that either, Anemos."

I laughed at that. A strange kind of laugh. I knew, in that moment, that she was handling this postponement far more exactly than I was.

. . .

The sun went fully down.

We sat listening to the sound of water for a while without speaking. Stars came out one by one. The city's lights and the valley's darkness divided the space between us.

That night, for the first time, I understood what this book was trying to say — not through words, but through where we sat. I didn't persuade Eikon. She didn't persuade me either. We just sat in the same place, with one unanswered question between us.

. . .

Eikon rose first.

"…See you tomorrow." she said. The same goodbye as always.

"…See you tomorrow."

She walked off. I watched her back. Her walk was the same as yesterday's. But I knew now that the walk wasn't the same as yesterday's at all.

That night I opened the water flask and drank, thinking. I'd spent this whole book waiting for the moment someone changed for certain. The way my mother had. But Eikon didn't come that way. She only left a door open a crack behind her. That crack looked smaller to me than a closed door. But I know now: a door left open, however little, is a completely different thing from a door that is shut.

Writing this chapter, I rewrote the ending more than once. I tried writing an ending where Eikon chooses release in the end. I didn't like it. I tried an ending where she refuses to the very last. That wasn't it either. In the end I decided to leave it exactly as it happened that day. What this book is trying to say was never a conclusion — it was simply the fact of a door left open.

(Continued in Chapter 46.)

Chapter 46. Being Able to Die Again

> *_Previously_ — Eikon asked about release, but did not decide that day. Instead she said, "Ask me again later." I promised her I would. She left the door neither open nor closed.*

Around that time, we found a house.

Two rooms, deep inside the city. Smaller than the room the Preserve had lent us. But it was ours. The day my mother first crossed its threshold, she stopped for a moment and rested her hand on the door frame.

"…A house of our own." she said. "Was it always allowed to be this small?"

I laughed at that. The house at the settlement had been small too. My mother seemed to have forgotten.

. . .

We spent our first ordinary days in that house.

My mother woke each morning and drank water, my brother played in the yard, and I still went out to help Speon. In the evenings the three of us sat together and shared bread. I still hadn't gotten used to that ordinariness.

I remember those days exactly, even now. Days where nothing happened at all. I had not had days like that in seven years. I only half knew,

then, how precious that was.

. . .

Then my mother began to cough.

At first it was just a dry cough. I thought it might be her throat, still unused to things. Speon had said the same — that her throat was just startled, after so long.

But by the third day, the cough hadn't stopped.

. . .

That night my mother ran a fever.

I only found out when I touched her forehead. It was hot. Facing that heat, I didn't know for a moment what to do.

I had seen sick people many times before. At the settlement, across seventeen funerals. I had thought I knew what to do in front of someone sick. But that night, for the sole reason that it was my mother, I knew nothing at all.

My brother woke.

"…What's wrong with Mom?"

"…She has a fever." I said. "She'll be fine."

Saying it, I wasn't sure I believed it myself.

. . .

The next morning I carried my mother on my back to the Preserve.

The Preserve had a physician. A place the city's people rarely needed, since they never fell ill. I opened that door for the first time.

The physician examined my mother. It didn't take long.

"…This is common after release." he said. "The body's starting to use functions it hasn't used in a long time, and the immune system hasn't fully found its footing yet."

"…Is it dangerous?" I asked.

"…Not right now." he said. "But we need to watch it. This kind of thing can turn suddenly."

. . .

I stood there for a moment, hearing that.

Can turn suddenly. I knew that phrase. All seventeen funerals had begun with it. First a cough, then a fever. The year sickness swept our settlement had begun exactly that way too.

In that moment, for the first time, it truly hit me. My mother was now a body that could die again. I had known that sentence many times over. I'd read it in the paperwork, heard it from the Curator, repeated it to myself more than once. But until I laid my hand on that hot forehead, I had not truly known it at all.

. . .

I brought my mother back home.

I gave her the medicine the physician had given us. I had her drink water often. That was all there was to do. That was so little, it frightened me.

"…Brother." my brother asked. "Will Mom get better?"

"…She'll get better." I said.

"…How do you know?"

I had no answer to that question. I didn't know. I truly didn't know.

. . .

From that day I didn't leave my mother's side.

I told Speon I couldn't come out for a few days. He nodded without much comment.

"…Go on." he said. "The ditch isn't going anywhere."

I turned away without even managing to say thank you properly.

. . .

Eikon came by that evening.

She didn't come inside. She just stood leaning against the door frame, looking into the room.

"…I heard your mother's sick." she said.

"…Yeah."

"…Are you worried?"

I looked at her for a moment at that question. It wasn't a question she would have asked before.

"…Yeah. A lot."

"…I still don't really know what that's like." Eikon said. "But looking at your face, Anemos, I don't think it's only a bad thing."

I didn't know how to answer that.

. . .

"…Why do you think that?" I asked.

"…Because if it were only bad, I don't think you'd keep staying beside her like that." she said. "Wouldn't you avoid something that was only bad?"

I couldn't answer that. I had no room, right then, to judge whether she was right or wrong.

Eikon asked nothing more. She set down a water flask by the door and left.

"…For your mother." she said. "I don't really know, but I heard people bring things like this at times like this."

I looked at that flask for a long while. I didn't ask who had told her that.

. . .

Writing this chapter, I thought I should set one thing down honestly. During the seven years my mother was preserved, I never once needed to stay by her side. She wasn't sick, she wasn't in danger, she didn't disappear. The phrase staying by her side didn't even apply. How do you stay by someone there is nothing to stay for?

But now, my mother was sick. And I did not leave her side. I set those two sentences beside each other and looked at them for a long time. I've decided not to explain them in this book. I'll just leave them side by side.

. . .

The nursing was simple.

Touching her forehead, fetching water, tucking in the blanket. I repeated those simple tasks several times a day. At night I sat beside my mother and listened to her breathing.

I barely washed those days. I didn't change my clothes. My brother cooked the meals instead. Clumsy, but edible. Eating that food, I felt for the first time how heavy it was that there were only the three of us in this house. At the settlement, the neighbors would have brought over porridge. Here, we didn't have neighbors like that yet.

Once, at night, my mother gave a small moan. I shot upright at the sound. It turned out she'd just been lying awkwardly. I couldn't lie back down after that and sat up until morning.

There were nights her breathing wasn't even. On those nights I couldn't sleep either.

I was a counter. On those nights I counted her breaths. One, two, three. When it was uneven, I counted more often. I'd thought, more than once, that it was a bad habit. But on those nights, there was nothing else I could do but count.

. . .

On the second day, the Curator came.

He looked into the room for a moment from the doorway and didn't come in.

"…Is there anything you need." he asked.

"…We're all right." I said. "The physician came by."

The Curator nodded. But he didn't leave.

"…To be honest with you." he said. "Every time I see something like this, something in me goes complicated."

"…In what way?"

"…I kept your mother preserved for seven years. None of this happened in that time. No sickness, no sleepless nights like this one. That was the result of my work going well."

I didn't know how to answer that.

"…But now." he went on. "This feels more right, somehow. I still can't fully explain why."

He left it at that and turned away. I watched his back for a long while.

On the third night, the fever rose and fell again. I wrung out the wet cloth fresh, over and over. My hands cracked. I tried not to count that either.

. . .

On the fourth night, the fever climbed higher.

My mother spoke in delirium. Things about the settlement, about the water jar, names I couldn't make out. I sat beside her, holding her hand. Her hand was hot.

My brother watched from the doorway and cried. Trying hard not to make a sound.

"…Brother." he said. "I'm scared."

"…Me too." I said. Honestly, for the first time.

. . .

I thought about that moment for a long time afterward. I had played the adult in front of my brother, all this time. I know, it'll be fine, words like that. That night, those words wouldn't come. I was

scared too. I didn't hide it. Strangely, that seemed to put my brother more at ease.

We both slept beside my mother that night. Or more precisely, we didn't sleep. I counted my mother's breaths until dawn. My brother fell asleep against my shoulder at some point.

. . .

By morning the fever had come down a little.

The physician came and examined her again.

"…I think she's past the worst of it." he said. "But we'll need to watch her a few more days."

I nearly sank to the floor at that. I only realized then how hard it had been just to stay standing.

. . .

Speon came by that afternoon.

He brought a water flask and dry bread. He set them down without a word and turned to go, and I stopped him.

"…Speon."

"…Yeah."

"…Is this how it really is? Becoming a body that's alive again."

Speon looked at me for a moment.

"…Yeah." he said. "This is how it is."

"…I'm scared. I didn't know it would be like this."

"…If you'd known." he asked. "Do you think you wouldn't have done it?"

I couldn't answer that question right away.

. . .

"…No." I finally said. "I think I'd have done it anyway."

"…Why."

"…I don't know. It's just — having something to watch over gave me something else, alongside the fear. Something different."

Speon nodded at that.

"…Water's the same." he said. "Once you cut a channel, you also get the worry of it overflowing. When there's no water, there's no such worry either. But is that worry a bad thing? I don't think so."

. . .

I held on to that for a long time. I'd heard this book's question asked in different words, more than once by then. Is what's preserved different from what's alive. I'd tried to find the answer through argument. But that answer came, that night, not through argument, but through my hand — laid on my mother's hot forehead.

There is nothing to watch over beside a preserved person. There is something to watch over beside a living person. Having something to watch over means being afraid. And I know this too — that without that fear, I would have had no reason to sit this long beside my mother.

. . .

On the fifth day, my mother opened her eyes. Her mind was clear.

"…Anemos." she said. Her voice was weak.

"…Yes."

"…How many days was I like that."

"…Four days."

My mother closed her eyes, then opened them again.

"…Were you here the whole time?"

"…Yes."

"…Did you not sleep at all?"

"…I slept. A little."

My mother's face didn't believe that. In truth I had almost no memory of really sleeping across those four days.

. . .

"…Why." she asked. "You're busy. You have the ditch to dig."

I laughed at that question. A strange laugh.

"…I didn't know back then." I said. "When you were preserved. There was nothing to watch over, so I didn't need to. But now there's a reason to watch over you."

My mother listened quietly to that. Her face understood something.

"…So that's what being able to die again means." she said, almost to herself.

"…Yes."

"…And." she went on. "You staying by my side like this — that's part of it too, isn't it."

I had no answer to that. It was true.

. . .

My brother heard that and ran into the room.

"…Mom!"

"…Hey." my mother smiled. A weak smile, but a real one. "Mom's okay."

My brother took my mother's hand. Didn't let go.

"…I was scared."

"…Me too." my mother said. "But I'm not scared now."

. . .

That afternoon, Eikon came again. This time she stepped a few paces inside the door.

"…Are you all right?" she asked my mother directly.

"…I'm all right." my mother said. "Thank you for coming."

Eikon looked a little flustered at that.

"…I didn't really do anything."

"…You brought the water flask." my mother said. "Anemos told me."

Eikon had no answer to that. I saw something unfamiliar cross her face. The face of someone who wasn't used to being thanked.

"…Was that really that big a thing?" she asked. Her face was genuinely curious.

"…It was a big thing." my mother said.

Eikon turned that over for a long while, then left without another word. Watching her walk away, I knew that another question had come to settle inside her.

. . .

I wanted to leave that as the last line of this chapter. But I'll set down one more thing after it. I only fell asleep that night. Beside my mother, with my brother next to me. For the first time while falling asleep, I didn't count. Not because there was nothing to count. That night simply wasn't heavy, even without counting.

I wrote this chapter more carefully than any other in this book. I didn't want to turn it into a story where being sick is a good thing. My mother was sick, and that was bad. But alongside that badness, there was something that hadn't been there before. I set both of those down here.

I stayed by my mother's side for several more days after that. The fever never rose again. I didn't dig the ditch once in all that time. Speon never once asked about it. I learned, in my body, that a channel growing a little slower doesn't mean it will run dry.

(Continued in Chapter 47.)

Chapter 47. How Long Have You Been Here

> *_Previously_ — My mother fell ill. I didn't leave her side for four days. While she was preserved there had been no reason to watch over*
> *her. Now there was. Hearing that, my mother smiled quietly. "So that's part of it too."*

After my mother recovered, I spent a few more days at home.

Only once I'd confirmed her body had fully come back did I find room to think about work outside again. My brother had started going to something like a school. A new place had opened in the city for living children, they said. My brother was delighted at the news.

Then, one morning, I went back down into the valley.

. . .

There was nothing special about that morning. I woke as usual, my mother made breakfast as usual, my brother put on his clothes to go to the new place.

I was packing the water flask when my hand stopped, without my meaning it to. Up until that instant I'd had no plan to go back to the valley. But with the flask already in my hand, I realized my heart had already leaned that way.

"…Not going to the ditch today?" my mother asked.

"…I'm going to go somewhere for a while."

"…Where."

I hesitated for a moment at that question.

"…The valley."

My mother's hand stopped at that. She didn't ask anything more.

"…Be back before evening." she said.

"…Okay."

. . .

It's hard to say exactly why.

In the four days my mother was sick, I had come close to the word dying again. Eikon had left me waiting at a door half open. My brother kept drawing his lines on the wall. Carrying all of that, I found myself, without quite meaning to, thinking of that place again.

The place where the bones had been. The place where he was. I'd thought, once I left that valley, that I would never go back. But one morning, I simply found myself walking that way.

. . .

I went without telling Speon.

On the way I passed the channel. The water was pushing past the edge of the city now. I followed the flow with my eyes and confirmed again that it was headed toward the valley. It hadn't reached there yet. But the direction was clear.

The path down the cliff was the same as before. My body remembered where to set its feet. I found that strange — I'd only walked it once.

Reaching the bottom, the dry smell came. The same smell as before. Earth, old wood, and another smell hard to name. I stopped walking for a moment, taking it in. The scattered shoes, the faded scraps of cloth, the small bones — all of it was still there. Nothing had been moved.

I've decided not to describe this valley again in detail. I already did that once. Writing it again, I felt, would blur the weight of the first time. But I'll set down one thing. Walking among those remains, I wasn't afraid, unlike before. Before, this valley had been a strange land of death. This time it felt like walking to meet a familiar face.

. . .

He was there.

Not in the same spot as before. A little further in, among the dry trees. He was crouched beside the bones. I couldn't see what he was doing from a distance.

I walked toward him. Dry things crumbled underfoot with every step.

. . .

Up close, he was simply sitting there.

He held nothing in his hands. He wasn't touching the bones either. He was just sitting beside them, watching the wind carry the soil, little by little.

"…Back again." he said. Without turning to look at me.

"…Yes."

. . .

I sat down beside him.

We said nothing for a while. I went back over everything that had happened, in order. My mother's release, her laugh, and then the fever. Eikon's name, and her silence. The lines on my brother's wall.

He didn't hurry that silence.

The wind blew once more. I thought of how that wind was the same word as my name. The thing that cannot be kept. I thought that wind must have been carrying this valley's soil, little by little, for a very long time. And beside it, this man must have been sitting, unmoved, through all that time.

"…The bones here." I spoke first. "There seem to be fewer than before."

"…Is that so."

"…Yes. Or am I imagining it."

"…You're not imagining it." he said. "When the water gets closer, the soil moves. When it moves, the traces move with it."

I thought of the channel again at that. It hadn't reached here yet, and already something was changing.

. . .

"…You asked me something before." I said, speaking first. "Whether you think these can live again."

"…I did."

"…I said I didn't know."

"…That's right. That was the right answer."

"…Now." I said. "I still don't know. But I think I know something."

He looked at me for the first time, hearing that.

. . .

"…What do you know." he asked.

"…That being alive means being afraid." I said. "My mother was sick. For four days. Those four days were the most afraid I've ever been. But those four days were more time spent beside my mother than all the seven years I spent visiting her."

He listened to that quietly.

"…I still don't know what that means." I went on. "But I have the feeling of knowing something."

"…That's enough." he said. "You don't have to know everything to know something."

. . .

I decided to bring out a question I'd been holding onto for a long time.

I didn't know exactly when I'd started carrying it. Probably from the day I first came down into this valley.

"…Can I ask you something." I said.

"…Go ahead."

"…How long have you been here?"

. . .

He looked at me.

And laughed.

I'll set down that laugh only briefly. I already knew he was a man who never got angry. But even so, that laugh caught me by surprise. I felt something very old inside it. I didn't know what.

"…That's an interesting question." he said.

"…I didn't ask it to be interesting."

"…I know."

. . .

"…You're not going to answer?" I asked.

"…No." he said. Briefly.

"…Why not?"

"…Some answers." he said, "outlast the one who hears them. I think this one would be too heavy for you."

I started to argue with that, and stopped. I couldn't be sure he was wrong.

. . .

"…Then just one thing." I said. "Were you here before I came?"

"…That's the same question." he said. "Just dressed in different clothes."

I laughed at that. Oddly, I wasn't angry.

"…You're right." I admitted. "But I'm really asking because I'm curious."

"…I know you're curious." he said. "But being curious doesn't mean you get an answer."

. . .

"…Then how about this." I asked again. "Has anyone else come down here and asked you something like this? Besides me?"

He looked steadily at me for a moment at that question.

"…There's always been someone asking something like it." he said.

"…What did you tell them?"

"…The same thing I'm telling you now."

I laughed at that answer. I felt like I should be angry, but oddly, I wasn't.

"…That seems a little unfair." I said.

"…What does."

"…That I'm not the only one getting a special answer."

He laughed out loud at that, for the first time. A short laugh.

"…Wouldn't it be more unfair." he said, "to answer everyone the same way?"

I turned that over for a long while. It sounded right, and it sounded wrong, both at once.

. . .

We fell quiet again.

The wind blew. Dry soil swirled low across the ground. Watching that swirl, I thought it was exactly the same sight I'd once seen here before.

Strangely, I was comfortable inside that silence that day. I'd always felt frustrated, before, not getting an answer. The Curator, Speon, this man — all of them, at some point, stopped answering. But that day, it didn't frustrate me.

. . .

"…Can I ask one more thing." I said.

"…Go ahead."

"…Are you going to stay here? Even after the water reaches this far?"

He seemed to think a little longer over that question.

"…I stay where I need to be." he said. "That doesn't change, whether the water comes or not."

. . .

"…And that's here?"

"…For now." he said.

I felt that answer was different from the others. It wasn't a complete evasion. But it wasn't a complete answer either.

I couldn't pin down that difference precisely, then. I still can't, even now. But I had the sense that he'd given a little more of himself away in that question than in the others, that day.

. . .

The sun was sinking little by little. The shadows against the valley wall were growing long.

"…I should get going." I said.

"…All right."

I stood, then looked back at him once more.

"…Can I come again?"

"…No need to ask." he said. "You're going to come again anyway."

. . .

I stopped at that.

"…How do you know that?"

He didn't answer. He just laughed. The same laugh as before.

I thought about that laugh the whole way up. I hadn't gotten an answer that day either. When he'd started being here, whether he'd still be here — I left the valley without knowing any of it for certain.

But writing this question down for the third time in this book, I came to know one thing. Some questions aren't meant to get an answer. The act of asking itself carries the person holding onto the question somewhere. That day, in that valley, I climbed out having received not an answer, but that carrying.

. . .

Climbing the cliff, I looked back once.

He was still there. Crouched beside the bones, watching the wind carry the soil. The same posture as before I'd come.

I held that sight in my eyes for a long while. Then I started walking again.

. . .

On the way back into the city I ran into Speon.

He was adjusting the direction of the channel at its far end. Seeing me, he set down his shovel.

"…Where'd you go." he asked.

"…The valley."

Speon's hand paused at that.

"…Did you meet him?"

I was surprised by that question. I had never told Speon much of anything about him.

"…Do you know him?"

"…Know is a stretch." Speon said. "I've crossed paths with him a few times. Well-diggers run into someone like that, oddly often."

"…What did you two talk about?"

"…Not much." Speon said. "Just a few nods of the head."

. . .

"…I asked him today." I said. "How long he'd been there."

"…What did he say?"

"…He just laughed and didn't answer."

Speon nodded at that. His face wasn't surprised.

"…Figured as much." he said.

"…How did you know?"

"…Because I asked him too, once." he said. "A very long time ago."

My eyes went wide at that.

"…What did he say?"

Speon swung the shovel back onto his shoulder.

"…He laughed." he said. "The same as he did with you."

. . .

I couldn't say anything for a while, hearing that answer. I had thought, up till then, that I was the only person to have ever met him in that valley. I wasn't. I was only the most recent one.

"…Weren't you angry?" I asked. "That he wouldn't answer?"

"…At first, yeah." Speon said. "But I know now. For some questions, it matters more to keep asking than to get an answer."

I held on to that for a long time.

He picked the shovel back up and went back to the channel. I watched his back for a moment, then turned my steps toward home. The sun hadn't set yet. I had kept my promise to be back before evening.

. . .

I came home to find my mother making dinner. My brother was excitedly listing off everything he'd learned at the new place.

"…Where'd you go today, Brother?" my brother asked.

"…The valley."

"…What's there?"

I thought about that question for a moment. Bones, soil, and him. I didn't know where to begin.

"…There's a man there." I said. "A strange man."

"…Strange how?"

"…He doesn't really answer when you ask him things."

My brother laughed at that.

"…You do that too. To me."

I had no comeback to that. My mother was laughing quietly beside him.

. . .

After dinner, I sat alone in my room and went back over what had happened that day.

How long have you been here. I'm writing that question down for the third time now. There is still no answer. But I know something now. I wasn't the only one who ever carried this question down into that valley. Speon had, and maybe someone else too, carried the same question and sat in that same place, and come back up. And none of them, I think, ever got an answer either.

Strangely, that fact comforted me. That not receiving an answer wasn't something that belonged to me alone. That night I fell asleep thinking of that laugh again.

I still don't know how long he's been there. Even now, finishing this book, I don't know. I've stopped finding that strange. Some things can be kept close without being known. I learned that, that day, and walked out of the valley.

(Continued in Chapter 48.)

Chapter 48. The Breath

> *_Previously_ — I went down into the valley and asked him, "… How long*
> *have you been here?" He only laughed and gave no answer. Speon said*
> *he had once asked the same question and gotten the same answer. That*
> *night I fell asleep having learned that some things can be kept close without being known.*

It was about ten days later that the channel reached the edge of the city.

I was digging soil with Speon that day, same as always. But something was different that day. The dampness at the tip of the shovel ran deeper than it had yesterday.

"…We're almost there." Speon said.

"…Where."

"…The edge of the cliff." he said. "Past that is the valley."

. . .

I set down my shovel at that and walked to the edge.

The place where the city ended. Beyond it, the ground dropped away. I thought back to the day, months before, when I'd first stood at this

spot and looked down. I'd known nothing then. Now I knew who was down there.

The channel had come to a brief stop at that edge. One last mound of earth still stood in its way.

"…So all we have to do now is break that open?" I asked.

"…Yeah." Speon said. "But we're not breaking it open today."

"…Why not?"

"…To give a little time to get ready." he said. "For the water, and for people too."

. . .

That evening I brought Speon something I'd been building up to say for a long time.

"…Speon." I said. "Will you teach me how to dig wells. Properly."

Speon stopped putting away his shovels and looked at me.

"…Isn't what you've learned so far enough?"

"…I've only ever helped from the side. I want to learn it properly. Start to finish."

. . .

He looked at me for a long while. It wasn't a judging look. It was a weighing one.

"…Why." he asked.

I couldn't answer that right away.

"…I don't know." I finally said. "But I want to keep doing this. When one city's done, I want to go to another. There might be no water there either."

Speon smiled a little at that.

"…You said you learned from that old man, at fourteen."

"…Yes."

"…What did he tell you?"

"…That you don't find water. You make it a way."

. . .

"…I heard something similar myself." Speon said. "From someone else."

"…Who?"

"…That's an old story." he said. "I learned it when I was about your age too. That person barely spoke either. But once, just once, he told me this. Water finds its own way even where no one's watching. Whether a person's looking or not, water just goes to the low ground."

I turned that over for a long while.

"…Where is that person now?"

"…He stopped." Speon said, briefly. "A long time ago."

I didn't ask anything further at that. I thought I understood why he didn't say the name.

. . .

"…That's how the craft gets handed down." Speon said. "The one who teaches disappears someday, but the teaching doesn't. You got it from that old man, and I got it from someone else. And now I'm giving it to you. Someday you'll give it to someone too."

"…Will I be able to teach it?"

"…Don't know." he said. "But that's not something to worry about now. For now, just learn."

. . .

"…Still don't fully know what that saying means?" he asked.

"…I know a little." I said. "But not all of it."

"…Good." Speon said. "If you knew all of it, I wouldn't have anything left to teach you."

He handed me a shovel. A little longer than the one I'd been using.

"…Let's do this properly, starting tomorrow." he said. "This one was mine, a long time back."

I took the shovel in my hands. The handle was worn smooth. The shape of a hand that had used it for a long time was still pressed into it.

. . .

Taking that shovel, I thought back to the moment the old man had once handed me one of his own. I was fourteen then. I'm sixteen now. I started to count the years between, and stopped myself. Some things carry on without being counted.

Eikon was there. Sitting by the channel, the way she always did each evening.

"…So Anemos is becoming a well-digger too now?" she asked.

"…Learning to be."

"…Is that a good thing?"

"…I think it is." I said.

Eikon listened to that quietly. She didn't ask anything more. I knew she was still holding onto that one question of her own. I didn't ask about it either. I'd promised.

. . .

The next morning, a handful of the city's people gathered at the edge.

Word must have spread. That the channel would open into the valley today. Not a large number. Little more than ten. Most of them had the faces of people who'd simply come to watch.

The Curator was there too. He was holding his papers, as he always did.

"…Do you record this kind of thing too?" I asked.

"…No." he said. "I only came to watch, today."

I was a little surprised by that. It was the first time I'd ever seen this man standing somewhere for a reason that wasn't work.

"…Are you all right?" I asked. "Your face looks a little different today."

The Curator laughed at that. It was the first time I'd seen that too.

"…I've managed preservation in this city for a long time now." he said. "But today, I feel like I've come to watch over something different. Not to manage it."

"…What does that feel like?"

"…I can't quite explain it." he said. "But it isn't a bad feeling."

I decided to remember that answer for a long time. I hadn't heard this man say anything other than sorrow very often.

. . .

My mother and brother came too.

My brother had made a friend at the place he'd been attending lately, and had brought him along. The unfamiliar boy looked down at the channel with wonder.

"…Does that really go all the way down there?" the boy asked.

"…Yeah." my brother answered proudly. "My brother dug it."

I wanted to correct that. I hadn't dug it alone. But I let it stand.
For my brother, that was the true version.

. . .

Among the crowd there were a few unfamiliar faces too. Not people of this city — people who had heard the rumor and come from a nearby settlement. One old man among them came and stood beside me.

"…So it's true, water's coming out here." he said.

"…Yes."

"…I was half doubting it." he said. "I'd heard this city never had a well of its own."

"…It has one now."

The old man nodded at that, looking down over the edge of the cliff.

"…I thought about going down there myself, once." he said. "I have someone from my family down there too."

I looked at him, startled.

"…Have you gone down?"

"…No." the old man said. "There was no reason to go. But now, I don't know. Seeing this water, it feels different, somehow."

I said nothing back to that. I just stood beside the old man for a moment.

. . .

Speon stood in front of the last mound of earth.

"…One thing before we open this." he said, to the gathered people. "Opening this doesn't suddenly change anything. Water is just water. It only flows downward. The rest is each person's own."

No one answered. Speon didn't seem to mind that silence. He picked up his shovel.

"…Anemos." he called me over. "Let's do this together."

I stood beside him. We dug the last mound of earth together.

. . .

After a few strokes of the shovel, the water began to move.

Slow at first. It seeped forward through the gaps in the soil. Then, at some moment, it suddenly quickened, and went over the edge of the cliff.

The sound of falling water echoed inside the valley. I heard it from the edge. Not loud. But it was the first sound to ever break that valley's long quiet.

No one cheered. No one clapped. The people just listened to that sound.

. . .

Eikon came and stood beside me.

"…That sound. I'm hearing it for the first time." she said.

"…The water falling?"

"…Yes. It's strange. I've always heard the sound of water, but this is a different sound."

"…How's it different?"

Eikon thought about that question for a moment.

"…The channel's sound was just a flowing sound." she said. "This is a sound of something falling. Downward."

I thought that distinction was exact. I had never split sound apart that way before.

"…Doesn't it scare you?" I asked.

"…No." she said. "It just sounds big."

We stood there side by side and listened to that sound. She asked nothing. I asked nothing either.

. . .

I set this moment down more quietly than anything else in this book.
I had expected something dramatic. Light bursting, the ground shaking.

Nothing like that happened. Water simply ran down the face of a cliff. But that quiet felt, to me, larger than any dramatic scene could have.

My brother took my hand.

"…Brother, look at that."

I looked where he pointed. The water was falling down the cliff face in a thin thread, glinting silver.

. . .

That afternoon, I went down into the valley alone.

I wanted to see the place where the water reached the bottom. Even on the path down the cliff, the soil had already changed. Not dry brown anymore, but wet brown.

Reaching the bottom, I found the water threading thin among the scattered remains. Not a large stream yet. Just a thread of a flow. But it was moving, unmistakably.

I walked along that flow. I passed the place where a single shoe had lain. The leather had darkened where the water had touched it a little. I crouched in front of it and looked for a long while. It hadn't crumbled. It had simply gotten wet.

I passed a pair of shoes lying side by side too. The stream of water was grazing past them. I paused my steps there for a moment, then walked on.

I passed the place where a small child's shoe had been. The one worn thin at the toe in that particular way. The water hadn't reached that

far yet. I stood in front of it for a moment, thinking the water would reach there someday too. Just not today.

I set down here that I stood in front of that shoe for a long time. I never did find out who that shoe had belonged to, that day. I probably never will. Standing there for a moment in front of it was the only thing I could do.

. . .

He was standing beside that stream of water.

He looked at me as I approached.

"…You came." he said.

"…Yes."

We stood side by side and looked down at the water. It passed a dry shoe, then flowed on toward an old scrap of cloth. The soil took in that water little by little, darkening as it did.

"…Do you think these can live again?" I asked. Handing back, word for word, the question he had once asked me.

He smiled a little at that.

"…I don't know either." he said. "You gave the same answer back then."

"…Yes."

"…That answer still holds."

. . .

"…Then why did this water come?" I asked. "If it wasn't to bring these back to life."

"…It may well have come to bring them to life." he said. "But you still don't fully know what living means. I won't claim to know it all either."

"…Can you tell me just one thing? What it means to be alive."

He fell silent for a long while at that question. I didn't expect an answer this time. Sure enough, he laughed.

"…Same question again." he said. "Just dressed in different clothes."

I laughed at that too. He never did answer directly, to the very end. By that day, even that refusal to answer no longer felt strange to me.

. . .

I listened to that and watched the water run for a long while.

I tried to find an answer in this book. Is what is preserved different from what is alive. I never did find that answer through argument. But I know this now. My mother became a person who could grow sick again, and I stayed by her side. My brother is still eight, and I will ask him again every year. Eikon left the door half open, and I've decided not to rush her. This valley is being wetted, for the first time, right now.

I don't tie all of this together into one answer. I can't.

. . .

As the sun began to sink, I walked a little further along the stream.

The water sought out the low ground, flowing on. Exactly as Speon had always said. That you don't find water — you make it a way. I watched that water already finding its own way, on its own.

At one spot I stopped walking.

There, among the soil the water had touched, I saw a very small green.

. . .

It was smaller than the width of a finger's joint.

I crouched in front of it. I didn't know what it was a sprout of. Grass, or a tree, or maybe just something like moss. It wasn't big. It wasn't showy. Just, among the dry soil, in one small wet patch, there was a very small green.

I looked at it for a long while. I didn't touch it. I just left it there.

The wind blew once. That small green shivered slightly, then went still again. It didn't come loose. I noticed that too.

. . .

I mean to close this book with that one small green. I don't want to write it as some great miracle. I'm not writing an ending where the

valley becomes a forest overnight. This isn't that kind of book.

Speon told me a very old story once. A valley full of bones, the very dry ones. And that question. Can these bones live. I had never heard that story until he told it to me. To the very end of this book, I never answered yes to that question. I never answered no, either. I only set down that I saw one very small green thing. That was the whole of what I could do.

I set down only this one thing. In a place that had only ever been dry, one very small thing had come to be. Whether it will grow, or dry up again, I don't know. But I know that I stood in that place that day, and watched my own footprint stay pressed into the soil. Before, a print like that would have crumbled away in the wind before long. But that day, the soil was wet, and it stayed.

. . .

I stood beside that footprint for a while.

He was watching from a little way off. He said nothing. I said nothing either.

The sound of water spread low through the valley. Listening to it, I stood there still not knowing how much more of this valley would grow wet, still not knowing how much larger that small green would grow.

But I know now that it's all right not to know that.

Before the sun went fully down, I climbed the cliff again.

. . .

Reaching home, I found my mother standing outside the door.

"…You're late." she said. Not a scolding voice.

"…I went to see the water. I went all the way down into the valley."

"…How was it."

I thought for a moment about how to answer that question.

"…There was one small thing there." I said. "It's hard to explain."

My mother didn't press for more at that answer. She just touched my shoulder once and went inside.

My brother was already asleep. Passing by him, I looked at the wall. One more line had been added. I didn't count how many there were. I didn't need to count to know that it was still growing, and that was enough.

My brother's breathing spread evenly through the room. I sat beside him for a moment and listened to that sound. I didn't count it. I just listened.

. . .

That night, I lay down with the water flask set by the window.

I don't carry that flask everywhere with me anymore. This city has water running through it now. But I never threw it away. I just keep it close by.

I often find myself picturing this flask beside the water jar my mother left filled, seven years ago, the day before she was preserved. I didn't drink that water for three days. Because drinking it would have used it up. The water in this flask, now, is water it's all right to use up. Because I can go and draw more. I've carried that difference with me all the way to the last chapter of this book.

At the start of this record, I wrote that I had come to wake my family. And I confessed, somewhere around chapter thirty-nine, that another meaning was hidden inside those words. That I had come to go back to a time when I wasn't alone. I've carried both of those hearts with me to the very end of this book. I haven't set either of them down. Because both of them were real.

. . .

Tomorrow I'll dig the channel again with Speon. Tomorrow I won't ask Eikon anything. Tomorrow my brother will draw one more line on the wall. And this valley's small green thing will still be there, even while I'm gone, standing in wet soil, quiet.

(The End.)

The Dry Valley

Jaehyuk Choi